MY NATION IS MY WITNESS

Ekrem İmamoğlu · Foreword by Özgür Özel

ACKNOWLEDGMENTS

Thank you…

To my wife, Dilek; my children, Selim, Semih, and Beren; my mother, my father, and every member of my extended family…

To my imprisoned companions in this struggle, my friends and their families; to the Family Solidarity Network (ADA)…

To my Party Chairman, my friend and brother, Mr. Özgür Özel, who has led this struggle…

To Özgür Çelik, our Istanbul Provincial Chairman…

To my lawyers, Hasan Fehmi Demir, Fikret İlkiz, Tora Pekin, Mehmet Pehlivan, and Ceren Öztürk…

To the Union of Turkish Bar Associations; to all the bar associations that have lent their support, particularly those of Istanbul and Tekirdağ; and to the courageous lawyers defending my colleagues who are standing trial alongside us…

To my friends, my companions in this struggle, and the elected representatives of the Republican People’s Party (CHP); to political party leaders, representatives, members of parliament, officials, and the valued members of our party organization…

To the entire Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality (İBB) family, its Municipal Council, administrators, and employees; and to Acting Mayor Nuri Aslan…

To our fellow citizens: the courageous mothers, elders, and children who have supported us, cast their votes, offered their prayers, sent messages, and signed petitions…

To the millions of young people who launched the movement outside Istanbul University…

To the 15.5 million who cast their votes, the 25.1 million who signed their names, and all 86 million of my fellow citizens…

Thank you…

FOREWORD

Özgür Özel

Dear Fellow Citizens,

On March 19, 2025, our country was subjected to a civilian coup directed against the political opponents of a government that had come to power through elections but was unwilling to relinquish power through elections. Having lost the confidence and affection of the people, those in power attempted to carry out a civilian coup to eliminate their political rivals through the judiciary and establish an autocratic order founded on repression and prohibitions.

Unlike the coups of the past, this one did not come with tanks, rifles, or military boots. It came dressed in the robes of judges and prosecutors. The ruling party created its own “judicial wing” within our judicial institutions and deployed it against political opponents under orders. This coup targeted not only our presidential candidate, Ekrem İmamoğlu, and our companions in this struggle, but also our people’s right to vote and stand for election, as well as the achievements of our Republic.

After 24 years in power, the AKP government, now looking down upon its citizens with arrogance, politically aged and exhausted by competition, is searching for a way to escape the will of the people. An attempt is being made to destroy the people’s “power to change their government through democratic means.”

Silivri Prison, where Ekrem İmamoğlu and our companions have been held in pretrial detention for 17 months, has become a veritable monument to shame in this tragic period of Türkiye’s history. The slander directed against our companions, and the suffering endured by those who have been threatened through their families and pressured into betrayal, have already taken their place among the darkest pages of our history.

In the largest political trial in our history, it is the most fundamental of human rights for our companions to defend themselves against the charges brought against them. Yet, regrettably, our country is confronted with a repressive regime in which even the right to a defense is disregarded. Mr. Ekrem İmamoğlu was unlawfully and forcibly prevented from delivering the defense he was supposed to present in the courtroom. For this reason, we are sharing this historic defense with our people in written form.

Every line of this defense carries profound significance for Türkiye’s past, present, and future. It is an act of defiance against those who, by targeting Mr. Ekrem İmamoğlu and our companions, seek to point an accusing finger at the nation and put it in its place; against those who seek to force our people into submission through their attacks on our struggle.

Above all, it is a manifesto written for Türkiye’s future. As you read this manifesto, written for the future of our country, you will discover not only resistance, but also the dreams we have envisioned together for Türkiye, the goals toward which we have worked, and the new order our people deserve.

Our greatest strength against this coup is our people. As the late Mehmet Âkif Ersoy, the poet of our national anthem, wrote:

> “A nation left undefended is destined to fall;
>
> But if you stand by your homeland, it shall never fall.”

Together, let us move toward a Türkiye that is free, just, democratic, prosperous, and at peace…

Let us march forward, my friends!

Özgür Özel
Chairman of the New Party

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INTRODUCTION

On the morning of March 19, 2025, Türkiye awoke to yet another coup. The illegitimate AKP government, having stepped outside the law, struck a blow through the judiciary against the opposition—an indispensable element of the constitutional order. This was the first civilian coup in our history.

On May 21, 2026, the intervention against the Republican People's Party (CHP) under the doctrine of “absolute nullity” marked the second stage of this civilian coup against democracy and the Republic.

The target of this coup—carried out by using the judiciary as an instrument and made permanent through operations against one of our municipalities almost every day—is our republican, democratic, and just order. We are living through a period of the gravest damage to our humanity, our consciences, and the fabric of our society.

The manifold cost of the collapse experienced by the AKP and Erdoğan after twenty-four years in power—particularly under the regime effectively put into practice following the 2017 referendum on the Presidential Government System—has been placed on the shoulders of our 86 million citizens.

One concrete result of that collapse is that the AKP government has grown distant from the people, retreating into a 1,150-room palace and severing its bond with the nation. Erdoğan fears the ballot box, elections, and the will of the people. Because of that fear, he has embarked upon a search for a new regime, irregular practices, repression, and operations, and he continues on multiple fronts. The name for this enterprise is the civilian coup.

Silivri Prison, where I too have been held for seventeen months, has become something like a museum of shame for this sorrowful period in Türkiye's history.

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Many fine people who devoted years of their lives and their work to serving their country and its people have paid, or continue to pay, the price for that service here.

Through investigations marked by oppression, torture, harassment, and threats, people and their families have been targeted, taken captive by unlawful decisions, and torn from their loved ones and their duties.

With cases brought on the basis of purported indictments running to thousands of pages, and purported trials conducted while defendants remain in detention, Türkiye is passing through a period in which social peace and democracy are being destroyed.

* * *

Historically, trials during periods of military coups have been conducted in special courtrooms, before specially constituted benches, under special procedures. The case brought by the civilian coup—which seeks to manufacture a criminal organization out of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality—is proceeding under the same methods in a courtroom confined within a prison. So are the fifteen other criminal cases brought against me in the past year alone. So many cases have been filed that they demanded I appear in three different courtrooms at the same hour on the same day. Is there any precedent for this in history?

On July 8, 2026, after sixty-four hearings since March 9 in the principal case against the alleged IMM organization (!), the time finally came for me to be questioned about an indictment that had already been torn to pieces. It was my turn to respond to an indictment that had completely collapsed and become a document of “the lawlessness of the century.” Unlike my colleagues, whose statements had not been subject to time limits, I was told to deliver my defense in a single day—a total of seven or eight hours—in a case in which I faced a demand for 2,400 years of imprisonment and allegations concerning 143 acts. A time restriction never previously imposed was used to interfere with my right of defense.

When I objected to that imposition, the court went further: first it ordered me removed from the courtroom. Then, in full view of everyone present and the members of the press, it turned what had actually happened on its head and entered a false statement in the minutes, claiming that I had “exercised my right to remain silent.”

In our history, during military coups and political trials, political leaders—even leaders and administrators of terrorist organizations—have been permitted defenses extending over days, weeks, even months. Yet fear of İmamoğlu has so thoroughly taken hold of Erdoğan and every instrument of his puppet system that…

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...the mentality that has banned my social-media account, my photograph, my words, my voice, and my image also prevented me from speaking at the hearing.

What were the accusations made against me in this indictment of slander?

Winning elections in Beylikdüzü and Istanbul, taking control of the CHP, supporting Özgür Özel, becoming a presidential candidate, and wanting to become president!

Yes, that is what the allegations amount to. This case, along with every other case fabricated around it, is political. Naturally, I have a political address to give and observations to make. I have thoughts, to be presented at length, about the Türkiye I envision and about a future that responds to the aspirations of our 86 million citizens. This text, drawing on my fifty-five years of life, seventeen years in politics, local experience, and everything I have lived through, represents ideas shared with thousands of friends, fellow travelers, administrators, and political colleagues who form its backbone.

In defending Türkiye's fundamental values, I put on trial the attacks against them, the wrongdoers and their wrongdoing, the dark order that has descended upon Türkiye, the structures that run through every branch of power—including the government and the judiciary—and their trustees, puppets, and instruments.

As you have seen in all my other cases, I never simply read a prepared text straight through. I constantly interject. Sometimes I recount something that happened, an anecdote. I add arguments that occur to me in the moment, notes taken that very morning, and the latest developments. A principal text of fifteen minutes can become an address lasting one or two hours. I speak to my fellow citizens. Whether at election time, on the street or in a public square, or from the defendant's stand, I share my thoughts and troubles with my nation. Unlike some, I am not exhausted, oblivious to my own words, past my time, or captive to a teleprompter.

The prepared text you are about to read would also have become a speech from the defendant's stand—had the court not prevented it—complete with emotional emphasis, extensive explanations, spontaneous remarks, and additional facts illuminating various matters.

An instruction came, the attitude changed, and an arbitrary deadline was invented: the first hearing had to end on July 9. They would not permit it. They obstructed me. It does not matter. Words cross every wall and reach anyone willing to listen.

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The book you hold in your hands contains the words the court prevented me from speaking.

I am in this text, and so are capable, deserving people. It contains my companions in fate—many fine people who devoted their years and labor to serving their country and its people, who stood firm against plunderers, pillage, and conspiracies, and who have paid the price in captivity. You are in this text, too: my beautiful people, my fellow Istanbulites, and our 86 million citizens. It contains what we have experienced together as a precious nation and what was inflicted upon us before your eyes. It contains our dreams, the prosperous future of Türkiye, and what we intend to do for the future of our brilliant children and energetic young people. It contains a manifesto for Türkiye's future.

I am addressing you, speaking with you. Through you, I became who I am. I tell you how a government built in response to your wishes and demands, together with the children of all 86 million, will come into being.

In this text, I describe a new generation of politics, a new century, a new-generation world, a new generation of local government, and a new and stronger consciousness of democracy.

Our assurance is our people. Our strength is our youth. A way will be found; a road will be built. Let no one be anxious.

Everything will be beautiful!

CHAPTER ONE To Surrender Is One Thing; To Be Taken Captive Is Another

I stand in defense of my homeland, my nation, justice, democracy, the Republic, and the future! I put those who attack these values on trial!

I put on trial the indictment that embodies the lawlessness of our age, those who ordered it to be written, and those who wrote it! That is why I am here!

My dear people, my esteemed fellow citizens,

We have the answers to every slanderous accusation made against us. Every single one of those accusations will be dismantled in this defense. But first, we must explain what this is really about!

Through this defense, the betrayal of this nation's will, its dreams, and its future shall itself be put on trial!

As I begin,

I want first to address my companions in this struggle, who, like me, have been deprived of their freedom for the past year, torn from their families, sent away to prisons far from their homes, and subjected to every conceivable lie and slander.

I am proud of you! You are heroes, every one of you!

And I am not alone in that pride. Your families, your friends, your neighbors, and the entire Turkish nation are proud of you.

Türkiye's history will never forget you!

You are the soldiers of democracy in the greatest political trial in the history of our Republic. Despite all the pressure, despite all the suffering, despite being deprived of your freedom and separated from your families, you stand firm in defense of the truth. You fight for the Republic, for democracy, and for the rule of law. You put yourselves on the line for what you believe in.

You refuse to yield, for the future of your children and grandchildren, for the future of Türkiye. You resist for the children and grandchildren of all 86 million of our people.

These oppressors have not only inflicted cruelty upon you; they have inflicted it upon your families as well. They showed no mercy even to our companions struggling to stay alive, battling serious illnesses.

Their consciences have grown blind, their ambitions have consumed them. The fear of losing their precious positions, their privileges, and their power has driven them into a frenzy.

But have no fear. These are the final desperate convulsions of those in power and of the merciless mentality behind them.

Nothing can stop a change whose time has come!

No sham trials, no sham declarations of "nullity," no sham judicial proceedings, and none of these acts of oppression can prevent the change that is inevitable!

Change is approaching at full speed!

Our nation has a conscience. Our people are compassionate and pure of heart. Our people have a deep sense of justice; they never forgive injustice.

Our people love their homeland. They have no affection for those who regard the country as their personal property.

The people of this beautiful country believe in the sanctity of the family. They do not forget the wrongs inflicted upon spouses, children, mothers, and fathers. They condemn them. They curse them.

They have made our mothers weep, our wives and husbands weep, our sons and daughters weep...

But do not grieve. Do not give in to anger.

They will be defeated by the conscience and wisdom of Türkiye. History will consign them to its dustiest shelves, where they will be remembered in disgrace.

You, on the other hand, are the heroes who, at a turning point in Türkiye's destiny, refused to bow your heads; who stood tall against oppression; who remained honest, hardworking, patriotic, devoted to the Republic, and committed to democracy!

They concocted a cheap story about a criminal organization, threw us into prison, and gathered us here in this courtroom.

But what unites us is neither the March 19 coup nor the pages of this fabricated indictment!

What truly unites us is our love for our country and homeland, and the love and respect we have for our work.

It is the fact that we carry Istanbul in our hearts, that we strive to make Istanbul the jewel of the world, that we work day and night for its 16 million residents...

What unites us is our comradeship in the pursuit of democracy and the rule of law!

What unites us is our boundless love for and faith in this nation, in these people!

What unites us is our love for the Republic and Mustafa Kemal Atatürk!

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I have said this many times, and today I say it again to the court:

Take me captive. Me alone! I accept it.

Do not stop at putting me on trial with a possible sentence of 2,352 years. That is not enough!

Put me on trial for 3,000 years, 5,000 years, 10,000 years!

But release my innocent companions. Leave their families alone. Spare the sick and the women.

At least apply the law for their sake! At least do what the law requires for them. Release them!

My companions in this courtroom have been imprisoned on the basis of false accusations, despite being innocent. Most have been behind bars for more than a year!

The hearings began five months ago. You have listened to all of them. You have seen just how utterly baseless every allegation is. Yet dozens of our companions are still waiting to be released!

For an innocent person to spend even a single day in prison is a profound injustice and a form of torture.

The moment my "defense" is finished, I expect you to release every one of my companions!

And even today, there are dozens of our other companions being held in prison, outside this case, without so much as an indictment having been prepared against them!

None of this can be called a trial. It is torture. It is captivity. It is oppression. It is lawlessness!

Those responsible will certainly be held accountable before the law.

What a disgrace! Enough is enough!

Let mothers and fathers be reunited with their children. Let sick mothers, their eyes filled with tears, embrace their sons and daughters again.

Enough of this cruelty!

It is me you are after. You know it, the nation knows it, and the whole world knows it!

I am here!

Take me captive, but release my friends at last!

I want to speak to my companions in this struggle.

Some of you I have known for years. Others I met in the course of serving Istanbul, and we became companions in our work and in our shared destiny.

This case has proven something else as well: you were all recruited through such a merit-based system that I genuinely met many of you for the first time here.

Day after day, I have listened to every one of you with the utmost attention. My already profound respect for you has grown immeasurably!

I knew, of course, that we had an exceptionally capable team. But here, once again, I have been deeply impressed by your knowledge and experience, your courage, your integrity, and your patriotism.

Every one of you is now more than a companion in this struggle. You are my family.

All of us standing trial here, together with our families and the millions of citizens who support us, have become one enormous family!

A family that loves the most beautiful country in the world with an extraordinary passion, and believes with all its heart that this country and this nation deserve none of the evil being inflicted upon them!

I am proud of this great, courageous family of ours!

I read, one by one, the thousands of letters that reach me in prison. I am sure you receive letters too.

In those letters, you must feel that immense love: the great heart of our nation, the sincere affection of our children, the heartfelt prayers of our mothers, the solidarity of our brothers and sisters...

There is another reason I am proud of you.

Through courage, science, and reason, each of you has demonstrated that this so-called indictment — this catalogue of slander masquerading as an indictment — is nothing but an empty piece of paper.

In the face of your composure, your evidence-based arguments, and, above all, the justice of your position, even those who have oppressed you were overcome with shame and lowered their heads.

Every day in this courtroom, reason, merit, science, knowledge, experience, goodwill, and competence have spoken.

Every day, the pure hearts of people who have devoted years of their lives to serving their country, their city, and their nation have spoken.

And every day, as you spoke, the mediocrity, inexperience, ignorance, and ill intentions of those who wrote this clumsily constructed scenario became more and more apparent.

We have drawn strength from the justice of our cause. As I speak here today, we are far stronger and far more determined than we were four months ago.

Have you noticed?

Once you began speaking, they stopped talking about this trial built on a conspiracy!

Day after day, they tried to change the agenda with some new sensational operation or announcement. They did everything they could to divert the public's eyes and ears away from this case.

Because you demolished the indictment. You destroyed it. Not even its "crumbs" remain.

Because you proved to the entire world that this indictment was prepared in bad faith, unlawfully, and not in the service of justice, but in pursuit of a political objective.

Not only Türkiye but the entire world witnessed this amateurishly staged, disgraceful piece of theater.

This judicial scandal made headlines around the world. Numerous articles and commentaries were published about it in different languages.

What a shame.

As a nation, we did not deserve such a spectacle. As Türkiye, we did not deserve such disgrace, such a betrayal of the people's will and the law.

Despite all this cruelty and pressure, you were not crushed. You did not give in to fear. You did not retreat.

You tore the indictment apart, argument by argument, and reduced it to nothing!

And as I listened to you, I kept thinking:

"What extraordinarily capable companions we have chosen at the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality!"

I did not know many of you personally. After all, whatever kind of "organization" this is supposed to be, most of you became my colleagues by passing interviews and examinations.

Thanks to this trial — if one can call it that — I have come to know you better, and my pride has multiplied many times over.

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...and my pride grew many times over.

What a successful human-resources system we must have built to mobilize so many capable, accomplished, knowledgeable people of character in the service of Istanbul!

Silivri must surely be the prison with the most highly educated and accomplished detainee population in the world!

Every one of my companions is an expert in their field, with extensive professional experience and a history full of achievements!

But there is something far more valuable than your education, expertise, or knowledge: your character, courage, and honesty.

And thanks to this case—if that is the word for it—all Türkiye and the entire international community have seen that.

The oppression inflicted upon my companions held hostage in prison and in this courtroom for seventeen months, upon our families who awaken to this nightmare every morning, and upon the millions starved of justice has long since transcended both the walls of this courtroom and your indictments, which are null and void!

While we stand firm here in these dungeons, a resistance no less important or glorious is taking place outside.

Above all, my brother, my fellow traveler, the courageous elected leader of the Republican People's Party, Mr. Özgür Özel, together with our party's elected organizations, members of parliament, provincial chairs, administrators, and members, have given us extraordinary support: tirelessly, without regard to snow, winter, or rain, and courageously despite pepper spray, detention, and arrests!

To everyone who has refused to leave us alone throughout this year—young and old, members and voters, those close to our party and those who identify with other parties, yet who stand in public squares for justice despite cold, rain, and repression—and to the mothers who lift their hands in prayer for us each day: I send my great nation my love and endless gratitude from here!

I also thank the Istanbul Volunteers and Türkiye Volunteers—whom I call the guardians of Istanbul and Türkiye—and send them my love and gratitude!

How fortunate we are to have you all. Thank you, may you be blessed; if you feel I have any claim upon you, I release you from it, always. May God keep smiles upon your faces!

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Moreover, our entire great family, led by my brother, fellow traveler, and party chair, Mr. Özgür Özel, is resisting not only for those of us in prison, but also against the coup directed at democracy and at the Republican People's Party—the founding party of the Republic of Türkiye and now the country's leading party!

As you know, on May 21 a court without jurisdiction—the Ankara Regional Court of Appeal—attempted to appoint a trustee to the Republican People's Party, trampling upon the will of its delegates, members, and voters, and in effect to shut the CHP down!

On May 21, a court without jurisdiction, backed by the government, dared to commit an unprecedented act of lawlessness!

Do you know how it dared? Because the Supreme Election Council did not—could not—stand by its constitutional duty.

At the next elections, the votes and will of 86 million people will be entrusted to the Supreme Election Council. Do you think a council that remains silent today in the face of blatant illegality against the CHP will be able to protect the opposition's rights and the rights of millions of our citizens tomorrow? Do you realize the danger?

I appeal once more to the Supreme Election Council from here: fulfill your constitutional duty!

Thanks to the silence of the Supreme Election Council, whose leadership changed on May 6, the ruling handed down by the regional appellate court on May 21 was not, in truth, a “judicial decision”; it was a coup against the Republican People's Party, which, under its new leadership, became the country's leading party in the 2024 elections! Both March 19 and May 21 were coups against the will of millions of our citizens. Indeed, the “absolute nullity” operation against the CHP is a continuation of the March 19 coup process. March 19 and May 21 are different phases of the same coup against Turkish democracy.

The coup's ultimate objective is to bring the democratic order to a complete end, extinguish our people's will and right to govern themselves, and make a different regime permanent.

The great CHP family and all democrats will repel this insidious coup.

The CHP is a party founded in the people's squares and on the fronts of struggle. It lives not in buildings but in streets, squares, coffeehouses, marketplaces, and homes. It carries the spirit of the National Struggle in its very genes. That spirit is with us today in all its freshness.

Translator's note: BAM is the Turkish abbreviation for a Regional Court of Appeal (Bölge Adliye Mahkemesi).

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The spirit of the National Struggle is the greatest force capable of halting this coup against national sovereignty. Wherever that spirit lives, there lives the true institutional identity of the party that founded the Republic and democracy!

At this critical turning point for our country, I say to all the politicians, writers, thinkers, opinion leaders, artists, and academics who have not buried their heads in the sand, who have spoken up, written, and made their voices heard for us: may God bless you! I also express my gratitude to the opposition leaders who have not left us alone.

To those representatives of the government, and even its coalition partners, who cannot accept what is happening and send us messages in secret, trying to object even through hints: I understand you too. I only wish you had more courage, that you could say more loudly that no government can be built upon such cruelty.

I understand the pressures and difficulties you face, but this has become a matter of the homeland—a question of what kind of Türkiye we will leave our children and grandchildren. Whatever the difficulties, I call on you to show greater courage and speak the truth.

I swear that we will never forget anyone who has supported us openly and bravely through these difficult days! Everyone who stands with us today, regardless of party, identity, or opinion, will be among our most valued lifelong companions under the roof of Türkiye. I believe both our nation and our state will be saved by the patriotism of those capable of calling right right and wrong wrong.

When the road is free of thorns, everyone claims to be a patriot; true patriots reveal themselves in difficult times!

* * *

As you know, before 2019 the AKP had governed Istanbul uninterrupted for twenty-five years. Back then, Erdoğan could not believe that the opposition might win Istanbul in a democratic election—a city he would have given anything to keep under his control.

But a child ran after our campaign bus and cried, “Everything Will Be Beautiful!” We believed him. And everything truly did turn out beautifully!

Today I tell you again with still greater resolve, excitement, and conviction: “Everything Will Be Beautiful!”

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The March 19 coup began on a day in Ramadan. These hearings, too, began on March 9, during Ramadan. My diploma was revoked on March 18, also during Ramadan! And, looking still further back, the 2019 Istanbul election that I won was annulled on May 6—again, during Ramadan!

Yet Ramadan is a blessed time symbolizing spiritual purification, self-discipline, patience, abundance, sharing, solidarity, and peace. Those who laid these traps for us, stole years from innocent people's lives through this fabricated case, and inflicted suffering on our families have failed to discipline their desires; nor do they understand sharing, solidarity, or peace. Their consciences are blind, their hearts darkened, cruelty ingrained in every part of their being.

The discipline of one's desires, above all, requires each person to reflect upon their life and decisions. Anyone who yields to ambition and behaves unjustly for gain or out of greed, who lies, slanders, oppresses innocent people, or separates them from their children, commits the gravest sins.

This, then, is the court hearing the coup case initiated by a handful of sinners during blessed Ramadan. It hears the fabricated prosecution begun with unlawful predawn raids on homes at the time of the pre-fast meal, carried out by hundreds of police officers before innocent people and their children.

This unjust case has no place in our law, conscience, faith, ancient culture, or the course of our history.

* * *

We are struggling here for democracy, justice, peace at home, and peace abroad. We will leave Silivri—one stop on this journey—with clear consciences and heads held high. We will emerge much stronger than when we entered, because we have proved that we are right. We will emerge more mature, more knowledgeable, and more just.

We will come away with a deeper understanding of people, love for humanity, and the value of solidarity. Our determination to serve our nation will have multiplied. Most importantly, we will emerge fully prepared to govern our country. For even under prison conditions, we work here day and night.

While resisting pressure, oppression, and lawlessness here, we are also working for the day when our beautiful Türkiye will rise again...

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While we resist repression, oppression, and lawlessness here, we are also working to lay the intellectual foundations of a future in which our beautiful Türkiye will rise again.

For this defense is not merely a legal defense. It is a manifesto expressing our determination to place humanity, democracy, justice, and development once again at the very foundation of the state.

We will govern our country together.

We will govern this country not through fear, but through reason; not through hatred, but through justice; not according to the will of one man, but through the collective wisdom of the people.

Together, we will free our nation from this order of wrongdoing.

We are almost there!

The darkest hour of the night is the one closest to dawn.

My beloved wife, Dilek, has loved Nâzım Hikmet since her youth. Addressing both her and all of you, I say:

Believe me: We shall see beautiful days, children, sun-filled days we shall see. We shall drive our engines toward the blue horizons, children, toward the radiant blue we shall drive...

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Having greeted my companions standing trial alongside me, those watching us in this courtroom, and our nation listening beyond these walls, we must first speak of the historical significance of this case.

We must properly understand what lies at its heart and where it stands in the history of our nation.

And let me make one thing absolutely clear from the outset:

I am not speaking to the court! I am addressing my beloved nation!

They, and they alone, are the people to whom I answer.

Because it is always the nation that delivers the true verdict. It is always the nation that has the final word.

Here, I will both account for my actions before my beloved people, my valued fellow citizens, and share with them my dreams for the future — the future we will build together.

Everything I have to say is addressed to my nation.

Because this case, and the more than twenty other cases brought against me, are in fact all parts of one great case. I call them the “İmamoğlu Trials.”

And at their heart, the İmamoğlu Trials are “Trials of the Struggle for Democracy.”

Together with all our companions, we are waging this struggle for democracy on behalf of our people.

That is why my audience is, and can only be, our people.

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My dear fellow citizens,

For nearly five months, you have listened to the defenses of my companions.

You have heard from people accused of belonging to the so-called “organization” I supposedly established — people, many of whom I met for the first time here.

By now, it has become clear to you, to us, to our nation, and to the entire world:

This is not a corruption, espionage, or terrorism trial. This case is an attempt to usurp the nation's sovereign right to govern itself!

The intention of those who have brought us together before this judicial panel is to put an end to democracy!

Those who wrote the script for this trial do not recognize the citizens' right to vote or to stand for election.

But we know they will not succeed.

Our history has witnessed similar trials before.

And in such cases, it has always been the nation that delivered the final verdict.

Before the judgment of the people, every government and every ruling loses its authority.

What we are fighting to defend in this case is the right of an equal and free citizen of the Republic of Türkiye to compete in elections; the right of every citizen to vote and stand for office; the sovereignty of the nation; and the will of the people.

We are a great nation that has founded states and empires and built a Republic!

We have endured wars, devastation, and coups.

Yet we have never surrendered to despair!

At no point in its history has the Turkish nation bowed to oppression or surrendered to tyrants.

Our people have known how to tear through darkness, overcome oppressors, and lead their homeland toward brighter days.

In every era, courageous and selfless sons and daughters of this nation have succeeded in building a stronger state and a better life.

The history of our democracy is a history of struggle.

Not a single right we have won has come without sacrifice.

In the Yassıada trials, the March 12 trials, the September 12 trials, and the February 28 trials, countless innocent people paid a terrible price.

Each time, our nation taught the coup-makers a lesson!

It taught a lesson to those driven by ambition who imagined their temporary hold on power would last forever!

As a nation, we know all too well that our country has experienced political trials time and again.

The parties involved have changed, but the outcome has always been the same: judicial decisions condemned by the conscience of society.

Yesterday, the hearings at Yassıada. Today, the hearings at Silivri.

Those who sentenced Adnan Menderes, Fatin Rüştü Zorlu, and Hasan Polatkan to death are condemned today.

If the death penalty still existed, those in power today — who are putting me on trial while seeking a prison sentence of 2,352 years — would have sought my execution!

Because today's government has brought the Yassıada trials to Silivri.

Let us briefly compare the trials of Yassıada and Silivri.

A new court was established to try Menderes, Zorlu, and Polatkan. It was called the “High Court of Justice.”

Its judges were appointed by the members of the National Unity Committee, the very people who had carried out the May 27 coup.

The principle of the “natural judge” — the right to be tried before a court established by law rather than one specially constituted for a particular case — was violated.

And in Silivri?

Let no one take this personally. I am speaking about principles, not individuals.

Of the three judges on the panel trying us, two were appointed afterward.

Once again, the principle of the natural judge was violated.

Now let us turn to the question of judicial independence.

Following May 27, the National Unity Committee appointed the judges.

In today's Türkiye, judges are appointed by the Council of Judges and Prosecutors.

The chairman of that Council is the politically motivated chief prosecutor who wrote this catalogue of slander masquerading as an indictment.

The majority of the Council's members, meanwhile, are appointed by the President and his party.

In short, it is the President who appoints the Council and its chairman.

And who is the President?

He is the person who ordered all these operations to be carried out, the person who commissioned the script for this fabricated trial.

There is no difference.

Back then, the judiciary was under military tutelage.

Today, it is under the tutelage of a single individual...

Let us also compare the actual conduct of the proceedings at Yassıada and Silivri.

At Yassıada, arresting defense lawyers was a practice of the coup courts.

Indeed, Prime Minister Adnan Menderes's lawyers, Burhan Apaydın and Talat Asal, were arrested and thereby prevented from mounting a defense.

Hüsamettin Cindoruk — who represented Finance Minister Hasan Polatkan and many others, and who passed away recently, may God rest his soul — was also arrested because of remarks he made before that court.

The situation in Silivri is no different.

My lawyer, Mehmet Pehlivan, is under arrest.

Many of our other lawyers have also been taken into custody during this process, and cases have been brought against them as a means of intimidation.

Wherever lawyers are subjected to such pressure, the conditions of a coup prevail.

Because in a democratic state governed by the rule of law, the right to a defense is inviolable.

Salim Başol, the appointed judge at Yassıada, told the elected Prime Minister Adnan Menderes:

“Stop speaking. If you won't stop, we'll make you stop.”

And at Silivri, the appointed prosecutor said to me, the elected mayor of Istanbul's 16 million residents:

“Know your place. If you don't, we'll teach you your place.”

No judge or prosecutor could speak this way in a normal court.

Such oppressive conduct belongs to coup courts.

Under a coup regime, elected representatives are not treated with respect. On the contrary, those in power seek to intimidate and suppress them through mistreatment, imagining that this will break their resolve.

At Yassıada, prosecutor Altay Ömer Egesel prepared the statements of university students who were to testify, made them sign those statements, and threatened those who refused.

Today, in Silivri, many individuals who had benefited from the provisions on “effective remorse” have withdrawn their statements, admitting that those statements were obtained under threats.

People were threatened through their families and their assets.

One person who had invoked “effective remorse” openly stated that his testimony was a “template” prepared by the prosecutor's office, which he simply signed as it was.

Numerous defendants have also testified in this courtroom that their statements were distorted by the prosecution.

At Yassıada, when Samet Ağaoğlu, a prominent figure in the Democrat Party, pointed out certain inequalities and injustices, the presiding judge said words to the effect of:

“That is what the force that threw you in here wants.”

In other words, the judiciary was operating under the control of the real decision-makers who had thrown politicians into prison.

Today, we face the same situation.

Those whom the government wants imprisoned are prosecuted; those it does not want imprisoned are left alone.

Take the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality as an example.

Every action taken by the municipality after 2019 is scrutinized in minute detail.

Yet when we submit information from before 2019 in files requested on a particular matter, the prosecutor's office immediately rejects it.

Because the objective is not to investigate corruption.

The objective is to throw certain people into prison.

Just as it was at Yassıada.

The decision of “absolute nullity” against the CHP is another instrument of a coup.

Those who carried out the September 12 coup shut down the CHP.

The present government, too, attempted to shut it down in practice.

Yesterday, May 27 and Yassıada.

Yesterday, September 12 and the dissolution of political parties.

Today, the coups of March 19 and May 21, and the hearings at Silivri.

The methods are the same.

Whether carried out by soldiers or civilians makes no difference.

Such methods are prohibited in a democratic state governed by the rule of law.

These are the methods of a coup!

And, of course, the similarities are not confined to Yassıada.

Yesterday, the martial-law courts of March 12.

Today, Silivri.

Those who sentenced Deniz Gezmiş, Yusuf Aslan, and Hüseyin İnan to death are condemned today!

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The government of today has brought the Yassıada trials, the March 12 trials, the September 12 trials, and the February 28 trials to Silivri.

History has passed judgment on the Yassıada, March 12, September 12, and February 28 trials. Tomorrow, history and our nation will judge the Silivri trials as well! Indeed, they are judging them today, at this very moment!

Now, too, before the coup courts of March 19 and May 21, our nation is undergoing another great test. Yet I have not the slightest doubt that these trials, with no standing whatsoever in the nation's conscience, will be remembered with condemnation and revulsion, just like their historical counterparts.

Those who defend the nation's rights, its law, and its will against the March 19 and May 21 coup trials in these courtrooms will take their place in the golden pages of our democratic history.

* * *

My Dear People,

We all know the history of this great nation. As you will appreciate, the Turkish nation did not easily gain control of its own future. Nor will it relinquish that control easily!

A constitution, elections, representation, a parliament: these are rights won through great struggles even during the imperial era. The most important achievement of our struggle for freedom spanning more than two centuries is the Republic itself, founded upon national sovereignty and the equality of citizens.

During the republican era, we built our multiparty democracy step by step, establishing fair and democratic political competition. The struggle for democracy under the Republic was interrupted by coups from time to time. Yet our people ultimately never surrendered their sovereign rights; they forced every oppressive coup-maker to face the ballot box and knew how to consign them all to history through elections.

Today our democracy is once again passing through a difficult test. The current government is trying to destroy the gains of our history of struggles for freedom and democracy merely to remain in office a little longer. It is trying to reverse the course of history, to end fair and democratic elections, the equality of citizens, and the sovereignty of the nation.

Throughout our history, democratic struggles have always been waged against concentrating extraordinary powers in the hands of a single person. For...

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...unlimited power is sooner or later abused, gives rise to arbitrariness and injustice, and ultimately always works against the people.

The struggles to limit the boundless powers granted to one person and to secure our nation's sovereignty are continuous: they form the main current of our history.

Our Republic, too, under Atatürk's leadership, is the product of our people's great struggle for democracy and freedom and of their collective will.

And what are we experiencing today? The three-times-elected mayor of a city of sixteen million, a presidential candidate backed by twenty-five million, and his colleagues are in prison. The Republican People's Party, which founded the Republic, won the favor of our citizens in 2024, and became Türkiye's leading party, has been subjected to a coup, and a person selected by the government has been appointed as trustee!

As I said earlier, a major blow was struck against democracy on March 19 and May 21.

Today we are struggling against the disastrous consequences of the Presidential Government System, introduced in 2017 through various political tricks and a questionable referendum. Yes, here in this courtroom, we are trying once more to put our democracy back on its feet.

History has once again placed upon us the responsibility to fight to remain a strong, sovereign nation against the desire to establish rule by a single sovereign and a “dynastic” regime—a desire now openly voiced!

Once again, speaking here on behalf of all our citizens, I say: this “new regime” established in 2017 has nothing to do with the Republic or democracy. The words “republic” and “democracy” both have their roots in the people: sovereignty of the people.

What authority can governments whose time has passed, rulers who have become weak and dependent on the outside world, or administrators who do not derive their legitimacy from the nation claim against popular sovereignty?

Our democracy, matured over the depths of history, cannot and will not be sacrificed to an irresponsible, unchecked, obsolete style of government—armed with excessive powers yet no longer strong enough to exercise even those powers, having destroyed institutions without building anything to replace them, and serving a privileged few. In the regime they seek to institutionalize, there is no “nation,” no “people”: there is one person. A ruler.

This new regime, which they are trying to make permanent, seeks to abandon the destiny of each citizen and of the whole nation to the mercy of a single person and a dynasty...

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...and to subordinate the state to the wishes and ambitions of that person and the small, privileged oligarchic circle surrounding him.

That is what we must stop!

Never again should our country be abandoned to government with such excessive powers and no oversight. Our country will not retreat a single inch from the achievements won through more than two centuries of difficult democratic struggles: popular sovereignty, the equality of citizens, and fair and democratic elections.

This case is about the nation's claim to its own future. It is a contest between those who defend a state that derives its legitimacy from the nation and those who believe their authority legitimizes itself. It pits those who would destroy our constitutional democratic order—based on popular sovereignty, equal citizenship, rights and freedoms, and fair democratic elections, all won through great historical struggles—against those who resist them. It is between those seeking to nullify the will expressed by the nation through elections and those who uphold that will. It is between those seeking to plunder the public resources built up by our people's labor and those seeking to share our country's wealth fairly. It is between those fighting to make all 86 million equal stakeholders in this country and those making a handful of people into a privileged class. It is between those working to bring to power our nation, the only true owner of Türkiye, and those who think themselves the landlords and the people merely their tenants. It is between those who work to restore order and justice to our state and those who abuse the power of the state for private gain. It is between those who defend the Republic and democracy and those who seek to destroy them. It is between good and evil; the nation and a handful of privileged, power-hungry individuals. And the nation, without doubt, will prevail!

Goodness will always win. Sooner or later, justice will be done!

Whether at home or abroad, no “dynasty” possesses enough strength or endurance to enslave a Turkish nation animated by the spirit of “I have lived free since time immemorial, and free I shall remain!”

* * *

We stand at a turning point in history, at the very height of betrayal...

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...and as we walk this road with all our hearts and souls, our nation is balanced on a knife's edge! Either we will be drawn into a long darkness with no end in sight, or we will transform this historic crossroads symbolized by Silivri into the beginning of a journey toward the light—the first great step in a march toward democracy and the rule of law.

I know it will be the latter. Let none of you doubt that for a moment!

On this journey toward the light, we must reorganize politics to attain a pluralist democracy, a strong state that protects its country against threats, and a peaceful, prosperous society.

The way to rescue politics from decay and raise its quality is to make political competition fair, democratic, and civilized.

Real political competition is not simply a requirement of democracy. It means allowing the best policies for citizens' prosperity and society's development to compete. Where competition is absent, favoritism, abuse, corruption, and decay take hold.

Fair and democratic political competition is also the foundation of our country's economic development and strengthens its competitiveness. When competition is abolished, our businesspeople, entrepreneurs, scientists, artists, athletes, and young people all lose the ability to compete with their counterparts around the world.

That is one of the forms of devastation we are experiencing today.

Our citizens are growing poorer because this government is determined to hold on to power without engaging in political competition. Türkiye is losing altitude. Our country's competitive strength and capacity are declining.

My Dear Fellow Citizens,

Do you know what it means to imprison a politician who became a presidential candidate with the support of twenty-five million people, and to place Türkiye's main opposition party under a trustee forcibly installed by the government? It is an attempt to annihilate and usurp the opposition and the will of millions!

They want to stage a sham democracy: an opposition that conducts politics in comfortable halls, within a space allocated to it. They seek to create His Majesty's Opposition. They want to tell the nation and the world: “Look, there is democracy in Türkiye, there is an opposition. What more do you want?”

Do you really think this nation cannot see through this theater? This...

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The mentality behind this staged performance holds our nation in utter contempt!

And they have found a mysterious justification for every unlawful act, every wrongdoing they commit: "reason of state."

They draw this mysterious veil over even their most outrageous actions to prevent our people from questioning them. Apparently, "reason of state" demands it.

Nonsense!

This is not reason of state. It is the thinking of a handful of power-hungry individuals who refuse to surrender their comfortable positions and the system of privileges from which they profit.

To call what is happening "reason of state" is an insult to our thousand-year tradition of strong statehood.

Those who arrogantly claim to embody "reason of state" dare to mock the intelligence of the nation.

True reason of state is justice.

A form of reasoning that knows no justice can never be reason of state.

An election is a genuine election only when there is both a government and an opposition — a real, independent opposition — competing at the ballot box.

Yet the current government is effectively telling this nation:

"Even if we give you a ballot box, I will decide what choices you have. I will choose my opponents. I will even control the parties competing against me."

This nation will never accept that!

Suppose you imprison me.

I am prepared to pay that price. On a personal level, I can accept it.

But this is not simply about Ekrem İmamoğlu.

Nor is it merely about the CHP!

The real question is whether the ballot box placed before the nation is genuine or counterfeit.

Whether elections are real or merely for show.

Whether the multiparty system is genuine or nothing more than an illusion.

I cannot accept such a loss for our nation. I cannot resign myself to it.

Whether a citizen loves me or despises me, whether they vote for me or not, I will not allow anyone to rob them of their rights!

I will not allow the value of a single vote cast into the ballot box to be diminished!

Throughout our political history, we have seen many governments come and go.

With their achievements and their failures, they served this country.

And when their time came, governments changed. The opposition took its turn in office through the will of the people.

Yes, throughout our history, there have also been governments that granted privileges to their supporters while excluding and purging those who refused to support them.

At times, this mentality dragged our country into destructive cycles of revenge.

But today, we have entered a far darker phase.

Because this time, the objective is not merely to intimidate or suppress one segment of society.

The objective is to seize the nation's sovereign right to govern itself!

The objective is to render the ballot box meaningless, hollow out democracy, and effectively abolish the people's power to change their government.

The mentality that has lined us up in this courtroom intends not merely to punish us for our achievements, but to eliminate the opposition altogether.

That is the difference today.

Political purges are no longer merely an occasional display of harshness. They now aim to eliminate democracy permanently by rendering elections, the law, and state institutions incapable of functioning.

That is why the danger is so immense!

Look closely. What they intend is erasure.

I am standing here before you, yet they are trying to make me cease to exist in public life.

They want to erase me from public life, to remove my image, my voice, and my ideas from everywhere.

They want to strip me of all recognition and standing.

If they could issue a ruling of "absolute nullity" against Ekrem İmamoğlu himself, they would do so without hesitation.

What does it mean to declare my university diploma invalid?

As I keep saying, if they could, they would place my birth certificate before you and demand:

"Cancel it!"

This is an attempt to erase someone from existence.

Likewise, when the CHP became the country's leading party under its new leadership, they began trying to "erase" that successful leadership.

"Absolute nullity" is an attempt at erasure.

But I know that whatever they do, they will never be able to erase us from the minds, consciences, and hearts of our people.

They will fail.

Because if this intention were ever to succeed, our country would lose not only its democracy, but also its shared future, its institutional capacity for sound governance, and its social peace.

That is why this case represents a historic rupture.

It is an attempt to destroy genuine opposition at its roots, to eliminate the very possibility of the opposition coming to power, and therefore to destroy democracy itself.

It is an attempt to tear this land away from the course of its own history.

* * *

We do not deserve this, my dear people, my dear companions!

We deserve not the dark order imposed by those who have abandoned democracy, but a life of peace together and a pluralistic democratic system founded upon the absolute equality of citizens.

Every child of this nation deserves to live freely and securely, without fear of some calamity befalling them.

Every citizen deserves to feel equal, to receive a fair share of the country's wealth, and to live in a public environment where they can express their political views freely.

As a nation, we deserve to be happy!

* * *

This court is an institution.

It is an institution of this state.

And the institutions of this state derive their structure, strength, and traditions from the centuries of struggle undertaken by our ancestors.

Look at the case this court has been compelled to hear.

An institution forced to devote its time to a case devoid of substance.

This is precisely the distortion and hollowing out that is taking place throughout the institutions of the state.

We cannot allow it.

Today, from this courtroom, we declare that we will not allow the handful of people who wrote this indictment, or ordered it to be written, to overturn the institutional foundations our ancestors built through centuries of struggle.

This nation wants to be able to trust the institutions of its state.

It wants to trust its judiciary, its official documents, its property deeds, and its university diplomas.

And its political choices are shaped by that fundamental need for trust.

Look at history.

Despotism and arbitrary rule have never succeeded in establishing a permanent foothold in this country. They have never generated genuine legitimacy.

Whenever governments have descended into arbitrary rule, the will of the nation has eventually brought about their replacement.

Rights, the rule of law, justice, and the security of property all depend upon the continuity of institutions.

The desire for freedom and a life of dignity runs through the veins of this society. It has become part of the nation's character.

Today, as attempts are made to tear Türkiye away from its historical course, the objective is not merely to render democracy and the Republic dysfunctional.

It is also to dismantle the institutional continuity of the state itself.

It is to cut through the very pillars that hold the state upright.

Who would want to live in a country where their university diploma, property deed, promissory note, or any official document they possess offers no security whatsoever?

Who could accept living under a state that cannot be trusted?

The attack directed against me is an attack upon precisely this institutional trust.

Shortly, I will describe in detail the "judicial assault" I have experienced.

I will explain how my university diploma, which I had held for 32 years, was revoked.

How the assets built through 60 years of my family's labor were seized in a single day.

And how, to accomplish all this, our institutions — from our oldest and most established state university to the judiciary itself — were used, and how their reputations were damaged in the process.

Here, simply to prevent my companions and me from succeeding, and to preserve their own positions of power, they are attempting to destroy the institutional foundations, reputation, archives, and collective memory of the state.

If this were merely a case of political competition becoming more intense, we could endure it.

Thank God, we possess the strength to fight such a battle.

But imposing upon this society a regime alien to the state's historical memory, to the deeply rooted fabric of society, and to Türkiye's accumulated political and institutional experience concerns everyone.

It concerns the entire nation.

Government and opposition alike — it concerns us all!

The history of Türkiye is a history of progress, democratization, and liberation.

But it is also the history of a strong state, sustained by its institutions and its laws.

This is the essential, authentic national story of Türkiye.

In this sense, this case concerns not only the present, but both Türkiye's past and its future.

Together, we are defending this country's historical legacy, built upon the Republic and democracy.

We are defending our nation's right to determine its own future, together, through its own free will.

At the same time, we are defending the very meaning of statehood: the seriousness and responsibility of the state, the continuity of its institutions, and the integrity of its promissory notes, diplomas, property deeds, and archives.

Let no one forget:

Against the so-called "reason of state" that one individual is attempting to force upon the nation, our thousand-year tradition of statehood — a tradition belonging to all 86 million of our citizens — will prevail!

* * *

There can be no legitimate government in a country without genuinely competitive, fair, and free elections.

Yet the political leadership that came to power promising to "eliminate the regime of tutelage" is now attempting to establish the tutelage of a single individual!

Today's government is behaving as though it were the heir to the coup-makers of September 12.

In the 103-year history of our Republic, the Republican People's Party, founded by the great Atatürk, has been targeted in this way twice.

First, by the coup-makers of September 12, who shut down the CHP in 1981.

And now, by the current government, which appointed a trustee and attempted to shut the party down in practice!

Even the coup-makers of 1983 accepted the result when the candidate they supported lost the elections.

They bowed to the will of the nation.

Yet today's coup-makers could not accept our victory in Istanbul, nor could they accept our aspiration to govern Türkiye.

Instead, they chose to betray the will of the people!

That is how utterly consumed by ambition they have become!

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Today, an attempt is being made to establish an order even more regressive and darker than the one that followed the September 12 coup! I want to offer a brief historical reminder here.

The Republic of Türkiye entered a new era with the military coup of September 12, 1980. The 1982 Constitution, in its original form, was a document built around a system of tutelage; it restricted democratic development. Nevertheless, Türkiye returned to democracy after the coup. Severe crises marked the 1980s and 1990s, but democracy did not disappear. On the contrary, it grew stronger.

The September 12 coup was later condemned both by history and before the law; the intervention of February 28 likewise never gained legitimacy in the conscience of the nation. In 2002, the AKP came to power with strong public support, promising to overcome political instability, resolve economic problems, and address deeply rooted issues such as the Kurdish question.

Yet over time, that support was used against the people to consolidate the government's hold on power. Those in power began acting as though they would never leave office. Public resources were used arbitrarily; corruption and waste reached extraordinary levels; and the networks of vested interests clustered around the government developed into an oligarchic structure. A privileged class was created.

Those who came to power promising to “end tutelage” established their own system of tutelage over every institution of the state, the private sector, and the sovereignty of the nation. They wagged accusing fingers at society, at young people and women; cities, green spaces, and olive groves were plundered; and they sought to impose a mentality that restricted freedoms.

We remember the Gezi Park resistance of 2013. We have not forgotten. Whatever contrary account may be offered, the truth we witnessed with our own eyes remains before us. This resistance was a spontaneous, growing expression of public opposition to arbitrary rule, authoritarianism, and an order that opened our cities to plunder.

Afterward, through fabricated trials — and by disregarding earlier acquittals — attempts were made to turn the truth upside down. Convictions arising from those cases still stand, despite rulings by the Constitutional Court and the European Court of Human Rights.

After 2013, repression intensified further. The government's conception of democracy ceased to be “sovereignty of the people” and became “sovereignty over the people.”

Erdoğan's alliance with FETÖ poisoned every institution of the state. Trials built on conspiracies eroded confidence in the judiciary, and hundreds of innocent people were sent to prison, just as they are today. The very organization that the government had nurtured with its own hands — the organization to which it had said, “What did you ask for that we did not give you?” — carried out the attempted coup that subjected us to some of the most shameful moments in our history. We endured that as a nation.

In the hands of those who described it as “a gift from God,” the attempted coup of July 15 became a pretext for constructing a new regime with no place for democracy, the rule of law, or freedoms.

As a nation, we were neither deceived nor taken in. Yet for years we suffered oppression and insults at the hands of Erdoğan's “companions,” even as he claimed that he himself had been “deceived.”

We made it through those days, once again at the cost of sacrificing innocent sons and daughters of the nation, amid the destruction inflicted upon the state. But we must never forget that we are now confronting different formations of the very same mentality!

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At its core, this case was initiated to make permanent the “one-man” or “single-ruler” system introduced in 2017 under the conditions of the state of emergency, through a disputed referendum involving “unstamped ballots.”

The disputed referendum held in 2017 after the July 15 coup attempt was the first major step toward changing the regime. It was followed by the annulment of the May 6, 2019 Istanbul election, the March 19, 2025 operation against the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, and the nullity ruling of May 6, 2026 — all blows against the national will and the multiparty system. These were the final critical steps taken to make the regime introduced in 2017 permanent, despite the nation's demand for change.

This case and the March 19 coup are a continuation and a natural part of the grotesque Presidential Government System, which seeks to impose a great U-turn on the course of our historical development.

Under one-man regimes, the people eventually demand change. That is because such regimes leave society increasingly impoverished and unhappy. But one-man systems cannot tolerate competition, because genuine democratic competition — elections with an uncertain outcome — would mean the end of their rule.

To understand the historical place of the case being heard here today, we must return to 2017 and understand the Presidential Government System. Introduced through a disputed referendum in 2017, this grotesque system concentrated all power in the hands of one person — the President — while reducing the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye, the only body in which the entire people are represented, to something almost symbolic. It destroyed the separation of powers and the mechanisms of checks and balances.

This system demolished the fundamental principle that has been the guiding maxim of our Republic since its founding and has appeared in all our constitutions:

“Sovereignty belongs unconditionally to the Nation. […] The exercise of sovereignty shall in no manner whatsoever be left to any person, group, or class.”

That principle still exists today in Article 6 of our Constitution, but it has remained on paper alone.

The Presidential Government System and the current regime are the very opposite of the ideal of the Republic. They represent an attempt to make a U-turn away from the Republic — an ambition to transfer the sovereignty of the nation to one single person.

The judiciary, meanwhile, was brought under political control and turned into an instrument of those in power. Members of the Council of Judges and Prosecutors, the judiciary's key governing body, are now appointed by the President and his party in the Grand National Assembly. The chair of the Council is the Minister of Justice, who is also appointed by the President. Judicial independence is impossible under such a system.

Having been made dependent upon political authority, the judiciary is no longer used to deliver justice. It is wielded as a cudgel to intimidate anyone who displeases the government.

Türkiye has become a country that wakes each morning to “breaking news” of politically motivated detentions and arrests! And this is no longer an issue affecting politicians alone. Everyone's turn is coming!

Our nation has witnessed coups and postmodern coups. What we are experiencing today, however, is a “ghost coup.” It seeps in gradually. Wherever it enters, it spreads rapidly. It does not merely target; it destroys. Erdoğan is carrying out this “ghost coup” not only against us, but even against those within his own party who might aspire to succeed him.

People go to bed each night wondering, “Who will be detained or arrested tomorrow?” Will tomorrow morning's “operation” target journalists, artists, businesspeople, or politicians? It could be anyone.

This is precisely what feeds the empire of fear they are trying to build. Everyone in Türkiye knows that you need not have committed any crime to be taken from your home at dawn, held in some dreadful place many floors underground, and perhaps even placed under arrest!

People are being frightened. Courthouse corridors are treated like the pages of a gossip magazine; names are leaked to the press, and fear spreads. And do you know what happens next? Innocent people are punished before they have even been tried. They are handcuffed as though they were “hardened criminals”; their right to be protected from public stigmatization is violated; they endure four dreadful days in police custody. Some are formally arrested and held in detention — only for us to discover that, one day, they are suddenly released!

These people are not merely being punished. Their dignity is being destroyed; the presumption of innocence is disregarded; and they and their families are made to suffer immense devastation. That is why, for months, I have not been speaking from this stand solely about my own case!

I have been explaining how the law is being trampled underfoot in this country. When you examine recent events, you see that every segment of society, for different stated reasons, is being exposed to the same judicial pressure.

One day, an operation is launched against some of Türkiye's largest poultry producers. Allegations that might fall within the scope of competition law lead to trustees being appointed to companies and executives being taken into custody. A few days later, all those measures are lifted. The next day, similar operations are launched in numerous other sectors, reaching once again into people's property, assets, and businesses.

I said it before: “Those who cancel my diploma today will want to seize your property and assets tomorrow!” Then, in operations against certain holding companies, we saw that even these cases were being discussed as part of power struggles within the government itself.

Trustees were appointed and people were arrested; then those same trustees were removed and those same people released! Throughout that process, we all saw the same thing: a television news channel could be seized overnight, and the management of a long-established media organization could be changed with a single decision. A university could be ordered shut, abruptly altering the fate of thousands of students and academics. Once the law ceases to be predictable, no property right, no institution, and no citizen can feel secure.

At the same time, the world of the arts was targeted. Ayşe Barım was deprived of her freedom for months. Afterward, numerous actors and artists were compelled to give statements at prosecutors' offices. The message was clear: Artists whom you regard as opponents, too—

[The final sentence continues on printed page 39.]

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Artists whom you regard as opponents were now targets too. This intimidation of the cultural and artistic world remains etched in our memories as yet another means of suppressing freedom of expression.

Meanwhile, almost every week we were confronted with sensational headlines announcing major operations involving “drugs,” “prostitution,” or similar allegations. Celebrities, artists, social media personalities, journalists, and other well-known public figures were targeted one after another. In many of these investigations, statements from secret witnesses, testimony obtained through the provisions on effective remorse, and methods designed to brand people guilty in the public eye before any trial once again came to the forefront. Just as we have seen how secret-witness accounts and the mechanism of effective remorse were used in my own case, we now see the same methods becoming routine in other investigations.

Journalists faced the threat of prosecution for their reporting, commentators for their words, academics for their ideas, and artists for the positions they took.

And now it is not merely criticism that those in power cannot tolerate. They cannot even tolerate humor. The proceedings against comedian Deniz Göktaş became one striking example of how even a joke can become the subject of a criminal investigation. A mentality that seeks to punish humor fears not only society’s freedom to think, but even its right to laugh and experience joy.

Viewed individually, these may appear to be separate investigations. Viewed together, however, the picture becomes far clearer. Businesspeople, journalists, artists, figures from the world of sport, social media personalities, academics, politicians... Everyone faces different case files and different accusations, but the same methods: appointed trustees, secret witnesses, pressure through effective-remorse provisions, dawn raids, the destruction of reputations, pretrial detention turned into punishment, and public declarations of guilt before any verdict.

This is the country we live in: no one enjoys security of person or property! No one has any guarantee of their freedom. Anything can happen to anyone at any moment. Can a judicial system operate this way? Can a nation be strong, happy, and at peace under such conditions? Of course not!

The case in which my companions and I stand trial today is part of this very picture. That is why I stand here to defend the principle that the law must continue to protect everyone.

* * *

Another defining feature of this regime is the hundreds of thousands of our citizens who have faced proceedings for the offense of “insulting the President.” Since 2014, more than 400,000 citizens have been investigated for “insulting the President,” and nearly 100,000 have been convicted of this “offense”! Even children under the age of eighteen have been prosecuted!

Before Erdoğan, the figures numbered in the tens, at most the hundreds. Presidents then generally sought, once elected, to remain impartial in accordance with our Constitution and to represent the entire nation. They did not seek to polarize society or wage war against their own people. Even when citizens criticized them, they did not send those citizens before the courts. Erdoğan, by contrast, fashioned the judiciary into a shield for himself. He sent hundreds of thousands of people before judges and had them punished. The number of his own citizens whom Erdoğan has brought before the courts runs into the hundreds of thousands.

In what democracy could such a thing happen? I will tell you: in none.

A person who represents the state and the nation cannot, and must not, be so deeply at odds with their own people. A president should embrace all 86 million citizens. When criticized, a president should try to understand, listen, and respond with goodwill, whatever the circumstances!

Instead, a process of building a veritable “Republic of Fear” through the judiciary has begun in our country.

Can our country live indefinitely under such constant tension? Can it be happy and peaceful? Can it develop? Can it prosper? Of course not!

I want everyone to take careful note of this: the Constitution guarantees fundamental rights and freedoms. But the independent judiciary is itself the safeguard of the constitutional order. The only institution capable of protecting fundamental rights and freedoms is a judiciary independent of political authority and every other center of power!

But do we have a judiciary today that protects citizens and their rights? Do our citizens feel safe? Do they trust the courts?

You know the figures yourselves: sadly, 85 percent of our people do not trust the judiciary and do not believe their rights will be protected. Not a single citizen wishes to enter the courts that were established to protect every citizen!

I want everyone to reflect on this. Today, the government expects the judiciary to protect not the rights and freedoms of citizens, but the government itself and its hold on power. Our judicial institutions should be the first to resist this. This very court should resist it.

That is why I ask, again and again: will you deliver another kick to the great Turkish judiciary, already brought so low? Or will you show the courage to issue just decisions and help raise the Turkish judiciary back to its feet?

* * *

The Grand National Assembly of Türkiye—the assembly of the nation—has been stripped of almost all its powers of oversight. Even its budgetary authority has been taken away!

For centuries, one of democracy's most important principles has been that the power of the purse belongs to parliament. We have departed even from that principle.

All appointments within the state have been left, without oversight, to the discretion of a single individual. No system of checks and balances has been established, as exists in democratic presidential systems.

In this way, the institutional structure of our state has been brought down. Merit has disappeared. Strong state institutions have been hollowed out. The state has become a party-state—indeed, the state of one individual.

District governorships have effectively become district party offices, and provincial governorships have become provincial party offices. The party-state Erdoğan so ardently desired has been created. The Turkish nation cannot endure this!

Favoritism has spread in chains from the very top to the bottom, virtually engulfing our country. It has damaged our people's sense of justice and robbed our young people of a future. In the past, the head of state was a president without party affiliation: impartial and unifying. Under the new regime, we have a president who belongs to a party and is even its chairman. And because this "party-affiliated president" also appoints all senior state officials at will, our state has sadly and rapidly become a "party-state." Can a president who closes rival parties, imprisons mayors, and transfers elected officials through unethical methods be fair? He cannot! At most, he can be the chairman of one political party!

They have left no mechanism for collective deliberation within the executive.

You may remember the decisions of the Council of Ministers. The prime minister and ministers signed those decisions, which emerged from deliberation. Now our country is governed by presidential decisions and decrees, signed by one individual who answers to no one. Decisions are no longer taken before the eyes of the nation, in Parliament, through transparent and accountable processes. They are taken behind the enormous, closed doors of a palace far removed from the people.

We watch that mysterious Palace from afar. Our country of 86 million is governed by one person living in a palace of 1,150 rooms, together with three or five people around him. And

these are three or five people we do not know and have never met! We do not know who they are. The Turkish nation does not know who truly governs Türkiye. We have no idea how decisions are made. Society cannot know or trace which influential figure has arranged for which decision to be taken, or how.

Today, everyone is left waiting to see which adviser will interfere with which institution on which day; which newspaper headline will be used to intimidate whom; and which institutions will be ordered into action.

Such an order destroys citizens' trust in the state, because trust can be built only through transparency and accountability. The people's trust in the state rests on justice, merit, inclusion, and sound institutions.

Institutional governance has ended; arbitrariness reigns. This is the so-called "new regime" established after the constitutional changes of 2017. With arbitrary rule came irrational, inconceivable "economic experiments." The intoxication of power had become so extreme that even the voice of science could no longer be heard.

What followed is known to us all: the highest inflation and cost of living in the world. The resulting crisis, which has left our people unable even to feed themselves adequately and has abandoned them to hunger, remains unresolved. Nor can those who created this crisis ever resolve it.

This is the result of one-man rule. An entire nation has lost its freedom and become poorer. Our people's prosperity, freedom, happiness, and peace have been destroyed.

When people can no longer trust the law or the protection of property rights—when a family's accumulated wealth of sixty years can be seized overnight—and when there is no atmosphere of peace and freedom, investment dries up. A tremendous exodus of talent and capital begins, and the economy sinks further into collapse.

And the greatest betrayal of the order into which Türkiye has been driven today is also—

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That is precisely where the problem lies: in the destruction of trust. No one trusts the regime; the regime trusts no one; and institutions do not trust one another. Fear, anxiety, tension, and anger are the prevailing emotions in society. In such an atmosphere of mistrust, the economy cannot breathe.

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Do you know the real reason behind March 19 and May 21 — the attempt to eliminate the opposition? It is to make the “one-man regime” I have described permanent. Those in power know very well that if elections are fair, they will lose.

The government no longer has either the prospect or the hope of winning a fair election. That is why it seeks to move beyond “competitive authoritarianism” into a pitch-black dictatorship. Its only way to remain in power is to eliminate democratic competition!

Would a government confident in itself, its achievements, and its place in the hearts of its people stoop to such unlawful methods? Would it throw its rival into prison and try to silence every dissenting voice by force?

Let me tell you something else, and I ask everyone to listen carefully: there is another reason for the May 21 coup. It is the ambition to make a new regime permanent through a new constitution.

By appointing a trustee to the CHP and seeking the support of certain CHP members of parliament, they imagine they can even keep such a constitution from the people! They imagine that, if they secure enough votes in Parliament, they can adopt a new constitution without asking the nation what it thinks!

Even if they do ask the people, they will say, “Look, the CHP trustee supports it too.” They aim to secure the backing of 360 or 400 members of parliament. Do you realize how great the danger is?

I call upon all my fellow citizens, all political parties, and every conscientious, democratic member of parliament in this country: authoritarian regimes never amend constitutions in order to become more democratic!

Of course they present their amendments in that guise. Of course they package and dress them up beautifully. They include plenty of attractive provisions and offer reassuring promises to every section of society.

But constitutional changes made by authoritarian regimes always have one purpose: to strengthen the regime, make it more rigid, and entrench it permanently.

What do they say? “We will rid ourselves of the coup constitution!”

Are you not the very person whose actions make people look back on the September 12 coup-makers with something approaching nostalgia? Are you not the architect of the “phantom coup”? How many times have you amended the Constitution? Did you not take advantage of the impact that FETÖ’s treacherous coup attempt had on society to change the Constitution?

The current government did precisely this with both the 2010 and 2017 referendums. We have all seen and experienced the disasters into which the amendments made through those two referendums dragged our country.

To expect anything different from a third constitutional amendment by the same government would be irrational. Both referendums were products of the same mentality; a third will be its product too! The constitution they envisage is a “March 19 coup constitution”!

They dazzle people with attractive provisions, while the truly consequential provisions that entrench the regime are technical and go unnoticed. Yet once the regime is entrenched in this way, those attractive provisions become merely symbolic. The regime applies whichever article it wishes however it wishes. No institution remains capable of saying no to its demands, its pressure, or its bullying.

Is that not already the case today? The government does not enforce the provisions of our present Constitution that protect freedoms! What difference would it make to add more such provisions to a new constitution, or to write them more elegantly? Whenever it suits the government, it will simply disregard them again! Let no one make this historic mistake. Neither our nation nor history will forgive it.

Only genuine democrats — people at peace with the Republic, who have truly internalized democracy and are wholeheartedly committed to pluralism and fundamental human rights and freedoms — can draft the democratic constitution Türkiye deserves in the twenty-first century!

A government that first enacted the most anti-democratic constitutional reforms in the history of the Republic through the 2010 referendum and then, just nine years ago, through the 2017 referendum; that refuses to implement rulings protecting freedoms issued by the Constitutional Court and the European Court of Human Rights; that imprisons elected mayors or appoints trustees to municipalities; and that seeks to eliminate the main opposition and its rivals through the coups of March 19 and May 21 can never produce a democratic constitution!

The government uses the cover of a “new constitution” solely to manipulate elections, divide the opposition, make the one-man regime permanent, and extend its time in office.

Please listen carefully: a constitution could be drawn up under which no election would ever matter again. No one must fall into this trap!

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At this point, I want to emphasize another extremely important issue: democracy is fighting for its very survival around the world, dear friends. For some time, we have witnessed democratic backsliding in various parts of the world. Democracy indices are declining globally. There are even self-styled geniuses who now claim that we “no longer need” democracy! A campaign of manipulation seeks to portray democracy as an obstacle to development and security.

Opponents of democracy in Türkiye draw encouragement from this. They say, “Democracy is not necessary for development,” or “In conditions of regional conflict, democracy is a luxury.” Remember how even the “world powers” that have appointed themselves guardians of the region come here and make declarations such as “The Middle East has too much democracy” or “Monarchy is the form of government best suited to this region.”

In other words, they are saying openly that national sovereignty, the right of people to determine their own destiny — in short, democracy — is “too much” for your people. You would do better to relinquish your sovereignty, submit to a sultan, and hope that he is merciful and well-intentioned!

Those who say this do not know our history! We are a people who began our struggle 107 years ago under the leadership of Mustafa Kemal Atatürk; whose men and women, young and old alike, fought and sacrificed tens of thousands of martyrs to win their sovereignty!

Moreover, the arguments of those who seek to diminish the importance of democracy contradict the fundamental logic of both economics and security.

Democracy and the rule of law are the guarantees of development, economic prosperity, and security! Democracy brings legitimacy, checks and balances, freedom, institutional continuity and predictability in government, collective wisdom, and the rule of law.

Democracy is indispensable to economic development! Without the rule of law, oversight, and sound state institutions, trust cannot take root. When the judiciary is not independent and falls under the shadow of arbitrary power, people's trust in one another and in institutions collapses.

Trust is the most fundamental prerequisite for development. Trust that one's property is secure, that contracts and documents issued by the state are valid, that rules will not be applied arbitrarily, and that decisions will be subject to review...

Trust is built step by step, through institutions, people, and relationships. No one who lacks confidence in the future will invest in it. Long-term planning becomes impossible; capital flight and the emigration of skilled people accelerate. The country's risk premium rises. The result is borrowing at high interest rates; when investment fails to arrive, unemployment or low-wage labor; and ultimately a poorer society.

That is why democracy is indispensable to development! The institutional structure of the state and the rule of law are not luxuries of economic progress. On the contrary, they are its essential foundations.

Democracy is also indispensable to security! The price of security must not be our rights and freedoms. Authoritarians who tell their citizens, “To survive, you must surrender your rights and come under my protection,” cannot keep their nations safe anywhere. Nor can they themselves endure!

True security is achieved not through weapons, coercion, tanks, or rifles, but through democracy sustained by a sense of belonging and the consent of the governed. Democracy is society's consent to its own political system.

It means that the state stands not through force, but through law, justice, and collective wisdom. A political order that derives its legitimacy from the people, with fair and inclusive governments, finds the whole society standing beside it in solidarity in times of crisis.

Democracy is not merely a form of government. It is the condition for a political system to be accepted and embraced by society. Democracy, therefore, is directly a question of the regime's legitimacy. Türkiye's democratic tradition is a great gift bestowed upon us by history. To sacrifice democracy in the name of security is a profound failure of judgment. For democracy is the most fundamental condition of legitimacy, and legitimacy is the most fundamental condition of security.

When legitimacy erodes, a regime turns inward. It increases its pressure on everyone who opposes it. To strengthen its authority, it constantly searches for an “enemy within.” We are living through this.

Those who divide society and exhaust its people by turning them against one another seek legitimacy abroad. But that makes neither our borders more secure nor our citizens and our homes stronger. On the contrary, it makes both our country and our society more vulnerable. That is the lesson to draw from both history and geography!

Democracy and the rule of law are not luxuries; they are essential to prosperity and...

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...is also an indispensable condition of security.

Democracy and the rule of law are the guarantees of a strong, independent Türkiye, united in solidarity. Democracy is also a safeguard for peace in our region and throughout the world.

It was precisely to prevent such devastation from ever happening again that, following the destruction caused by the Second World War and by populist and authoritarian regimes, the United Nations, the European Community, and various human rights conventions — to which our country is also a party — were established.

For history taught the entire world a lesson: a pluralistic democratic order, fundamental human rights and freedoms, equality before the law, freedom of the press and expression, and strong, independent institutions are the greatest safeguards of peace, both at home and abroad.

Peace depends, above all, on governments subject to scrutiny, established institutions, collective wisdom, and the freedom of the people and the press to express themselves and, when necessary, to stand against reckless and dangerous actions.

The safeguard of peace is a government that derives its legitimacy from the people. Its greatest enemy, by contrast, is a leader consumed by the ambition to rule as a sovereign, possessing unlimited authority, able to make every decision alone, and ultimately concerned only with personal interests.

Unchecked, unaccountable one-man regimes inevitably lead to chaos. That is why democracy is not an ideal to be remembered only when times are good. It is an indispensable condition of lasting prosperity, security, and peace.

This is precisely what we stand for: to lead Türkiye out of a climate of insecurity governed by arbitrary power and restore a democratic order founded upon the rule of law, institutional continuity, and the will of the nation.

As the world faces an immense test, in an age of wars, crises, and disasters, Türkiye must strengthen its social solidarity and preserve its determination to live together if it is to emerge from this period unharmed. That strength can only be reinforced through a participatory, inclusive, democratic state governed by the rule of law.

To keep our nation safe and make our state resilient against global and regional threats, we must strengthen our democracy and our institutional structures. Leaders and governments may change, but our institutions must remain standing — strong, resilient,

and worthy of public trust.

That is how we protect our nation from threats, wars, crises, and disasters. That is how we strengthen our capabilities in every field, from defense and foreign policy to the economy and domestic security.

All 86 million citizens must feel equal and free under the rule of law and the principles of justice. This is how our national unity will grow stronger, polarization will disappear, and solidarity within our country will become stronger and more unshakable than ever.

This is the vision that will protect our citizens, give them a sense of security, and carry every one of them toward a better future. May God protect our nation from authoritarian minds that say only "I," and that seek to make the state indistinguishable from their own person!

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The 2017 constitutional amendment and the practices that followed it are classic consequences of power going to one's head. Those who forgot that they had been entrusted with public office for a limited period gradually came to regard themselves as the "owners of the country."

At this point, I want to address a matter to which I attach the utmost importance. I ask everyone to listen very carefully.

It is precisely to prevent this destructive intoxication with power that developed democracies have introduced a two-term limit for the head of the executive. In democratic systems, this rule must be strict. It must not be open to negotiation or manipulation!

The two-term limit is one of the most important safeguards of a democratic order. Yet in our country, it has not been enforced! This principle must be applied without exception. Rules must be established to prevent it from being circumvented by indirect means.

Claims that the system has changed and therefore "the term count has been reset" are unacceptable! Claims that elections can be brought forward by a month or two to allow someone to serve a third term are equally unacceptable! None of this can be accepted in a democratic country.

Let me make you an unequivocal promise today: If, with God's permission and the confidence of our nation, we are elected, we will never, under any circumstances, bend the two-term rule by even a single inch or a single day!

We will enshrine this rule in our Constitution in the clearest and strictest possible terms. Our country will never again be held captive by one individual's intoxication with power.

Everyone who comes to power must know that, after a certain period, they will have to "retire" from political office. Anyone who governs knowing that one day they must leave office will hesitate before committing injustice, suppressing the opposition, or engaging in corruption — because they know that one day they will have to surrender their seat of power.

Until we establish this awareness, genuine democracy will never take root in our country. Whoever governs Türkiye must govern with the knowledge that one day their power will come to an end. Never again should anyone regard themselves as the owner of this beautiful country!

We are coming to establish a lasting democratic order. This is not a question of Ekrem İmamoğlu or any particular political party coming to power. We seek to govern with a full understanding of that responsibility. This is our promise.

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In the years following 2017, our nation clearly expressed its desire for a new political alternative to emerge through democratic means and for a change of government to take place as part of the country's natural political development. But those in power resorted to various methods to prevent this process.

They believed that through extensive control over the media, malicious propaganda, and the politics of fear, they could conceal the truth, convince the public, and intimidate our nation into submission.

But what was the result? A deepening economic crisis, growing impoverishment, and widespread social despair.

We can now see that these methods, too, have reached their limits. Our nation has paid the price for the government's stubborn refusal to yield. It has paid through high interest rates. Through high inflation. Through poverty, unhappiness, and despair. And most painfully of all, through the loss of hope for the future.

We will reclaim that future! We will emerge from these courtrooms, break through these walls, and take it back! Let no one doubt it: We will succeed! Let that be entered into the record!

***

My esteemed fellow citizens,

What has brought us into this courtroom? The ambitions of a handful of incompetent people. Nothing more!

The real reason we are here is the outcome of the 2024 local elections! It is the fact that those elections unmistakably revealed Türkiye's desire for change. It is the defeat of the ruling party and the emergence of the Republican People's Party as the country's leading political party. It is the fact that we won in Istanbul despite facing seventeen government ministers. It is the fact that I won an election for the fourth time.

The reason they sought to punish us through raids in the middle of the night is that the nation began to place its hopes in us. That is our crime: showing our people that a democratic change of government is near — very near — and giving them hope! This is what is natural in a democratic republic: the people decide that it is time for change, and the government changes.

I fulfilled my responsibility to that hope. In February 2025, I announced my candidacy for the presidency. I entered the selection process through an entirely democratic method. I received the support of our party members and 15.5 million citizens in the primary election. Subsequently, the number of signatures from citizens demanding freedom for me and all my companions exceeded 25 million.

As a citizen, seeking the presidency is my most legitimate right. It is also a responsibility entrusted to me by my nation. Precisely because they recognized this desire for change, those in power became afraid and resorted to unimaginable measures.

First, they revoked the university diploma I had held for 32 years, in a manner that defied every rule, established procedure, and accepted practice. Just hours after the revocation of my diploma, I was taken into custody alongside dozens of my companions and subsequently imprisoned.

Today, cases have been brought against me on allegations that no one can honestly believe in their conscience. Prison sentences amounting to thousands of years are being sought. We face an extraordinary array of accusations, involving everything from my diploma to an alleged criminal organization, corruption, terrorism, and espionage.

In the same climate of disregard for rules and the law, they even attempted to place the great Republican People's Party under the control of a [puppet] trustee! At the trustee's request, they "seized" the CHP headquarters using tear gas, water-cannon vehicles, and police intervention!

To them, comfortable chairs, concrete buildings, and official positions are what matter. But our home is in the hearts of our nation!

I have bad news for those in power. As I said a moment ago, they have constantly tried to manufacture enemies within society so that not a single seed of hope might take root in the hearts of our citizens.

They failed. They could not turn us into enemies. Despite all the suffering and injustice that my companions and I have endured, the desire for revenge has never darkened our eyes or our consciences. And it never will!

If we begin to resemble those who do wrong and become corrupted ourselves, then we lose — and our nation loses with us.

On the contrary, thank God, we have always been deeply sensitive to injustice. We have always fought against it. But from this day forward, no matter who is subjected to injustice, ...

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...we will take an even stronger stand against injustice than we have in the past.

* * *

My beloved nation,

Every judicial proceeding must be assessed on its own legal and historical merits. Yet one truth remains unchanged: if you try to eliminate someone who holds a place in the people's hearts by abusing public power, it will backfire. As history has shown time and again, when the sense of justice is wounded, society does not forget. When the day comes, the people correct that injustice at the ballot box and deliver their own verdict.

Those who unjustly put their rivals on trial stand condemned in the conscience of society.

Those who wield power are temporary; the will of the people endures. The law must safeguard political competition. But when the law is politicized, turning points arise that ultimately lead to the renewal and strengthening of democracy.

* * *

I want all 86 million of our people to hear this:

Let our journalist friends, our lawyers, my companions standing trial alongside me, the families and friends who have come to observe these proceedings, and all our people be reassured.

After five months of proceedings, neither my hope nor that of my companions or our 86 million citizens has diminished. On the contrary, it has grown many times over!

We have not weakened, grown tired, or cowered. Quite the opposite: our determination has deepened, our energy has increased, and our resolve to struggle has grown. Today, in every respect, we are stronger than yesterday!

* * *

After listening to our companions for nearly five months, everyone's hope has multiplied!

When investigations were launched, operations came in successive waves, hundreds were detained and arrested, and a so-called indictment running to thousands of pages — a catalogue of slander — appeared, people who did not know us well may understandably have had questions.

But these five months, these hearings, have shown all 86 million people just how empty that supposed indictment is: nothing but an enormous lie, a malicious and amateurish script.

At the beginning, everyone must have wondered: “Could it really be possible? How could anyone tell so many lies, make so many baseless allegations, spread so much slander?” What we have experienced over these five months has shown that such wrongdoing really is possible.

Everyone saw how amateurishly, maliciously, ignorantly, and to order this so-called indictment was written. All 86 million saw it. The entire world saw it!

We also came to understand more clearly just how little knowledge and competence those seeking to bring our country under the control of a handful of people truly possess. We listened as every line of the indictment was torn to pieces. We came to understand once again, with horror, the inconceivable, absurd, fabricated pretexts on which innocent people have been kept in prison for months. We saw still more clearly the cruelty and torment inflicted upon their families.

My beloved nation,

After four months, consciences were aching!

Everyone now knows very well that this indictment is a frame-up, one that will go down in history as a great stain on our judiciary.

Our hope is greater than ever. Türkiye will certainly free itself from this burden! There will be prosperity, equality, justice, freedom, and unity and solidarity — not poverty, unhappiness, polarization, and captivity. Love will overcome hatred.

We all know, and you know very well, that the current government has reached the end of its time and is trying to play on into extra time. Our nation wants change, while those in power are trying to cling to their seats through every kind of trickery and pressure. But the time has finally come.

When the time for change arrives, no conspiracy, no so-called trial, no repression can stop it! And in today's world this change has become even more vital, because, as I said earlier, democracy is retreating in some places.

Yet in many countries around us, the winds are blowing in favor of democrats! Now it is our turn; we are almost there. Faced with crises sweeping the world, societies that unite strongly without leaving anyone behind will set an example for the world. We will be that example!

In all our differences — in faith, ethnic origin, and identity — we will stand together with our nation as one, as equals, as free individuals under our flag bearing the crescent and star! Under the roof of our secular, democratic state founded on the rule of law, we will live with happiness, hope, and security! We will uphold the vision of our Republic and carry it, strengthened, into its second century.

With this national consciousness, we will develop and prosper. We will enhance our country's standing and become a source of hope for our region and the world!

Nations that have secured social peace, that rest upon the equality and freedom of citizens, that have established justice and live in peace, build strong foundations through strategies that foster development and production, embrace the latest technological advances, and ensure a fair distribution of income. These foundations enable nations to rise to the highest ranks in every field. We have done it before, and we will do it again. Let no one doubt that.

The founding principles established by the Republic of Türkiye 103 years ago brought about a tremendous leap that placed us among the world's respected states. What made this possible was the principle: “Sovereignty belongs unconditionally to the nation.”

Mustafa Kemal Atatürk's leadership, which vested sovereignty in the nation; his ideal of individuals “free in thought, free in conscience, free in knowledge”; his use of reason and science as guiding lights for his people; and his maxim “Peace at home, peace in the world” have ensured that Türkiye has always been a guiding star in our region.

Thanks to the solid foundations and vision of our Republic, despite everything, we once again offer the promise of the twenty-first century's strongest democracy to our neighboring lands — to the Middle East, Persia, the Caucasus, the Balkans, and North Africa. We will inspire our region. Indeed, we must.

The Republic of Türkiye will continue to stand firm, sustained by more than two centuries of struggle for democracy and freedom, more than a century of constitutional history, eight decades of multiparty political life, and the strong foundations of its state.

As I explained in greater detail earlier, it is authoritarian leaders who are doing the greatest harm to the world today. The world is in the grip of the savage imperialist ambitions of those who would not hesitate to throw nations into the flames for their own political interests and boundless ambitions. The order built upon institutions, rules, and values is in danger of collapse. The lawless struggles for power and the oppression taking place in Gaza, Ukraine, Iran, and Venezuela are consequences of this.

Authoritarian leaders who say “I am the state” create the greatest uncertainty and the greatest danger, both for their countries and for the world. Because no one can predict

what they might do tomorrow to protect their personal interests and remain in office.

* * *

This courtroom, where we have spent so many months, has now become an arena for the people's struggle.

Here, my companions and I represent millions of citizens who live by the ideals of the Republic and democracy, and we resist on their behalf. They, in turn, support us from outside.

The conscience of our nation will deliver the final verdict. The conscience of our nation will unravel these conspiracies.

For months you have listened to my friends. With their knowledge, insight, experience, and, most importantly, documents and concrete facts, they have shredded this so-called indictment — this catalogue of slander — to pieces! Against “hearsay” and slander, we responded with documents. The supposed indictment has taken its place in history as a document of shame. Day after day, my companions have proven again and again that the indictment is nothing more than a crude instrument of a coup.

Today, I too am putting this coup on trial. And it will not end here: the conscience of the nation and history itself will pass judgment on these days.

After the account my companions have given of our approach to government, and their careful, point-by-point technical defenses, there is scarcely anything I need to add. I fully agree with and confirm what they have said. I will put this case, and the handful of people responsible for what they have done to our beautiful country, on trial here!

Let me say at the outset what I might otherwise have saved for the end: the Republic and democracy will prevail here!

They are so afraid that they are trying to break in the corridors of the courthouse the strength they could not overcome at the ballot box. But they will fail! Here, it is the will of the nation, not the will of one man, that will prevail. Here, freedom and hope will triumph. Change will emerge from this place! When its time comes, no power can prevent change! For no court, no so-called courtroom, no so-called trial can stand in the way of the change demanded by millions!

In this courtroom, a struggle is being waged for the rebirth of justice. Very soon, at the very next election, the nation will deliver its verdict, and a government of the people will be formed!

From here, I declare once more: the nation always has the final word! The nation always wins!

CHAPTER TWO

The Judicial Assault Orchestrated by Erdoğan's Will and a Politician Disguised as Chief Prosecutor

English translation | Original printed pages 55–58

The reason for everything we are experiencing today is very simple: the intoxication of power, the obsession with never relinquishing office, and the fear of losing a system of vested interests built by a handful of individuals...

Let me explain.

Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, who is now fighting desperately to remain in office, has governed this country for a full 24 years! And throughout that time, he has ruled single-handedly, wielding absolute authority.

When the powers he exercised exceeded constitutional limits, the Constitution was amended. A constitution was written to suit one individual.

Whenever his own political companions were in a position to restrain his authority, he discarded them without hesitation. He always had the final word.

Over the past eight years in particular, he has done whatever he pleased through decrees issued as though he were an absolute monarch issuing imperial edicts.

Yet even all that power was never enough for him. Because he is profoundly intoxicated by power. He has forgotten that his true duty is to earn the consent of the nation. He has forgotten that the people are the ones in charge.

Erdoğan realized that his vision and his record in office could no longer win back the hearts of the people. Worse still, the nation had lost hope in the AKP and could no longer see a future with Erdoğan.

It was then that he began searching for a way never to surrender power — preserving his networks of vested interests, damaging the very fabric of the Republic, trampling upon the will of the nation, and forgetting that he, too, is mortal.

He abandoned all restraint. He even dared to determine who would govern this country after him.

Rather than compete against me under democratic conditions, he was prepared to launch a ruthless operation through a politician masquerading as a chief prosecutor — and to put democracy on the shelf.

But there was one problem. What legal professional would agree to carry out an operation so flagrantly unlawful, a coup of this kind?

They had already found the person willing to do it. They had recognized his particular "talent" and promoted him at lightning speed.

Several years earlier, they had singled out a judge who would sign, without the slightest hesitation, every unlawful judicial decision the government demanded — even disregarding Constitutional Court rulings — and who handed down the harshest punishments against government opponents.

The more he trampled upon the law, the faster he would rise. He had become an instrument of those in power.

He was already signing politically motivated judicial decisions. Before long, he became a politician in every sense of the word.

On June 1, 2022, he was appointed Deputy Minister.

Later, on October 2, 2024, this politician was assigned to Istanbul as Chief Public Prosecutor to carry out the March 19 coup.

And just three months after the coup had been carried out and the indictment — that catalogue of slander — had been written in November 2025, he received the reward he had been promised.

On February 11, 2026, he returned to Ankara as Minister of Justice!

In short, a politician was sent to Istanbul for a single assignment lasting approximately one year. Once his mission was complete, he received his reward and returned to politics with a promotion.

Nothing more needs to be said to demonstrate the political nature of this indictment and this trial.

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My dear fellow citizens,

Do not misunderstand my intention. The legal professions carry a sacred responsibility.

A prosecutor is a prosecutor of the Republic. A judge dispenses justice.

Those who politicize these professions turn Türkiye's esteemed judiciary into an "instrument" of political power. They undermine the dignity of these professions and the position you must hold above politics.

And now the very person who has become a symbol of this transformation of the judiciary into a political instrument stands at the head of the justice system!

His task is to use the judiciary, under Erdoğan's orders, to eliminate the opposition — one of the fundamental pillars of democracy.

We have said this many times, but let it once again be placed on the record here today:

We are not uncovering some hidden agenda. This "indictment of slander" says it openly.

It portrays the Republican People's Party, which is on its way to power, as a criminal organization.

It describes the CHP's 38th Party Congress, over which I presided, as an activity of a criminal organization.

Why? Because that Congress expressed the will for change. And the nation heard us, placed its trust in us, and made us Türkiye's leading political party in the 2024 elections.

That was our real "great crime"!

And to punish that "great crime," they shamelessly attempted to portray a politician who had won the confidence of Istanbul's voters three times as the leader of a criminal organization!

Because they had become blinded by ambition.

But even that was not enough. After the March 19 coup, they carried out another coup on May 21!

As I explained in the previous chapter, on May 21 they used the judiciary to strike directly at the CHP — Türkiye's founding party, currently its leading political party, and also its main opposition party.

They installed a puppet trustee at the head of the CHP!

The perpetrators of the September 12 coup had dared to shut down the CHP. Now this government is attempting to shut it down in practice.

They could not defeat us. They knew they would not defeat us. And they knew they would have to leave office.

That is why they began searching for ways to keep the ballot box out of the people's reach.

The indictment states:

"The objective of the İmamoğlu Criminal Organization for Personal Gain is first to seize control of the CHP and then, through a presidential candidacy, to seize control of Türkiye."

Of course, they could not openly accuse the presidential candidate of the Republic's founding party and his companions of "engaging in politics."

They could not go so far as to classify political activity itself as a crime, as their allegations effectively suggest.

That would have made them look even more ridiculous than they already do.

So they resorted to the simplest, shallowest tactic imaginable.

They exploited our nation's deep sensitivity to corruption, built up over decades of frustration with the corruption of those in power, and accused us of "corruption."

In truth, these inept imitators copied an example from abroad almost word for word.

They did exactly what certain prosecutors and judges in Latin America did to Lula!

They cannot even come up with an original slander.

My lawyer, Mehmet Pehlivan, has explained this matter in detail both in this courtroom and in his book. [2]

In 2017, Brazil's former president, Lula da Silva, was convicted on "corruption" charges and spent 580 days in prison.

Because of his imprisonment, he was unable to stand for election in 2018, and Bolsonaro was elected president in his absence.

At that time, Lula and his companions were also likened to an "octopus"!

And there, too, the judge who convicted Lula, Sergio Moro, was subsequently appointed Minister of Justice!

The entire operation against us was carried out by the same copy-and-paste method.

Ultimately, in 2021, Brazil's Supreme Federal Court overturned Lula's conviction and ruled that Sergio Moro had been biased.

Lula ran again in the 2022 elections and was once more elected president.

The process intended to drive him out of politics ultimately returned him to office through the people's choice.

Have no doubt: the same will happen in Türkiye!

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Let me repeat:

We are confronting an extraordinarily malicious mentality that seeks to define a democratic process as a crime.

By that logic, did Erdoğan first try to seize control of the Virtue Party?

And when he failed, did he establish the AKP in order to seize control of Türkiye?

Did he commit a crime by winning elections?

According to the indictment, my ultimate purpose in "seizing control of the country" is to become wealthy!

People judge others by what they themselves would do.

Or did Erdoğan enter politics for the purpose of enriching himself?

What kind of distorted perspective is this?

What kind of hostility toward democracy is this?

If this is not an insult to the intelligence of the people and a denial of their will, then what is?

It is the distorted outlook of those who have already accepted that they can no longer win the nation's consent — those who see that they will lose to their political opponent and are losing sleep over it.

It is the outlook of autocrats seen repeatedly throughout history, who have each time faced the wrath of the people in their own countries.

It is a fascistic mentality obsessed with remaining in power at any cost.

What we are experiencing is the abuse of state institutions and the judiciary for personal political interests by a government that no longer has the people behind it.

We have the nation behind us.

We have the votes of 15.5 million citizens and the signatures of 25 million.

We have the millions who follow our Party Chairman, Özgür Özel, as he walks through the cities, towns, and villages of our country every day.

That is why this case is not between the prosecutor and me.

This case is between Erdoğan and the nation.

Erdoğan is not trying to punish me.

He is trying to punish the nation that he can no longer see standing beside him or behind him.

He wants to gain and retain power without having to ask the people.

Political competition is measured by public support.

Whoever has the people behind them holds the advantage in political competition.

Erdoğan is trying to secure that advantage through his control of state institutions.

But control of the state can produce only temporary and illegitimate power.

The support of the nation is the only genuine source of political strength.

And the nation is now with us.

Everything we are witnessing is the desperate final struggle of a government whose time has expired.

The people are patiently waiting for the ballot box.

The patience of the nation will bury the oppressor at the ballot box!

[2] Mehmet Pehlivan, Yargı Silahı (Lawfare), Kırmızı Kedi Publishing House, Istanbul, 2nd edition, April 2026.

CHAPTER TWO — CONTINUED

They will be gone at the very first election. You will see!

Now let us turn to the prosecutors' concerns that I intend to "take over Türkiye." I am not trying to "take over" Türkiye. But yes, we do aspire to govern Türkiye!

They must have confused us with someone else. Unlike those currently in power, we have never treated any office to which we were elected as though it were an inheritance from our fathers.

We can see that we are capable of governing Türkiye better. We know that we can provide solutions to our people's problems. We maintain that we can govern far more effectively, efficiently, and rationally than the current government. We achieved this in Istanbul! Thanks in large part to the tremendous efforts of my companions, the Istanbul Model succeeded. This court is a witness to that. For weeks, this courtroom has become a stage on which our approach to government has been demonstrated.

I thank my colleagues! They did more than tear the indictment to pieces: they proved to everyone just how capable and qualified the teams governing Istanbul are!

We succeeded in Istanbul, and we will succeed across Türkiye. That is why I became a presidential candidate.

Some 15.5 million people who believe in that ambition supported my candidacy with their votes, and 25 million with their signatures. That is precisely why the government is trying to push us out of the contest through the judiciary.

In any case, who could possibly "take over" a country as great as Türkiye? Are we an enemy force? Do we have tanks and artillery? Does the nation casting its votes lack the judgment to make its own decisions?

I am Ekrem, a son of the Black Sea, born in a village of forty households in Akçaabat, Trabzon. I studied, worked hard, struggled and persevered, always striving to be of service to this country. I have lived my life believing in the Republic founded by Atatürk and its promise of equal opportunity.

Seventeen years ago, in 2009, I entered politics as a district chairman in the Republican People's Party, Atatürk's legacy. In 2014, I defeated the AKP candidate and was elected Mayor of Beylikdüzü. Please pay attention to this: I was elected. I did not "take over" anything!

My colleagues and I worked extremely hard. We made Beylikdüzü shine like a star.

You know what the indictment says: that I supposedly established the organization in Beylikdüzü, and that its aim was first to "take over" Istanbul and then Türkiye.

Leaving aside the fact that this scenario was written by a government mindset intent on making people forget what democracy means, I did not even intend to run for Mayor of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality that year.

The proposal came from my party's then chairman and Istanbul provincial chairman, following our consultations and meetings. I had reservations, but not because I thought I could not win. I regarded serving my fellow residents and neighbors in Beylikdüzü for another term as my duty.

Nevertheless, I accepted my party's offer to stand as its candidate for Mayor of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality. Then I worked tirelessly, without a moment's hesitation. Our entire party organization worked hard and believed in what we were doing. The people of Istanbul believed in me and mobilized to help me win. I loved my people dearly, and they loved me in return.

Together with my companions, we did everything we could, and, by God's grace, we won three consecutive elections in 2019 and 2024. I hardly need to explain that those victories, and Erdoğan's successive defeats, are the real reason we are here.

Let us remember: by 2019, Erdoğan and his party had governed Istanbul continuously for twenty-five years! Twenty-five years—a quarter of a century. Easy to say, but think what it means.

What does Erdoğan always say? "Whoever wins Istanbul wins Türkiye!" We are here today because Erdoğan believed those words—and was frightened by them! Istanbul is a "miniature model of Türkiye." That is why Erdoğan's remark has become a significant observation borne out by the experience of Turkish political life.

For the first time in twenty-five years, Erdoğan deployed all the resources of the state and mobilized the media, yet lost Istanbul. He lost, but he could never accept it. He chose to forget that democracy means picking up your coat and leaving when you are defeated.

On the night of March 31, 2019, Erdoğan could neither accept losing Istanbul nor ignore the prospect that the next step would be losing Türkiye. That is why, from that day onward, I have been fighting an unprecedented "judicial assault" in our history!

Detention pending trial is a precautionary measure. True. And we, too, are being held in what is called pretrial detention. But not as the law describes it—as a measure to prevent the destruction of evidence or flight. We are behind bars as a precaution against our winning the next election!

As I said, the unprecedented judicial assault against me began with the race for mayor of Istanbul. Consider this: until I became a candidate for Istanbul, not a single case had been brought against me. ZERO cases!

So what does this "indictment of slander" claim? That I supposedly founded a "criminal organization" during my term as Mayor of Beylikdüzü. If that is so, why was there not a single investigation or prosecution concerning that period at the time?

Only one case was ever brought concerning my term as Mayor of Beylikdüzü, and that was not filed until January 2023! Four years after I won the Istanbul mayoralty. Yet that absurd case—in which I was acquitted—concerned an administrative act dating back to 2015! In other words, the case was brought eight years after the act in question.

Why? Because by then I had become a threat. I had won Istanbul. In short, the judicial harassment began because I won Istanbul.

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In fact, everything happened before everyone's eyes. He revealed his intentions on the very first day we won Istanbul, on the evening of March 31, 2019. First he tried to keep the election result from the nation; then, when he realized he had lost, he refused to play fair.

That night, Anadolu Agency fired the first shot in an assault on democracy when it cut off its election-data feed, citing an alleged "hack" that would later be disproved by a court ruling. My opponent tried to snatch away an election he had not won and present everyone with a fait accompli.

In a moment of complete irrationality, they plastered "We Won" across Istanbul. Remember the billboards my opponent Binali Yıldırım had put up everywhere proclaiming "We Won"! But the truth that emerged from the ballot boxes did not change.

Together with the people of Istanbul, we protected the ballot boxes, asserted our rights, and ultimately prevailed. We had won, yet they could barely bring themselves to hand over the certificate of election that was rightfully mine. For seventeen days they tried to decide what to do. It was only after immense public pressure that I received my certificate.

At the time, this government was even going to bring a case against me for signing the Anıtkabir memorial register on April 2, 2019. Just imagine: because I had signed the memorial register as Mayor of Istanbul...

And almost as soon as they had handed me my certificate, they took it back. May 6, 2019, was the first political coup carried out by this government!

They invoked FETÖ, they invoked gangs, and without a trace of shame declared the ballot-box committee chairs appointed by the Supreme Election Council to be criminals. They claimed votes had been "stolen." They brought the Supreme Election Council into play and had it declare three of the four votes placed in the same envelope valid, but one invalid!

As you may remember, back then—just as today—they spoke of a mysterious "organization," a criminal gang. Such a remarkable organization it was that, of the four votes placed in the same envelope, it had supposedly committed fraud with only one!

For example, this mysterious organization had not interfered with votes for the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipal Council (the AKP had won a majority on the Council), only with votes for Mayor of Istanbul! What an organization, utterly lacking in vision.

Back then, too—just as today—they said, "Even if nothing happened, something definitely happened." Today they say the same thing: even without a single concrete document or piece of evidence, "something must have happened"! Because they judge everyone by themselves and assume everyone acts as they do...

Once again during Ramadan, at the iftar table, they stole the will of the people and violated the rights of others before God. They destroyed the country's reputation.

I repeat: the person who had that election annulled was Recep Tayyip Erdoğan himself!

On the evening of May 6, the day the Supreme Election Council unjustly annulled the election, I issued a challenge: "I will not violate anyone's rights, but I will not let anyone violate mine!"

Had we bowed our heads that day, had we been frightened, had we backed down, democracy would have died then and there. But we did not bow our heads, we did not succumb to fear, and we did not back down. We rolled up our sleeves for democracy. And what did we say that day?

"Our road is long! Our excitement is boundless! We have our youth! We are the youth of Türkiye, thirsting for justice and unwavering in our faith in democracy!"

We boldly declared that we would fight even harder!

Since that day, our determination to struggle has never diminished. On the contrary, it is stronger today than ever! Because our country has moved even closer to the edge of the precipice, and our responsibility is greater still.

Back then, the government once again used the slander of a "criminal organization" to justify annulling the election. But no such organization was ever found! The ballot-box committee members and chairs accused at the time were acquitted, one after another.

They knew perfectly well there was no "gang" or "organization." But because they lacked even the slightest respect for democratic norms, they tried to make Türkiye believe their fabricated story. Simply to cling to office, they did not hesitate to cast suspicion on wholly innocent people.

CHAPTER TWO — CONTINUED

This government has no fear of slander! Yet is slander not one of the gravest sins in our religion and our ancient culture? And in a state governed by the rule of law, it is a crime.

They openly used the law for political ends. They continued to do so afterward, and they are still doing so today.

What happened then is no different from what is happening now. Back then, they spoke of a “gang” and an “organization”; they say the same today! There was no organization then, and there is none today! Back then, they cried, “They stole it”; today they make the same accusation! They spread slander then, and they spread slander now! A government of slanderers!

On that occasion, the nation refused to let injustice prevail. On June 23, speaking through me, the people told those in power: “I decide who gets elected. You stay out of it.” Yet the government neither understood nor heeded that message. I had won the March 31 election by a margin of 13,600 votes. On June 23, I won by a margin of 806,000!

That only made their inability to accept defeat even worse.

Throughout my time as Mayor of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, they put every kind of obstacle in my way. They thought I would lose heart, that I would give up. I did neither. And I never will!

The more they saw this, the more reckless they became. Despite all their attempts to obstruct us, even at the cost of punishing Istanbul's residents, we served the city with even greater determination. When roads were blocked, we found other routes. When there was no other way, we made one ourselves.

Our victory in 2024, by a margin of 1.1 million votes, is proof of that.

We worked without pause so that the nation's extraordinary support would not be wasted. When they realized they could not overcome us, they turned to the judiciary for purely political ambitions, even at the risk of shaking the foundations of the state. The judicial assaults continued, growing ever more intense.

Look at the facts: after I won the mayoralty of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, this government brought no fewer than fifteen criminal cases against me! [3] In addition, the separate investigation involving terrorism allegations, which led to my detention on March 19, is still ongoing. Understand this: all these investigations and cases are, in essence, one and the same case. Taken together, they constitute the “İmamoğlu Case.”

It would take days to list and explain every one of them. I will give just a few examples.

* * *

First, they attempted to force me out of politics with what may be the most absurd case in the world: the “Fool Case”!

Because I threw the word “fool” back at the then Minister of the Interior, Süleyman Soylu, who had used it against me, they took the matter to court as though I had directed the insult at the Supreme Election Council. That case is still ongoing.

Do you know why? Because they wanted to defeat me by a shortcut, to achieve through the courts what they could not accomplish in politics. They pushed and pushed until they secured a political ban in that case. I was sentenced to two years and seven months in prison simply for returning the word “fool” to the person who had used it against me! For such a word, this was a sentence without precedent in our judicial history.

And they could obtain that ruling only by changing the judge! When a conscientious judge refused to sanction such lawlessness, they replaced him and sent that judge to Samsun.

Despite complaints lodged with the Council of Judges and Prosecutors, they neither heard that conscientious judge nor investigated what had happened.

The case then sat before the regional appellate court for years. Evidently, the judicial panel could not bring itself to approve a decision so plainly unlawful. So what did they do? They transferred the presiding judge of the regional court and another panel member elsewhere. They then secured approval of that unlawful decision. The case is now before the Court of Cassation.

I believe this lawlessness will come to an end at the Court of Cassation. I believe our judges in the highest court will say, “Enough is enough. If you have a grievance against this man, settle it at the ballot box.” They will put an end to this arbitrariness and remind everyone that there are still judges in Ankara!

* * *

At that time, they were waiting for any opportunity to keep me tied up in the courthouse. They brought cases that should never have existed.

A dispute I had with a partisan governor was taken to court on instructions.

As I mentioned earlier, they manufactured a case in Beylikdüzü alleging bid-rigging, solely so they could exploit it during elections. They tried to prevent a verdict. For months, the prosecutor did not submit a final opinion, because there was nothing to say and no crime had been committed. They drove the trial judge to exasperation. In the end, however, they could not prevent my acquittal. And here, too, the judge who acquitted me was immediately transferred to Kahramanmaraş!

They had become so obsessed that they even went so far as to claim hundreds of terrorists had been hired by the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality. Of course, nothing came of that allegation either.

Another enormous allegation proved entirely baseless and unsupported. Once again, a grand accusation turned out to be nothing but slander.

The then Minister of the Interior later admitted in court that he had made the allegation about hundreds of terrorists working at the municipality “politically.”

Make careful note of that. We have seen time and again that, for this government, anything goes! To them, spreading slander is simply “doing politics.”

When they achieved nothing with all this, a succession of lawsuits began. The government of slander and fabricated plots continued its campaign against an Ekrem İmamoğlu it could not defeat.

I criticized the fact that, although Istanbul had thousands of expert witnesses, the same name appeared beneath every report against us. It was mathematically impossible for every file concerning CHP municipalities, and every file concerning me, to end up before the same court-appointed expert, Satılmış Büyükcanayakın! The mathematical probability was, quite literally, “zero.”

I criticized a situation that cast doubt on judicial independence and public confidence in the judiciary. They rushed to court. The prosecution is seeking a prison sentence of up to seven years for that criticism!

I was speaking at a conference on justice. I said, “We will bring justice to this country so that the chief prosecutor's children will not have to experience the lawlessness committed by their father.” They turned that into a threat!

The court of first instance sentenced me to one year and eight months in prison. The courageous judge who disagreed with the sentence and wrote a dissenting opinion was immediately transferred to a labor court!

When I appeared before the judge handling my detention request during the March 19 process, I criticized prosecutors without even naming them. They managed to turn that into yet another prosecution. I was accused of insulting two prosecutors who had prepared the case. One of those prosecutors threatened one of our companions here, a mother, that he would take her children away. What should one call such a prosecutor? Apparently he can do anything under the title of prosecutor, yet he must be immune from criticism, free to keep ruining more lives. From here, I again request that a criminal complaint be filed against that prosecutor.

Did the government stop there? As you can see from the fact that we are here today, it did not.

They failed to understand that political tricks would get them nowhere; that politics must be conducted honorably; and that otherwise they would be remembered with condemnation on the dustiest shelves of history.

I will explain in greater detail later the pressures exerted on the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality throughout this period, the obstacles placed in its way, and the countless

investigations launched against it.

* * *

Not even the resounding slap delivered by the nation on March 31, 2024, could stop them. We won by 1.1 million votes. Istanbul's people told us, “Keep serving, keep delivering, keep moving forward.” That only heightened their fear and drove them into a panic. On one hand, they invoked social security debts and taxes, cutting off municipal resources through measures they had never imposed on any AKP municipality. On the other, they stealthily escalated their unlawful actions in an effort to separate me from the people.

Incompetent rulers who know what awaits them in a fair contest try to stop their rivals by tripping them up and dragging them down. But that was not enough for them. They realized we would find a way around these maneuvers too, and continue serving the people.

* * *

Their panic deepened. When they saw that nothing was working, they decided to press every button at once. They planned the March 19 coup.

I said it at the very beginning, and I say it openly again from here: March 19 was a coup! A coup against Türkiye's democracy. A coup against Türkiye's state and its democratic order. A coup against the ballot box in Türkiye. A coup against the will of the electorate. A coup against the rights, the law, and the lives of all 86 million people living in Türkiye — workers, retirees, public servants, tradespeople, and businesspeople alike.

I declare from here: this coup was planned in the Palace. It was planned on the evening they lost the March 31, 2024 election.

Every move made and every step taken after that date, and the gang-like system within the judiciary, were devised and implemented by those in power.

To carry out the coup, they appointed to Istanbul, under the title of Chief Public Prosecutor, a politician — a Deputy Minister — a man whose name was already deeply controversial, someone who would carry out Erdoğan's every command to the letter, instantly and without question.

I would also like to remind you that our Republican People's Party...

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Our Party Chairman, Mr. Özgür Özel, acting as a responsible politician, gave the government an opportunity after the March 31 elections to strengthen the democratic foundations of politics once again. What the government called a period of “normalization” was, to us, an invitation to return to the norms of democratic politics. We accepted that responsibility. Unfortunately, while we were doing so, those on the other side were apparently preparing this conspiracy against us, in defiance of the people's will. It turns out that, during that period, we were dealing with “Erdoğan behind a mask”...

Gürlek left his position as deputy minister in Ankara and took up his duties in Istanbul in October 2024 with precisely that mission. His sole preoccupation was Ekrem İmamoğlu and the colleagues whose only ambition was to serve this city.

We all saw what happened. Once the politician serving as “chief prosecutor” completed his assignment and submitted his indictment, he received his reward: he returned to political office with a promotion and was appointed Minister of Justice.

Even if I spoke for a hundred hours to explain that this case is political, I could not make the point more clearly than that appointment does!

Everything is out in the open. For the handful of power-hungry individuals clinging to the lawless system of vested interests they have established, the success of this operation is their last chance. This court is their last chance.

I believe you can see the position in which they have placed you. Honorable Members of the Court, I ask you to bear this in mind when rendering your decision. Every attempt made by the government had failed. Despite all the obstacles they placed in our way, they lost the latest election by a margin of 1.1 million votes. They had understood that, unless they could stop us through the judiciary, they would lose power.

MY PRESIDENTIAL CANDIDACY

Let me remind you once again: I announced my presidential candidacy on February 21, 2025. My party had decided to hold a democratic primary on March 23 — a first in Türkiye's history.

Time was running out, and panic within the government was at its peak.

Summoning people who knew me to the prosecutor's office without lawyers present; collecting slanderous statements from fabricated secret witnesses; gathering false accusations from people embittered because the lucrative flow of municipal money they had enjoyed under the AKP had dried up — all of this reflected that panic. It was all part of the effort to squeeze the coup into that narrow timetable.

During my tenure as mayor of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, I underwent approximately 1,600 audits, inspections, and investigations! I will explain them all shortly.

Inspectors examined the documents in minute detail. Auditors from the Court of Accounts, MASAK, civil administrative inspectors, every state oversight body, and the Municipal Council's

Audit Commission — then controlled by an AKP majority — left no stone unturned. Inspectors virtually camped out at the municipality for months. Thank God, they found not a single irregularity. Thank God, they found not a single instance of loss to the public purse!

But the prosecutor did not need evidence. Indeed, he had found none and had no confidence in his own investigation. So they tried the shortest route — and in doing so, they exposed themselves.

With their own hands, they revealed that every attack was designed to prevent me from becoming a presidential candidate. They betrayed the fear driving all of this: “If this man runs against us, he will win, and we will lose our positions.” They went after the diploma I had earned through my own efforts 32 years earlier!

Their fear was such that, when they decided to detain me, they did not want to leave anything to chance. What if the trials dragged on? What if no political ban was imposed and an election took place in the meantime? They took precautions. On the evening of March 18, they annulled, overnight, the diploma I had earned 32 years earlier. Once again, during Ramadan, just before the breaking of the fast, they did not hesitate to violate another person's rights.

Let me add this: those who signed that decision, those who annulled my diploma under pressure from Akın Gürlek, had only one concern: office, status, and personal gain!

The man afraid of his rival wanted to prevent me from becoming a presidential candidate. To qualify as a candidate, I needed to have “completed higher education” (Article 101 of the Constitution). They followed the simplest line of reasoning and put into effect an ugly scheme, dreamed up by some would-be clever operator, to deprive me of my rightful due.

That is why the prosecutor's office, entrusted with pushing me out of politics, made my diploma its business. Letters were sent to Cyprus and to the Council of Higher Education (YÖK). When nothing came of those efforts, the party-state apparatus was brought into play, and institutions were pressured until the desired result was obtained.

Overwhelmed by that pressure, the dean of the Faculty of Business Administration — the faculty that issued my diploma and the only authority competent to revoke it — was forced to resign. In an official response to a complaint submitted through CİMER in 2020, the dean's office had confirmed that my diploma was valid and lawful.

That is precisely why they could not obtain the outcome they wanted from the faculty administration, which had the authority both to issue and to revoke the diploma. The prosecutor's office then wrote to the university rectorate in a panic: “Hurry. He may present this diploma to an official institution — the Supreme Election Council, for example. Revoke it at once.” [4] That is what they said...

In our country, the one circumstance in which a higher education diploma is required is a presidential candidacy! In their panic, therefore, the prosecutors did not even feel the need to conceal their objective. They placed the university administration under pressure, virtually threatening it through a letter to Istanbul University demanding an “urgent” response. With political assistance, the prosecutor's office thus secured the annulment of my diploma through the rectorate.

The diplomas of 28 other people were also annulled alongside mine. But do you know what happened next? Of those 29 people, only one — me — faced a criminal prosecution. Can there be a law tailored to one individual? There was. Could the entire machinery of the state trample the law in order to target one individual? It did.

And what was the allegation in the resulting case? “Forgery of documents”! Yet there was no forged document. Even the rectorate of Istanbul University acknowledged as much in court!

The whole world knows and sees what happened.

Did I enroll at a university in Cyprus officially established by a decision of the Council of Ministers of the Turkish Republic of Northern Cyprus, with the approval of the late Rauf Denktaş? I did. Did Istanbul University, one of our oldest state institutions, establish its regulations for student transfers in accordance with the law and publish announcements in newspapers? It did. Did I meet those conditions? I did. Were all the documents obtained through official channels delivered to Istanbul University? They were. Did I submit every required document accurately and in full with my application? I did. Was any document I submitted forged, misleading, or incomplete? No. In fact, no one is even making such an allegation!

Did Istanbul University's Faculty of Business Administration examine my documents and approve my transfer? It did. Did I then study for years at Istanbul University, work hard, and pass all my courses and examinations? Did I graduate honorably with an average grade of 60? I did. Did Istanbul University issue me a fully valid and lawful diploma in 1994? It did. And when the Faculty of Business Administration dean's office was asked in 2020 whether my transfer had been valid, did it say there was no problem and that the transfer was lawful? It did.

So where is the forgery? Which document is forged? What exactly did I do wrong? Neither the prosecutor's office, nor Istanbul University, nor YÖK has been able to identify any such act. Indeed, I can still hear the words spoken by Istanbul University's lawyer at the hearing before Istanbul's Fifth Administrative Court: “We are not, in fact, alleging any direct act on the part of the claimant [Ekrem İmamoğlu].” In short, even Istanbul University accepts that I committed no wrongful act.

Then how can my diploma be annulled?

I applied for a transfer because I trusted my state — Istanbul University is a state institution. Would the state lay a trap for a 19-year-old Ekrem? Why, then, was my 32-year-old diploma annulled? All 86 million citizens know the answer perfectly well: Erdoğan had my diploma revoked to eliminate the rival he feared from the race.

The forgery case continues without anyone identifying which document was supposedly forged or where any forgery occurred. The proceedings are being deliberately prolonged. But the case will end eventually. Then we shall see whether this was truly forgery — or political intolerance of defeat.

Naturally, neither this case nor the case we brought before the administrative court was left to proceed undisturbed. A few days before the crucial hearing on December 8, the judge in the criminal case was voluntarily transferred to Kahramanmaraş—

[4] See Table 2.

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...what was about to happen to us: indeed, a few weeks later, the decision rejecting our appeal arrived, signed, of course, by the new president of the court.

Our case and appeal were dismissed. But anyone who can read and write—one need not even be a judge—can see the plain truth here. I will win back my diploma, whatever it takes, and I will be acquitted in the criminal case brought against me.

The annulment of my diploma and the judicial proceedings that followed will go down in history as one of the greatest violations of the law Türkiye has ever witnessed.

I have spoken at some length, but one point must be clearly understood: the annulment of my diploma was one of the two principal, coordinated pillars of the March 19 coup.

* * *

During this process, the prosecutors completely lost all sense of restraint. As though the cases they had already brought were not enough, more followed. They tried to turn me, my valued companion Necati Özkan, and journalist Merdan Yanardağ into “spies”!

The government, with its campaign of slander, reached new heights of absurdity. Meanwhile, it seized TELE1, one of the few broadcasters still offering critical coverage, taking censorship to new extremes. At the end of April, before Merdan Yanardağ had even appeared in court, let alone been convicted, they hastily began proceedings to sell TELE1, the product of his years of hard work! Such brazen trampling of people's rights is unprecedented.

What investor would put money into a country where the fruits of years of labor and investment can be confiscated overnight on the strength of absurd allegations and unlawful court orders? Investors are not coming—and for good reason!

Returning to the espionage case... They tried to smear me as a “spy” by invoking someone I had seen for perhaps five minutes in my life—as one of the thousands of citizens who came to congratulate me after an election victory—and whom I could not even recognize when shown his photograph! A person I had seen for five minutes, with whom I had never had any contact, telephone conversation, meeting, or exchange of messages, was supposedly a “manager” of my alleged organization! Have you ever seen such a brazen, malicious, unconscionable farce?

Yet the very same person hosted İbrahim Kalın and AKP members of parliament in Britain. They held meetings and posed for commemorative photographs together. İbrahim Kalın was appointed head of the National Intelligence Organization, while I was branded a spy. İbrahim Kalın was put in charge of national intelligence; I was accused of running a criminal organization with this person.

Not one prosecutor thought to telephone the head of intelligence and ask, “Mr. Kalın, what do you have to say about this?” What splendid justice, what splendid courts, what splendid prosecutors—wouldn't you agree? But I am asking! Mr. İbrahim Kalın, do you know the person

with whom you organized a program? How many minutes did you spend talking to him? Is he a spy?

Heading the National Intelligence Organization is no small responsibility. I invite you to speak with courage and candor. To remain silent in the face of injustice is to be a mute devil.

Hüseyin Gün disclosed at last month's hearing that he had obtained authorization to act on behalf of Türkiye from Fuat Oktay, then Undersecretary to the Prime Minister and later Vice President. This was not merely a claim: he said it while holding the document in his hand. Has Fuat Oktay said a single word? No. Profound silence.

That same person is a friend—a close buddy—of the present Minister of Culture and Tourism. According to his statement, he made presentations not only to the minister but also to the police. I repeat: I have not the slightest idea who this person is. I saw him for five minutes in my entire life!

Here we also see what kind of “organized conduct” this Presidential Government System, this new regime, produces. Someone issued an order to “keep silent” to a vice president, ministers, and the head of national intelligence, and not one of them can utter a word about it! In this system, one person says “be silent” and everyone in the state falls silent. What a staggering display of helplessness!

* * *

Let me remind you of another absurd example. They accuse us of “supporting terrorism” because we nominated Kurdish candidates in western Türkiye and helped them get elected! Should one laugh or cry? A state governed by the rule of law cannot be mocked so shamelessly. Law, reason, logic, common sense, and conscience cannot be trampled upon so thoroughly!

* * *

The “espionage” investigation, the “support for terrorism” investigation, the “fool” case, the annulment of my diploma—what we are experiencing in this courtroom today is no different! It is equally baseless, unbelievable, and tragic! Those who have inflicted this evil upon our country have not hesitated to demolish the most fundamental principles of law.

In every case concerning me, the Council of Judges and Prosecutors (HSK) intervened in the court, and the judges in place when the proceedings began were replaced. Only one case continued before the same panel. And even in that case, the judge who dissented from the conviction and maintained that I should be acquitted was removed from his post after delivering his opinion. The HSK intervened in every one of my cases. Every single one! Eighteen judges handling my files were sent to other courts and other cities!

Wasn't the judiciary supposed to be independent? Wasn't the HSK supposed to be impartial? Do you know what this means? It means that the principle of the “natural judge,” one of the most fundamental conditions of a fair trial, was flagrantly violated.

Under that principle, everyone must be tried before a judge designated in advance by law. In other words, courts must not be created for particular individuals, and judges must not be

selected to suit particular defendants. What happens when they are? The law is murdered.

For purely political purposes, the rule of law has been openly murdered during this period!

* * *

At this point, I must explain something.

As I have just described, my university diploma was hastily annulled on the evening of March 18. A few hours later, at dawn, the March 19 coup—which I will describe shortly—was carried out.

Does that not strike you as remarkable? Matters that appear unrelated happening at the same time. Do you know what it tells us? That the entire process was coordinated by a higher authority. That authority was, of course, President Erdoğan. The politician disguised as a chief prosecutor, today's Minister of Justice, was merely the hand executing the plan.

All these cases and operations—from the 2019 decision to annul the election to the “fool” case, from the annulment of my diploma to the “espionage” case, from the coup case against the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality to the coup case against the CHP—are in reality parts of one enormous case. And that case is about changing the regime in Türkiye! It is about ending the sovereignty of the nation.

This entire operation is directed from a single center: the 1,150-room Palace! Everything that has happened is part of the same grand fabrication, the same elaborate script, the same great theatrical production—call it what you will.

Everyone has a role in this production. The Rector of Istanbul University has one; the secret witness known as Meşe has one. When Meşe has a crisis of conscience and withdraws, the role passes to İlke: Meşe's statement is copied and pasted, word for word, into what İlke is made to say.

* * *

And you know what they say: people tend to assume everyone else is like themselves.

Erdoğan told the chief prosecutor what he himself had done during his time as mayor and, saying “they must have done the same,” had an indictment drawn up. They had no evidence—not even the beginnings of evidence. But Erdoğan insisted that those running Istanbul must have “done these things,” and persuaded the politician serving as Chief Prosecutor.

They searched fields for buried safes; banks for secret safe-deposit boxes. They concocted scenarios involving hidden partnerships in companies and looked for gold in wells. My guess is that they had done such things themselves and therefore assumed we must have done them too.

They dug and searched everywhere but found nothing. They combed through hundreds of homes, all to no avail. They found neither the money they were looking for, nor safes, nor shoeboxes stuffed with cash, nor money-counting machines.

The March 19 Coup

They are planting dynamite beneath the foundations of the country without even realizing it. They think they can do whatever they want. Otherwise, how could anyone treat like a hardened criminal a politician who won the support of nearly 4.5 million voters in Istanbul's latest election and defeated his closest rival by 1.1 million votes? How can one explain the madness of sending hundreds of police officers to my door before sunrise, at the time of sahur on March 19, once again during Ramadan, to take me into custody?

I am Ekrem, a man from a village of forty households, who believes in the values of the Republic, understands the responsibility of the office he has attained, and holds himself fully accountable before his state and justice. I obey the rules. I do not violate anyone's rights. But, as I have always said, I will not allow my own rights to be violated either.

There had been unjust investigations before. Whenever I was summoned, I went to the courthouse. I was never even a second late. I gave my statement and left. Had they summoned me on March 19, I would have gone again.

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But those behind this are not concerned with justice. They are not concerned with upholding the law. Their concern is to eliminate me from the contest, to humiliate me in the eyes of the nation—or so they imagine—and to manufacture a public perception.

* * *

Think back. Remember...

To carry out the March 19 coup, they brought Istanbul to a standstill! They imposed a ban on gatherings and demonstrations throughout the city, deployed tens of thousands of riot police, even drawing reinforcements from neighboring provinces, and closed hundreds of streets. Even my lawyers had to walk for kilometers to reach the Vatan Police Headquarters. Staging a coup against the elected mayor of 16 million people, against the opposition's presidential candidate, is no small undertaking!

Istanbul was placed under siege. Before dawn, hundreds of police officers raided my home. While I was fasting, they detained me before the eyes of my family and children. For four days they kept me in a filthy cell underground at police headquarters, without asking me a single question.

Let me state this unequivocally: the conditions of my detention constituted a violation of human rights. They were a form of torture unworthy of Türkiye in the twenty-first century.

I want to share something that happened to me. After giving my statement to the prosecutor, as I was leaving his office with my lawyers, the prosecutor stood up, turned to me and said: “Mr. Mayor, please don't take offense. Tomorrow you may become president, and you will sit on this side of the desk. I will move to the other side, and then you will put us on trial.”

My lawyers witnessed these words. What more needs to be said? Even the prosecutor standing before me admitted that this process was being conducted not as a matter of law, but as a political reckoning.

Then, merely to satisfy the formalities, they sent the case to the prosecutor's office with fabricated charges, lies told by unidentified witnesses and slander from secret witnesses. Everything had been decided in advance. They did not even consider what my lawyers said or the documents they presented. The order was to send me to Silivri; they did not deviate from it by a millimeter.

The judge who ordered my arrest and pretrial detention could not even look me in the face. Without lifting his head, he signed the order and sent me to Silivri. That judge was later appointed president of a High Criminal Court, while his wife was made a deputy minister!

The judge who ordered the arrest of our Mayor Murat Çalık and many other valued companions, and rejected their applications for release, appeared right beside the new Minister of Justice—the man who wrote this indictment of slander—in all the photographs from the ministerial handover

ceremony!

A judge sitting on the bench is not an employee of the Minister of Justice. Wasn't the judiciary supposed to be independent? Give me a break!

* * *

Now I must tell you something of enormous importance: the cost of the March 19 coup to our nation!

In the first six months alone, the cost of my detention to our nation—through increased interest rates on Treasury borrowing, the sale of foreign-exchange reserves to defend the currency and similar items—was a full $150 billion! One hundred and fifty billion dollars—nearly 7 trillion Turkish lira, or 7 quintillion lira in the old currency—is the direct price my detention imposed on our country and its 86 million citizens.

Let me emphasize that $150 billion represents only the direct cost to the public balance sheet during the first six months of this operation. It does not include the burden that persistently high inflation and interest rates placed on our people and businesses. By the end of the first year, that cost had reached $250 billion!

Do you know what could have been done with $250 billion? [5]

Every retiree, widow and orphan in Türkiye could have received a one-time payment of 690,000 lira! The state is building 600,000 homes in the earthquake zone; we could have rebuilt the earthquake zone four times over! The whole of Türkiye could have been made earthquake-ready! Every at-risk building could have been made safe against earthquakes!

We could have provided one free meal and milk every school day for 30 years to our 15 million children attending state schools, from primary school through the end of secondary education.

There are 25 million citizens in our country at risk of poverty or social exclusion. With the cost of this operation, all of them could have been lifted above that threshold in a very short time.

We could have eliminated the special consumption tax and value-added tax burden on our citizens for two full years. The disposable income of every household could have increased by 40,000 Turkish lira per month for an entire year.

These days they are discussing transferring the revenues from the Bosphorus bridges! We could have built 80 Bosphorus bridges like the Yavuz Sultan Selim Bridge! We could have laid 30,000 kilometers of railway reaching every province, industrial zone and port, every corner of the country! We could have built hundreds of thousands of student dormitories!

And that is only the tip of the iceberg. Because my detention and imprisonment shook confidence in the rule of law, the indirect cost to our country has been many times greater: canceled investments, factories forced to close, brilliant minds accelerating their search for opportunities abroad, banks raising interest rates, and more.

Confidence is what drives the economy, and my unjust imprisonment shattered it. Look at the bill you have forced our nation to pay just to remain in your seats a little longer! And for what? For the ambitions of a handful of power-hungry people...

Think about it. They called it “the corruption of the century.” First they claimed the figure was 560 billion lira. Then they said, “Sorry, it was 160 billion.” And of that 160 billion, 50 billion rests on an utterly absurd allegation about international loans, while the other 110 billion rests on an even more absurd allegation concerning Cebeci!

I will explain both the international loans and Cebeci later.

They scrutinized my companions and me for months and years, then fabricated a figure of 160 billion lira on the basis of a few absurd slanders. Do you know how many dollars 160 billion lira amounts to? $3.5 billion! They concocted $3.5 billion out of lies and slander, and burned through $250 billion because of that fabrication! They recklessly squandered 71 times the amount they invented—the people's money! Why? Because they were afraid. Because they wanted to eliminate an opponent they could not defeat.

I address our pensioners who cannot make ends meet, our mothers devastated because they cannot feed their children, and our young people whose futures have been darkened: this coup was carried out with your money, with the 7 trillion lira that rightfully belongs to you. Never forget that! Those in power are stealing both the present and the future of our nation, merely to eliminate a rival they know they cannot defeat! Merely to remove the opponent Erdoğan fears!

During those four days that I was held in custody, the nation rose up at its own home, Saraçhane, against what had been done to our country. The first to object were my young friends at Istanbul University, where I graduated. Those who sought to make their protest invisible and prevent it from taking place received the greatest lesson of their lives from these young people.

They crossed the barricades and refused to heed the threats. They stood up for their rights, for the votes they had cast, and against the medieval darkness toward which Türkiye was being dragged. They galvanized the entire country and inspired courage.

I thank each and every one of them, and send them my affection. Those young people multiplied my faith in this great nation. Nor will I ever forget how, driven by fear, the government detained thousands of young people in those days, arrested 400 of them, and kept many behind bars for months.

All right, I am your political rival. But what had these young people done to you to deserve such treatment? What did you want from the children of this nation? Can a president hate his own country's youth?

Those young people were held in prison for months, beaten, subjected to harassment; many missed their exams and saw their lives disrupted. And what happened in the end? Of course they were acquitted, because all they had done was exercise their constitutional rights!

Who will answer for the pain and suffering you inflicted on those young people and their families? How will you ever make amends?

The lawlessness inflicted upon our youth has gone down in history as a great stain of shame!

After the young people came millions, pouring into Saraçhane. I am grateful to every one of them!

The resolute stance of our Party Chairman, my brother Mr. Özgür Özel, and our people's discernment in recognizing the truth came as a tremendous shock to those who had set this dangerous scenario in motion.

Leaders of political parties, civil society organizations and hundreds of thousands of people of every persuasion came to Saraçhane. They all understood that this attack was directed not at one person or one party, but at the Republic of Türkiye and democracy itself.

This nation refused to indulge the destructive mentality of those governing the country who insist on clinging to their seats at any cost, who shy away from an honorable contest and seek to force their opponent out of the race by breaking the rules.

Not only outside Saraçhane but throughout Türkiye, millions opposed this lawlessness. They understood very well that what had been done to me was in fact an attack on Türkiye's future. They saw that the investigation was political, not legal.

[5] See Table 3.

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That is why, on the morning of March 23, as soon as they got up, they rushed to the presidential primary ballot boxes set up by our Republican People's Party. In defiance of those who had subjected Türkiye to a dark day, millions went to the polls and protested what had been done through their votes. They showed friend and foe alike that this country is not a place where anyone can simply come and do as they please.

An elderly woman who went to vote with a walking stick cast her ballot so that her children and grandchildren might live in a state governed by the rule of law. A woman who went to the ballot box carrying a baby in her womb voted as an act of protest, so that her child might receive an equal education and justice might be administered equally to everyone. And the young people who rejected the government's thoughtless attitude of "Those who want to go abroad should go" gave their answer: "I want democracy in my country. I want merit to count. I am fighting for these things, and I am not going anywhere."

To the millions who waited in line for hours that day, I offer my heartfelt thanks! Thank you, each and every one of you. I will remain grateful to you all my life. I will never forget the voice you raised, and I will always work to deserve your trust.

From that day onward, there has been a constant cry of protest. The unshakable will of 15.5 million people who said, "Wait—we have not yet had our final say," and gave hope to all of Türkiye, together with the 25 million voters who declared, "I want the ballot box before me and my candidate beside me," was a powerful slap in the face to a government that had taken the wrong path!

Even today, I see you every week, standing in the public squares through snow, rain, the bitter cold of winter, and now the heat of summer.

To all of you who have stood in those squares, in temperatures as low as minus 6 degrees and as high as 47 degrees, to defend our Republic and our democracy: I will be grateful to you for the rest of my life! My gratitude to my nation will never end.

I have come to understand even more deeply how right I was in what I said on the morning of March 19. I had entrusted myself first to God, and then to my nation. You honored that trust to the very end. Thank you all! Together, we will stand by the Republic and democracy!

As heartening as it has been to see that the public's enthusiasm has never waned for more than a year, it has been equally shameful to witness the ruthlessness of those who, during that year, turned an investigation into an instrument of revenge.

WE HAVE ENDURED — AND ARE STILL ENDURING — A BRUTAL ORDEAL!

For a year, innocent people have been subjected to systematic oppression. We must put this on the historical record: this process is not merely unlawful. It is savage. It is merciless. It is immoral!

If only these hearings had been broadcast live, as we requested! If only all 86 million of our people could have heard, in real time, the truths that everyone in this courtroom has heard! If only all 86 million could have heard how dozens of people were held for months in appalling prison conditions on the flimsiest of fabricated pretexts!

Let us recall what happened. Because we knew ourselves and knew we were innocent, we had complete confidence from the very first day. We wanted our nation to see and hear everything. We demanded complete transparency.

In May 2025, the Republican People's Party introduced a bill in the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye to have this trial broadcast live on TRT. Subsequently, at MHP parliamentary group meetings on July 8 and November 18, Devlet Bahçeli called for "this trial to be broadcast live on every television channel!" The following day, July 9, Erdoğan said: "If Mr. Bahçeli has said such a thing, I think it is an entirely welcome judgment. I hope it will bring good results."

And what happened next? On December 2, 2025, votes from the AKP and MHP blocked the CHP's proposal to place its bill for a live TRT broadcast of this trial on the Assembly's agenda! Neither Erdoğan nor Bahçeli dared to allow a live broadcast of this case or let our nation see the truth!

The conscience and heart of 86 million people could not have endured so much injustice. The government would have lost the few supporters it still had. For our nation has a conscience and a sense of justice. Our people would have seen what a vicious conspiracy this case was, how utterly empty it was, and what oppression, torture, and tragedy it had inflicted upon hundreds of innocent people and their families. Those in power would have been disgraced!

And how afraid they were of my image, my voice, and the things I had to say! How afraid they were of what my honest, capable companions would say, because they knew those companions would demolish this indictment! My people, never forget this cowardice!

* * *

Throughout this process, they tore mothers away from their very young children, knowing perfectly well that those women were innocent. They did not care that the children fell asleep every night longing for their mothers, grew up in fear, and suffered psychological trauma!

In our culture, motherhood is sacred. The family is sacred. But this twisted mentality holds nothing sacred. There is only one thing sacred to them: their hunger for power.

During this process, 20 innocent mothers were separated from their children! New operations are launched every day, and dozens more mothers are torn away from their children. These heartless people have punished not only the mothers, but their children as well. This is not law. This is an outright operation of revenge.

One of our department heads was kept in prison while his wife was experiencing a high-risk pregnancy. His request for permission to be with her during childbirth was refused. While she struggled through a difficult delivery, he waited helplessly for news in Silivri. Both God and our nation see those responsible for this inhuman cruelty.

Fourteen of our companions were transferred from Marmara Prison in Silivri to other provinces without even informing their families. One of our female general managers was hurriedly sent to Afyon in handcuffs just before Eid al-Adha. In her first days there, she was made to sleep on the floor and subjected to psychological pressure.

We were all chilled to the bone as we listened to how another of our female general managers had been subjected to the torture of a strip search and threatened through her two young daughters.

I do not like using myself as an example, but I was unable to attend my sister-in-law's funeral. Is that compatible with basic humanity?

You heard it in the hearings: dozens of our companions, women and men alike, were forced to live 60 or 70 to a ward intended for 20 or 30! Many slept on the floor. They battled bedbugs. This is torture. This is oppression. My companions lived through hell.

Another of our companions held a man in his arms as that man died. Who can erase traumas like these?

Dozens of fathers were left longing for their little daughters and sons. Many could not even tell their children they were in prison; as a result, they could see them only once a month, for one hour during an open visit! What kind of heartlessness is this? What kind of monstrous cruelty is this?

And yet, despite all of it, our companions endured. They did not give up. They did not turn away from the truth.

Of course, there were also people who could no longer withstand so much oppression and torture, who gave in to their fears; there were those who said, "Just tell us what you want, and we'll sign it."

That is the sole foundation of this case: defamatory statements extracted through oppression and threats. This case rests on accusations obtained by throwing people into prison and threatening their families and their property.

You saw it yourselves. We were all in this courtroom for four months. There is nothing else in this case!

Would a state treat its citizens this way? Bandits, gangs, and mafias might behave like this. But a state does not. I ask you: what possible legal explanation is there for all this cruelty?

You are punishing people who have not even been convicted. This is not a trial. It is the execution of a sentence in advance.

I have companions in captivity who suffer from serious medical problems and cannot obtain adequate healthcare. Their mothers, relatives, and loved ones wait helplessly outside hospitals.

The children, nephews and nieces, and siblings of some of my valued companions have been detained or arrested as a means of pressure.

The son of one dear companion, barely more than a child, was held in prison for a year solely to pressure his father. He was released as soon as he gave a statement.

They detained another valued companion's wife and even laid hands on the children's piggy bank and earrings, trying to put pressure on him through his wife and family. What appalling heartlessness!

And what of my lawyer, Mehmet Pehlivan? Simply for doing his job and defending me, he was accused of being the "member responsible for legal affairs" of this imaginary organization. He has been held hostage in a high-security prison for more than a year.

As though all that were not enough, they used methods beyond belief to force friends with whom I have walked this path for many years into fabricated confessions, simply because they stood firmly beside me.

To break these people and force false confessions from them, they used methods amounting to torture, constantly seeking to pressure them through their families!

Through this enormous conspiracy, countless unsung heroes and companions have seen devastation brought upon their homes, paid the heaviest prices, and endured the cruellest injustice while resisting silently and with dignity!

You have all seen over the past four months that many people, too, have supposedly invoked "effective remorse"—

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Many people also withdrew the statements they had made under the so-called “effective remorse” provisions, explaining that they had given them under pressure. It emerged that prohibited interrogation methods had been used. For example, while a businessperson is being questioned, he is told that his wife is being taken into custody at that very moment. Terrified that his children will be left without either parent, he says, “I’ll sign whatever you want.”

Other statements revealed that whatever “template” the prosecutor provided had simply been repeated word for word. In other words, the prosecution wrote the script and, through pressure, made a handful of people claiming “effective remorse” recite it.

Our blood ran cold as we listened in this courtroom to what had been done during this brutal process! The suffering inflicted upon people and their families was appalling. Why? Because there is no crime in this case, and naturally, no evidence either. The entire case rests on statements extracted through force, pressure and threats—on lies and slander.

My esteemed fellow citizens,

Look, this session is drawing to a close. Hearings have been going on for four months. Has the prosecution presented a single piece of evidence? No!

Not one piece of evidence! The prosecution has been unable to produce a single item of evidence or a single counterargument against any of my companions’ detailed, concrete, evidence-based defenses.

Can this be called humanity? Can human lives be used to send a message? Can you send a message by targeting a person's spouse, children, elderly mother and father—their entire family? Such things are not done even in war.

I ask you: What kind of ambition makes you so ruthless that you would risk these people's lives without a moment's hesitation? What kind of ambition is this? What kind of violence?

I leave those who believe their power is unlimited, and who carry their ambitions so far as to torture others, to the judgment of God and my conscientious nation.

Those who set this trap for us turned even the detentions into a spectacle and an assault on human dignity! Photographs were circulated of our companions exhausted after detention, unshaven and handcuffed, positioned between police officers.

Consider one of my valued companions. He goes in voluntarily to give a statement. But no—that does not fit the image these coup-makers wish to create! He must be made to look as though he has been “captured.” Human dignity must be trampled upon.

Pro-government newspapers must be able to run the headline “Fugitive Captured!” So what did they do? They staged no fewer than three separate photographs to make it look as if he had been caught!

As I said, we are trapped in a badly staged piece of theater. But you have no right to drag our great tradition of statehood and our respected institutions down to this level, or to turn them into props in this disgraceful performance!

All of this was done merely to shape public perception—to brand every one of them guilty in advance. Even the fundamental human right to be free from the stigma of unfounded accusations was deliberately trampled underfoot! Drivers, staff working in private secretariats, dozens of employees with no decision-making authority... And in other operations, dozens of working people are still in prison without even having indictments drawn up against them. For no reason other than oppression and intimidation. They were mercilessly imprisoned to frighten others—and perhaps in the hope that they would make some false accusation.

They did something else that would be unthinkable in a state governed by the rule of law—indeed, something that should not happen even under the law of the enemy: they targeted the lawyers defending us!

My lawyer Mehmet Pehlivan has been held in pretrial detention for more than a year. Operations were also carried out against the lawyers defending Pehlivan and our other companions. These people went so far as to detain my lawyer’s lawyer.

Mehmet Pehlivan explained it here: these shameless imitators copied the Lula case to the letter even in this respect! Lula’s lawyer was arrested; my lawyer was arrested too!

How can my right to a defense be taken away from me? Even the law of the enemy cannot justify this! What is it you want? I truly do not understand. You will line up your slanderous allegations and no one will be allowed to challenge them—is that it?

You will seize even the right to a defense, intimidate every lawyer, and then call this justice? Can there be a fair trial when even the defense is kept under pressure? Spare us such claims.

And they did not stop there. They exerted their most severe pressure through our families...

Wasn't the family supposed to be sacred? Isn't it me you are after? Then settle your score with me.

I address the man who fears his political rival: I am here! I stand before you like a lion! If you have the courage, fight me—and me alone!

But my wife, her family... Her older brother and her nephew are imprisoned. Her nephew’s two small children, aged five and eight, now have both their mother and their

father in prison! What kind of blind cruelty is this?

And what kind of heartlessness is it to make defendants of my son Selim and my father, who is approaching eighty, on such absurd and nonsensical grounds? What does it mean to go after my children, my mother, my father and the families of my companions—to hold family members hostage?

This is shameful. It is weakness. It is cowardice. Cowardice has permeated this entire mentality, from those at the very top to those who carry out their orders.

In the meantime, I want to send my warmest greetings to my esteemed friends who serve as mayors, who were arrested, held unjustly in prison for months and subsequently released. May every one of my companions soon enjoy the same freedom! Yet even today, twenty-eight of our mayors remain behind bars, and indictments have not even been prepared for twelve of them!

Let me draw your attention to another very important point. In a state governed by the rule of law, a pretrial detention order is subject to many conditions—the risk of flight, the possibility of tampering with evidence and others. But the most important requirement is the existence of strong, concrete evidence. And when such an order concerns elected officials and their teams, these requirements must be applied with still greater care and to an even higher standard.

Throughout this process, detention orders have been issued without any concrete evidence. That is why the indictments keep failing to appear: they cannot be written! It is not easy to put baseless, absurd allegations into an indictment when there is no evidence. Moreover, the sole purpose here is to punish people in advance and create a climate of fear and manipulated public perception. There is no genuine legal process.

There are people who have been held for more than a year without even seeing an indictment against them. Arzu Can, Onur Gülin, İlkay Onuk, Doğukan Arıcı, Çağatay Takaoğlu, Evren Buçan... They have still not been able to learn, before a court, precisely what they are accused of. Some have been torn from their children, others from their spouses, and others from professions to which they devoted years of work.

The right to be tried within a reasonable time—one of the most fundamental safeguards of the law—has been suspended. People have been condemned to wait in uncertainty. Months, even years, pass before an indictment is prepared. This silence has long since ceased to be a delay that can be explained by the normal workings of criminal justice.

Nor did it end there. While people waiting for their indictments remained behind bars, the operations did not stop. On the contrary, they expanded in wave after wave. In June 2026, a new operation was launched against Beylikdüzü Municipality. Around the same time, an operation targeted İmamoğlu İnşaat. Then came Adalar Municipality. Earlier, Ağaç AŞ, the Boğaziçi administration and numerous municipalities had been subjected to successive investigations.

Before one file was completed, another was opened. Before one indictment was written, new detentions were carried out. Rather than moving toward resolution, the legal process was constantly expanded.

What has emerged goes far beyond a series of isolated investigations. Resul Emrah Şahan, Rıza Akpolat, Alaattin Köseler, Mehmet Murat Çalık, Hasan Akgün, Utku Caner Çaykara, Hakan Bahçetepe, Hasan Mutlu, İnan Güney, Özgür Kabadayı, Onursal Adıgüzel, Bora Balcıoğlu, Ali Ercan Akpolat... With every new operation, more mayors' names have been added to the list.

Cases have been brought against some; others remain under investigation. But one fact is common to all: the operations continue without pause, while uncertainty grows ever deeper.

Inevitably, one asks: How far will this go? How many more municipalities, how many more mayors, public officials and employees will be taken from their homes at dawn? How many more people will wait months or years for an indictment?

If the purpose of the law is to establish the truth, indictments are prepared, cases are brought and trials are held. But under a system in which investigations never end, operations follow one another and indictments are continually postponed, what remains is not legal certainty, but an unending state of uncertainty and the “punishment in advance” of innocent people.

Take our own case. We were detained on March 19 and placed under arrest on March 23. The indictment was written in November 2025—fully eight months later! The hearings did not begin until March 9, a year after our arrest!

In Europe, proceedings involving defendants held in pretrial detention take, on average, no more than three or four months. In our case, a year! This is a grave human-rights violation. A whole year passes without evidence, without an indictment, without a hearing.

A year—it is easy to say. Innocent people spend a year in prison. They are punished before trial. Then, many of them are released as soon as they have presented their defenses. Because the accusations are utterly empty, nothing but enormous lies.

The moment they are allowed to speak, all of Türkiye understands that there is nothing in the case file. Yet on the strength of these empty allegations, these innocent people are punished for a year; for many, the period has now approached a year and a half.

This process is a violation of human rights! It is a process of punishment in advance: punishment without trial!

CHAPTER TWO — Conclusion

Let me be perfectly clear. This process has shown just how devoid of conscience people can become when they are afraid of losing their positions. How merciless they can be. How heartless. How far they can stray from their duty to serve the state and the nation.

This is the kind of evil we are fighting. But those who do evil will, in the end, always lose. And those who stand for what is good will ultimately prevail!

Never forget: a state becomes worthy of that name when it makes justice, mercy, and compassion a reality in the lives of its citizens!

What they are trying to pass off to us today as “reason of state” is nothing more than one person's desire to remain in power forever, his ambition to establish a dynasty!

That is why this case is about the Republic itself! This is a case about democracy, freedom, and equality!

CHAPTER THREE

Our Crime Is Defending the People’s Rights; Our Crime Is Succeeding

Original printed pages 88–90

I said it at the outset.

We all know that this is not a genuine “trial.” It is part of the relentless judicial harassment and the March 19 coup I have just described.

All my life, I have refused to pretend. I have never been false; I have always been genuine. And I will not start pretending today! I have no intention of going through the motions of presenting a “defense” in a so-called trial that is not a genuine legal proceeding.

Our nation knows this too. The overwhelming majority recognize this case for what it is: a “political script,” a shoddy, poorly staged conspiracy. They know who wrote the plot, who staged it, and who put it into action.

I will never play the role of the “defendant” defending himself in such a charade! But I must briefly explain just how divorced from reality this script is, how utterly absurd it is, and how little it reflects even the most basic common sense or elementary knowledge of law.

I address those who wrote this indictment and those who ordered it written: You branded the patriotic, honest, decent people here today — my companions — “members of a criminal organization” merely because we work together, merely because they hold positions at the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality. History will never forgive you for that!

The Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality has been characterized as a “criminal organization”! Has your obsession gone so far that you are prepared to disregard the state, trample upon its very structure, and label the municipality's lawful organization a “criminal organization”?

You questioned why its senior officials met with one another and why they spoke so frequently! You took everyone serving in the municipality's officially established senior management positions and turned them, on paper, into the hierarchy of a criminal organization!

Did you feel no shame in doing this? You called people “leaders or members of a criminal organization” simply for carrying out their duties at the municipality. You defined the İBB organization itself as a “criminal organization”!

But first, everyone needs to understand the answer to one question: why did they commit such brazen lawlessness?

Because they had lost all restraint. Because, one way or another, they had to send me to prison — and send my companions there too, as a means of putting pressure on me. Because

they could not break the bond between me and the people, they apparently hoped I might be forgotten inside a twelve-square-meter cell.

Desperate and in a state of panic, they wanted to bury me beneath concrete, whatever the cost. They knew they could not hold us captive without alleging the existence of a “criminal organization.” So they had to invent an accusation this absurd, this devoid of any legal foundation.

There is no need for any of this. Whatever you intend to do, do it to me. Leave my companions alone!

You took the meetings, conversations, and lawful, necessary working relationships of municipal employees carrying out public service — their HTS telephone-traffic records, the number and duration of their calls — and presented them as evidence of “continuing ties within a criminal organization”!

You called a lawful institution of the state a “criminal organization”!

And this misguided mentality does not even realize what a dangerous precedent it is creating.

Have you stopped for even a moment to consider what might happen if these same descriptions were applied to any organized state institution — a ministry, for example — one day in the future? Could three or five secret witnesses be assembled and the entire senior management of a ministry, or any executive body, then be arrested as “members of a criminal organization”?

You called the head of Türkiye's largest municipality a “criminal organization leader,” and the municipality's administrative organization a “criminal organization”!

Will someone in the future be able to gather three or five secret witnesses, obtain slanderous statements under pressure, and put the head of a lawful state institution on trial as the “leader of a criminal organization”?

As you know, under the Presidential Government System, the President is both the head of the executive branch and, under the Constitution, the sole holder of executive power. If you take the state's lawful administrative organizations and attribute the acts carried out within them to their head, could a president one day be tried as the “leader of a criminal organization”?

Consider this: under this system, the President personally appoints all the state's senior officials — more than 4,000 public administrators. Does that mean that whenever a criminal complaint, a slanderous allegation, or a “statement” is made concerning an arm of the state, the head of state could be tried as the “leader of a criminal organization”?

It sounds insane, doesn't it? Yet that is exactly what you are saying in this indictment. That is precisely the path you are opening. You are establishing a precedent. With your own hands, you are laying the foundations of an extraordinarily dangerous practice!

You cannot even hear the implications of your own words, because you have become consumed by one objective: to put Ekrem İmamoğlu in prison by any means possible. You did not hesitate to make yourselves servants of another man's will, all to carry out the orders of the mentality at the head of the government!

* * *

This “criminal organization” is supposedly so extraordinary that one of its most important “acts” was the Republican People's Party Congress held in November 2023!

Because this criminal organization is alleged to have a very dangerous ambition: to seek the right to govern Türkiye!

Indeed, just a few months after the CHP's November 2023 Congress, the party became Türkiye's leading political party in the March 2024 local elections, for the first time in decades! Could there be a greater crime than that?

The “crime” committed by the members of this supposedly vast criminal organization was to belong to the CHP and to demand change within the party after the elections lost in 2023; to be happy when Mr. Özgür Özel was declared Party Chairman and to join the celebrations!

What staggering ignorance of democracy! A handful of prosecutors who do not even understand what democracy means are openly targeting the main opposition party! They object to that party's desire for change following its defeat in the May 2023 presidential election.

Who are you? Where do you get the audacity?

The CHP is the founding party of this country. It is the nearly two million members of our proud CHP, its millions of voters, and its delegates who decide who leads the party — not a handful of prosecutors!

And certainly not the ruling party that gives them their orders!

CHAPTER THREE — CONTINUED

Our Crime Is Defending the People’s Rights; Our Crime Is Succeeding

English translation · Original printed pages 91–94

The prosecution does not even feel the need to conceal its purpose. In the indictment, it openly calls on the Chief Public Prosecutor's Office of the Court of Cassation to take action! Using photographs of celebrations at the party congress, it shamelessly tells that office to "shut down" the main opposition party!

It explicitly invokes Article 69 of our Constitution, which concerns the dissolution of political parties. Even the existence of a main opposition party, the bare minimum requirement of a democracy, troubles them. Especially when that opposition party has become Türkiye's leading party...

As you know, there is no evidence in the indictment. Now I am going to show you the real "evidence of a crime" that is missing from it. As you can see on the map, our greatest accomplices are the 60 million voters! [6]

Apparently, they failed to obtain the result they wanted from the Chief Public Prosecutor's Office of the Court of Cassation, so they secured a ruling of "absolute nullity" against the CHP from a Regional Court of Appeal!

The Regional Court of Appeal's decision of May 21 is inseparable from the March 19 coup; it is a continuation of that coup. Do you know what the May 21 decision really amounts to? "Since we couldn't get the CHP formally shut down, let's at least try to shut it down in practice. Let's install a puppet trustee at its head!" The March 19 coup and the May 21 coup are, in essence, two stages of the same coup. Its purpose is to bring an end to our country's democratic order, national sovereignty, competitive elections, and multiparty system.

* * *

Now I want to explain these matters in greater detail, because they lie at the very heart of this case.

As I explained a moment ago, our victory in Istanbul in 2019 after 25 years of AKP rule, the CHP's subsequent emergence as the country's leading party, and my presidential candidacy in February 2025 led to the March 19 coup.

The indictment before you makes it abundantly clear that it is an inseparable part of that coup, indeed its principal instrument. The prosecution has not even tried to hide its purpose: our crime is aspiring to govern the country!

Look at how the indictment defines the so-called "criminal organization" we supposedly established, in the very first sentence of the first paragraph on its first page. Here is its definition of this alleged "criminal organization":

> "*The 'İmamoğlu Criminal Organization for Personal Gain,' directed toward the purpose of taking control of the Republican People's Party, the political party to which Ekrem İmamoğlu belongs, and raising funds to secure the nomination of the organization's leader in the presidential election to be held thereafter...*"

Another passage from the indictment: the crime of wanting change within the CHP.

> "*[...] the organization leader selected Özgür Özel as the candidate to stand against Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu at the CHP's 38th Ordinary Congress, held on November 4–5, 2023,*" *and ensured that delegates* "*cast their votes in favor of Özgür Özel.*"

The indictment continues:

> "*The person who ensured that Özgür Özel stood as a candidate and was elected chairman at the CHP's ordinary congress was the organization leader, Ekrem İmamoğlu. [...] Following the election as chairman of the person put forward by the organization leader at the CHP's ordinary congress in 2023, the organization leader took control of the CHP's leadership...*"

Just look at those words! "Organization leader," indeed! Give me a break!

Look at the supposed crime: wanting change in the CHP after the electoral defeat of 2023; supporting Mr. Özgür Özel. That is precisely why the nullity ruling of May 21 is inseparable from the March 19 coup. The objective from the beginning was to eliminate the opposition, and the indictment makes that perfectly clear.

Let me continue with another passage from the indictment. The crime of running for president:

> "*[...] by attempting to bring people within the party under his protection, he aimed first to become the sole person whose word carried authority in the party to which he belonged and to take control of that party; his subsequent, third objective was to become his party's presidential candidate in the forthcoming presidential election.*"

That is the only true statement in the entire enormous indictment: yes, my aim is to become the Republican People's Party's candidate in the next presidential election!

Look at their choice of words: having "a say" within a political party, "taking control" of a political party, "becoming the party's candidate in a presidential election"!

Such sentences could only have been written by minds hostile to democracy, minds that have never understood what competitive democracy means!

Look at the objective of this "criminal organization": aspiring to govern the country! Aspiring to the office occupied for 24 years by President Erdoğan!

What a grave crime that must be! Even a demand for 2,352 years in prison is surely too lenient a punishment for such an offense! I know this all sounds tragicomic to us, doesn't it?

I am not being ironic: the indictment explicitly identifies a presidential candidacy as the objective of a criminal organization! Of course, they are right: who would dare take that office away from Erdoğan?

According to Erdoğan, that office belongs not to the nation but to him! He inherited it from his father, and he will pass it on to his son! Erdoğan believes he was elected to hold that office for life, and he already regards himself as immortal. But if one day he has to hand it over, he thinks, "Naturally, I'll pass it to my son; and if not to my son, then to my son-in-law!" Preparations are being made for this, and the whole country knows it. Everyone sees what is happening!

A "one-man regime" was not enough. Now they want to turn that regime into a monarchy, a dynasty. Power must pass from father to son; failing that, to the son-in-law! That is the plan. And that is why Ekrem İmamoğlu is such a nuisance: where did this man come from, threatening to disrupt their plan?

Now I will read another section. The crime of winning district municipalities:

> "*Following the change in the leadership of the Republican People's Party, control of the party passed entirely to the organization leader, and many candidates for provincial and district mayoralties in Istanbul's districts and across Türkiye in the March 2024 local elections were selected by the organization. In districts including Şişli, Üsküdar, Beylikdüzü, Esenyurt, Eyüpsultan, Bakırköy, Sancaktepe, Kadıköy, and Çekmeköy, the organization leader nominated people loyal to him.*"
>
> "*He also brought the mayors of Büyükçekmece, Küçükçekmece, and Tuzla under his control. The mayoral candidates for Avcılar, Sarıyer, Beyoğlu, Bayrampaşa, and Gaziosmanpaşa, meanwhile, were selected by Rıza Akpolat because of his role in the Istanbul provincial chairmanship elections and the ordinary party congress.*"
>
> "*It was established that Ekrem İmamoğlu, who acted like the tentacles of an octopus and took control of municipalities, upon becoming aware of the progress of the investigation, brought forward his prospective presidential candidacy in an effort to prevent public discussion of the criminal organization he had established.*"

I imagine you have noticed what all the municipalities listed by the prosecutors have in common. Every one of them is a district won by the CHP in the 2024 local elections! In most of them, the CHP won for the first time in 2024. The prosecutors, however, have not listed the municipalities we lost. Apparently, there is no problem with my "taking control"

of those or selecting their mayoral candidates, because we did not win them. That is the real crime!

Now I want to show you another piece of real "criminal evidence" that is absent from the indictment. Here is "Exhibit No. 2": a map of Istanbul. The CHP won 26 districts; Ekrem İmamoğlu came first in 32 of the 39 districts. Ekrem İmamoğlu: 32 districts. Murat Kurum: 7 districts! [7] You can see the crime, can't you? Apparently I swept through the districts like an octopus and seized them! Surely there could be no greater crime! But in a democracy, this is called nominating the right candidates to win elections!

Indeed, by using the expression "the tentacles of an octopus," the people who wrote this indictment have themselves admitted that it is not a genuine indictment, not a legal document, but a political one.

In speaking of "the tentacles of an octopus," the indictment simply copies the expression Erdoğan used in May 2025! Because the real author of the indictment is President Erdoğan.

And where did Erdoğan get the expression? From Brazil! As I explained earlier, the terms "polvo tentaculos" (the tentacles of an octopus) were also widely used in connection with Lula. That trial was political, and so is this one! They copied and pasted the whole thing, but apparently never considered that the story would end the same way. Lula is President today!

* * *

Moreover, page after page of images and photographs from the CHP's 38th Congress, where Mr. Özgür Özel was elected Chairman, have been included in the indictment. The faces of our companions who attended the congress were marked in red! As though merely being present at the CHP Congress, supporting Mr. Özel, and celebrating the arrival of change within the CHP...

[6] See Table 4. [7] See Table 5.

The final sentence continues on original printed page 95.

CHAPTER THREE — CONTINUED

Our Crime Is Defending the People's Rights; Our Crime Is Succeeding

English translation | Original printed pages 95–98

...as though attending a CHP congress, supporting Mr. Özel, and rejoicing at the change within the CHP were evidence of some grave crime!

The Crime of Attending the Party Congress:

> *"It is understood that the individuals detained within the scope of the investigation, together with the individual named Ekrem İMAMOĞLU, stood alongside CHP Chairman Özgür Özel, together with Ekrem İmamoğlu, at the 38th Congress ... that these individuals were also present at the congress meeting, and that, in view of these circumstances, they supported the individual named Özgür Özel, who assumed the chairmanship of the CHP, together with Ekrem İmamoğlu, the leader of the criminal organization."*

Just look at the alleged crime!

Now I will show you several photographs presented as "evidence of crime." They even had the audacity to put these photographs in the indictment! Indeed, these are the only pieces of "evidence" it contains! [8] Because there is no evidence whatsoever in the indictment, they have resorted to such supposed "evidence." It is the height of absurdity!

And look at the language they use! Look at the disrespect: they refer to the Chairman of the CHP as "the individual named Özgür Özel"! It is disgraceful. Such language is unworthy of the dignity of the state and of any democratic political culture.

I want to draw your attention to something. This indictment is so far removed from the law that those who wrote it did not even make an effort to give it the appearance of a legal document! They deliberately used the expressions of Erdoğan, the true author of the indictment: "the tentacles of an octopus," "the individual" ... You have heard Erdoğan say it in dozens of speeches: "the individual at the head of the CHP!"

The government that ordered this indictment to be written was, naturally, deeply disturbed by that Party Congress. Yet on the evening of the Congress, millions of CHP supporters were rejoicing. For the first time since the lost presidential election, they felt hope again.

Despite everything we have been through, let me remind you that I was the person who held the most rallies in support of Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu in the May 2023 presidential election, who campaigned hardest for votes for the opposition's candidate, the man who was then Chairman of the CHP. I worked wholeheartedly, day and night, sincerely,

sweating and giving everything I had. I did not stop to catch my breath for a single day. I did it for my country.

Yet despite all our efforts, sadly, we did not succeed. Following the defeat of May 28, 2023, profound disappointment and hopelessness took hold among opposition voters. That great wave of despair could have been democracy's death warrant! So, rather than act behind closed doors, I spoke openly and courageously. On the morning of May 29, after a sleepless night, I recorded a video in which I said, “The only constant is change,” giving the first unmistakable signal that significant change was needed within the CHP as well. These were my exact words:

> *“My esteemed fellow citizens, my dear fellow Istanbulites, The May 28 election is over. As a politician following in the footsteps of Gazi Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, who declared that ‘Sovereignty belongs unconditionally to the nation,’ I naturally hope that these results will bring good to our nation and our beautiful country. Türkiye now urgently needs to return to normality and find solutions to its real problems. I know that tens of millions of people are profoundly disappointed today. Dear children, please, please do not be sad. My dear young people, never, ever give in to hopelessness. Ladies, do not be anxious. Gentlemen, keep walking with your heads held high. We are a nation capable of accomplishing great things in a short time. We can do it again. We experienced a similar disappointment five years ago. Yet just nine months later, we achieved remarkable results in the local elections. We did the right things, and together we achieved results. We succeeded together. Let no one worry. Everything is beginning anew. Remember: the only constant is change. Change in every field, in every sphere ... We will no longer expect different results by doing the same things! We will act as Mustafa Kemal Atatürk did at the age of 38, as Sultan Mehmed the Conqueror did at the age of 21. Today is May 29. Today marks the 570th anniversary of the conquest of Istanbul. For centuries, countless armies and commanders returned empty-handed from the gates of Istanbul. But then the day came when Mehmed changed his methods and his means, conquered the city, and became the Conqueror. He conquered not only this ancient city, but also the hearts of its people. That is how he made the conquest enduring. We, too, set out to win hearts. We will continue striving to win every heart. As the great Atatürk said: ‘There are no hopeless situations, only hopeless people.’ In Istanbul there are millions, like me, who are hopeful—deeply hopeful—soldiers of democracy; across Türkiye, there are tens of millions. During this election campaign, I witnessed time and again their determined, resilient struggle and their refusal ever to give up. I invite all of you—above all you soldiers of democracy, our dear children, our wonderful young people, mothers, and everyone in Istanbul—to the 570th anniversary celebrations of the Conquest that we are holding today at 8:00 p.m. in Maltepe Square. Tonight we will look one another in the eye and stand heart to heart. We will talk about what we intend to accomplish and about change. Together, we will discuss how we can move faster to win every heart. Believe me: we have a long road ahead, we have our youth, our faith is unwavering, and trust me: Everything Will Be Beautiful!”*

I told young people and all CHP voters not to lose hope. In essence, I said, “If the CHP changes, Türkiye will change.” And yes, I worked to bring about a change in the CHP's leadership. I did not conceal it; I said so openly! As in every democratic country, a political leader who loses an election must make way for a new generation. This was not my demand alone. It was the demand of millions. I simply had the courage to say it aloud.

In democracies, leaders who lose a major election of this kind deliver a speech of thanks that same evening and announce that they will step down from their party's leadership. That was what should have happened on the evening of May 28. But it seems that the prospect of change within the main opposition party greatly disturbed those who had been in power for 24 years and had no intention of losing that power.

Let us return to the Party Congress that they cite as evidence of the formation of a “criminal organization.” A few months after the November 2023 “Change” Congress, the local elections were held in March 2024. For the first time in many years, the CHP became Türkiye's leading party! The CHP won local administrations in areas where 70 percent of our people live! In Istanbul, my companions and I won for the third time, this time by a margin of 1.1 million votes! Istanbul won!

Is it not obvious why that Congress disturbed them so deeply? Is it not obvious why they are terrified of change? Is it not obvious that this change will bring an end to a government that has been in office for 24 years and creates more problems every day? This is our greatest crime: making the CHP the leading party and turning it, in the hearts of our nation, into a genuine alternative capable of governing!

That is why the true purpose of this indictment, which explicitly targets the CHP Congress and the change within the CHP, is to eliminate the democratic opposition.

As this indictment makes clear, March 19 and May 21 are, in essence, two stages of the same coup. March 19 was its first stage; May 21 was its second. The ultimate aim of this great coup, carried out by using the judiciary as an instrument, is to eliminate an opposition capable of offering an alternative government and replace it with a puppet main opposition—one that exists merely for show, with neither the ability nor the ambition to change those in power.

Only a mentality that has learned nothing of democracy, one intent on imposing a profoundly dark one-man system upon our country, could produce an indictment attacking the main opposition party.

And the main opposition party in question is no ordinary party! It is the founding party of our country, the Republican People's Party, founded by Mustafa Kemal Atatürk and now Türkiye's leading political party!

Once before, the CHP was shut down along with all other political parties by the generals who carried out the September 12 military coup. Now, through what the text here calls the coups of May 19 and May 21, the government is seeking to install Erdoğan's appointed

trustee at the head of the CHP and shut the party down in practice. This alone is enough to justify our describing March 19 as a coup.

The government that orchestrated the coups of March 19 and May 21 is, in truth, the heir to September 12!

We must look at the whole picture. This is no longer merely a question concerning the CHP. It is a question of ending the multiparty system and ending democratic elections!

I must say a few words about the mentality behind coups and the appointment of trustees. Former Chairman Kemal Kılıçdaroğlu, who accepted the role of puppet trustee in the unlawful "nullity" coup against the CHP, has unfortunately managed to place his name at the very top of one of the darkest pages of betrayal in Turkish political history.

After losing a general election, he failed to respond to the winds of change within the party and the expectations that came with them. Then, despite losing the party chairmanship at the 38th Congress, he was still unable to let go. He stood by while insidious conspiracies, schemes, and acts of betrayal were devised.

Although he had declared that he had nothing to do with any of this, that it had nothing to do with him, that he would work to put matters right, and that he stood by me in every way, he instead pursued processes and strategies to the contrary and joined those who devised these treacherous schemes.

He has received the answer he deserves in the conscience of CHP supporters, our people, and everyone who believes in democracy and justice. And he will continue to receive that answer.

It is deeply distressing to see a person fall into such a condition after the age of 78. He is now someone who should no longer occupy our thoughts or much of our time.

He should, of course, be seen as someone who has harmed democracy and stood on the side of oppressors, despots, and the dark order. Lessons must be drawn from this, and it must not be forgotten!

Source notes

[8] See Table 6 in the original book.

Source-text discrepancy: On printed page 98 the Turkish reads "19 ve 21 Mayıs darbesiyle" ("the coups of May 19 and 21"); elsewhere, including the next sentence, it refers to March 19 and May 21. The printed wording has been preserved rather than silently amended.

Continuity: The final sentence above is completed using the first line of printed page 99. The next translated installment will continue with the next full paragraph on that page.

Our Crime Is Defending the People's Rights; Our Crime Is Succeeding

Original printed pages 99–102

Today, he has one final opportunity to change the pitiful and distressing position in which he finds himself. The former Party Chairman, now the “palace-appointed trustee,” has one last way out. He must make a decision, a choice. Either he will go down in history as a puppet who helped entrench the rule of a despotic, autocratic, plundering oligarchic clique, or he will immediately—without the slightest delay or delaying tactic—convene a CHP congress and hand the party back to its legitimate, elected leadership. Either he will be remembered as a Hızır Pasha, a tool in the hands of oppressors, or he will be remembered with dignity for his contribution to the policy of reconciliation in politics. This coup is a move to put an end to democracy in Türkiye!

That is why the coups of March 19 and May 21 are not merely about Özgür Özel, Ekrem İmamoğlu, or the CHP. This case, and what has been done to the CHP, concern the Republic of Türkiye, democracy, and the sovereignty of the nation! This is a struggle between those who seek to protect our Republic and those who seek to destroy the constitutional order!

Turning the İBB's Structure into a “Criminal Organization” Betrays Ignorance of How the State Works!

First, let us ask a straightforward question: Why are my companions and I standing trial on the accusation of belonging to a “criminal organization”? For two fundamental reasons. First, to put us in prison. Because “leadership of a criminal organization” is listed among the statutory catalogue offenses, the prosecution imagined that this would clear the way for us to be detained pending trial. This is a classic method in fabricated prosecutions: abusing the designation of a catalogue offense.

The second reason is to shape public perceptions. They imagine that by repeatedly using the phrase “criminal organization,” they can convince people that some enormous crime has been committed and spread fear throughout society.

These are classic methods of a frame-up. By using a designation as frightening and grave-sounding as “criminal organization,” they found a way to accuse and imprison everyone, from our security officers to the people who serve our tea. And so people with absolutely no connection to one another, accused of acts with absolutely no connection to one another, were gathered into a single case before a high criminal court instead of being tried in 143 separate cases before criminal courts of first instance. Of course, in reality, those 143 cases would have

amounted to nothing but rubbish as well. Everything was done to create the impression of “the corruption scandal of the century,” the greatest lie in the world.

And that was still not enough. You put pressure on people through their families. How many children did you knowingly separate from their mothers? And all of it without a shred of evidence, on the basis of a fabricated “criminal organization” label...

There is, of course, no “criminal organization” here. There is the honorable administration of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality. There are hundreds of patriotic İBB administrators! There are our civil servants, drivers, and employees, working with everything they have!

I address those in power: There is no need whatsoever for these absurd “criminal organization” labels. I have said this time and again, and I will say it plainly once more: It is me you are after! Do not compound your wrongdoing. Release all my companions immediately! I am prepared to pay a price so that democracy does not die in Türkiye, but leave my companions alone! What you call an “organizational chart” is the İBB's administrative structure, apart from a few names artificially spliced into it!

And speaking of those “few names artificially spliced in,” let us examine more closely the individuals whom the prosecution describes as the senior leadership of this supposed “organization.” According to the prosecution, one of its six senior leaders is Hüseyin Gün. I have already spoken about Hüseyin Gün. For heaven's sake, what kind of “criminal organization” is this? I have seen one of its supposed six top leaders only once in my entire life, for five minutes!

According to the prosecution, another senior leader of this alleged organization is Murat Gülibrahimoğlu. I will explain his position in greater detail when I discuss Cebeci. Murat Gülibrahimoğlu is a businessman who has been closely involved with the AKP throughout his life and who, through his connections to those in power, has operated in Cebeci since long before our time. In the most recent Istanbul election, he supported my opponent and channeled millions to media outlets supporting that opponent and to foundations run by President Erdoğan's family!

According to the prosecution, yet another senior figure in the supposed organization is Adem Soytekin. He said it himself in his testimony here: He does not accept that any such “organization” exists. He stated openly that the expressions “system” and “organization” were not his words, but part of a “template” placed before him by the prosecution, which he was compelled to sign.

We all remember the hearing. When the prosecutor reminded Soytekin of the statement attributed to him describing “a criminal organization for financial gain whose foundations were laid in Beylikdüzü and which spread throughout the whole of Istanbul,” Adem Soytekin replied:

> *“I saw that statement as a template; those words were not mine. I regarded it as a template. Otherwise, how could I possibly have known in 2014 that Mr. Ekrem would become a candidate in Beylikdüzü, or be nominated? He would be nominated, then Mr.*

> *Ekrem would be elected in 2024, and afterward become President... That would be rather fanciful. So I understood it as a template question put to me."*

Thus everyone understood that the central "script" of this indictment of slander did not come from a supposed cooperating witness claiming "effective remorse"; it came directly from the prosecutor!

According to the prosecution, another senior leader of the supposed organization is Ertan Yıldız.

The late Yalçın Küçük described making confessions as "a person vomiting up their own self." He put it very well. May God rest his soul.

Then come the words, "I heard," "I had heard," "That was my understanding..." Thousands of them. And what comes next?

A 4,000-page indictment... But there is nothing in it. Four thousand pages, merely to conceal the absence of substance. A system that renders people helpless cannot be a system of justice. Manufacturing statements of "effective remorse" out of that helplessness cannot be called a trial! This is a frame-up. This is a coup.

We also discovered that the word "system," just like the word "template," is nothing more than a lie introduced by politically motivated prosecutors to manipulate perceptions. The word first appeared in the Aziz İhsan Aktaş case. And, remarkably, anyone who used the word "system" in a slanderous statement was immediately released.

The key to release: signing, without question, the "template" prepared by the prosecution, containing the word "system"!

The remaining two leaders of the supposed "criminal organization" are my deeply valued companions: Murat Ongun, my press adviser for twelve years, and Fatih Keleş, my political companion for seventeen years and President of the İBB Sports Club.

Some "organization" this is!

If so many lives had not been devastated, I would call it tragicomic. But as things stand, it is simply tragic, malicious, and absurd.

* * *

As I said, apart from a few names artificially inserted into it, the chart of the alleged "organization" is actually the İBB's administrative organizational chart. Turning the İBB's administrative structure into the chart of a criminal organization—is that what you are doing? It is a disgrace to the rule of law!

I never imagined that one day I would have to explain the most fundamental principles of administrative law before a court! The structure that the prosecution describes as a “criminal organization” is the very structure of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, defined down to the smallest detail in our Constitution and laws!

If there is an “organization,” it is the Metropolitan Municipality's organization, established by law and fully compliant with the applicable legislation! Let me explain this briefly as well.

The İBB is part of the institutional structure of the state. Its institutional organization is determined by our Constitution and laws, and it is subject to administrative tutelage and oversight by the central government.

The prosecution knows these things perfectly well. But to achieve its objective of keeping us captive, it chooses to pretend otherwise. In this trial, the İBB's lawful administrative organization is being portrayed as a supposed “criminal organization” in order to keep us in prison!

In response to this malicious approach, I will first explain that this historic, deeply established institution was created by our state, that every moment of its operations is subject to the state's powers of oversight and administrative tutelage, and that my companions and I did nothing more than work day and night in the service of this respected institution.

Let us remind those trying to turn the İBB into a “criminal organization” of a few basic facts. For example, let me explain the principle of the unity of administration and the extensive power of administrative tutelage that the government—the central administration—exercises over local authorities.

Türkiye's administrative structure consists of two main parts: central administration and local, or decentralized, administration. Article 127 of our Constitution expressly establishes the central government's power of “administrative tutelage” over local administrations—that is, its authority to supervise decentralized government.

The purpose of this structure is to ensure that public services throughout the country are carried out effectively, efficiently, and lawfully, in accordance with the principle of the unity of administration. In short, local authorities operate within the unity of administration, under extensive and powerful supervision.

Since the transition to the Presidential Government System in 2017, the President has been the sole holder of executive power and the head of state. There are numerous institutions through which the central administration headed by the President exercises its powers of administrative tutelage.

Moreover, throughout my term as Mayor of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, the leadership of all these institutions was appointed either by the President or by the President's party in the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye.

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Let us examine these institutions one by one.

The State Supervisory Council: It has extensive powers of oversight, and the President appoints all its members.

The Court of Accounts: Acting on behalf of the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye, it examines and audits the accounts of municipalities and their affiliated companies in detail every year. Its members are appointed by the ruling party's majority in Parliament.

The Ministry of Interior: It, too, has extensive powers of administrative tutelage over municipalities. It exercises these powers primarily through provincial governors' offices and civil administration inspectors. Governors have comprehensive powers of administrative tutelage, general administration, and supervision over municipalities on behalf of the President! Civil administration inspectors have scrutinized every account, every transaction, and every tender of our municipality and its affiliated bodies! During our time in office, they made full use of their powers to conduct preliminary examinations and investigations!

Inspectors from the Ministry of Trade audit municipal companies. Indeed, several companies affiliated with the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality were audited under these powers between 2019 and 2025—for the first time.

The Ministry of Environment, Urbanization and Climate Change sets standards for municipalities' organizational structures, vehicles, and staffing, and monitors their investments. Take careful note of this: the most important executives of the supposed İBB “organization”—the İBB Secretary-General, the General Manager of İSKİ, and the General Manager of İETT—are appointed with the approval of the Minister of Environment, Urbanization and Climate Change!

The Ministry of Treasury and Finance approves and supervises all foreign loans taken out by municipalities. MASAK, the Financial Crimes Investigation Board, and the Banking Regulation and Supervision Agency (BDDK) also exercise extensive investigative and supervisory powers on behalf of the Ministry.

The Ministry of Labour and Social Security conducts inspections through its own inspectors.

Finally, numerous other bodies attached to the central administration—including the Human Rights and Equality Institution of Türkiye (TİHEK), the Personal Data Protection Authority

(KVKK), the Ombudsman Institution (KDK), and the Energy Market Regulatory Authority (EPDK)—supervise municipalities within their respective areas of responsibility.

Under our legislation, the central administration possesses powers of “administrative tutelage” over local authorities to ensure that local public services are delivered in accordance with the principle of the unity of administration, that public administration remains coordinated, and for similar purposes.

In short, throughout our entire time at the İBB, those in power possessed extraordinarily extensive powers of supervision and administrative tutelage over us! And they exercised those powers to the fullest. Yet it never occurred to anyone to accuse us of wrongdoing, and no one called us a “criminal organization.”

Now, if we follow the logic of this so-called indictment, are we supposed to believe that, although the state, the President, and the ministries and institutions under his authority were responsible for supervising us, they somehow failed to notice for six whole years that a “criminal organization” was governing Türkiye's largest city?

Give me a break!

* * *

What is more, our administration was subjected to an unprecedented volume of external audits and inspections. The state itself certified that we had governed the municipality honestly and well!

As I have just explained, numerous external oversight bodies supervise our municipality. There are also different forms of external oversight: general inspections, special inspections, audits and formal inquiries by the Court of Accounts, examinations by governorates, preliminary examinations, and investigations.

I need to explain some of the external audits carried out during our term, shown in this table,[9] so that you can better understand the absurdity of the indictment before you.

Between 2014 and 2019, under AKP administration, the İBB underwent a total of 147 external audits.

— During our term, that total reached 1,590! We were audited eleven times as often!

— We also underwent two separate comprehensive inspections: one special inspection and one general inspection.

— It would be no exaggeration to say that, during our administration, the İBB was being inspected every day, on virtually every subject!

And do you know what the result was? No loss to public funds was identified!

As you can see from the table, we were subjected to many different kinds of scrutiny. Let me explain each category briefly.

Preliminary examinations and investigations:

— Between 2014 and 2019, the Ministry of Interior conducted a total of 26 examinations, inquiries, and preliminary examinations concerning İBB mayors Kadir Topbaş and Mevlüt Uysal. Permission to open an investigation was granted in only one case.

— I, on the other hand, was subjected to 46 examinations, inquiries, and preliminary examinations. Permission to investigate was granted in 13 of them.

I will give just a few examples below. The Ministry of Interior granted permission to investigate us over matters so absurd that it is difficult to imagine anything more ridiculous.[10]

During the pandemic, we launched a solidarity campaign together with eleven CHP-led metropolitan municipalities. For that, 60 million Turkish lira of our funds, in today's money, were seized! They seized money intended to help our people in their hour of need!

We were investigated because I stood with my hands on my hips while waiting for a commemorative ceremony to begin at the tomb of Sultan Mehmed the Conqueror, on the 567th anniversary of the conquest of Istanbul.

Because we displayed posters reading “Either the Canal or Istanbul” and “Who Needs Canal Istanbul?” to inform Istanbul residents about our objections to the Canal Istanbul project...

Because we purchased a portrait of Sultan Mehmed the Conqueror, attributed to the workshop of the celebrated Italian painter Bellini, at an auction in London and brought it back to its homeland...

Because our Istanbul Foundation, which has existed for more than thirty years and has been used by successive mayors for charitable purposes, installed kiosks together with İSBAK to collect donations...

Investigations were opened because we established 127 childcare centres that employed young women and provided mothers with an essential social service—childcare. The Ministry of National Education had previously sent a letter demanding that these centres be “shut down.”

Of course, they asked questions, and I answered them. I never avoided being investigated, because there was not a single action of mine for which I could not account.

Let us also take a closer look at the audits and formal inquiries of the Court of Accounts.

— Under the AKP administration, the Court of Accounts audited the İBB only five times, and raised only one formal inquiry. During our term, the İBB, İSKİ, İETT, and our affiliated companies were audited a total of 82 times, with dozens of Court of Accounts auditors

conducting examinations every year. So far, those audits have resulted in 16 formal inquiries directed at me.

We were audited by the Court of Accounts more than sixteen times as often as in the preceding term!

We see a very similar picture in the inspections carried out by civil administration inspectors.

Under AKP administration, those inspectors audited the municipality 115 times. During our term, they carried out 1,042 inspections! An entire large floor of the İBB building was set aside for them. They examined and scrutinized our municipality in minute detail!

We were inspected by civil administration inspectors more than nine times as often as during the previous administration!

— Finally, as I mentioned earlier, there are dozens of other institutions empowered to inspect municipalities. Between 2014 and 2019, under AKP administration, these institutions carried out no inspections whatsoever at the İBB. Zero!

— During our administration, however, they conducted 378 inspections!

I should also say a little about the inspections that most strikingly demonstrate the extent of the ruling government's scrutiny of our municipality.

The Ministry of Interior's civil administration inspectors may conduct a general inspection, in which they request and examine every document and every piece of information held by the municipality, or a special inspection focused on a particular matter.

Before we took office, the Ministry of Interior had last carried out a general inspection of the İBB in 2012. For seven years, there had been no such inspection! Not one!

During our term, however, the İBB was inspected twice: once through a special inspection and once through a general inspection.

General inspection: Between December 9, 2024, and January 17, 2025, the Ministry of Interior's Civil Administration Inspection Board conducted a general inspection of all the activities and transactions of the İBB, İSKİ, and İETT covering the five-year period from January 1, 2020, to January 17, 2025. The inspection was coordinated by eight civil administration inspectors, with assistance from specialists in the relevant fields.

In other words, a very large team from the Ministry of Interior, under the coordination of eight inspectors, scrutinized five years of our administration for weeks. And the reports produced following this general inspection of the İBB, İSKİ, and İETT identified no loss to public funds!

Special inspection: You will remember that the then Minister of Interior, Süleyman Soylu, claimed that 557 terrorists had been employed by the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, İSKİ,

İETT, and their affiliated companies. Immediately afterward, on December 27, 2021, he launched a special inspection with great fanfare!

Under the coordination of Arif Yıldırım—a chief civil administration inspector at the Ministry of Interior who had previously sought nomination as an AKP parliamentary candidate—the inspection team included four civil administration inspectors, one chief inspector from the Ministry of Trade, one chief inspector from the Ministry of Treasury and Finance, MASAK, and more than fifty specialists.

For approximately nine months, from December 27, 2021, to August 26, 2022, they subjected all the İBB's personnel matters, tenders, workplace-opening and operating licences, and other activities and transactions from the 2019–2021 period to a special inspection. And the result? They established neither that a single terrorist had been hired nor that any irregularity or corruption had occurred in the tenders!

In short, their accusations did not hold up.

[9] See Table 7 in the original book.

[10] See Table 8 in the original book.

Translation continuity: The first sentence of printed page 103 was already completed in the preceding installment and is not repeated here. The final inspection narrative is completed with the opening lines of printed page 107, so that the sentence is not broken across PDFs.

CHAPTER THREE — CONTINUED

Our Crime Is Defending the People's Rights; Our Crime Is Succeeding

Original printed pages 107–110

Süleyman Soylu's lawyer later wrote to the court that these blatant slanders had been uttered “for political purposes” and “within the scope of freedom of expression”!

It should not be so easy to spend public money on such baseless investigations. Nor should it be so easy to slander people and trample on their dignity!

It is especially important today to remember how readily this government can resort to slander for political ends. Because we are once again facing accusations that defy belief.

Those who read today's catalogues of slander and think, “There cannot be such blatant lies; no one could be so utterly devoid of conscience; perhaps there is some truth to it,” should remember how, at the end of 2021, the government loudly proclaimed that the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality was a haven for terrorists. Of course, it all turned out to be lies and slander.

* * *

One truth is beyond dispute: my colleagues and I were the most extensively audited team in Türkiye!

As I have just explained, over six years, every state institution—from the Court of Accounts and the Ministry of Interior's inspectors to KVK, the Ministry of Labour, the Ministry of Trade, and MASAK—all the institutions controlled by the government, scrutinized, audited, and investigated Ekrem İmamoğlu and his colleagues **1,590 times**, with unprecedented determination, and found no wrongdoing whatsoever!

Yet the prosecution expects us to believe this: “Forget these facts. Disregard these countless audits. Instead, convict Ekrem İmamoğlu and his colleagues on the strength of hearsay from a handful of slanderers who have since withdrawn their accusations, repented, or listened to their consciences!”

Is that so? Give me a break!

The prosecutors' argument is a grave insult to every institution of our state. For six years, my colleagues and I were the most thoroughly audited team in Türkiye. I could almost say that, throughout our term, the inspectors never left the municipality.

And what was the outcome? **Those 1,590 audits and inspections confirmed the integrity of our administration!**

Today, I speak not merely on my own behalf, but on behalf of everyone who has carried out public service honestly and transparently, above all my colleagues. When those 1,590 audits, together with one general inspection and one special inspection, failed to produce a single allegation of corruption that could be sustained against my colleagues or me, a decision was taken to imprison

us on purely political grounds, with the cooperation of a few highly questionable secret witnesses. That is the essence of why we are here.

This is a so-called case launched by President Erdoğan because, having realized that he could no longer win another election, he feared competing against his rival and sought to eliminate him. In reality, it is a politically orchestrated case, a coup carried out by turning the judiciary into an instrument of power!

This is a political frame-up! This is a coup against the democratic opposition! This is a coup against the Republic and the nation's sovereign right to govern itself!

* * *

As I explained a moment ago, the state's institutions found no loss to public funds during our administration. The Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality also submitted documentary confirmation of that finding to the case file. Indeed, precisely because no loss to public funds had been established, the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality did not join this case as a participating party.[11]

In an official circular dated **December 6, 2025**, numbered **2668168**, the Office of the Mayor of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality asked İBB departments, its affiliated bodies (İSKİ and İETT), and all its subsidiary companies whether any **final determination of loss to public funds or to a company** had been made following internal or external audits conducted since **June 23, 2019**.

I shall read from the response dated **December 22, 2025**, numbered **2809558**, issued by the Department of Correspondence and Decisions after the replies had been collected:

> “...According to letters bearing various dates and reference numbers received from the Internal Audit Unit, the Guidance and Inspection Board, the Department of Financial Services, the General Directorates of İETT and İSKİ (their Guidance and Inspection Boards, Internal Audit Units, and Departments of Financial Services), and 30 subsidiary companies, no final determination of loss to public funds has been made in relation to the period following 23.06.2019; [...]

>

> The tender procedures, personnel matters, workplace-opening and operating licences, and related activities and transactions of İBB, İSKİ, İETT, and their subsidiary companies during the period 01.01.2019–31.12.2021 were subjected in 2022 to a special inspection coordinated by civil administration inspectors of the Ministry of Interior, with the participation of a chief inspector from the Ministry of Treasury and Finance, a chief inspector from the Ministry of Trade, and experts from the Financial Crimes Investigation Board (MASAK);

>

> Furthermore, the activities and transactions of İBB, İSKİ, İETT, and their subsidiary companies carried out between 01.01.2020 and 17.01.2025 were subjected to a general inspection by civil administration inspectors of the Ministry of Interior;

>

> The reports prepared following all these audits, together with the special and general inspections conducted by Ministry of Interior inspectors, contained no finding of a final determination of loss to public funds...”

That is what the official response states.

If, throughout our entire administration, the public suffered no loss—as determined by institutions controlled by the government—then what are we even discussing here? Why are we standing here now, inside this prison complex, in a place pretending to be a courtroom? Why have my colleagues and I been deprived of our liberty? How can you conjure a “criminal organization” out of an Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality that has caused no loss to the public?

* * *

This malicious mentality tells us: yes, no loss to public funds was established during Ekrem İmamoğlu's administration of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality; no money went from İBB's coffers into anyone's pockets. Yet somehow there is a vast criminal organization, the corruption scandal of the century!

How can you treat honest public officials who have caused no loss to the public as hardened criminals? Every one of the public servants you see here, my colleagues, is honest and patriotic! There is not a single piece of evidence against any of them!

You have seen their MASAK reports and examined their assets here in this courtroom. Did you find even one instance of unexplained enrichment involving any of them? No! Not a single instance!

Then why have these people been held hostage in prison for almost a year and a half? This is an appalling lack of conscience!

Are the rumours spread by a few dubious secret witnesses somehow worth more, or more reliable, than the findings of all our state institutions, their inspectors, and the experts of the Court of Accounts?

This is an insult to our state, an insult to every one of its institutions!

Dozens of elected mayors and public officials were detained and imprisoned on the basis of vague statements from a few secret witnesses—statements along the lines of “I heard” or “I suppose.” People were then threatened through their families and assets, and slanderous statements were extracted under pressure.

Take a look at this table. Here is the indictment of slander in a nutshell...[12]

The circumstances surrounding the witnesses on whom this indictment of slander relies are themselves profoundly murky and suspect.

During the investigation, at least **17 secret witnesses** were brought forward to inflate the case file and create a false public impression. But when the matter reached the courtroom, where claims must be weighed against the truth, that swollen list suddenly evaporated, and your court summoned only **eight** of them to testify. This enormous fortress of lies, erected to mislead justice, had already crumbled at the courthouse door.

Of the few people whom the court decided to hear, the supposed witness who made the greatest number of accusations—and whom my colleagues have described and you have questioned—is the person using the code name **“İlke.”**

The fabrication is so amateurish, so devoid of morality, that they took false statements attributed to another secret witness they had invented, called **“Meşe,”** copied them shamelessly, and loaded them onto “İlke.”

Yet even “İlke,” on whom those statements were foisted, refused to be made a party to this dirty game. That person submitted a formal petition declaring, **“I do not wish to act as a secret witness,”** and withdrew from the scheme. And this happened back in **2024**.

This machinery of blackmail and fabrication was operated so recklessly that other witnesses named in the file also objected. When a witness named **Orhan Alkan** discovered that rumours he had heard in the media had been entered into the file as though they were his formal testimony, he immediately sought legal recourse. In his petition, he stressed that he had made no statement in the case before you, whether as a person with relevant information or as a witness, and demanded that his name be removed at once from this file full of lies.

Now let us turn to another “witness,” **Ahmet Taşçı**...

The people on trial here have repeatedly stated in their testimony that prosecutors added words they never uttered to the official records. Even the judicial panel expressed skepticism and asked, **“Did you not have a lawyer with you? Did you not read the text before signing it?”**

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[11] See Table 9 in the original book.

[12] See Table 10 in the original book.

Translation continuity: The special-inspection sentence that begins on printed page 106 was completed in the preceding PDF and is not repeated. The final question above includes the opening line of printed page 111 to keep the court's quotation intact. The remainder of page 111 will follow in the next installment.

CHAPTER THREE — CONTINUED

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Original printed pages 111–114

But we can now see that the prosecution did not confine this practice of adding words people never uttered to official records to the defendants. They have subjected even witnesses to the same disgraceful frame-up!

We can substantiate everything we say. We speak the truth, our record is clean, and everything we have done is entirely lawful. The prosecution knows this perfectly well. Yet it questions someone as a supposed witness and then enters into the case file and official record words that person never said. The witness personally acknowledged that the prosecutors had distorted their words, transformed what they had said into something entirely different, and entered it into the file, without their consent, as a secret-witness statement.

The person withdrew as a witness, explaining that everything they had related was based entirely on secondhand hearsay. It is not enough for them to intimidate, blackmail, and exert pressure. The prosecution either fabricates vague falsehoods under the cover of secret witnesses or uses coercion and deceit to insert into the case file statements that even identified witnesses never made!

Most of these “secret witnesses” have extensive criminal records. Some have stood trial, or are still standing trial, for disgraceful offenses! Just think: almost all of them have problems of their own with the justice system. We know very well what they are being told: “Tell a lie, make a false accusation against İmamoğlu, and your own cases will disappear.”

We all know how this government operates. Did they not do the same thing to mayors, turning the judiciary into an instrument of their own interests? We have seen with our own eyes dozens of examples of the message: “Join the AKP and you will be acquitted in every case against you.”

We know only too well the psychological violence and impossible predicaments into which this machinery of fabricated charges drives people.

And so this indictment of slander before you has been built on coffeehouse gossip supplied by a handful of questionable individuals. The most appalling coffeehouse gossip imaginable!

* * *

This is no state governed by the rule of law. It is nothing but the law of the jungle!

If a few dubious secret witnesses know better than all these institutions of the state, then let us close every one of those oversight bodies. Let every government find three or five secret witnesses, put pressure on them, extract a few scraps of gossip, and prosecute everyone who displeases those in power—elected officials and civil servants alike—and even keep them detained while they stand trial!

Do you truly understand the danger of the judicial precedent you are creating? Can a state be run like this? Can such a thing be called a state governed by the rule of law?

The rule of law means a system in which those in government, those in opposition, and all 86 million citizens are subject to the same rules of fair trial.

To accuse my colleagues and me of corruption after we have been audited **1,600 times** is absurd. It is incompatible with law, conscience, and morality!

I want to read Article 2 of our Constitution to you:

> "The Republic of Türkiye is a democratic, secular and social state governed by the rule of law, respectful of human rights, in a spirit of social peace, national solidarity and justice, loyal to the nationalism of Atatürk, and based on the fundamental principles set forth in the Preamble."

Look closely. Under our Constitution, justice, respect for human rights, and the character of the state as one governed by the rule of law are among the most fundamental and defining features of our Republic. To tear down the rule of law is to destroy our constitutional order.

As you know, this is an extremely serious offense. In our Turkish Penal Code, under the section entitled "Offenses Against the Constitutional Order and Its Functioning," **"Violation of the Constitution"** is among the gravest offenses: the offense of attempting to abolish the order prescribed by the Constitution or to prevent that order from operating in practice.

Those who commit this offense will, when the day comes, be held accountable through a fair trial.

Having held public office for eleven years and worked alongside thousands of honorable, patriotic public servants, I know better than most the sacrifices public employees make.

And I know better than anyone how hard you, my colleagues at İBB, have worked, under what difficult conditions, with what sense of responsibility and love of country.

I will never allow your rights to be trampled upon!

* * *

To describe İBB's organizational structure as a "criminal organization" defies reason.

I would therefore like to explain briefly the organizational structure and management responsibilities of İBB, which the prosecution calls a supposed criminal organization.

İBB consists of the Mayor, the Municipal Council, the Municipal Executive Committee, İSKİ, İETT, UKOME, AYKOME, the Guidance and Inspection Board, the Internal Audit Unit, the Private Secretariat, advisers, the General Secretariat, the Legal Counsel's Office, seven Deputy General Secretariats with 30 departments and 123 directorates reporting to them, and 30 subsidiary companies under the Subsidiaries Coordination Branch Directorate.[13]

İBB's organizational structure was established under the law as part of the administrative organization of the Republic of Türkiye. To portray that structure as some sort of organized crime group, as has been done in this process, is beyond comprehension.

I must emphasize that it is the state itself that determines İBB's structure and operations. For example, even if I wanted to, I could not increase the number of Deputy General Secretariats from

seven to eight.

Although I am the head of İBB, an institution established by law, above me stand the governor, the ministers, and, at the top, the President.

İBB is an immense institution, with approximately **93,000 employees**, now carrying out its work more effectively and efficiently. It has dozens of department heads, general managers of subsidiary companies, deputy general managers, and directors with signing authority. There are more than **1,000 senior managers** at director level or above alone!

By the logic of this indictment, the President is the head of the “organization.” After all, under the principle of the unity of the administration, İBB—the institution now described as a “criminal organization”—is hierarchically connected to the President.

As I explained a moment ago, the governor's office exercises administrative tutelage over our municipality on behalf of the President. (The President holds executive authority and has disciplinary-supervisory authority over all public officials serving in public administrations. Ministers, in turn, are the highest executive authorities responsible for the delivery of public services. Governors are the highest administrative authorities in their provinces and are responsible for ensuring that those services continue without interruption.)

As the highest-ranking official within İBB, I have the authority and responsibility to direct and manage the municipal administration. But İBB is a vast institution employing **93,000 people**, which has conducted **114,000 tenders in six years**. That is precisely why İBB, İSKİ, and İETT have Guidance and Inspection Boards and Internal Audit Units to carry out oversight.

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[13] See Table 11 in the original book.

Each of our subsidiary companies, established under the Commercial Code and possessing its own separate legal personality, also has internal and external audit mechanisms and disciplinary boards.

As I have said, the mayor is the highest-ranking official responsible for overseeing the municipality's management, financial operations, and use of public resources. I carried out my work with a full awareness of this oversight responsibility, and I took it extremely seriously.

I have always been a manager who understood very well the consequences of a mayor's failure to fulfill those obligations, and who consistently relied on capable, qualified people within the institutional structure.

As the highest-ranking official of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, from my first day in office I directed and managed the organization with a view to protecting the municipality's rights and interests as effectively as possible. In every action and transaction, I kept the public interest foremost. I made every effort to ensure that procedures were conducted transparently, accountably, and in accordance with the law. As mayor, I fulfilled my duties and responsibilities in compliance with the law.

Meanwhile, governors and ministers—and above all the President, the sole holder of executive authority—bear the same authority and responsibility, and indeed more. Have they undergone as much scrutiny as I have? Have they discharged those responsibilities?

My colleagues and I passed those tests successfully, with our heads held high!

* * *

Far from establishing a “criminal organization,” I have already described the external scrutiny we faced. And on top of that, we introduced internal auditing at İBB!

We opened İBB to scrutiny by the people! **We made all the walls of İBB transparent!**

I acted with determination to ensure that the internal audit system within the municipality functioned effectively, so that problems such as irregularities, corruption, and favoritism would not arise in the metropolitan administration and undermine public trust, damage its reputation, or lead to the misuse of municipal financial resources.

For the first time, effective internal audit systems were established at İBB.

As I explained earlier, after 2019 our municipality was already subjected, on a scale never seen before, to extraordinary external scrutiny by all the public institutions acting under the government's authority.

Translation continuity: The court's question at the beginning of printed page 111 was completed in the preceding installment and is not repeated here. The sentence crossing from printed page 114 onto page 115 has been completed here; the next installment will continue with the discussion of internal auditing.

CHAPTER THREE — CONTINUED

Our Crime Is Defending the People's Rights; Our Crime Is Succeeding

English translation · Original printed pages 115–118

As for **internal auditing**, my colleagues and I did everything we could to make effective the internal audit systems that had never previously been put into practice. We worked constantly toward that goal. Would someone intent on establishing a "criminal organization" strengthen internal oversight? Come on!

Not everyone may know this, but İBB is subject to internal oversight by the İBB Guidance and Inspection Board, the İBB Internal Audit Unit, and the İBB Municipal Council Audit Commission.

Let me explain what we did.

1. First, we established a system of recordkeeping. Effective auditing requires records. Just imagine: before our administration, electronic signatures were virtually nonexistent at İBB! As soon as I took office, we ensured that all official correspondence would be conducted and signed electronically, allowing every action and transaction to be archived transparently and accountably. I ask you: would a manager who wanted to conceal wrongdoing or engage in corruption do such a thing?

2. We opened channels for complaints and applications concerning errors, irregularities, and corruption. We drafted and implemented a directive establishing procedures for reports and complaints. We made those procedures operational and introduced a way to submit them electronically.

3. We requested the recruitment of inspectors to strengthen internal auditing. But the İBB Municipal Council, where the AKP held the majority, rejected our request.

The İBB Guidance and Inspection Board examines, audits, and investigates every kind of municipal activity and transaction. It is a vital pillar of internal oversight.

We consistently sought to strengthen that Board. In 2020, for the first time in İBB's history, we recruited six qualified *assistant inspectors* through a process requiring the Public Personnel Selection Examination (KPSS) and involving both written and oral examinations. Our subsequent requests to recruit additional inspectors were blocked, first by the AKP-majority Municipal Council and then, regrettably, by the Presidency and the Ministry!

It is contrary to fairness, conscience, and the law to expect me, while protecting the municipality's rights and interests, to conduct audits personally as though I were an inspector. What you should have done was give me the means to strengthen oversight still further!

If I had intended to establish a "criminal organization" (!) in Istanbul, would I ever have sought to increase the number of inspectors? What kind of logic is that?

4. Oversight by the İBB Municipal Council, where the AKP held a majority, is another essential point. From 2019 to 2024, the AKP controlled the İBB Municipal Council. Do you know what that means? For five of the six years covered by the indictment, the AKP held the majority on the Municipal Council. The AKP controlled the Council!

The İBB Municipal Council is the municipality's highest decision-making and oversight body! The strongest form of internal oversight over our administration was the Council's scrutiny. Every important matter concerning İBB's management is subject to the Council's supervision and approval.

Besides such critical responsibilities as approving purchases and sales of immovable property, conditional donations, and development plans, the Council oversees the Mayor's Office and the administration through written questions. It also examines all our activities through the Municipal Council Audit Commission. For five years, that Commission was under AKP control and monitored and audited our every step!

After five years of scrutiny, they found no irregularity or corruption in violation of the law, identified no loss to public funds, and filed not a single criminal complaint. Did the AKP-controlled Municipal Council somehow fail to notice this enormous “criminal organization” for five years? Or did its members join the organization and become partners in it too?

5. The Municipal Executive Committee was also under AKP control for five years. This Committee is one of the municipality's most important and powerful bodies. For five of the six years covered by the indictment, it, too, was controlled by the AKP!

Every measure taken by our administration was carried out under the Committee's oversight and within the framework of its decisions. Between 2019 and 2024, while under AKP control, the İBB Municipal Executive Committee conducted exactly **878 tenders**. Most decisions were unanimous. Political dissent was recorded in only a very small proportion of cases; **95 percent of the tenders were approved**, and the AKP-controlled Committee made no criminal complaint concerning any tender!

The Committee's decisions were also reviewed by chief civil inspectors during both the special and general inspections, through the end of 2024, and no adverse finding was made. They were examined in annual audits by the Turkish Court of Accounts as well, with no audit query raised concerning the Committee's tenders.

Let me say it once more: for five years of our administration, the municipality's two most powerful bodies—the İBB Municipal Council and the Municipal Executive Committee—were under AKP control.

So the AKP, which challenged us every day in these municipal bodies and watched our every move, somehow failed to see the “corruption organization of the century”? Oh, come on!

6. We activated the Internal Audit Unit that had not been put to work under the AKP administration. During the AKP years, the İBB Internal Audit Unit had never been made operational. The number of audits conducted in İBB departments before 2019 was **zero**! This was a

serious irregularity. We filed the necessary criminal complaints, but of course no prosecutor took any interest in them...

Under our administration, internal audits were carried out across virtually every area of the municipality's departments. Between 2020 and 2025, exactly **140 internal audits** were conducted in our İBB units.

7. I introduced a mayoral authorization process so that audits could be carried out on any matter. I did not postpone problems, sweep them under the rug, or neglect them. In keeping with the principle of the unity of the administration, I chose to share the resulting reports with the relevant state institutions and agencies, so that problems could be resolved together.

Let me give you an example involving a much-discussed matter.

I authorized the İBB Guidance and Inspection Board to examine and investigate a site in Arnavutköy, to determine whether the dumping of excavated earth, which must be carried out in accordance with the Environmental Law, was being conducted in compliance with the regulations.

Following its work, the Inspection Board reported its findings to both the Governor's Office and the Istanbul Chief Public Prosecutor's Office on **August 14, 2023**. The prosecutor's office decided that there were **no grounds for prosecution**. Nevertheless, we ensured that municipal enforcement officers who had turned a blind eye to illegal dumping were dismissed from public service.

There is, incidentally, an important distinction here: unlike Cebeci, the site in Arnavutköy is **not a mining zone**. That is why we have a certain degree of oversight authority in Arnavutköy.

* * *

I have told you something about external and internal oversight. Do you know what else is crucial to running an honest and successful municipality? **Qualified people appointed on merit.** In serving the public interest, we treated merit as our foremost value.

I am a manager who knows his responsibilities very well and has discharged them with care. Because I understood those responsibilities, I always worked with qualified teams. I also consistently placed great importance on transparent and institutional governance, accountability, and effective financial management.

Let me tell you a little more about how a public institution should be run.

We made major improvements in merit-based management during our time in office.

If these five months of hearings have taught us anything, it is just how exceptionally qualified the people with whom we governed Istanbul were!

My dear companions, I am proud of every one of you! I knew that the more capable, knowledgeable, honest, and accomplished the managers I worked with, the better I could protect the public interest. My aim was to serve the people of Istanbul in the best possible way.

Far from establishing a “criminal organization,” we demonstrated how a public institution can be properly managed—how a state ought to be governed!

We built such strong teams that, despite nearly **100 of our senior managers being held in pretrial detention**, hundreds of our colleagues now standing trial, and my own imprisonment, Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality continues to serve **16 million Istanbulites** exceptionally well!

I want to thank once again my companions at İBB, who work day and night under all these difficulties and safeguard the responsibility entrusted to them. I am grateful for every one of you. May God bless you all! I thank each of you personally, and I am thankful that you are my companions in this struggle!

Everyone is surprised. No one can quite believe it...

Do you know what we owe this success to? To the institutional structure we built, our model of good governance, and of course our decision to work with competent managers at every level. We owe it to the fine people and capable managers you see here, who recruited and trained the right people to work alongside them and established sound institutional structures.

Our institutional strength came from our determination to build the highest-quality workforce possible. **We kept nepotism away from our door!** We rejected the practice of favoring friends, acquaintances, or relatives. We chose as our companions people who were trustworthy, honest, knowledgeable, and committed to serving their ideals.

Of course, we have had shortcomings, made mistakes, and been wrong at times. But in the overall quality of our administration, we acted not out of party favoritism, but according to the principle of giving the children of this nation equal opportunities.

We deprived no one of what was rightfully theirs, and we allowed no one else to do so!

Continuity note: The opening of printed page 115 completes a sentence already translated in the previous installment and is not repeated. The last sentence of printed page 118 is completed with its final words from page 119. The next installment begins with the following paragraph on nondiscrimination.

CHAPTER THREE — CONTINUED

Our Crime Is Defending the People's Rights; Our Crime Is Succeeding

English translation · Original printed pages 119–122

We never discriminated against anyone. We made no distinctions in the services we provided—not between districts, political views, ways of life, or beliefs—and we did not tolerate the slightest discrimination in recruitment. We never considered a candidate's identity, faith, political opinions, or party affiliation. **Merit was our only criterion.** We never subjected anyone else to the discrimination we ourselves had suffered.

We always stood with labor and working people. When we took office in 2019, we had approximately 15,000 unionized employees; today that number exceeds 70,000. We removed the barriers that prevented our colleagues from organizing and established a 40-hour working week for our employees.

We are the only institution to have signed agreements simultaneously with all three of Türkiye's labor confederations—Türk-İş, Hak-İş, and DİSK. Every year, we conduct and conclude dozens of collective bargaining negotiations peacefully. In their statements at the time, the leaders of these three major confederations praised the professional and worker-friendly approach taken by our İBB administration. All of them thanked us, describing the agreements we signed as “very important” and “exciting.”

From here, I ask the representatives of all three labor confederations: **Will you give Ekrem İmamoğlu and his companions your blessing?**

Merit Was Never Just a “Slogan” for Us: For the First Time, We Established Systems at İBB to Put It into Practice

Merit means appointing people to duties and responsibilities on the basis of their knowledge, skills, experience, and competence. It improves an institution's efficiency and the quality of its services, and is of great importance to public trust. By ensuring equal opportunity and fairness in public employment, and preventing discrimination, it also makes a substantial contribution to social peace.

Recruitment based on merit takes account of candidates' education, professional experience, abilities, and ethical values. We adopted the following methods to ensure merit-based recruitment at İBB.

First, we began publicly announcing every vacancy in our institution through transparent job postings. One of the very first things we did on taking office in June 2019 was to launch **kariyer.ibb.istanbul**, making every open position at İBB immediately visible to people throughout Türkiye. The platform made it possible for people throughout Türkiye to apply for jobs at İBB; the number of résumés submitted has now reached two million.

Young people and job seekers across Türkiye now know how to apply for work at İBB. They can apply, of their own free will and through their own efforts, for positions they believe suit them—without needing someone to slip them a note saying, **“The bearer of this card is a close acquaintance of mine.”** Young people, like all Istanbulites, have thus been able to apply with hope and confidence.

Second, every recruitment process was conducted with a level of transparency and objective assessment unprecedented in Türkiye. Vacancies were advertised through social media, İŞKUR, and other channels. On the basis of their scores in the Public Personnel Selection Examination (KPSS),

applicants were invited to practical tests and/or interviews. All tests and interviews took place in rooms arranged to ensure transparency and were video-recorded.

Candidates and institutional staff alike welcomed this process as a model for recruitment practices throughout public administration.

For the second category, employees of our municipal companies, the process was conducted with the same transparency and objectivity, except for the KPSS requirement, which does not apply to company employment.

The elimination from recruitment of the political references and personal connections relied upon before our administration generated tremendous enthusiasm, first and foremost among existing employees.

Most importantly, we never discriminated on political grounds. We applied the same commitment to fairness in promotions. **Sixty percent of the people we appointed to managerial positions came from within İBB**, having developed their careers in the institution before our administration took office.

Most of those appointed to İBB's senior management under my administration were not people I had known beforehand as friends, acquaintances, or associates. I imagine that has become abundantly clear over the course of these five months of hearings!

Many of the bureaucrats standing trial here passed a series of examinations and interviews. In many cases, they came to know me closely for the first time during this trial! Would an administration seeking to establish an “organization” and conduct secret dealings ever behave this way?

They applied or were recommended for the relevant positions entirely on the strength of their knowledge, skills, and experience; they passed the assessment procedures and were appointed accordingly. **We govern our institution through institutional values, not personal relationships.**

There is another matter I want to address here, one that is particularly important to me.

During our administration, the number of women in senior management positions **tripled**. For the first time, we had women serving as deputy secretaries-general. We employed women in fields and lines of work in which they had never previously been represented. Our determination to govern Istanbul together with women and men was always strong, and we put that determination into practice.

It can be done, when the will is there!

I am proud of my courageous women colleagues in this struggle. I will never forget you!

In essence, we accomplished at İBB what the government today cannot—or, more accurately, does not want to—accomplish in Ankara. Because we know that public trust can only be built on justice. We governed justly.

Two principles formed the foundations of our approach to governing the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality: **merit and collective wisdom.**

I have already spoken about merit. To me, “collective wisdom” means encouraging the participation of different stakeholders, consultation, and shared deliberation in every decision-making process, so that we may arrive at the best possible outcome.

Before making any decision, I attach great importance to collective wisdom and teamwork. Everyone who has worked with me will tell you that. It is perhaps my most distinctive quality as a manager. In public administration, this is indispensable—an essential means of minimizing mistakes. In this way, we strengthened democratic participation at İBB and guided Istanbul's development through collective wisdom.

Appointing the right people is vital. Equally important, however, is ensuring that managers work, think, and make decisions together in pursuit of the overall performance of such a large organization—and that performance is monitored. In short, this approach is called **“good governance.”**

The İBB governance model gives priority to making the best decisions for Istanbul together, continually sharing and developing knowledge and experience, and maintaining the highest possible efficiency.

One important reason Istanbulites entrusted us with office again in 2024, by a margin of **1.1 million votes**, was this strong governance model. It demonstrated how much merit-based appointments and cooperation among institutions matter.

Enough of this “criminal organization” nonsense! The İBB management model we have implemented since 2019 is a model that can serve as an example for public administration throughout our country.

That is what truly troubles Recep Tayyip Erdoğan's government: everyone in Istanbul, and indeed throughout Türkiye, has seen that Istanbul can be governed with justice and merit. **Eighty-six million people said, “So it can be done!”**

That is precisely why we trouble those in power so much.

The principal causes of the profound collapse we are experiencing in so many areas of our country today are nepotism, benefits bestowed on friends and relatives, politically appointed cadres without the necessary qualifications, and the refusal to seek collective wisdom. The whole of public administration has been sacrificed to partisanship. I will go further: this is an attempt to build **a party-state**!

Instead of calling us a “criminal organization,” why not learn a little from what we have done? But you cannot learn, and you do not want to. You have no intention of doing so. You lack the ability. It would not suit your interests. All that matters to you is the happiness of that privileged handful.

You have stifled this beautiful nation, made it unhappy, polarized it, and driven its people apart. You have secured comfortable lives for families within a small privileged circle. We can see this clearly in the three or four favored individuals to whom you awarded scholarships under earlier İBB administrations, and in the posts you handed out to your friends and relatives.

The amounts Erdoğan's administration awarded in scholarships to those three or four privileged individuals, we distributed fairly among thousands of students!

That is the difference between our understanding of public service and yours.

CHAPTER FOUR

A “CRIMINAL ORGANIZATION”?! QUITE THE OPPOSITE: WE PUT AN END TO THE AKP’S SYSTEM OF PROFITEERING AND WASTE AT THE ISTANBUL METROPOLITAN MUNICIPALITY!

English translation | Original printed pages 123–126

My dear nation,

As you have seen, our achievements over six years, our performance, and our practice of a “bountiful budget” — giving the people's money back to the people — are plain to see. And, as countless audits have shown, we achieved these results through honest administration.

There is therefore one thing we can all see clearly: This is not a “corruption trial”! Quite the opposite. My companions and I are being tried here because we brought an end to the entrenched system of profiteering and waste that existed before 2019, shutting off a vast source of illicit gain for those in power and the handful of people around them!

We have just seen that no loss to public funds was identified during our administration. But now let us look at the AKP years.

I can only address this briefly, because we were prevented from seeing the whole iceberg: the files we identified were seized, and no prosecutor's office pursued the matters.

Look: before we took office, not a single report had been drawn up concerning losses to public funds. For the first time during my administration, reports seeking recovery of those losses were prepared and sent to the Offices of the Chief Public Prosecutor, the Turkish Court of Accounts, the Ministry of the Interior, and the Office of the Governor of Istanbul.

We identified corruption amounting to $2.5 billion, backed by concrete evidence.

I particularly ask the journalists to listen very carefully to what I am about to explain.

I will describe only a small part of the corruption committed during the AKP period. Despite the destruction or removal of evidence, we found more than TRY 115 billion in corruption across 146 files supported not by “gossip,” but by concrete evidence.

We sent those files to the prosecutors' offices, the Turkish Court of Accounts, the Ministry of the Interior, the Istanbul Governor's Office, and the relevant district governorates.

Do you know what happened to them?

The Ministry of the Interior seized the files being investigated by our İBB inspectors — in a manner contrary to every established practice, something never seen before!

The Ministry arbitrarily took possession of files establishing $2.5 billion in corruption and buried them. Decisions not to prosecute were issued on the basis of fabricated expert reports, or by

prosecutors allowing the matters to become time-barred. This is institutional and moral decay. It is corruption. It is arbitrariness at its very worst!

Yet you are trying my companions and me while keeping us in detention, without a shred of evidence! Do you really imagine our nation cannot see this hypocrisy?[14]

To give you a sense of what these files contain, I will briefly describe just four examples.

1. PURCHASE OF A MILITARY SITE THAT MET NO LOCAL PUBLIC NEED OF İBB, CAUSING A LOSS TO PUBLIC FUNDS

On October 24, 2016, İBB purchased a privately owned property in Başakşehir, designated as a military area, for a sum in Turkish lira equivalent to approximately $13.5 million at the exchange rate of the day.[15]

The inspectors' report established that the property was purchased by direct acquisition; that the owners' legal representative was Kamil Barkır, a former AKP district chairman in Maltepe; and that the purchase price was transferred directly to his bank account.

The report also found that the property's designated use in the zoning plans was a “strategic military area,” making it impossible for the Metropolitan Municipality to use it for any of its services.

It must also be stressed that the land lay within a military area, had not even an access road, and was not a site that could be subject to expropriation!

In short, the AKP-led administration of İBB had paid $13.5 million for land it could never use. And that money had gone into the pocket of an AKP district chairman — and who knows who else within İBB.

A property valuation prepared in 2021 put the land's value at TRY 13,350,000 — approximately $2 million — because it was in a strategic military zone.

In other words, the real value of land bought by the AKP administration of İBB for $13.5 million was at most $2 million! Even five years after the transaction!

The loss to public funds: $11.5 million! Concrete and clear. Not gossip.

Just as the first findings were being established, the Ministry of the Interior took over the matter, and the case was closed.

2. KİPTAŞ LAND PURCHASE: $27 MILLION TRANSFERRED FROM İBB'S BUDGET INTO SOMEONE'S POCKET IN FOUR DAYS

During the AKP administration, KİPTAŞ bought a plot of land in Bahçeşehir for TRY 300 million.[16]

According to the Metropolitan Municipality inspector's report, KİPTAŞ paid far above market value for the land. The loss, measured as of the payment date of January 11, 2016, was found to be around $50 million.

But there is another side to this affair — one so devious it would put the devil to shame.

On January 7, 2016, the portion of the Bahçeşehir property belonging to Nurol İnşaat Ticaret A.Ş. was purchased — or made to be purchased! — by Atmaca Gayrimenkul A.Ş. for TRY 49.5 million.

Just four days later, on January 11, 2016, Atmaca sold that very same property to KİPTAŞ A.Ş. for TRY 130 million!

I want you to pay attention to this. In just four days, the company that bought — or was made to buy — the property earned TRY 81,000,000 in 2016 money: $27 million, or TRY 1.2 billion at today's exchange rate!

What extraordinary foresight! What commercial genius, indeed!

And what is the truth? Someone in the middle grew immensely wealthy, while KİPTAŞ once again bought land at an exorbitant price!

This is not gossip or hearsay. It is corruption backed by concrete evidence. Total loss to public funds at today's exchange rate: TRY 2.32 billion.

The inspector's referral report was sent to the Istanbul Chief Public Prosecutor's Office on March 8, 2021.

And the outcome? On August 14, 2024, the Bakırköy Chief Public Prosecutor's Office decided that there were no grounds for prosecution. Our objections came to nothing, and that decision became final!

3. PURCHASE OF LAND ON VATAN AVENUE IN FATİH (THE FAIRGROUND SITE): PROFITS AND A WINDFALL ARISING FROM DISCUSSIONS AT THE PRESIDENCY

The site on Vatan Avenue in Fatih, known to my fellow Istanbul residents as the fairground land, was purchased by İBB in 2017 from Metal Yapı Konut A.Ş. for approximately TRY 430 million — $119 million at the exchange rate of the time.[17]

Yet Metal Yapı Konut A.Ş. had paid the Fatih Municipality only TRY 25 million ($13 million) when it bought the site in 2011!

After Metal Yapı acquired the property from the Fatih Municipality, the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipal Council amended the zoning plans, increasing the land's value.

We know this process was carried out according to a plan from two petitions submitted by the chairman of Metal Yapı A.Ş., both of which are preserved in the administration's official records.

Those petitions state where the company intended to use the money it would receive and that the transactions had been agreed upon following discussions at the Presidency.

While our Inspection Board's investigation was still proceeding on several fronts, the Ministry of the Interior took control of the matter.

A further valuation of the land purchased in 2017 was commissioned in 2021. It calculated a difference of $106 million between the value of the site when İBB purchased it and its then-current market value.

Thus, with the Presidency's knowledge, Metal Yapı sold to İBB for $119 million a property it had bought from the Fatih Municipality for $13 million.

The total loss to public funds and the proceeds of this scheme: more than $106 million!

Let us all recall what Erdoğan, then Prime Minister, said during the December 17–25 investigations:

> *“When someone says corruption, this is what I understand: Is money leaving the state's treasury, or not? If no money is leaving the state's treasury, you cannot call it corruption!”*

And what will Erdoğan say to this? With his own approval, an extra $106 million was paid out of İBB's treasury — that is, the state's treasury!

What a wonderful arrangement!

Buy land without development rights at a low price. Then have İBB grant it commercial and residential zoning. Have the land valued on that basis. Sell it to İBB. Once the money has been paid, have İBB change the zoning again, reducing the value of the land it now owns.

And in this way, transfer more than $106 million from the municipality's treasury into the pockets of certain individuals!

Look, these are not rumors or things we merely heard. This is concrete, clear corruption supported by evidence!

Those who carried out this planned raid on public funds are free. Ekrem İmamoğlu, who set the Inspection Board to work exposing it, is in Silivri.

SOURCE TABLE REFERENCES

[14] See Table 12 in the original book.

[15] See Table 13 in the original book.

[16] See Table 14 in the original book.

[17] See Table 15 in the original book.

TRANSLATION CONTINUITY

The closing sentence extends into the beginning of printed page 127; it is completed here. The fourth example, beginning on page 127, belongs to the next installment.

CHAPTER FOUR — CONTINUED

Not a "Criminal Organization" at All: On the Contrary, We Put an End to the System of Profiteering and Waste Established by the AKP at İBB!

English translation · Original printed pages 127–130

4. I must also tell you about the tender file involving Adil Karaismailoğlu. This is another extremely important corruption case, and one that was closed through the intervention of the judiciary.

Shortly after we took office, we identified an irregular tender in the Information Technology Department and documented the irregularities in a report. We found that almost none of the contracted works had been carried out in accordance with the contract and technical specifications, and that the inspection, acceptance, and progress-payment procedures had not been performed properly. Nevertheless, payments totaling **18,240,000 Turkish lira, including VAT**—equivalent to **154 million lira in today's money**—had been made, and we determined that this amount constituted a loss to public funds.

Accordingly, in 2020, we filed a criminal complaint, principally against Adil Karaismailoğlu, who had been Deputy Secretary-General and the official authorized to conduct tenders and approve expenditures at the time.

And what happened next? I think everyone can guess. Of course, on **April 24, 2024**, the Istanbul Chief Public Prosecutor's Office issued a **decision not to prosecute**—investigation number **2020/181467**, decision number **2024/56923**.

Is that the end of what I have to tell you? No. We learn that the expert report on which this decision was based was prepared on **December 4, 2023**, by Satılmış Büyükcanayakın—the supposedly all-knowing court-appointed expert who, strangely enough, keeps being assigned to our cases.

The prosecution disregarded reports prepared by engineers and qualified technical specialists. Instead, relying on a single sentence written by an accountant serving as an expert witness, who had no education or training whatsoever in information technology, it declared that there had been no tender-rigging in this case.

And I am still not finished. Information about this criminal complaint appeared in both the print and broadcast media. Access to the reports was then blocked. After that, even the news reports about the access restrictions were themselves blocked!

The individual who was serving as Minister of Transport and Infrastructure at the time declared that he had nothing to do with these matters. Yet his name and signature appear on the minutes of the inspection and acceptance committee. Indeed, it was he who approved an increase in the scope of the work on **March 27, 2019**, just four days before the local elections. It was also he who signed, on **April 8, 2019**, shortly after the election and before I received my certificate of election, the record stating that the work had been carried out **"incompletely and flawlessly."** His name and signature also appear on the payment-order documents as the official authorized to approve the expenditure.

In the face of the established findings of the technical staff, I leave it to your conscience to judge how the Istanbul Chief Public Prosecutor's Office closed the case concerning corruption amounting to **154 million lira at today's exchange rate**, on the strength of a contrived expert report!

These are not rumors traded in coffeehouses. These are instances of corruption documented by evidence.

On the basis of findings concerning **abuse of office, bribery, embezzlement, interference with public tenders, and irregularities in the performance of contractual obligations**, we sent **62 reports** to the Offices of the Chief Public Prosecutor. We filed criminal complaints on the basis of concrete documents, not “things we had heard” or “gossip.” Yet in almost every case, the prosecution decided that there were **no grounds for prosecution**.

Were we surprised? Of course not!

If you belong to the AKP, even the most concrete evidence is ignored. If you are in the opposition, mere “hearsay and gossip” can be enough to have you arrested!

When the CHP is involved, corruption accusations are conjured out of nothing. When the AKP is involved, corruption cases backed entirely by concrete evidence disappear—simply evaporate.

So corruption was what concerned you, was it? **Liars!** The whole world knows that their concern is not so-called “corruption”!

A government built on slander!

If you are really looking for a “criminal organization operating for financial gain,” look at the profits generated through zoning decisions during the AKP's years at İBB!

By now, everyone should see that the AKP government has served not our nation, but a handful of people, and that it has known no limits when it comes to corruption!

Look: after I became metropolitan mayor, I had **130 zoning files** examined. Out of approximately **8,000 projects**, by examining just **130 development projects**, we identified the transfer of **85 billion dollars in windfall gains—approximately 4 trillion lira—to certain individuals**. That figure is equivalent to roughly **ten years of İBB's budget**!

These 130 projects were subjected to detailed review because of changes to zoning plans, changes in designated land uses, or practices outside the regulatory framework. Through zoning amendments and special planning approvals, these projects largely transferred areas reserved for public facilities—often publicly owned land—into the hands of private capital.

In other words, parks that belonged to all of us, sites reserved for schools, and land set aside for hospitals were buried under concrete to build luxury residences, shopping malls, and hotels, so that a handful of individuals could grow rich.

I will now discuss a few of these 130 selected projects that generated such profits. Through the example of Fikirtepe, I will also explain briefly how a city can be degraded in the name of urban transformation by the AKP-era İBB administration and the Ministry responsible for urban development, and how society can be made miserable merely to benefit a handful of people.

The first is the Şehrizar Konakları project.

Under the zoning plans of **1992**, the entire site was designated as **green space**. It had been expropriated by the General Directorate of Highways. Later, the land was transferred to Emlak Konut A.Ş. and subsequently put out to tender.

Beginning in **2005**, development plans were prepared repeatedly, first by İBB and then by the Ministry, and the courts repeatedly annulled them. At one point, the courts even revoked the building permits. Judicial proceedings are still ongoing.

Although the site lay within a protected skyline area—meaning that buildings, if permitted at all, could be no higher than **6.50 meters**—structures **9.50 meters** high were built. Moreover, construction was permitted even though the land lay within first- and third-degree protected natural areas.

Despite all this, the project went ahead. So it was a protected site, a green area, part of the Bosphorus skyline, public property—none of it mattered to them. **Profits, profits, and nothing but profits!**

Another project is Koru Florya, in Bakırköy.

The land was entirely in public ownership, having been acquired by TOKİ, and the zoning plans designated all of it as a **healthcare-facility area** and as a **helipad for emergency and disaster response**.

In **2009**, a development plan prepared by TOKİ opened the site to development as **145,000 square meters of commercial space**. Plans later annulled by the courts continued to be prepared, first by İBB and then by the Ministry.

Land previously surrendered by its owner for public use was handed over through TOKİ to politically favored interests.

The third project I will discuss is Hattat Tower (Diamond of Istanbul).

In **2008**, the allowable floor-area ratio was increased from **2.30 to 3.00**. The court annulled the zoning plans. İBB prepared new plans in **2010 and 2011**.

In **2015**, a protocol was signed between İBB and the landowner providing for the **“unconditional donation” of 18 properties** in return for approval of the preliminary architectural project.

In other words, the preliminary project was approved in exchange for a donation!

According to the indictment now before us, wasn't that called **extortion through abuse of public office**?

Eleven of those parcels were around Kadir Topbaş's home in Büyükçekmece. In **2017**, the court annulled the plans. In **2019 and 2020**, development plans were approved by the Ministry of Environment and Urbanization.

Then there is the Onaltıdokuz İstanbul project in Zeytinburnu: the “16/9 Towers.”

In **2008**, a site-specific planning amendment increased the floor-area ratio from **1.00 to 2.50**. The height restriction was lifted. The permissible construction area was increased by **50,000 square meters**.

This project damaged Istanbul's unique historic skyline!

UNESCO warned the public authorities because the project altered the centuries-old protected silhouettes of monuments such as **Topkapı Palace** and the **Sultan Ahmed Mosque**, and changed the appearance of the historic city.

What was done was a betrayal of Istanbul and its incomparable history.

So did the prosecution open an investigation into this grave offense against the city? Were people taken into custody at dawn? Were they arrested? Of course not!

All Erdoğan said about the businessman who built the towers was: **“I was hurt. I haven't spoken to him for five years.”**

No prosecution, no accountability, no arrests—only a personal falling-out!

For the final example, let me turn to something that might interest the central figure in this indictment—or rather, this instrument of promotion. The TemaPark project in Halkalı.

Hundreds of thousands of square meters of land, all of it designated as green space, were opened to development. Even the planning changes were not enough; urban design projects were used to generate windfall gains.

An area entirely reserved for public facilities was opened to construction, with hundreds of thousands of square meters made developable through an urban design project.

Although all of the land fell within a **“Regional Park Area,”** İBB redesignated it in **2010** as a **“Special Project Area”** with a floor-area ratio of **0.25**.

Later, through a reference to an **“urban design project”** in the plan prepared by the Ministry of Environment and Urbanization, the allowable floor area was increased from **450,000 to 600,000 square meters**. An area of **150,000 square meters** that should have been reserved for recreational use was instead used for housing and commerce.

I would also like to share an interesting anecdote. As I heard it directly from a senior AKP official, when Erdoğan saw the tall buildings and dense development in the area, he asked: **“I can see the TEMA, but where is the PARK?”**

In other words, even at the very top, this betrayal was recognized—and yet it was tolerated and covered up.

Now let me tell you a little about the **Fikirtepe scandal**, another offense against the city. The transformation this district has undergone sums up the AKP's approach to urban planning and urban renewal. It is also an example of failure, both in terms of the loss to public resources and the additional pressures it has placed on the city through population growth, infrastructure demands, and similar burdens.

Translator's source note: On printed page 127, the Turkish source describes a record as showing that work was performed “eksik ve kusursuz” (“incompletely and flawlessly”). The apparent contradiction has been retained rather than silently corrected.

Continuity note: The sentence ending printed page 126 was completed in the previous installment and is not repeated here. The final sentence above continues onto printed page 131 in the source; it is completed here to preserve meaning. The next installment begins with the following paragraph.

CHAPTER FOUR — CONTINUED

Not a “Criminal Organization” (!) — Quite the Opposite: We Ended the AKP's System of Rent-Seeking and Waste at İBB!

English translation · Original printed pages 131–134

It was also an example of failure, both in terms of the loss inflicted on the public and the burdens it placed on the city through population growth, infrastructure demands, and the like.

The area was declared an “urban transformation zone” in 2007. In 2011, development plans approved by İBB granted it a floor-area ratio of **4.14**—an extraordinarily high level of building rights.

The development plans were subsequently annulled by the courts on numerous occasions. After the area was declared an “at-risk area” in 2013, the Ministry of Environment and Urbanization divided it into blocks and prepared new development plans. During this process, numerous companies collected signatures from residents in the area. Some companies went bankrupt, and construction sites were left unfinished. Rent assistance could no longer be paid. Middlemen operating in the area made substantial profits.

In 2022, the Ministry intervened directly, allocating tens of billions of lira in today's money to restart construction on unfinished sites. Yet there are still reports of problems at the handover stage. Ultimately, vast amounts of construction in the very heart of the city, together with the population it brought, produced severe traffic congestion. The urban transformation process, meanwhile, became a never-ending saga that dragged on for years.

Fikirtepe, together with Esenyurt, is among the worst practices of the AKP era—a candidate for a museum of urban crimes.

And then there is the Üsküdar waterfront. As an example of what we were up against, I must tell you how, in response to our demolition and clearance efforts, the minister himself sought to introduce development rights along the shores of the Bosphorus under the pretext of protecting the occupiers of land we had ordered cleared.

Eight cafés unlawfully occupying the area between Üsküdar Square and Harem were demolished. These cafés were on İBB property.

In 2023, the Ministry of Environment and Urbanization prepared a development plan in an attempt to prevent the demolition of the unauthorized cafés. The site was designated a **“Day-Use Facility Area.”** Following the lawsuit we brought, that development plan was annulled. A proposed plan designating the site as a **“Public Square Area”** was submitted to the Ministry on **June 12, 2026**.

And while all this was happening, our department head, my valued companion **Ramazan Gülten**, who was working to protect Istanbul, was physically attacked. His bones were broken!

* * *

I must also tell you about the ten years of findings that reveal how, before 2019, the İBB Municipal Council and its zoning commission were turned into instruments of private gain and plunder, and how they worked in concert with landowners to betray Istanbul.

Between **2009 and 2019**, the AKP-controlled İBB Municipal Council approved no fewer than **7,642 parcel-specific amendments to development plans**. The AKP administration proposed them, and the Council approved them. Approximately one-third of these—**2,278 amendments**—were intended to increase the amount of land permitted to be developed.

During **2019–2026**, when our administration was in office, the İBB Municipal Council approved only **69 proposals** that we had determined were not driven by private windfall gains. Moreover, even these 69 proposals did not originate with our administration. They came from the İBB Municipal Council, in which the AKP held the majority between 2019 and 2024. Only 69 proposals that were not motivated by private gain were approved. **Look at the difference.**

The purpose and scope of those **2,278 amendments** made during the AKP years tell the whole story of a system built on private gain and plunder.

In a special study, my colleagues examined just **130 projects** from that ten-year period and calculated the windfall gains generated by them at **85 billion dollars**!

It is no coincidence that my valued colleagues who are urban planners are now imprisoned.

My companions and I stood in the way of crimes against our cities. We fulfilled our duty to ensure that our cities developed in a healthy and safe manner—and all of us were arrested. This was certainly no coincidence. It was a deliberate choice. The reason is clear: a government that transfers wealth by controlling the profits generated through urban development is targeting urban planners and public-interest professionals working in local government.

Through their decisions at the local level, their participation in planning processes, and their objections grounded in scientific knowledge, urban planners have stood in the way of many projects designed to generate private windfalls. As a result, numerous projects—particularly in Istanbul and other major cities—that ran counter to the public interest and threatened the environment and places where people live were either stopped or altered.

During the previous administration, opening public land to development transferred more than **85 billion dollars in public resources** to certain companies. Under AKP rule from 2009 to 2019, the power to plan Istanbul was used, in particular, to grant increases in development intensity on individual parcels and to create fortunes for a handful of people out of public land and areas reserved for public amenities. This was **“profit-driven planning.”**

(Some readers may not be familiar with the term *public amenity area*. It refers to land set aside for the public services and social or technical infrastructure that a settlement needs.)

Our period, by contrast, was one of **“planning focused on the public interest and social amenities.”** We sought to remedy deficiencies in the city's technical and social infrastructure, virtually eliminated parcel-specific increases in development rights, and subjected the small number that were approved to rigorous scrutiny.

This is a question of mentality. At the heart of our planning philosophy is service to Istanbul and its residents. Under the AKP, however, our beautiful Istanbul was treated as though it were **“one enormous plot of land waiting to be plundered.”** Erdoğan did not say, **“We betrayed this city,”** for nothing! The betrayal was so immense that even he could no longer bear it and admitted it himself.

* * *

Let us take a closer look at the difference between development planning under the AKP and under our administration. First, the AKP period, from **2009 to 2019**.

As you can see in the table, the number of plots for which development rights were increased on a parcel-specific basis during the AKP period was **2,278**![18]

We reviewed approximately **23,780 council decisions** made during that period. Of those, **14,298** concerned amendments to development plans. In other words, under the AKP, development-plan amendments and planning matters occupied **60 percent** of the İBB Municipal Council's agenda. The AKP-controlled Council approved **7,642 planning proposals**. Of these, **2,278** were amendments designed to increase permitted development—the **“profit-driven”** changes.

In short, during the AKP years, the İBB Municipal Council's principal occupation became granting development privileges to enrich a handful of people.

Public land—belonging to the people, to Istanbul's 16 million residents above all, and to all **86 million** of our citizens—was transformed through various devices into enormous projects, especially luxury housing and shopping centers, that generated profits for a select few. Sports grounds, military sites, parks, and reserves of green space were sacrificed through tricks in plan notes, increases in floor-area ratios, and the removal of height restrictions. Development-plan amendments during the AKP period were consistently vast in scale, designed to generate enormous gains, and involved high-density construction.

Istanbul's land, every stone and every handful of soil as precious as gold, brought immense wealth to a handful of people in power and close to those in power!

Between **2009 and 2019**, **30 percent** of the plans approved were aimed directly at increasing the area permitted to be developed. Just think: thousands of zoning amendments created opportunities for private gain. There are more examples than anyone could possibly list.

The gains generated through such projects for a handful of people in power or close to them amounted to **85 billion dollars**. If you have the courage, **this is where you should look for the corruption of the century!**

There were **2,278 parcel-specific increases in development rights**, and every single one of those transactions was, in itself, the corruption of the century!

Do you know what is even more frightening? In doing all this, the AKP administration completely disregarded Istanbul's earthquake risk. Hundreds of enormous sites that should have served as

emergency assembly areas were allocated to luxury housing and office developments. **They valued human life far less than they loved the profits to be made.**

Another striking feature of the AKP's years in charge of İBB was its habit of circumventing the law. The courts annulled many of these plans on the grounds that they were **“contrary to the public interest.”** Nevertheless, the AKP administration in Istanbul pushed the plans through the Council again, with the backing of the Ministry or **TOKİ**.

* * *

Under our administration, by contrast, our proposals to amend development plans were aimed at meeting needs for social and technical infrastructure: nurseries, rail systems, stream rehabilitation, the integration of road and junction projects, education, health facilities, piers, and similar services.

Only **69 proposals** for parcel-specific increases in development rights were considered. The total was **33 times lower** than during the AKP period. They were also qualitatively different: they concerned much smaller plots and were designed to protect citizens' rights.[19]

For example, an increase in development rights on a **50-square-meter plot** is not the same thing as an increase on a **5,000-square-meter plot**. One addresses an individual's particular problem; the other is driven solely by the prospect of private gain. Moreover, from **2019 to 2024**, the AKP held the majority on the İBB Municipal Council—and thus the power to make these decisions.

I want to emphasize one point as strongly as I possibly can: **The number of development-plan amendments initiated by our administration for the purpose of increasing development rights was zero. Not one.**

During our administration, only **69 parcel-specific increases in development rights** were made, whether at the request of citizens or district municipalities or as required by court decisions. **Not one of them was a profit-driven amendment.**

Source notes: [18] See Table 16 in the original book. [19] See Table 17 in the original book.

Continuity note: The opening sentence completes a sentence begun on printed page 130. The final sentence is completed using the opening lines of printed page 135; those lines should not be translated again in the next installment.

CHAPTER FOUR — CONTINUED

Original printed pages 135–138

Only 69 parcel-specific increases in development rights were approved. None of them, moreover, were changes driven by private gain.

During our administration, we established a screening mechanism focused on the public interest and public amenities. In short, we did not assess the proposals in terms of the profits they might generate. We looked at them entirely in terms of what would benefit Istanbul and its people. We did not casually open tens of thousands of square meters of extensive green space or prime land to development and turn them into luxury residences.

The plans prepared by İBB now centered on improving people's everyday quality of life: sites for nurseries, rail transit routes, stream rehabilitation projects, junction improvements, protective zones around ferry piers, and, more broadly, the social and technical infrastructure needed for education and healthcare. **We put an end to the practice of handing out zoning privileges, parcel by parcel, company by company!** We take pride in having given Istanbul seven years of clean government!

By approving comprehensive district plans at a scale of 1:5,000 for the city as a whole, we resolved property-related problems within the framework of the public interest.

In conclusion, the system of profit-seeking and plunder conducted by the AKP administration between 2009 and 2019, through its own political cadres, constitutes a grave offense against the city. Every file concerning these unlawful practices, involving tens of billions of dollars, should be brought before the courts.

* * *

We moved away from a decade in which Istanbul had become a **"real-estate capital driven by developers and speculative profit"** toward a vision of a **"people-centered city for living, prioritizing public amenities and infrastructure."**

Under the AKP, Istanbul was plainly betrayed, and unfortunately we continue to live with and witness the consequences every day. They left us a city increasingly difficult to live in, whose infrastructure struggles to bear the burden of enormous housing, office, and shopping-mall developments.

We, by contrast, put an end to the plunder of Istanbul with an entirely new philosophy. We achieved this together with my valued companions here—the finest urban planners in Türkiye. We ended the era in which Istanbul's public land was plundered. And that is precisely why they are all in the dungeons of Silivri today: they frustrated the dreams of so many people who had hoped to profit from the city!

My esteemed fellow citizens,

I want to ask you a very simple question, and I ask you to think carefully about it. If, as the saying goes, Istanbul's very stones and soil are "gold," and if the AKP administration generated $85 billion in development profits from just the 130 projects we examined closely, why would my colleagues and I have put an end to Istanbul's profit-driven development projects if we were pursuing personal gain? Does that make the slightest sense?

If we had wanted to enrich ourselves as the Mayor of Istanbul and its administrative team, the easiest source of profit would have been to allow increases in development rights. **We did not.** On the contrary, we prevented them as far as we could. We protected Istanbul and the people of Istanbul.

In their defenses, my valued companions Buğra Gökçe, Gürkan Akgün, Ali Kurt, and Ramazan Gülten described to you what we accomplished. At times, they fought unlawful developments built for private profit at the risk of their lives; they were even attacked by mobs! My companions also described the AKP era's betrayal of Istanbul.

They explained how Istanbul had historically developed along an east-west axis, and how the AKP opened the city's northern region to construction at the cost of destroying our forests, agricultural land, water basins, and air corridors.

They explained how, in response to the AKP's betrayal of Istanbul's skyline, we established an **Architectural Aesthetics Commission**, and how responsibly we acted toward this city.

They also explained that our approach to urban planning was about benefits for the entire nation, not profits for particular individuals, and that we created 19 public squares for that purpose.

And you yourselves saw that, in a department through which billions of dollars in speculative gains had flowed during the AKP period, not a single penny went into anyone's pocket under our administration. Everyone knows this!

This indictment of slander belongs in the trash. Give me a break! You will never convince anyone of this case!

* * *

With a major earthquake looming over Istanbul and the Marmara region, high-density projects were stubbornly imposed on the city's most vulnerable areas despite the warnings of urban planners and scientists.

Those who opposed these projects and exposed what was happening are the very people now in prison.

The participatory and transparent plans prepared by İBB, grounded entirely in scientific evidence and genuinely attentive to people's needs, blocked profit-driven projects.

Meanwhile, the most important new target for speculative gains in the coming years is Kanal Istanbul. I will shortly explain how we opposed that project in order to save Istanbul. **Our struggle against Kanal Istanbul is also a major reason why we are imprisoned here!**

Today, urban planners, architects, and engineers are being arrested simply for practicing their professions and defending the public interest. But let it be known: this pressure will not deter us. We will continue defending our cities and protecting the public interest.

Remember that Recep Tayyip Erdoğan himself said, "We betrayed Istanbul." The urban development profits generated through just 130 AKP-era planning files—the very practices he was referring to as a betrayal—amount to **$85 billion**! At today's exchange rate, approximately **4 trillion Turkish lira**! In the old currency, **4 quintillion lira**! If you are looking for the "corruption of the century," look at the development profits of the AKP era!

A moment ago I described a few profit-making projects from the AKP period. Now I want to show you some photographs of those projects. The real "corruption of the century" can be seen in these photographs.[20]

The money generated from just these 130 selected projects was equivalent to:

- Istanbul's gross domestic product in 2020;
- The central government's tax revenue in 2021; and
- Approximately ten years of İBB's budget!

This money belonged by right to the people of Istanbul. But where did so much money go? Into whose pockets?

Just think: the profits that went into the pockets of a handful of people rather than to Istanbul's residents were equivalent to roughly ten years of İBB's budget!

Do you know what could have been accomplished with this money that went into the pockets of a privileged few?

- All of Istanbul's transportation problems could have been resolved! Consider this: building every metro line Istanbul needs would cost around **$15 billion**.
- **Ninety-four metro lines** like the Yenikapı–Hacıosman line could have been built! Istanbul's traffic problem could have been solved at its roots!
- Building Hızray, running from Beylikdüzü to Sabiha Gökçen, would cost **"only" $7 billion**. The money that went into AKP supporters' pockets: **$85 billion**!
- **1,250,000 social housing units** could have been built, ending the housing crisis for good!
- An amount equal to **41 times** what TOKİ spent on urban renewal over a full 18 years could have been invested, eliminating earthquake risk! Hundreds of thousands of Istanbul residents could have been given safe lives, free from fear of earthquakes!
- **2,500 nurseries** could have been built, securing the future of all our children!
- The sum is so enormous that **two million households** could have received support for **78 years**, eliminating poverty!

Who swallowed up these enormous profits? **This** is where you should be looking for bribery and extortion through abuse of public office! If you have the courage, investigate the **4-trillion-lira**

corruption!

Does openly admitting that you betrayed Istanbul, and apologizing for it, absolve you of legal responsibility? Is that how the rule of law works?

I ask the President: as head of our state, why have you not launched a single investigation into these betrayals? Will you call upon the State Supervisory Council or the independent judiciary to investigate those projects that betrayed the city?

Of course you cannot. Let us recall what Erdoğan Bayraktar, then Minister of Environment and Urban Planning, said on December 25, 2013:

> "*...a large proportion of the zoning plans were prepared on the instructions of the prime minister [Recep Tayyip Erdoğan]. I wish to state that I believe the Prime Minister should resign, and I offer my respects to our great nation...*"

He spoke those words and openly made a number of admissions. Not a secret witness—an **open witness!**

* * *

I also want to take you a little further back, to the period when Erdoğan governed İBB (1994–1998)...

There are two matters I want to address. First, the AKP's habit of profiting from zoning decisions began in those years.[21] Second, many people have forgotten that there were dozens of corruption files concerning Erdoğan's years as Mayor of Istanbul, and lawsuits were brought as well. There were numerous cases involving İGDAŞ, İSTAŞ, İDO, KİPTAŞ, and other organizations.

Source references: [20] See Table 18; [21] See Table 19 in the original book. The next original page begins with the discussion of those cases.

CHAPTER FOUR — CONTINUED
Original printed pages 139–142

There were corruption investigations and cases concerning Erdoğan's time as mayor of Istanbul, involving institutions from İGDAŞ to İSTAŞ, from İDO to KİPTAŞ.

Let us recall the best-known of them, the AKBİL case. It was alleged that part of the revenue generated by AKBİL, the electronic fare-payment system used on Istanbul's public transport, had been kept off the books. Irregularities were also alleged in BELBİM's accounting records.

This was not a matter of secret witnesses, gossip, or things someone claimed to have “heard.” All the data were examined at the time, and numerous serious irregularities were identified. In short, the amounts loaded onto and used from tens of thousands of AKBİL devices were understated, concealing revenue.

The whereabouts of approximately 2.6 trillion lira, in the currency of that time, could not be explained. A case was brought against 37 defendants. Those charged, including Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, were accused of embezzlement, counterfeiting public transport tickets, forgery, and forming an organization to commit crimes. The allegation was that Erdoğan subsequently used this money to establish the AKP. In other words, it is highly probable that the AKP was founded and operated with money belonging to the people of Istanbul—with proceeds from corruption.

Erdoğan then became a member of parliament and later Prime Minister, thereby gaining immunity. His case was separated from those of the other defendants and shelved.

Several points must be made about this:

— Despite the enormous corruption allegations—and, moreover, allegations based not on gossip and secret witnesses but on records, documents, and concrete evidence—apart from three people, Erdoğan's associates and bureaucrats were never taken into custody or arrested in connection with these cases! The three who were arrested were released in less than two months. The defendants remained free pending trial throughout the proceedings.

— The required authorization to investigate civil servants was obtained; the law was not disregarded.

— Their families were not subjected to pressure, and their assets were not seized!

— Erdoğan accepted no responsibility in these cases. He said: “I was the mayor. I knew nothing about what happened. I cannot be held responsible for the actions of a company on whose board of directors I did not sit.” That was his defense. In essence, he shifted responsibility onto his colleagues and bureaucrats.

Erdoğan and the politician-chief prosecutor who wrote today's indictment should read the file from those days and remind themselves of it! Let them see that detention is an exceptional measure. Then the wrongfulness of the captivity we are enduring today will become even clearer.

I request that this file—the AKBİL case in which Recep Tayyip Erdoğan was a defendant—be obtained and brought before the court. Then we can see how the judiciary acted and what decisions it reached when faced with similar accusations.

But the story of this file did not end there. Something extremely interesting happened—perhaps something unprecedented. It was reported in the news, yet those involved said nothing and did not deny the reports.

As I said a moment ago, the case against Erdoğan was shelved because of parliamentary immunity. Yet that file was taken off the shelf. Erdoğan has enjoyed immunity ever since he was elected to parliament in 2003. So some will wonder how and when it was reopened.

The answer to how it was reopened may lie in the answer to when. We cannot see the decision because they have kept it secret. If we ask for the case file, we can all see that too.

Before the 2023 presidential election, Erdoğan's lawyers reportedly applied for the file to be reopened and for a decision to be rendered despite his immunity. The presiding judge of the Istanbul 6th High Criminal Court, where the file had been kept, said: “I cannot render a decision while immunity remains in force.” Imagine that—a judge making a decision in accordance with the law! Naturally, someone else was appointed in his place. The court then reopened the case despite the immunity and issued an acquittal. The prosecution did not appeal, and the decision became final.

I do not know whether Erdoğan thought, “If I lose the presidency, I don't want to have to deal with this case,” or whether they had some other reason. But that is what happened. We do not have this file. Let it be brought here, as I have requested, so that we can examine it.

* * *

A criminal organization, is that what you call us? On the contrary, we accomplished many times more with fewer resources![22]

While the average annual budget of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality under AKP management in 2014–2018 was $4.9 billion, the amount of budgetary resources used by İBB under Ekrem İmamoğlu's administration in 2020–2025 was $4.5 billion.

The current dollar value of land sold during 2014–2019 is $1.66 billion—an average of $270 million in land sales per year. The current total value of land sold during our administration is $570 million: only $91 million per year. Land worth three times as much was sold during the AKP administration of 2014–2019.

In 2014–2019, an average of 82,000 households received social assistance each year. Between 2020 and April 2026, we tripled that number to 240,000. With fewer resources, we tripled the number of households receiving social assistance.

Over that period, the number of student dormitories rose from zero to 16, and the number of nurseries, also from zero, rose to 127. We provided an average annual subsidy of 180 million Turkish lira for 6,232 students. Our investment in dormitories reached 4 billion lira.

Over five years, students staying in these dormitories saved their families 4.5 billion lira in expenses. That money stayed in the families' pockets. Total investment in student dormitories since 2021 is approximately 2 billion lira.

For example, approximately $500,000 was paid to just three favored individuals, whom I will not name. All three belong to families whose members, under AKP rule, seem forever to reappear as members of

parliament, ministers, or public officials. In today's money, that is 23 million lira!

Look at the difference in mentality between Erdoğan's administration of Istanbul and İmamoğlu's. They granted extraordinary scholarships to three well-connected individuals. We award scholarships to 100,000 students every year.

The most important İBB investment for Istanbul is the metro system. I will explain the “transport revolution” we have achieved shortly. For now, let me say only this: we built vastly more metro lines than all the administrations before us! I will share all the figures in a moment.

Our administration has also seen the greatest investment in maritime transport. In June 2019, City Lines operated just 28 vessels on 21 routes. Under our administration, it now operates 863 daily services on 32 routes with a fleet of 83 vessels.

During the AKP's 2014–2019 term, annual support for maritime transport was $56 million (a total of $337 million including 2019). Under our administration, this support increased to an annual average of $96 million during 2020–2025, and a five-year total of $576 million.

And while making all these investments, İBB under our administration was also paying down debt. İBB's financial debt, which stood at $2.5 billion in 2014, had risen to $3.8 billion by 2019, when we took office. Today, despite all these investments, İBB's financial debt has fallen to $3.2 billion.

We both made enormous investments and restored İBB to a sound financial position, reducing its outstanding debt. When you look at these concrete facts, is it not obvious who engaged in corruption? Of course it is. And the people of Istanbul knew it too, which is why they entrusted us with the job again in 2024!

THE 24-YEAR SYSTEM OF PROFITEERING AND CORRUPTION

I do not need to explain this at length. All of Türkiye knows how corruption has increased in our country under this government. That is why everyone knows this case is not about “fighting corruption.”

A government that has driven our country down the international rankings for integrity in governance does not “fight corruption.”

According to Transparency International's Corruption Perceptions Index, our country fell from 64th place in 2002 to 124th place in 2025![23]

Not only the Turkish nation but the entire world is aware of what is happening!

If we are in this condition today, if the great majority of our people are struggling with poverty, there is only one reason: the AKP came to power promising to eliminate “Poverty, Corruption and Prohibitions,” and then did precisely the opposite.

I will discuss this in far greater detail shortly.

Sadly, because of a handful of power-hungry people, the AKP's name has now become associated with corruption. The President knows this. So, like the saying “The brazen thief shouts down the owner,” they attack us in an attempt to create the impression that “corruption is not confined to the AKP; the CHP is corrupt too.” But it is futile!

I make you this challenge: go out into the streets today and ask one hundred people—when they hear the words corruption, plunder, profiteering, looting, or prime parcels of land, who comes to mind? Which political party comes to mind? If you have the courage, let us ask them!

Under the President, who heads the administrative structure and is the sole holder of executive authority, Türkiye has, in terms of corruption...

* * *

[22] See Table 20 in the original book.
[23] See Table 21 in the original book.

Translator's continuity note: The last sentence on printed page 142 continues on page 143; it is intentionally left unfinished here.

CHAPTER FOUR — CONTINUED *Not a “Criminal Organization” (!) — Quite the Opposite: We Put an End to the AKP’s System of Privilege and Waste at İBB!*

Original printed pages 143–146

Has Türkiye not fallen down the international rankings on corruption under the President, the head of the administration and sole holder of executive authority? Why did the President tell those who wanted to introduce a political ethics law, “We wouldn’t be able to find district chairpersons”? Why did no one question those words? Why has this government not enacted a genuine political ethics law? They have held a parliamentary majority for 24 years. Why have they not passed it?

I have repeatedly called for this: Every one of us holding public office, without exception, should disclose the assets we possessed when we entered politics and the assets we possess today. Our families’ assets, too. Indeed, let us go beyond first-degree relatives and include second-degree relatives as well! I made that call on social media, too.

Are you willing, AKP? Are you willing, Mr. President, AKP members of parliament, ministers, Justice Minister Akın Gürlek, deputy ministers, department heads, mayors? On the instructions of our esteemed Party Chairman, our parliamentary group deputy chair submitted a proposal to the Grand National Assembly. Go ahead—put it into practice! Let us pass this bill through Parliament in a single day! [24]

We have shouted this at the top of our lungs, and we are still shouting. Not a word from you. What are you afraid of? Why have you not made a single statement? I put the same question to the other partners of the People's Alliance. Why are you all silent?

Veteran politicians will feel no shame. They will stand at podiums and slander my companions and me, talking of theft, extortion by public officials, and bribery. Then, if you have even a little courage and honor, pass the law immediately and let us all account for ourselves. Are you in or are you out?

I am reporting your silence to the nation, here and now. You are afraid. You are running away, because you have so much you cannot account for before the people!

I call upon every opposition leader: Bring the bill before Parliament, and let us see who accepts it and who refuses! To those in power: Come on, let us see how sincere you are! Are you willing? **I am!**

But this matter does not end here. Since we are talking about organized crime from this stand, it is not enough for me to expose the wrongdoing of the earlier administrations of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality.

If you are genuinely looking for a criminal organization, you must examine the following crimes. You cannot erase them from our memory or our hearts by ignoring them, covering them up, and systematically rejecting the parliamentary inquiries proposed by the opposition about them.

With the indignation rising from our consciences and our hearts, I remind you:

The killer of the tens of thousands of our fellow citizens who died in the earthquake of February 6, 2023, was not the natural disaster called an earthquake. It was the AKP administration, which for a

quarter of a century failed to fulfill its responsibility to take precautions; which did not spend the approximately **$55 billion**, at today's value, collected in earthquake-related taxes on earthquake preparedness; which for years failed to carry out the necessary inspections because of corruption; and which, on top of all that, rejected science and passed zoning amnesties.

Fifty-five thousand of our people died, and you did not even come forward to apologize! In Chile and Japan, fewer than 55 people die even in stronger earthquakes!

Here, I give this promise to our entire nation: Under our government, within **five plus five years**, we will remove the fear of earthquakes from life in Türkiye altogether! We will make our country fully prepared for earthquakes. Like Japan, we too will become a country that lives with earthquakes without fear, a country in which every citizen's life is precious.

The AKP administration bears responsibility for the deaths of our fellow citizens in fires, train crashes, workplace accidents, mining disasters, and road accidents through its failure to fulfill its duty of oversight. What turns accidents into mass killings is the AKP's organized evasion of oversight—whether for profit, illicit gain, or simply by rendering institutions dysfunctional. The Soma Mine Disaster, the Amasra Mine Disaster, the Çorlu Train Disaster, the Aladağ Dormitory Disaster, the Kartalkaya Disaster...

Has anyone among the handful of power-hungry people who make every decision in this country been held accountable for these massacres? Has anyone been brought to trial over them? No. Why did our people die in these places? Are you truly looking for a “criminal organization”? Then look here.

Do you know what this case is really about? The AKP is continuing the “frame-up trials” it knows so well. Speaking on March 20, 2015, about the arrests of military officers during the Ergenekon and Balyoz operations, listen to what Recep Tayyip Erdoğan said:

> *“...Through these operations, in which the guilty and the innocent, truth and lies, right and wrong were all thrown into the same bag, the entire country, myself foremost among them, was misdirected and deceived. Together, we were subjected to a plot, an attempted coup, carried out by a structure embedded within our institutions and equipped with strong media support, seeking to seize control of Türkiye. I say this sincerely: My heart never consented to the arrest of many commanders whom I knew closely through working together, particularly our former Chief of the General Staff. I expressed my doubts and objections to those responsible at the time, and even spoke of them publicly. But in the face of the documents and information presented to us then—much of which later proved to have been forged or distorted—there was nothing left for us to do, out of respect for the law...”*

Yet the whole of Türkiye witnessed the very same Erdoğan, during those frame-up trials, declare on **August 5, 2010**, just 16 years ago: **“I am the prosecutor of these cases!”** He lent the schemes his power and became their guarantor. He threw everything he had behind them! Just as he is doing today.

I, meanwhile, was at Silivri in those days, alongside hundreds of companions, standing against those frame-up trials. Erdoğan, the prosecutor of the Ergenekon and Balyoz cases, is today the true “prosecutor” of these new frame-up trials. He rewarded the chief prosecutor who prepared this fabricated indictment with the Ministry of Justice! In essence, President Erdoğan is saying today, **“I am the prosecutor of this frame-up trial, too!”** Indeed, all the indictment's key descriptions come

from Erdoğan, from “the tentacles of the octopus” to “a criminal organization for personal gain.”

I genuinely wonder how President Erdoğan will try to explain away his words on the day those he had carry out the March 19 and May 21 coups flee like rats—or fail to escape and are held accountable before the fair courts of the Turkish judiciary!

At this point it is worth recalling the frame-up trials of the AKP era. Beginning in 2007, the investigations and trials launched through the alliance between the Fethullahist Terrorist Organization and the AKP caused tremendous suffering, led to the deaths of many innocent people, and subjected hundreds of innocent people to torture.

At a certain point, however, a rift began to open between the two. The conflict took a different turn with the December 17–25 investigations. The AKP first took steps to shut those investigations down. It then began purging Fethullahists from the judiciary. The July 15 coup attempt followed, and after the attempt was defeated, the purge reached its peak. More than a quarter of the members of the judiciary were dismissed. Proceedings were brought against them, and convictions were handed down within the framework of FETÖ/PDY (the Parallel State Structure).

Some figures fled abroad, such as Zekeriya Öz, the emblematic prosecutor of the period, whom Erdoğan had supported to the extent of placing his armored vehicle at the prosecutor's disposal.

And the frame-up trials continue today. Almost the entire İBB organization is here. Yesterday it was Zekeriya Öz; today it is Akın Gürlek. Yesterday, Prime Minister Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, the entire government, and the pro-government media could not praise Zekeriya Öz highly enough. Today, President Erdoğan, the entire government, and the pro-government media cannot praise Akın Gürlek highly enough. They never learn. Never.

Are there no differences between those carrying out today's frame-up trials and the Fethullahist prosecutors and judges of the past? Of course there are. There are great similarities, but differences too:

The former tried to manufacture evidence with forged CDs and viruses planted on computers. The latter make do with a few secret witnesses and informants frightened into making false accusations through pressure, threats, and imprisonment. Those of yesterday made use of technology. Those of today take picks and shovels into fields in search of boxes of money.

* * *

Let us remember **Izmir in 2011**. When people speak of frame-up trials, they generally recall the cases brought in Istanbul. But I want to remind you of the Izmir Metropolitan Municipality case to show how history is being made to repeat itself.

The prosecutors of that period accused CHP Mayor of Izmir Aziz Kocaoğlu and his colleagues at the Izmir Metropolitan Municipality of “establishing a criminal organization for personal gain.” There was one difference from our case: They could not arrest Kocaoğlu. Under the circumstances of the day, they did not dare to arrest the mayor. But they arrested many of his officials and companions—and kept them in prison for a year.

As you know, the Izmir Metropolitan Municipality case was concluded after the December 17–25 conflict and the events of July 15. By the time judgment was delivered, the specially authorized high

criminal courts no longer existed.

They were acquitted!

Had that conflict not occurred, had the AKP–Gülen alliance continued, perhaps today Mayor Aziz Kocaoğlu and his companions would be in prison, facing an indictment fabricated like ours, with **397 years' imprisonment** sought on charges of leading a criminal organization and corruption. [25]

Notes: [24] See Table 22 in the original book. [25] Footnote marker carried forward from the opening of original printed page 147. Source allegations, quoted statements, and figures have been retained as statements made in the book, not independently verified findings. The last sentence was completed using the first line of printed page 147.

CHAPTER FOUR — CONCLUSION

Original printed pages 147–149 · English translation

And since today's architects of fabricated trials have learned nothing, and do not hesitate to imitate yesterday's perpetrators, continuing to accuse CHP municipalities they cannot defeat at the ballot box of being criminal organizations, I can say this with complete peace of mind: I have absolute confidence in every one of my companions!

Together, we governed Istanbul with the highest standards of merit, transparency, accountability, and integrity. My colleagues, in turn, built their own strong teams. And today, even though we are all behind bars, thanks to those capable teams, İBB continues at full speed to deliver services and get things done!

I am proud of my colleagues who are unjustly imprisoned today, and equally proud of those who continue to serve outside despite all the pressure!

May I tell you something? It was my beloved mother's prayers that brought these wonderful people into my life. My mother used to pray for me: “May God bring good and honest people into your life!” Thank you, dear mother! Your prayers have been answered.

* * *

A moment ago, I explained how the government exercised the full power of the central administration to audit our municipality, subjecting us to many times more inspections than previous administrations, yet finding no loss to the public purse.

But we underwent an even greater examination. We worked and struggled for five years, and when that period ended, we stood for election again. To me, the people of Istanbul are the highest authority of all when it comes to scrutiny and accountability!

We succeeded despite Erdoğan's deployment of the full power of the state against us. We succeeded even though he mobilized all his ministers and every state institution under his command.

Indeed, let me give you a particularly striking example. I will show you the money Erdoğan personally sent from the presidential budget to 24 AKP-run district municipalities in Istanbul, just two months before the Istanbul election, in order to sabotage the will of the people. That money belongs to all 86 million of us.[26] The President sent the country's and the nation's money to AKP municipalities solely so that his own party would win!

Despite all this, the people of Istanbul saw the truth. They understood perfectly well who was honest and who governed well. At the ballot box, they carried out their own assessment of those five years and entrusted the administration of the Metropolitan Municipality to us once again—by a clear margin. They gave us a lead of **1.1 million votes** over our opponent.

The people of Istanbul delivered their verdict at the ballot box, choosing CHP candidates to govern **26 of the city's 39 districts**. In **32 of those 39 districts**, Ekrem İmamoğlu came first in the vote for metropolitan mayor.

A criminal organization, is that it? With this utterly absurd allegation, you are actually insulting the intelligence of Istanbul's 16 million people!

You are insulting the will of the nation! My colleagues and I take immense pride in having received the people's endorsement of our record and, once again, their mandate to serve.

[25] Note for those interested: The prosecutor who accused the Izmir Metropolitan Municipality of being a "criminal organization" was dismissed from the profession and sentenced to seven and a half years in prison for membership in a terrorist organization.

[26] See Table 23 in the original book.

CHAPTER FIVE — THIS INDICTMENT IS NULL AND VOID!

Original printed page 150 · English translation

What do I say in response to the indictment?

First, let there be no misunderstanding. Out of habit, I sometimes call this rag an “indictment” myself. But it is an **indictment of slander**! A completely unlawful piece of paper that does not even deserve to be called an indictment. As I explained a moment ago, this indictment of slander is **null and void**!

Should the state use the judiciary as a weapon? Should the judiciary treat its own citizens as enemies? Should a prosecutor lay a trap dictated by politics through an indictment? Of course none of this should ever happen, yet today we are experiencing all of it.

Nearly four months of hearings have made this reality even more unmistakable. What is the trap?

To place before me a 4,000-page heap of nonsense, produced from statements made by people turned into informers in order to save themselves, their families, and their assets, and then say: “Go on, defend yourself!”

I will never take part in your game. I will never lend myself to your attempt to dress an entirely political fabrication up as a legal proceeding.

The indictment does not merely contain accusations unsupported by evidence. It is overflowing with improper language intended to vilify us. Its purpose is to shape public perception, not to pursue proceedings based on facts. This indictment of slander is written not in the language of a lawyer, but in that of a partisan media commentator.

It speaks of “the tentacles of an octopus,” of “the organization's intoxication with power,” of “seizing control of the CHP ... seizing control of the district municipalities ... seizing the presidency.” The indictment even says that we “usurped” things.

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED This Indictment Is Null and Void! English Translation | Original printed pages 151–154

These phrases were devised solely to be fed to the media, without the slightest thought given to what they actually mean in law.

Take the word “seizure,” for example. Under the Penal Code, the offense involved is classified as robbery. An indictment either charges someone with robbery or it does not. No such charge has been brought against us. Yet the indictment casually says that we “seized” things.

The prosecutors evidently have no concern that what they write should have legal meaning or weight. They are entirely at ease, because they know that no competent authority or institution will ever hold them to account. They are at ease because theirs is a political assignment, not a legal one, and they know perfectly well that doing their job successfully will earn them a reward.

As you know, Akın Gürlek, the politician–chief prosecutor who was made a minister in return for his role in this case, did not stop at what he wrote in the indictment. While trying to buy time to prepare it, he summoned journalists and gave this supposed investigation a name: “The Corruption of the Century”!

And yet what have four months of hearings shown us? This case is “The Frame-up of the Century”!

Not only Türkiye, but the entire world knows where this chief prosecutor found the audacity to brand us perpetrators of the century’s greatest corruption before the trial had even begun.

When Akın Gürlek, a politician disguised as a prosecutor, accuses us of the corruption of the century, he is not exercising authority granted to him by the laws of the Republic of Türkiye. He is not acting on behalf of the Turkish nation. He displays this audacity in defiance of the laws of the Republic and in defiance of the nation. It was Recep Tayyip Erdoğan, under whose protection he has taken refuge, who gave Akın Gürlek both this audacity and this assignment! The task given to Akın Gürlek, the politician disguised as a prosecutor, is to prevent Ekrem İmamoğlu from standing against Erdoğan in an election, whatever the cost.

The people, and the people alone, decide whom they will elect at the ballot box. Anyone who uses power to take away the nation’s right and authority to choose is a coup-maker. Whether they wield armed force or judicial power, they are coup-makers all the same.

A coup is among the gravest offenses that can be committed against the constitutional order. The case being heard here today is one of the most important stages of just such an offense, an attempted coup. This attempted coup, which they seek to carry out through the judiciary, bears the signatures of Recep Tayyip Erdoğan and Akın Gürlek. One designed it; the other put it into motion.

Whatever has brought each of us into this courtroom, we have a duty to stand for our Republic, the law, democracy, and the will of the nation against the attempted coup unfolding before our eyes.

With that responsibility in mind, I will explain what has happened as plainly and clearly as I can. You will see that what confronts us is a fully fledged, comprehensively organized coup operation.

You will see that this investigation and this indictment are evidence not of our guilt, but of the guilt of those attempting the coup.

Remember how, from the very outset, one of the principal occupations of the politician–chief prosecutor and the other prosecutors was to violate the confidentiality of the investigation in order to manufacture a public perception. Every manner of false and misleading material was leaked to pro-government media so that we could be pronounced guilty in advance. We live in a country where someone who cares nothing for the presumption of innocence, who sees no distinction between an accused person and a convicted criminal, and who disregards the dignity and reputation of defendants can become chief prosecutor—and even Minister of Justice!

From the very first day, this politician disguised as a prosecutor attempted to brand me the "Leader of a Criminal Organization" and my colleagues "Members or Managers of a Criminal Organization," before there was any judicial ruling—indeed, before there was even an indictment. This is no way to administer justice. It is something only a person acting under orders would do, in pursuit of position, status, and personal advantage.

Meanwhile, as documents were flying out to the pro-government press, they would not give our lawyers a single document. It was an extraordinary case: the investigation was confidential, but confidential only to the defense. Confidential only to those imprisoned and to the suspects. To journalists favored by the government, it was completely open.

They did something that would be unacceptable even in wartime: they targeted our lawyers and treated the very act of practicing law as a crime. The right to a defense could hardly be violated more severely. I will never accept this.

Their hostility toward lawyers reached such a point that, on the day they were going to arrest us, even the respected leadership of the Istanbul Bar Association was refused entry to the courthouse—the very place where its members work. I later learned that citizens who came to show solidarity were prevented even from entering the square. A courthouse surrounded by countless police officers. Scenes not witnessed even during periods of military coups. A process in which the courthouse was closed to journalists, lawyers, and citizens.

And then there are the arrests, on which I have insisted again and again. As people were detained without anyone looking them in the eye or listening to what they had to say, just one judge stood up and said: "Pretrial detention is a last resort. Judicial supervision is sufficient; there will be no detention." The next day that judge was removed from the position! Those placed under judicial supervision were subsequently detained. And we are supposed to call this not a "coup," but an "independent and impartial judiciary"?

Eventually the indictment was written. The chief prosecutor—who presents himself as a politician, a corporate executive, and a legal professional—summoned journalists and shared the indictment with them before submitting it to the court. Yet before the court has decided to accept an indictment, it is not even shared with suspects. It certainly must not be shared with journalists. This is no part of a prosecutor's job, but evidently prosecution was not the former chief prosecutor's real job anyway.

The indictment they handed to journalists in November was not given to me until January 22, on DVDs. Alongside the 4,000-page indictment, the DVDs apparently contained another 80,000 pages of attachments. We are allowed two hours of computer use per week. I am expected to read 84,000 pages with two hours of computer access a week. And this is supposed to be a criminal trial? This is no criminal trial at all! It is an attempt at political punishment and extrajudicial execution of the kind one would expect to encounter only in inhumane regimes.

* * *

During the process they call an investigation, they scrutinized everything about us, going back generations. They even dug up the garden of my father's house. They could not find a single penny that had improperly entered our pockets!

They unleashed MASAK, TMSF, BDDK, and every institution against my bureaucrats and colleagues at the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality. They did not find a single penny. They found nothing because not one penny of illicit gain has ever passed our lips. They found nothing, yet they did not hesitate to throw more than a hundred people in prison.

And when they found nothing, what did they do? First, they blocked my social media accounts to silence me. We opened a new one; they blocked that too. That was not enough: they threatened every municipality in Istanbul to make them remove my photographs from billboards and never display them again. That was not enough either. They turned my remarks during questioning before a criminal judgeship of the peace, my criticism of an expert witness who is a sworn enemy of the CHP, and an exchange with a citizen into criminal cases. They fashioned a terrorism case out of my criticism of the chief prosecutor and tried me before a high criminal court.

They even brought a case accusing me of insulting prosecutors over words I spoke in the exercise of my right to a defense before the criminal judgeship of the peace, in response to the request for my detention. Meanwhile, distinguished members of the AKP media tried to smear us every single day. They took the false and misleading information they received from prosecutors, exaggerated and distorted it a thousandfold, and accused us, accused us, accused us…

If you said even one percent of what they have said about us to an AKP member, you would be arrested that very day.

We turned to the judiciary over slanders, lies, and insults that made us say, "Surely they cannot go this far." Every one of our applications was rejected. Emboldened by that, they intensified their attacks with even harsher words and insults. But something happened that they had never calculated: THE NATION DID NOT BELIEVE THE LIES!

The great-hearted citizens of the Republic of Türkiye, whose consciences are clear and who cannot tolerate injustice or unfairness, saw the dishonorable, dirty political intent behind the lies and slanders, and could not accept it.

The fact that people refused to believe their lies drove them into a frenzy. The more frenzied they became, the more aggressive they grew, and the more lies they told. They called me, my colleague Necati Özkan, and Merdan Yanardağ, a journalist of forty years' standing, spies. Even espionage was not enough. They made my father a defendant. They made my eldest son a defendant. My

eldest brother-in-law became a defendant in this case. My other brother-in-law was detained on a different, absurd allegation. Even the niece of my beloved wife Dilek—a mother of two small children—and her husband were detained! From the first day, from the very first moment, my wife has never left me alone. She has never been silent. She will not be silent. She will not yield to them.

They tried absolutely everything to persuade the nation that I was guilty—from calling me a terrorist to fantastical tabloid lies, from corruption to espionage.

Just as in the 2019 Istanbul election, they acted on the logic that "even if he committed no crime, he must surely have committed something." But that diseased reasoning backfired then, and it is backfiring now. Such baseless, defamatory, hostile conduct finds no place in the conscience of the nation.

* * *

As you know, the sole basis of this supposed indictment—in reality, this indictment of slander—is the statements made by secret witnesses and by those they call "persons expressing effective remorse," people turned into slanderers, saying things like "I heard," "I think," or "It must have been so…" We have all seen how and under what conditions these statements were obtained, and what happened to those who refused to make them, or what threats were used against them.

[This thought continues on printed page 155.]

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED This Indictment Is Null and Void! Original printed pages 155–158

As you know, the only basis for this so-called indictment—in truth, this indictment of slander—is the statements of secret witnesses and of those informers whom they call people showing “effective remorse”: statements such as “I had heard,” “I think,” or “That must be how it happened…” We have all seen how those statements were obtained, under what conditions they were made, and what happened to those who refused to give statements—or what they were threatened with.

Many people withdrew their statements, saying, “I was forced to make these false accusations. They threatened me through my family and my assets.” These are prohibited interrogation methods. That is why these statements, and this indictment of slander itself, are unlawful and amount to violations of human rights. On this ground alone, the case has collapsed. This case is null and void.

A case conducted on the basis of human rights violations has no place in a state governed by the rule of law! And beyond being unlawful, it is devoid of conscience.

In our ancient culture, in our faith, in our moral values, there is no place for threatening people through their families.

Despite all these threats and blackmail, people who were forced into making false accusations have withdrawn them here. They told you that they were coerced into making those accusations. All the so-called “effective remorse” statements that formed the backbone of this indictment of slander are now null and void.

We have also seen here that many statements were recorded inaccurately or distorted. “That is not what I said” became the objection we heard most often.

Finally, the word “template” pierced the heart of this so-called indictment like a dagger. It emerged that the foundation of every accusation—the basic storyline of this cheap theatrical production—was a TEMPLATE text that the prosecution placed before the people making the accusations!

This supposed indictment—this indictment of slander—was already null and void as a matter of law. But after these four months, it has collapsed completely. Not even a fragment remains!

We will also see those who are standing trial without detention, those who made false accusations against my companions and me in order to avoid being detained themselves. We will confront them here! Of course I know the pressure, fear, and blackmail that drove them to make these accusations. But today is the day to stand tall and show courage—for our country, for democracy, for the Republic. I hope that, despite all their fears, they too will find the courage to stand on the right side of history. Otherwise, both history and our nation will see them as one with the perpetrators of the March 19 coup, and will never forgive them!

* * *

“The corruption of the century…” That is the accusation leveled against us. Apparently I had three objectives in establishing a criminal organization for the purpose of corruption.

My first objective was to win Istanbul. My second was to seize control of the CHP. My third was to become President! This is genuinely what the “thing” they call an indictment alleges. To prove these allegations, they identified 143 supposed acts. And they placed me at the very top of them all as the alleged leader of the organization.

I cannot accept as an “indictment” a document that portrays municipal services as crimes, the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality as a criminal organization, and its mayor as the leader of that organization. You could copy and paste the same vague phrases dozens or hundreds of times, turn them into thousands of pages, and attach 200,000 pages of documents. The result would not change. This is not an indictment.

I say it once again: I will never take part in your game. I will never lend myself to your attempt to present an entirely political construction as though a genuine legal process were taking place.

From the day I became Mayor of Beylikdüzü in 2014 until March 19, I answered every question put to me. I maintain that no one in the history of the Republic of Türkiye has undergone as many inspections, investigations, and audits as I have!

I explained it a moment ago: my colleagues and I underwent no fewer than 1,590 audits! Quite possibly no one in world history has undergone so many. Throughout that period, only one case was brought against me over a tender from my time in Beylikdüzü—and that was not until 2023, eight years after the tender! Even with the judiciary in its present condition, despite all the pressure on judges, I was acquitted a few months ago. The judge who delivered the acquittal was punished and transferred to Kahramanmaraş at lightning speed immediately afterward.

If you had asked me about the 143 alleged acts presented as my “crimes” in the indictment during the ordinary course of inspection and investigation, I would have answered every question. But I cannot accept that municipal procedures that have passed all internal and external audits and been cleared—many of them also approved by a Municipal Council in which the AKP held a majority—are now being presented to me as crimes, precisely when millions of voters have chosen me as a presidential candidate.

I will not participate in a game designed to dress a political objective—a coup—in the trappings of law!

This process began with the actions of a politician disguised as a prosecutor, specially assigned from Ankara to bring this case. It developed first through questionable secret witnesses, then through statements by people who, unable to withstand threats to their freedom, families, and assets, became false accusers.

Municipal transactions that had been cleared by dozens of state institutions were thrown together in a sack and labeled “criminal organization.” Seeing all this, I am not going to treat the indictment as worthy of consideration and debate these already-cleared transactions with you here.

I will not stand here explaining routine municipal activities—tenders, purchases, and the like—as though a real trial were underway, or as though these prosecutors were genuinely concerned about corruption. I will not fall for that. And my conscience is entirely clear.

For four months, my colleagues have answered every slander in the indictment down to the smallest detail. They have laid out every fact, supported by documents! They responded to each allegation one by one, and the indictment fell apart at the seams…

By the end of these hearings, not a single question remained unanswered. But you cannot force me to utter a single word that would obscure the fundamentally political nature of a case constructed from beginning to end for political purposes, or of an arrest carried out for entirely political reasons.

I address all my fellow citizens of conscience and common sense, whose eyes, minds, and hearts are fixed on this place. What is happening in this courtroom is the work of a mentality that sees itself as the owner of this country, the master of the nation, the very embodiment of the state. This entire operation has just one purpose: to make me fall from your esteem and affection, and to try to guarantee the outcome of the next election.

There is not a single person in this country who fails to see this truth. There are only those who hesitate to say what they see, those who try to forget the ugly picture before them. I am fighting this struggle to protect their rights too, and to help restore confidence in the judiciary.

Some institutions are so precious that there are times when their reputation must be defended even against the conduct of those who serve within them. The judiciary is one such institution.

It is with this sensitivity and this understanding that I reject the indictment.

This baseless, groundless, unlawful, rotten indictment and this case are NULL AND VOID! The schemes devised to strike a blow against the people's will, the conspiracies plotted to obstruct Türkiye's future and halt the nation's march forward, are NULL AND VOID!

What prevails is not the judgment of those who abuse the authority entrusted to them by the nation, but the judgment of the nation itself. It is the nation that decides political cases such as these. Before the nation's decision, every government is powerless. The nation is greater than any government.

* * *

My beloved people,

If I had been the first to be questioned on March 9, this is what I would have said about the alleged acts. I will read it exactly as written:

“I have just emphasized my trust in my bureaucrats, my companions in this struggle, in their honesty and their competence. A leader's greatest strength lies in the confidence they have in themselves and their colleagues. In this respect, too, I am a very strong leader. I am showing our nation the bigger picture and explaining the fundamental reason for this case. My colleagues will explain the facts in all their detail. By the end of this trial, not a single question will remain unanswered.”

And at that time, what was the real owner of this case saying—the man who had been made a “victim” by my election victories and presidential candidacy, the “personal complainant” behind this prosecution? “They never respond to the allegations put forward by the judiciary.”

And what was his mouthpiece saying? “Courtrooms are not political arenas. Mr. Ekrem must defend himself against the 143 acts attributed to him and disprove the evidence.”

Four months have now passed. You have listened to all those made defendants in this case, my bureaucrats, and my companions. Together, we can see that what I predicted I would say on the first day has come to pass. Not a single question remains unanswered!

It has become as clear as daylight that this indictment of slander consists of one vast collection of nonsense, lies, malicious accusations, fabricated reports, lying witnesses, and irrational allegations! It happened before your eyes. You heard it with your own ears: a “criminal organization” that never

existed, conjured out of unlawful statements extracted through appalling methods!

This is a case in which many people, some of whom do not even know one another, are being tried in the same case on completely unrelated allegations simply because of the claim that there was a criminal organization—while subjected to an entirely unjust and unlawful mass detention.

The allegations have all been disproved; every one of them has been thrown back at those who made it. The injustice of the detention orders has likewise been established beyond doubt.

I am proud of all my companions—not only for their devoted work and the projects and services they brought to Istanbul, but because, despite all the pressure, they stood at this lectern and laid out the truth, calmly and clearly, without fear or compromise!

* * *

I will briefly group the slanders presented to us as alleged “acts” into categories and remind you of the facts that have come to light. I will try to follow the order in which the panel questioned the defendants:

[Continues on printed page 159.]

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED *This Indictment Is Null and Void!*

English translation · Original printed pages 159–162

A case in which people, many of whom do not even know one another, are tried in the same proceedings on allegations wholly unrelated to one another, simply because of the claim that there is a criminal organization. And all of them are subjected to wholly unjust and unlawful mass detention.

Every allegation has been disproved and returned to those who made it. It has also been demonstrated beyond doubt that the detention orders were wrong.

I am proud of all my colleagues—not only for their devoted work and the projects, services, and achievements they have brought to Istanbul, but also because, despite all the pressure, they stood at this lectern and explained the truth, point by point, without fear or compromise!

*

Let me briefly group and summarize the slanders presented to us as “acts,” and let us recall the truths that have emerged. I will try to follow the order in which the panel questioned the defendants.

a) **Recruitment at the municipal subsidiaries.** First, you saw how the recruitment of executives at Ağaç A.Ş., İSFALT, Kültür A.Ş., Medya A.Ş., and the other subsidiary companies was conducted. You witnessed that professional background and sectoral expertise were the determining criteria; that no distinctions were made on grounds of political opinion or party affiliation; and that the sole aims were to improve the quality of services provided to Istanbul residents, manage public resources efficiently, and appoint to every position the specialist best qualified to do the job.

You also saw that the existing workforce was retained and the experience inherited from the previous administration was valued. You heard concrete examples of how all our colleagues took care to preserve the institutional culture of these subsidiaries while, of course, correcting anything that was going wrong. Because our approach is not to exclude people but to strengthen institutions. We always acted with the interests of 16 million Istanbul residents in mind, not those of a privileged few.

To touch on these matters briefly:

b) **AĞAÇ A.Ş.** You heard our colleagues testify here about Ağaç A.Ş. They refuted, one by one in this courtroom, the baseless claims put before us under twelve supposed “acts,” the obvious calculation errors in the MASAK reports, and the strained interpretations of HTS telecommunications traffic records.

By juxtaposing routine commercial payment schedules, such as year-end debt reduction, with statements of “effective remorse” subsequently altered in exchange for promises, they tried to write the story of a criminal organization that never existed.

Yet, as you saw from the documents, what we have here is not an organization using public resources for criminal purposes. Quite the opposite: it is a revitalized, transparent institution that, after 2019,

increased its turnover from 412 million lira to 9.7 billion lira, passed Court of Accounts audits with a clean record thanks to its qualified staff, and entered the ranks of Turkey's 500 largest companies.

Every slander directed at this honorable endeavor—one that serves Istanbul residents and has strengthened competition and institutional capacity by increasing the number of active suppliers—has been shattered by the facts and returned to its authors.

c) **İSFALT and road maintenance operations.** At this subsidiary and within our road maintenance departments, we worked with expert teams invited to serve solely on the strength of their qualifications and decades of municipal experience, regardless of political affiliation. These teams managed some of the world's most demanding winter-response operations without failure and did not leave 16 million Istanbul residents stranded on the roads in the middle of winter.

Services operated smoothly, and tenders passed Court of Accounts audits without adverse findings. What is more, these bureaucrats protected the public interest by imposing fines of millions of lira on contractors without hesitation, even for minor shortcomings. Yet we are confronted with slanders of “public loss” and a “criminal organization.” Clearly, what is really being put on trial and punished here is our honest, transparent, merit-based approach to municipal government, which would not allow a single penny belonging to Istanbul residents to be squandered.

d) **KİPTAŞ.** You heard a great deal here about KİPTAŞ.

The documents showed that in 2019 we took over a company that was virtually bankrupt: its headquarters building was mortgaged because of debts to public banks and tax offices; it owed the market 1.2 billion lira at the values of the time; it could not participate in tenders; and it was unable to deliver its projects. You also heard how, within just a year and a half, all its debts were paid and it was transformed into a strong organization with 1 billion lira in cash and 3 billion lira in receivables.

But the most important thing is not merely the figures. KİPTAŞ underwent a transformation in its outlook. For the first time in its 25-year history, a Real Estate Valuation Unit was established. Arbitrary practices and pricing below market value were brought to an end. Multiple-approval mechanisms replaced decisions made by a single signature. The “single cash pool, single account” approach was abandoned, ending the practice of consuming the resources of one project on another.

For the first time in KİPTAŞ's history, auctions were held openly and broadcast live. Draws for social housing were conducted in the presence of a notary and broadcast live. Through the “Istanbul Is Renewing” platform, we established a system based not on personal connections but on transparency. Everyone wishing to work with KİPTAŞ was given the opportunity to apply on equal terms.

Above all, beyond the figures, work was done that directly affected people's lives. Across 25 separate areas in three districts, 2,519 at-risk buildings were transformed, directly affecting the lives of approximately 11,000 people. Whereas urban renewal had been limited over KİPTAŞ's preceding 25 years, under our administration construction was undertaken on 18,258 independent units across 49 projects, and 11,705 independent units were delivered to their rightful beneficiaries.

What stands before us is not a criminal organization, but a revived institution, a system made transparent, and thousands of people whose lives have been improved!

e) **KÜLTÜR A.Ş. and MEDYA A.Ş.** The tenders of Kültür A.Ş. and Medya A.Ş. were the area in which the third-largest alleged amount of public loss was identified.

So what did we discover in the end about the allegations splashed across headlines for months and relentlessly exploited for days? We discovered that the tenders had been conducted properly. We discovered that these two subsidiaries, which had operated at a loss under the AKP administration, had been restored to health and turned into profitable institutions.

At this point, I must explain something very important. Let me tell you how a valuable asset was handed over from the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality to Kültür A.Ş., and from Kültür A.Ş. to a private company, with the signature of the then mayor, Erdoğan—for a margin of just **1%**, in 1994, a year of high inflation.

Look: this so-called indictment virtually treats the operation of Istanbul's billboards by Kültür A.Ş. as a crime. Yet Kültür A.Ş.'s operation of the billboards is nothing new; it has been a practice since 1994. The important distinction is that, before our administration, these activities were carried out under a questionable business model. Let me explain.

In 1994, when Erdoğan was Mayor of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, a tender was held for the operation of billboards and information boards. The tender was awarded to municipal subsidiaries, and the tender documents expressly gave the following justification:

> *"If they were operated by private individuals or companies, arbitrary practices might arise; taking into account the special nature of operating the billboards and information boards in question, the benefit to the administration if one of our municipal companies were the operator, and the possibility of requiring the premises to be vacated at any time in the future without having to file an eviction lawsuit..."*

On that basis, only three municipal subsidiaries—İSBAK, BELBİM, and Kültür A.Ş.—were invited. Just think: some of our colleagues have been in prison for a year and a half on allegations of restricting competition in tenders, yet here a model was adopted in which only municipal subsidiaries could participate.

The estimated tender price was also based on a standard-form letter from a Mayoralty Valuation Commission that offered no market research or comparable transactions. Despite this, Kültür A.Ş., the sole bidder, won the tender and then, without conducting any open tender, immediately subleased the operation to İnterpan, a company within the İlbak Group—which has somehow disappeared from the indictment—with a margin of **ONLY 1%** above that questionable estimated price! In substance, Erdoğan's İBB administration handed the billboards over to the İLBAK Group without a tender!

Indeed, the arrangement was brought before the courts, and in 1998 a tender was held as a result of judicial intervention. This time, competition emerged for the first time: the Gürsa–Alma Consortium entered the tender, offered a price far above the amount paid by the İlbak companies, and won. The fact that Gürsa–Alma bid many times more than the İlbak offer is clear proof of just how cheaply the billboards had been handed to the İlbak companies between 1994 and 1998, to the detriment of the public.

Despite this, Erdoğan, then Mayor of Istanbul, refrained from approving the tender. He gave his approval only after İnterpan, the company owned by the İlbak interests, was brought into the consortium that had won. Our esteemed prosecutors might consider this **extortion by a public official through abuse of office (*irtikap*)**!

Translator's note: “MASAK” refers to Turkey's Financial Crimes Investigation Board; “HTS” refers to historical telecommunications traffic records. “Effective remorse” denotes the Turkish criminal-law mechanism of etkin pişmanlık. The quoted 1994 tender rationale and the accusations concerning the tender are reproduced as claims and quotations in the source text, not independently verified findings.

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED *This Indictment Is Null and Void!*

English translation · Original printed pages 163–166

In the end, the wrongful practices of the previous administration—such as transferring rights for twenty years in exchange for only marginal profit margins—were abandoned, and in our administration the public interest alone was taken into account.

While improper practices were corrected, established and consistent practices inherited from earlier administrations that complied with the law were preserved. Our employees who contributed their knowledge and experience to the institution remained in their positions.

My colleagues explained all this here, point by point. They refuted, one by one, the biased assessments submitted to the case file as reports.

Among the companies involved in much of what is being presented as public losses in the culture and media sector are companies close to the government—the İlbak and Bacacı groups—which, for some reason, have not been included as defendants in the case. The Bacacı group was awarded a twenty-year tender in 2018, yet its name is scarcely mentioned in this case; it has not been added as a defendant. Let me be absolutely clear: there was no such irregularity, no such handing over of public assets to favored interests, during our administration!

Since the subject has come up, allow me a brief digression. One of the most striking features of the so-called indictment in this politically contrived case is that the politically motivated chief prosecutor designates and detains whichever individuals and institutions he wishes, while simply “overlooking” others. Let me give you a few examples of this application of two different standards of justice.

Acting as though everything before 2019 had been erased from history, the prosecution does not even identify as complainants or witnesses people known to be close to the AKP or Erdoğan. That alone reveals that the prosecution's intention is not to conduct a genuine trial.

For example, when the so-called investigation of the century was launched, why was no interest shown in the person whose identity was known and who had tipped off businessman Murat Kapki? Why was no statement taken from the individual who offered, in exchange for money, to have Murat Kapki removed from the investigation?

While Murat Kapki is accused of money laundering after transferring eight properties in Acarkent and three of his companies in a single day to a member of a family very close to the President, why is the recipient not treated as a party to the alleged offense? Likewise, why is Kapki's lawyer a defendant over another property transfer, while the name of this person close to Erdoğan does not even appear in the file? This is a concrete example of the entirely political motives behind the case.

A company whose premises contained the stamps of thirty-eight different firms, whose owner allegedly concealed several companies belonging to him, entered them in tenders, and arranged for false invoices to be issued is a defendant in this case—yet no prison sentence is sought against it. Is that because the company owner has a relative known as “Cübbeli”? What is the power that sets him

apart and keeps him free?

Under Alleged Act 13, prosecutors claim that the data of eleven million Istanbul residents was leaked. Moreover, those same prosecutors allege that the data was leaked to a company called Çekino. How, then, are we supposed to interpret the fact that nobody from Çekino was detained or questioned, that the company's premises were not searched by police, and that its digital materials were not seized? Did the prosecutors fail to write the truth? Does Çekino have powerful protection? What ties does it have to the AKP government?

We could recount dozens of similar incidents: people detained, imprisoned, and later released; people named in the indictment; four working-class drivers imprisoned simply because another driver named them—yet two brothers named in the very same person's statement are nowhere mentioned in the indictment, allegedly because they come from the justice minister's hometown and are close to him.

Many of my fellow defendants explained these matters one by one in their defenses. During the investigation, the statements of witnesses and people who had become confessors explicitly named many individuals publicly known to be close to the AKP or the Erdoğan family. Yet, curiously, when the case was filed, every one of those names appeared to evaporate from the file. Today those individuals are neither witnesses, defendants, nor complainants in this case. If everyone is equal before the law, where did these names go? Who removed them from the case? This process, carried out under the coordination of the Minister of Justice, is concrete proof of one of the gravest injustices of the century.

Those who wrote this indictment—a handbook of double standards, selective investigations, and, in short, lawlessness—can keep it for themselves!

Returning to the billboards...

Ultimately, your panel of judges did not accept the indictment's approach of presenting the entire contractual value of tenders that had been completed and performed as though it were a loss to the public. Once it became clear that no loss had occurred, the panel granted my colleagues the right to present an additional defense.

The allegations that had been discussed publicly for months and used as a weapon against my colleague Murat Ongun were shown to be untrue. That is the nature of the truth: however much you cover it up, however often you repeat a falsehood, the truth eventually emerges.

Here, I thank every one of our executives and colleagues who have defended their institutions, their work, and the fruits of their labor with dignity throughout this process. For what they have described is not a story of crime. It is the story of an approach to administration that puts the public interest first, restores loss-making institutions to health, and uses Istanbul's resources for the people of Istanbul.

f) Personal Data: Another allegation was that we obtained the personal data of Istanbul residents, leaked it, and used it unlawfully.

To tell the truth, when I first heard this accusation, I could not quite understand it myself. Indeed, we all witnessed the presiding judge in this courtroom express difficulty understanding what the allegation was based on.

I, too, discovered here, together with everyone else, what this claim was supposed to mean. It was such an absurd accusation that all of us struggled to make sense of it! The colleagues imprisoned because of these irrational allegations came forward and explained, step by step, what the "İstanbul Senin" ("Istanbul Is Yours") application is, what it is not, and what purpose it serves. And we saw that there was no data unlawfully obtained, no data leaked, and not a single item of personal information used unlawfully!

No personal data belonging to the people of Istanbul has been used unlawfully. There is no such fact established in this case, nor in the espionage case being heard in the courtroom next door.

Once again we saw that an accusation had been made first, and evidence to fit that accusation was sought afterward.

And once again we understood that it is possible to present a nonexistent crime as though it were real, but it is not possible to bring a nonexistent fact into existence.

g) Municipalities: You also listened carefully to the assessments concerning our Beylikdüzü and Beyoğlu municipalities.

The reason our mayors Resul Emrah Şahan, Mehmet Murat Çalık, and İnan Güney are here is not solely political.

They are here also because they succeeded, because they refused to permit offenses against the city, and because they placed the public interest first. You heard them describe their work here. I can say with complete confidence that many of the initiatives they implemented are exemplary not only for their own districts but for all local governments in Türkiye.

They explained, carefully and clearly, practices that should serve as models for every city: an approach founded on transparency, socially responsible municipal government, the right to the city, and the public interest. I hope that the commitment to public service and the philosophy of administration they described will spread throughout the country.

For an approach that protects our cities, places people before private gain, and stands firm against offenses against the urban environment should be emulated, not punished.

I believe that history, and our nation, will remember what was said from these lecterns not merely as a defense, but as the honorable struggle of people who stood up for their cities.

Another Allegation: Extortion by Coercion

Frankly, this allegation reminds me of a particular mentality.

Sometimes people assume that others must use the same methods they use themselves.

We are facing a reflection of the attitude: "If this is how we do things, then surely they must have done the same."

Our colleagues and defense lawyers explained everything here, point by point. But is there any coercion? Is there a single piece of evidence of pressure, threats, or compulsion directed at a businessperson? No. Is there the slightest proof that any official action was made conditional on a donation? No.

So what is there? There is support from responsible businesspeople who knew and believed that the work undertaken would serve Istanbul and its residents and that their contributions would be used for the public good.

That is all there is to it. But here is what really matters: some people keep using the phrase “personal enrichment.” They have written it repeatedly in the indictment. Yet is there a single piece of evidence? No. Is there proof that even one kuruş went into an individual's pocket? No. Because it is clear where these resources went: they went to childcare centers.

Continuity note: The list of public-benefit uses continues at the beginning of original printed page 167; the next installment will resume there.

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED *This Indictment Is Null and Void!*

English translation · Original printed pages 167–170

It went to student dormitories. It went to people in need. It went toward protecting our cultural heritage. It came back to Istanbul in the form of public services. It was spent on the city's needs. But it did not go into anyone's pocket! That is the difference between your approach and ours. We saw public resources as a means of serving the public good, not of personal enrichment.

The allegations of fraud, bribery, bid-rigging and other financial offenses in this case are products of the same mentality.

Allegations that kept changing shape from investigation to indictment, and from indictment to trial; allegations that contradicted one another and were supported by no concrete evidence beyond the statements of a handful of people who had invoked the provisions on effective remorse... One by one, they were refuted here, before your very eyes, in this courtroom. The truth emerged. The slanders were returned to those who made them. All that remained were assertions founded on assumptions and unsupported by evidence.

Finally, I want to address the allegation of a supposed criminal organization—the elaborate fiction they call the “SYSTEM.”

We were told that an organization called the “System” had been established to take control of the Republican People's Party (CHP) and influence the process of selecting a presidential candidate, and that illicit proceeds were gathered within it.

I only wish the people making these claims could stand behind their words. I wish they had dared to allow the hearings to be broadcast live, so that our nation could watch for itself how the lie they call the “System,” and the slander they call a criminal organization, amounted to nothing more than a fiction concocted by prosecutors; how stories were manufactured from templates placed before people who had been frightened, intimidated and terrified.

Fortunately, however, all of this has now been recorded in news reports, archives and official transcripts. And after months of hearings, the concrete truth has emerged: there is no criminal organization under my name, under the name “System,” or under any other name.

Many of the allegations put before us by the prosecution as “testimonial evidence” destroyed themselves in this courtroom. Statements contradicted one another. The fabricated narratives collapsed when confronted with the facts.

And that was not all. This case showed us people held captive for over a year simply because they were related to someone. People were arrested merely because they were my friends, and subjected to pressure, threats and all manner of coercion. There are people still deprived of their liberty despite not a single piece of concrete evidence having been presented against them. And regrettably, although this court has seen all of this, it has not shown—or has been unable to show—the resolve needed to bring this lawlessness to an end.

During these hearings, extremely serious allegations also emerged in this courtroom concerning pressure being brought to bear on people, attempts to obtain evidence through improper methods, and violations of the confidentiality of the investigation.

That is the picture presented by what the indictment calls its “acts”…

And despite everything, I want once again to thank my fellow travelers, colleagues and team: people who carried out the work of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality with tremendous dedication, whose public services were portrayed as crimes, and who were deprived of their freedom, yet still came to this lectern and refuted every accusation one by one. I am proud of you. You stood on the side of conscience, not fear; on the side of truth, not oppression! You stood on the right side of history.

At this point, we can see that there is no criminal organization. There is a fabricated case that has collapsed. There is no “system.” There are slanders that could not withstand being tested against reality.

Now let me continue...

*

Remember: when they mounted their dawn raids against the mayor of a city of 16 million people, the opposition's presidential candidate, and dozens of his colleagues, they needed an enormous pretext to justify this assault. So headlines such as “the corruption of the century” and “560 billion lira in corruption” were pumped out through the press and television around the clock! Before long, they reduced that figure to 160 billion Turkish lira...

But how did they arrive at 160 billion lira? Largely on the basis of two allegations:

1. Cebeci (110 billion TL); and 2. International loans (50 billion TL).

My colleagues have already answered every allegation in the greatest detail. Nevertheless, I want to say a few words about these two claims, which account for almost the entirety of the alleged “loss to the public.” I will explain just how empty—indeed, how absurd and founded on enormous falsehoods—these allegations are.

Let Us Begin with the Loans...

The allegation concerning the loans is evidence not of a loss to the public, but of a benefit to the public!

Alleged Act 60, the section on “Loans,” is perhaps the most striking culmination of this “slanderment”—an indictment that will go down in history, from beginning to end, as a document of ill intent and shame.

I must say something about Act 60. Most of the members of my team being tried in connection with this act are not being held in pretrial detention, so this allegation was not addressed during the hearings. Yet it supposedly accounts for roughly one-third of the “loss to the public” asserted in the indictment!

Do you know the mentality behind Act 60? “However much we slander them, we still cannot find any loss to the public. We need to raise the figures. Let's add together every loan the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality has taken out and call the total a public loss. That way we can create the impression of a huge loss to the public!” That is the mentality.

In Act 60, the prosecution alleges that funds raised through overseas borrowing, including loans and bond issuances, were “used for purposes other than those intended.” Ekrem İmamoğlu and his team are accused of using these resources to defraud a public institution and cause a loss to the public!

I will explain how irrational and absurd these accusations are. In fact, I owe the prosecution a word of thanks: because of this absurd Act 60, I have the opportunity to tell you about two of our administration's greatest achievements—financial management and the transportation revolution.

I cannot let this pass without mentioning that there are serious factual errors in all the figures cited in the indictment concerning the Seymen Waste Disposal Site Treatment Plant, the Eminönü–Alibeyköy Tram Line, and the Dudullu–Bostancı and Kabataş–Mecidiyeköy–Mahmutbey Metro Projects. In our written defenses, we will address all these grave factual errors and provide the technical answers. But I ask once again: can a supposed “indictment” really be written with such amateurism and such ill intent?

Can all the institutions of the state—the Banking Regulation and Supervision Agency (BDDK), for example—really be made instruments of such a plot, their reputations damaged in the process?

Contrary to the accusations, the competent teams at the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality protected the public interest through effective and efficient financial management.

It is obvious that the prosecution included Act 60 in the indictment in order to “inflate” the alleged loss to the public. The allegation is entirely baseless, and anyone with even a little knowledge of finance would find it laughable.

Since 2020, the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality has established an increasingly strong presence throughout the financial world, particularly in the international capital markets, which it entered for the first time. We achieved this through the confidence that investors and lenders placed in our administration, the positive impression we created, our skilled personnel and our fiscal discipline.

In international finance, the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality has become a recognized name in its category: in everyday terms, a public institution that “does its homework”—one that meets its payment obligations, is strong, dynamic, trustworthy, transparent and accountable. The awards our institution has received also attest to this.

Securing financing for large infrastructure projects—megaprojects—is no easy task! Indeed, it was under our administration that a local government first succeeded in undertaking megaprojects of this scale with international financing. First comes a preliminary design, then a detailed feasibility study; the most efficient sources of finance are identified, the project is designed, an investment budget is prepared, and all necessary bureaucratic approvals are obtained, among other steps. Achieving this takes exceptionally capable teams able to work to international standards. Under

our administration, that is precisely what we accomplished!

I graduated from the English-language business administration program at one of Türkiye's finest and most established universities. Unlike some people, I am no “fake economist”; I genuinely understand these matters!

When we took office at the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality in 2019, we inherited numerous “ghost” metro projects: projects tendered as far back as 2016 but never even begun because financing was lacking, projects with no completed designs, and others where little more than a construction site had been set up.

These are megaprojects requiring substantial investment budgets, the kind undertaken with international financing all over the world. Since 2019, my colleagues and I have worked intensively to bring these projects to our city and place them at the service of our people. As a result of that work, once our Financial Center metro line (Göztepe–Ataşehir–Ümraniye) opens in a few months, the total length of rail systems we have built in Istanbul will reach **82.5 kilometers**. [Sentence completed from the beginning of printed page 171.]

Continuity note: The source continues on page 171 with the total length including projects financed, followed by the funding approval process and further financial figures. These passages belong to the next installment.

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED *This Indictment Is Null and Void!*

English translation · Original printed pages 171–174

With the Financial Center metro line (Göztepe–Ataşehir–Ümraniye), which is due to open in a few months, the total length of rail systems we have built will reach 82.5 kilometers. Including the lines for which we have secured financing, that figure is 105 kilometers.

I will shortly describe the transportation revolution we have carried out.

These loans are subject to such extensive bureaucratic approval and oversight procedures that the accusation in Act 60 becomes even more absurd. To obtain external financing, our projects are first included in the Public Investment Program with the approval of the Presidency of Strategy and Budget of the Republic of Türkiye, in accordance with the applicable legislation. After also obtaining the approval of the Municipal Council, we apply to the Ministry of Treasury and Finance. With the external financing procurement permits issued by that Ministry, we secure loans from reputable, qualified financial institutions.

We have also issued bonds with the necessary approvals from the Capital Markets Board, including Türkiye's first green bond issued by a local government.

All the financing obtained, together with the corresponding repayment schedules and agreements, was reported to the Ministry of Treasury and Finance. Indeed, under the applicable legislation, municipalities cannot obtain any external financing without completing all these demanding bureaucratic approval and oversight procedures.

Now let us recall the concrete facts: under our administration, İBB has never defaulted on any loan it has used or any bond it has issued!

The net financing secured for our rail system projects from June 2019 through 2025 was **€2.832 billion**. A total of **€2.932 billion** was paid toward these projects. Moreover, on December 8, 2025, the first unsecured Eurobond repayment, amounting to **$580 million**, was made. The present-day value of the transportation projects we have delivered is at least **€5 billion**! What public loss are you talking about? By finding and using the right sources of financing and implementing efficient projects, we have created at least **€2 billion** in value for the public.

What the prosecution calls a crime in the indictment is effective, rational, and efficient financial management!

The prosecution is accusing İBB of repaying its debts and using its resources efficiently and equitably. It is not the undertaking of these actions that would be a crime, but the failure to undertake them!

Any financing obtained from abroad or domestically becomes a financial resource of our institutions as soon as it enters their accounts. It has been used effectively, economically, and efficiently, in compliance with the Regulation on Public Treasury Management and all other applicable legislation.

The principal regulation governing the use of such financial resources is the Regulation on Public Treasury Management. The İBB administration used and managed all these financial resources in **100**

percent compliance with that regulation. Far from causing a loss to the public, it prevented such losses through the effective and efficient use of public resources.

Will the Prosecution Open an Investigation into the Treasury of the Republic of Türkiye as Well?

If the prosecution alleges that the proceeds of bond issues have been used unlawfully, it can examine the bond issues of both the Treasury and all the banks. That is because the proceeds received by all these institutions and banks from bond issues are transferred into pooled accounts.

Funds are then drawn from those accounts as needed for various purposes. The principal obligation under such issues is simply to pay the interest and principal on time.

For instance, the agreement relating to the **$712 million "Green Bond Issue,"** the largest transaction cited in the indictment, contains the following provision:

> *"The Net Loan Proceeds will be managed by the Issuer on a **PORTFOLIO BASIS**. Until full allocation has been completed, unallocated amounts will be managed in accordance with the Issuer's **GENERAL CASH MANAGEMENT** policies."*

As this provision makes clear, the financing received was to be managed by our administration in accordance with its general cash management policies—and that is precisely how it was managed. Yet again, acting with appalling bad faith, the prosecution ignored even this perfectly explicit provision!

Or perhaps the prosecution genuinely did not understand these provisions or how finance works. I suspect that those directing the prosecution did not understand either. "Fake economists" may not fully grasp such matters. I am an **economist with a diploma**; I graduated from the Business Administration Department of one of Türkiye's oldest and most distinguished universities. Let me remind you!

There is something else I must mention briefly. In 2023, we issued **Türkiye's first municipal green bond**, with a five-year maturity and a total value of **$715 million**, on the London Stock Exchange. Türkiye's overall green bond target for 2023 was $1.5 billion; İBB alone achieved half that target.

The issue attracted a total of **$2.6 billion** in demand from more than 200 different investment institutions, representing approximately **3.6 times** the issue size and exceeding the demand attracted by all other corporate issuers. Thus, demand was approximately twice the total demand collected for all non-government issues in Türkiye in 2023. That is the standing İBB enjoyed under our administration!

The reason we attracted such strong demand was the confidence international markets had in our management of İBB!

Lenders—banks—are institutions that work with some of the most sophisticated and extensive legal teams in the world. They are not "consumers" in need of protection! Nor do they show anyone mercy: they have armies of lawyers draft the strictest contractual clauses. If a bank wishes, when extending a loan for a project, it can expressly stipulate that the funds must be held in a dedicated account and used only to meet certified payments for that particular project.

In most cases, however, banks understand the normal financing and cash-management needs of borrowers and therefore allow flexibility in this respect. If a borrower fails to manage its finances properly and defaults, the agreement imposes very severe penalties for that default.

And yet, although the provision allowing resources to be managed through a pooled account was actually reproduced in the indictment itself, the prosecution then inexplicably argued that this arrangement caused a loss to the public! I believe the prosecution has difficulty understanding even the most basic provisions of financing agreements...

If a story of public loss can be constructed from this, one might just as well claim that the Turkish Treasury causes a loss to the public whenever it transfers all proceeds of its bond issues into accounts at the Central Bank of the Republic of Türkiye on the same day! The same logic, the same practice.

As for loans, the syndicated loans obtained by all Turkish banks, including public banks, enter pooled correspondent accounts. Various payments are made from those accounts according to each bank's needs. Only at specified intervals is it then reported which export loan or green-transition loan the resources have been allocated to. Such contractual freedom is appropriate for both borrower and lender.

If the approach adopted by the prosecution in the indictment were applied consistently, payments that public banks make to their various customers from correspondent accounts after receiving syndicated loan proceeds would also have to be treated as losses to the public. On that reasoning, allegations of hundreds of trillions in public losses could be put forward!

What extraordinary bad faith—or what extraordinary ignorance!

Act 60 was written by a mind that does not understand the first thing about finance. To those in power who supposedly wish to make Istanbul a new “financial center” for our region, I say: take care! If banks read this indictment, you can forget your dreams of a financial center!

Can anyone do this much harm to our beautiful country merely to remove one person from an electoral contest?

Furthermore, this indictment casts suspicion on some of the world's leading financial institutions. We obtained the loans referred to in Act 60 from major international financial institutions such as **Standard Chartered Bank, ING, the French Development Agency, Merrill Lynch, Bank of America, Emirates NBD Capital, BNP Paribas, and J.P. Morgan**.

The Minister of Treasury and Finance should have been the first to object to leading financial institutions being cast under suspicion and dragged into such an ugly indictment. He should have said: “What are you doing? You will destroy our country's creditworthiness! How can anyone be so ignorant!” If the Finance Minister cannot do that, there is no need for him to keep traveling to London. In an environment where the rule of law is trampled upon to this extent, our country will attract neither investment nor inexpensive financing...

This indictment either understands nothing about “finance” and “cash management,” or maliciously pretends not to understand...

The indictment also contains this statement:

> *“...because the funds were transferred to these companies, the intended benefit from the foreign financing obtained could not be achieved, resulting in further foreign financing of a similar nature being used for the same purpose, thereby causing a loss to the public in pursuit of the organization's objectives...”*

That statement represents a complete suspension of reason.

The primary purpose of obtaining financing is to increase and manage our institution's financial resources to the extent permitted by law. Using these funds to make payments outside a particular project—but still to individuals and legal entities that are creditors of our institution—did not undermine that purpose in any way. On the contrary, because our institution was able to distribute payments evenly among its creditors, it benefited, and the financing achieved its purpose.

The breakdown of payments made by Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality to contractors, toward credit liabilities, and for similar obligations from 2019 to the present will make this readily apparent.

Continuity note: The preceding final sentence continues the argument onto original printed page 175, where the discussion of expenditure items and refinancing proceeds. That discussion will be translated in the next installment.

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED *This Indictment Is Null and Void!*

English translation · Original printed pages 175–178

[Continuing the sentence from page 174:] An examination of the distribution of payments made by Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality (IMM) to contractors, toward loan debts, and for similar obligations from 2019 to the present would readily demonstrate this.

Looking at the expenditure items cited in the indictment, one can see that every payment was made on a legally valid basis (loan repayments, Social Security Institution contributions, taxes, contractual obligations, and so on).

Moreover, the phrase “the repeated use of foreign financing of a similar nature,” in the passage quoted above, is offered as though it proved the existence of a loss. That, too, is wrong. According to the indictment, “approximately 20% of the financing was used again to make payments to foreign financial institutions; in other words, debt was repaid with more debt, causing a loss to the public.” To begin with, the assertion is not even true.

Not only is it factually incorrect; the truly disturbing aspect is this: in the first three months of 2026, the Treasury of the Republic of Türkiye repaid $5.5 billion on foreign-currency bonds (Eurobonds), while borrowing another $5.9 billion. In other words, for every $100 of debt it repaid, it borrowed $107. Its debt rollover ratio was 107%. Would the prosecutor who claims a public loss in our case over a rate of 20% also declare that the Treasury of the Republic of Türkiye caused a public loss at 107%?

In finance, this is called refinancing, or a “rollover,” and it is an entirely ordinary financing method used by government institutions and businesses everywhere. I repeat: this so-called indictment is, from beginning to end, a monument to ill will!

There Is No Loss to the Public: Not a Single Public Loss Was Identified in Any of the Audits Conducted Over the Years

The strongest evidence of this is that none of the internal or external audits of IMM conducted during our administration has ever made a finding of this kind!

The concept of “loss to the public” is principally governed by Article 71 of Law No. 5018 on Public Financial Management and Control. Under that article, public loss means “the prevention of an increase in public resources or the causing of a reduction in those resources as a result of decisions, transactions, or actions contrary to legislation arising from the intent, fault, or negligence of public officials.”

As is clear, before one can speak of a public loss, there must be a decision by a public official contrary to legislation; the action must arise from fault or negligence; and, as a result of that action, public resources must fail to increase or must diminish.

The article also sets out the criteria for determining a public loss. These include payments in excess of the amount due, payments made without goods having been received, and excessive or unjustified

payments, among others.

The mere allegation that foreign financing was transferred to different institutions for purposes other than its designated use cannot, by itself, establish that a public loss occurred!

The obligations attached to all the bonds and loans in question are governed by contracts. Those contracts reserve rights of objection to borrowers and lenders alike. Indeed, the relevant loan agreements spell out in detail the procedures to be followed in the event of a dispute. In this respect, there is no legal dispute with any creditor under the loan agreements concerned. To date, not a single lender or intermediary has brought proceedings against IMM or sent it a notice on these matters.

If you research the banks named in the indictment, you will find that they rank among the ten or fifteen largest banks in the world. I named a few of them earlier. Those banks employ hundreds of lawyers, and each also has legal representatives in our country. As if that were not enough, almost all of them naturally have contacts with senior government officials. Yet, strangely enough, none of these banks has considered the contractual terms to have been breached and filed a lawsuit, or even sent our municipality an oral or written notice. Instead, the prosecution has stepped forward on behalf of these foreign banks and chosen to defend their supposed rights (!). Of course, its real concern is simply how to smear Ekrem İmamoğlu!

Let me remind you once more: contrary to these allegations, we prevented losses to the public through good management.

Given the difficult economic conditions and the government's obstruction, if we had mismanaged our finances and resources, we might have had to pay heavy penalties to contractors or banks on IMM projects. In that situation, a public loss might indeed have occurred. But through effective management, we prevented it.

In short, considering the economic crisis experienced since 2019, it would have been a very poor choice to use foreign financing exclusively to pay the contractors on the financed projects, while paying our other contractors at much lower rates, limited by our own available resources. Such a course would have harmed commercial activity and distorted competition among contractors.

That is why we managed our funds fairly and sustainably, and as a result we have not had a single problem with our lending institutions to date.

Indeed, after the operations against us, in October 2025 we signed new loan agreements with ENBD for $75 million and €20 million; then, in February 2026, after the indictment had become public—and after this incomprehensible Act 60 had been written—we signed another loan agreement with the EBRD for €110 million.

The world's leading and most experienced banks did not even take the prosecution's accusations seriously. If they had taken those allegations seriously, would they have entrusted millions more to an IMM administration accused of “misusing loans”?

The prosecution takes ordinary account movements following external financing out of context and, ignoring the basic logic of how finance works, manufactures an allegation of public loss. This approach rests on an inconsistent assessment divorced from technical and financial reality.

Let me explain it in a way the prosecution might understand. You need a refrigerator, so you take out a consumer loan to buy one. The bank deposits the money in your account. You then go to the dealer and buy the refrigerator with your credit card. Your card payment falls due on the fifth of the month. Meanwhile, the beginning of the month arrives, and you use the money deposited from the consumer loan to pay your rent. On the fifth, your salary arrives, and you use that to pay the credit-card bill. So what happened? Did you misuse the loan? No. You managed your household finances and avoided putting your creditors in difficulty. I am sure the prosecutors who wrote this indictment have done the same in their own lives! If not, perhaps they have never had a lesson in household economics!

In conclusion, all the allegations raised under Act 60 of the indictment are completely unfounded in legal, financial, and technical terms. For the use of an external funding source outside its designated project to become the subject of an objection or lawsuit, the creditor institution would have to lodge a complaint; but that has nothing to do with our present circumstances.

Because the Government Delayed Loan Approvals, We Had to Refinance Our Own Resources Effectively on Many Projects

Through effective financial management, we ensured that IMM never defaulted on any project or loan. Because loan approvals were delayed, and because we did not want Istanbul residents to be deprived of transportation projects, we began many projects using IMM's own funds. We paid progress claims from those resources. When the loans subsequently arrived, we transferred the funds back into IMM's resources.

That is what good financial management means. The result was that projects benefiting Istanbul residents proceeded without interruption. We could not accept the people of Istanbul being punished because of the government's obstruction.

Had we waited for permissions delayed in bad faith, Istanbul's traffic problems would have grown worse by the day, and life would have become unbearable.

We practiced the kind of sound financial management that every competent and successful administration should practice. Moreover, had the government not delayed our project approvals so much, we could have obtained financing on even better terms.

The indictment failed to understand what refinancing an institution's own resources means, and treated these transactions as crimes! Let me give you some examples.

Dudullu–Bostancı and Kabataş–Mecidiyeköy–Mahmutbey Metro Projects: The financing obtained for Dudullu–Bostancı was also refinancing of our own resources: the institution had already paid the progress claims, and the money received was used to replenish those payments. Of the $191 million alleged to have been used, $167.4 million was used to purchase Treasury bonds (Eurobonds) from state banks. As IMM, we bought Treasury securities from state banks to protect our financial resources against inflation, and even that was treated as a crime! Under this allegation, the prosecution is accusing us of acting in our institution's interests!

Continuity note: The discussion of the Eminönü–Alibeyköy Tram Line begins at the end of printed page 178 and continues on page 179; its full account will appear in the next installment.

CHAPTER FIVE — CONTINUED *This Indictment Is Null and Void!*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 179–182

The Eminönü–Alibeyköy Tram Line was restarted using İBB's own resources before financing had been secured, and was subsequently completed after international funding was obtained.

The Rumeli Hisarüstü–Aşiyan Funicular Line project was financed and completed entirely from the İBB budget, with a funding plan based on our own resources, because it was not included in the Public Investment Program.

Waste Incineration and Energy Generation Facility: Once again, the prosecution either failed to understand the express provisions of the Agreement or pretended not to understand them! Here, too, we complied with the Agreement's provisions one hundred percent. All the funds used for this project were used for refinancing. In other words, project payments were made from our institution's own resources, and when the financing arrived, the funds were transferred back into the institution's own resources.

For the additional external borrowing of €75 million requested because of rising costs in completing the Çekmeköy–Sancaktepe–Sultanbeyli Metro Line, the application we submitted to the İBB Municipal Council in February 2023 was approved on November 27, 2023, after a wait of approximately ten months. Following the Council's approval, we submitted our request to the Ministry of Treasury and Finance on December 6, 2023. Only in April 2025—after a further wait of approximately one and a half years—was it finally approved!

Including the latest loan obtained from Dubai-based Emirates NBD, approximately €380 million in loans have been secured for the Çekmeköy–Sancaktepe–Sultanbeyli Metro Line project to date. Throughout the loan approval processes, which lasted almost one and a half years, the project continued entirely with İBB's own resources. Construction of the line never stopped.

There you have a few examples of sound financial management. To ensure that the people of Istanbul did not suffer, İBB began the projects using its own resources and paid the progress-payment claims arising from the works. Because loan approvals for the projects arrived so late, the loan proceeds were transferred to İBB when they finally became available. This is effective financial and cash management: it kept the projects moving without interruption. The people of Istanbul were the winners. Not the slightest loss to the public was incurred.

Conclusion

— During our administration, Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality conducted its international financing processes in full compliance with all applicable legal requirements. There was not a single transaction contrary to the law.

— International borrowing procedures already take place under an extremely stringent governmental approval and oversight process.

— İBB used the financing it secured effectively and efficiently, within the framework of the Regulation on Public Treasury Management and other applicable legislation.

— Incoming loan proceeds are deposited into current accounts and at that point become the institution's own financial resources. It is a requirement of effective financial management for a public institution to distribute the resources at its disposal in a balanced manner among its creditors and make payments accordingly.

— Not a single lending institution has filed a complaint or initiated legal proceedings against İBB.

— None of the projects cited in the indictment went into default. Every project proceeded in accordance with the applicable procedures, and no public loss occurred. On the contrary, we adopted an approach to cash management that served the public interest. Indeed, the dozens of audits conducted on this subject to date have found no loss to the public whatsoever.

Do you know what the essence of this matter is? It is this:

They set out talking about "the biggest turnip," "the corruption of the century," and so on. They broadcast propaganda about it around the clock on their television channels. They kept repeating the figure of 560 billion Turkish lira. Then they looked and found there was nothing there! First it was 560 billion; then it fell to 160 billion. Fine, but how were they going to "fill out" even that 160 billion? Add up the loans and you get 50 billion. Throw something vague into the bag about Cebeci—"damage to mineral reserves" and "illegal excavation dumping"—and call that another 110 billion. There you have it: 160 billion!

A WHOPPING 160-BILLION-LIRA LIE!

I will tell you about Cebeci shortly anyway. But for now, let us return to our subject.

*

Shall I tell you something else? The fact that we repaid every one of our loans on these megaprojects in full is actually a miracle—a miracle of good management! Because we achieved this despite all the unjust deductions and obstructions the government devised to put us in difficulty!

First, let me tell you about those deductions.

As of April 2019, deductions began to be made from the tax revenues allocated to İBB from the central budget—from İBB's share of Treasury revenues—for railway-system lines constructed by the ministry and subsequently transferred to İBB. What is more, while such deductions would normally be spread over twenty years, under our administration these enormous sums were deducted from the money we were entitled to receive from the Treasury in a single year!

These deductions totaled 15 billion Turkish lira—23 billion Turkish lira at today's value, or $500 million at the exchange rates prevailing on the relevant dates!

When we include these lines, which we paid for entirely ourselves, the total length of the rail systems we constructed and financed during our administration comes to 105 kilometers.

Had these deductions, made against İBB's will, not occurred, our administration could have invested those funds and earned income on them. Had our institution been permitted to finance these transferred projects, we could have obtained financing with maturities of up to 120 months. Instead, the government forced us to pay in one year rather than ten. Because they had become blind to everything else. They did not care in the slightest about the difficulties the people of Istanbul would face. They could see nothing except the desire to put us in a difficult position and punish us.

In addition to those deductions, let me briefly describe the obstacles placed in the way of our borrowing.

Our loan request letters to the Ministry of Treasury and Finance were sometimes left unanswered for years. It took at least one and a half to two years to obtain borrowing permission, and many of our applications were rejected. For example, we wrote about our Kaynarca–Pendik–Tuzla project in December 2023; no approval arrived, and we are still waiting.

Do not misunderstand: we were not asking the ministry for money. We were merely asking for permission for metro projects for which we had already found the sources of financing. Even in this, we were subjected to discrimination.

Moreover, not a single public bank extended us a loan! Just think about it: we are a public institution, we want to build a metro to make life easier for sixteen million Istanbul residents, and public banks refuse to lend to us. Do you know how much VakıfBank, Halkbank, Ziraat Bankası, or even İller Bankası—the bank that is supposed to support every municipality—lent us? **ZERO!**

And let me remind you: Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality is the largest shareholder in, and the municipality making the greatest contribution to, İller Bankası. Such arbitrariness and injustice are unheard of. This is precisely what a "party-state" looks like.

All these deductions and obstructions, together with the adverse effects of inflation on costs, harmed our cash planning. Yet despite all these attempts to hold us back, we completed so many projects and never defaulted on a single loan!

At heart, the allegations made in this so-called indictment, written by people with such a malicious mindset, portray as a crime the standard cash-management practices employed throughout the international financial world and by public institutions everywhere. In twenty-first-century Türkiye, a country that claims to aspire to be a regional "financial center," this indictment—and particularly "Act 60"—is a testament to ignorance and ill intent.

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Now let me tell you a little about the financing and the fiscal realities.

We Inherited a Financial Wreck After Twenty-Five Years of AKP Administration—and Transformed İBB Financially!

Let us go back to June 2019, to the days when we took over the administration of İBB. When we assumed office that June, we inherited what was, in effect, a wreck. The mighty Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality had a total of just **7 million Turkish lira** in its treasury! In July, İBB did not have

enough money to pay civil servants' salaries, let alone meet payments for metro construction or any other investment. The treasury had been left completely empty! What is more, there had been a grave irregularity:

The Treasury Share—a portion of monthly tax revenue accounting for more than 90 percent of municipal income—is always paid to municipalities on June 30. Yet in 2019, a total of **960 million Turkish lira**, approximately **9 billion Turkish lira in today's money**, was paid early, on June 10 and June 13. In other words, immediately before the June 23 election, which they knew we would win.

You know there is an utterly absurd "espionage" case: the supposed "spy" Hüseyin Gün allegedly met Necati Özkan ten days before the June 23 election and helped us win it. Oh, come off it!

By June 10, they already knew they would lose the election. That is why they rushed to have the Treasury Share paid ahead of schedule, contrary to established procedure, and distributed the money! An early payment of the Treasury Share was unprecedented in the history of municipal administration. On top of the Treasury Share, another **500 million Turkish lira**—approximately **5 billion Turkish lira in today's money**—was hurriedly paid to İBB as expropriation compensation. Yet the state generally does not pay expropriation compensation in cash.

Continuity note: The account of the municipality's finances and pre-election payments continues on original printed page 183.

CHAPTER FIVE — CONCLUSION *This Indictment Is Null and Void!*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 183–185

Finally, in May 2019, a property sale worth 1.7 billion Turkish lira—more than 10 billion lira at today's value—was hurriedly carried out. Not a penny of those proceeds was left for the period after June.

These enormous payments were made to İBB, through irregular means, immediately before the election, yet only 7 million lira of all that money was left in the municipal treasury.

Let us take a closer look. To whom was money urgently transferred, in such haste and in violation of proper procedures, just before the election? I ask everyone to listen very carefully to what I am about to say.

Erdoğan's lawyer was paid 15.5 million lira—146 million lira at today's value—more than three million dollars! If we had paid a single lawyer more than three million dollars, who knows how many investigations would have been launched against us?

Let me give you a few more examples of payments rushed through before the election. [27] Payments were made to companies close to the government and to certain law firms just one week before the election, leaving virtually nothing in the account.

We Transformed İBB from a Municipality on the Brink of Bankruptcy into One That Pays Its Debts on Time

When we took office, İBB's subsidiary companies had 661 million lira in overdue tax and Social Security Institution (SGK) liabilities—4 billion lira at today's value. When we took office, thirteen of our subsidiaries were unable to participate in tenders because of their tax and SGK debts. Today, as of April 2026, not one of our subsidiaries owes overdue tax or SGK payments!

İGDAŞ had accumulated a debt of 2.6 billion lira to BOTAŞ—25.3 billion lira at today's value. We paid off İGDAŞ's accumulated debt as well! İGDAŞ now pays every debt as soon as it falls due!

Do you know how we achieved all this? **Through competent and honest management.**

We inherited an institution with no money in its treasury, unsure whether it would even be able to pay salaries, and with companies owing billions of lira. In short, we inherited an institution on the verge of bankruptcy. We restored İBB to financial health.

I am glad the prosecution wrote this Alleged Act 60. It gave me an opportunity to explain all this to you. Which administration, in your view, managed İBB competently and honestly? The administration under which all its subsidiaries were unable to pay their debts and were facing bankruptcy, or the administration that put İBB back on its feet financially? The answer is perfectly clear.

We Transformed—and “Rescued”—İBB Through Sound Financial Management

Thanks to Alleged Act 60, I can explain to you how a municipality on the verge of bankruptcy can be restored to financial health by competent, honest public servants.

The fact that perhaps one of our greatest achievements is being presented as a “crime” makes the malicious intent behind this indictment even more glaring.

At the beginning of 2019, İBB's stock of financial debt stood at approximately **3.8 billion dollars**. We have now reduced that debt stock to **3.3 billion dollars**. (Moreover, once the dollar's loss of value over seven years is taken into account, the reduction in real terms is even greater.)

As I will explain shortly, despite making tremendous investments, we managed our debt so well that we succeeded in reducing our total outstanding debt.

As the table below shows, İBB's domestic and foreign borrowing had almost always proceeded at roughly equal levels. But after we took office, domestic public financing sources closed their doors to our investments. Despite this, to this day we have never defaulted on a single loan we used or a single bond we issued.

We also repaid our first Eurobond in full on **December 9, 2025**, paying **580 million dollars** and extinguishing the debt—despite all the pressure we have faced since March 19, 2025, and despite the detention and imprisonment of hundreds of our public servants. This is an extraordinary achievement. I thank all my colleagues once again for this tremendous success!

In September 2024, the Treasury had carried out a transaction involving *liability management*—a switch or buyback operation. Toward the end of 2024, with the repayment of our 580-million-dollar principal approaching, we said, “If the Treasury can do this, we should do it too. Let us restructure our bonds.” Unfortunately, that financial flexibility was granted only to the Treasury, not to us. Therefore, unlike the Treasury's bonds, we repaid our debt in one lump sum without undertaking any restructuring transaction! That is how competently we managed our finances: **we accomplished what the Treasury could not.**

You can see in striking terms how domestic sources of borrowing were closed to us. [28]

Source references: [27] See Table 24; [28] See Table 25. The original printed page 185 contains the reference to Table 25. Chapter Six begins on page 186.

CHAPTER SIX ## How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services

English Translation · Original Printed Page 186

The great majority of the loans classified as crimes under Alleged Act 60 relate to metro lines. The loans were managed properly and effectively, and that is how we completed all those metro projects! This gives me an opportunity to explain the revolution we brought about in Istanbul's transportation system.

Although we inherited an institution on the verge of bankruptcy, and despite the pandemic, the economic crisis, public banks closing their doors to us, and every obstruction placed in our way by the government, we carried out a genuine **Transportation Revolution!** Fundamentally, we were able to achieve this transportation revolution because we managed our financial resources well.

The only reason these accusations appear in the indictment is not simply that we repaired the economic wreckage left behind by the previous administration; it is also that they could not stop the transportation revolution we brought to our city.

Solving Istanbul's transportation problems requires vision. Let me give you a few figures to convey the scale of the challenge. Istanbul is a metropolis of **16 million people**, more populous than **131 countries**! With daily visitors, its population exceeds **20 million**! It is the most populous city in Türkiye and Europe! An average of **34 million journeys and movements every day**! **17 million visiting tourists annually**! An average of **15.5 million daily trips by public transport**! **6.5 million vehicles in traffic each day**! We approached transportation with a broad vision, and we brought about a revolution.

Of course, metro lines were far from the only things we built. I will concentrate on the metro here today because Alleged Act 60 concerns mainly loans for metro projects.

Yet our transportation revolution was based on a comprehensive vision: from new bicycle lanes and bike-sharing systems to **thirteen new maritime transport routes**; from park-and-ride car parks to an environmentally friendly transformation of transportation; from free public transport for mothers and jobseekers to round-the-clock services; from Türkiye's first and only public transport inspection and management center to the first and only vehicle-service-quality compliance inspection system in Türkiye and the world (**TAHKUK**)...

Continuity note: This sentence continues on original printed page 187; its closing description of the multidimensional and integrated transportation revolution will be included in the next installment.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED *How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services*

English translation · Original printed pages 187–190

...from the transition to environmentally friendly transportation, free travel for mothers and jobseekers, and round-the-clock services, to Türkiye's first and only public transport inspection and management center and the first and only vehicle service-quality compliance inspection system (TAHKUK) in Türkiye and the world. We delivered a multifaceted, integrated revolution in transportation.

Returning to the metro system... Of all İBB administrations in the last forty years, the administration led by my colleagues and me has built and financed by far the most metro lines!

— From June 23, 2019, through the end of 2026, approximately **105 km of metro lines** will have entered service during our seven-and-a-half years in office, including lines taken over from the Ministry of Transport and Infrastructure whose construction and rolling-stock costs were borne entirely by İBB. That amounts to an average of **14 km of rail system per year**. [29]

— The length of the network increased by **77.7%** during our administration.

— The number of stations increased by **59%**!

With the opening of the Göztepe–Ataşehir–Ümraniye metro, the number of rail-system stations operated by İBB will reach **251**. Viewed in this context, that represents an increase of 59%.

Let me begin describing our Transportation Revolution from the very first day we took charge of İBB. When we assumed the administration on June 23, 2019, we inherited **twelve rail-system projects totaling 140 km**. They had no financial planning—not even preliminary discussions with banks. Some had not been started; some had not even been designed; their vehicles had not been planned. Despite all the support of the government behind them, the AKP administration of İBB had failed to deliver these projects.

The condition of these lines presented a dire picture in technical, financial, and contractual terms:

— Construction of seven lines tendered at the beginning of 2017 had been halted in less than a year, by a letter dated December 29, 2017, from the then-mayor, Mr. Mevlüt Uysal, on the grounds that they served no public interest.

— Construction on three other lines had come to a standstill on its own because funding was insufficient.

— Thus, we took over **ten lines totaling 103 km** on which no construction work was taking place on site.

— Work on the remaining **two lines totaling 38 km** was proceeding at a very slow, inefficient pace and had effectively almost stopped. These stalled projects also carried **€70 million in debt**. [30]

It was transferred to the Ministry of Transport and Infrastructure (UAB) by Presidential Decision No. 2884, published in the Official Gazette of April 30, 2020.

İBB immediately set about addressing this alarming legacy, launching a comprehensive effort to bring the projects into operation:

— First, financing plans were prepared, and the outstanding debts and obligations were resolved.

— For the suspended lines, detailed schedules covering construction, procurement of materials, and inspections were developed in parallel with revised payment timetables. Responsibilities and critical delivery dates were assigned, and the restart of the projects was coordinated.

— Technical and contractual difficulties were resolved. Half-completed tunnels and existing infrastructure risks were handled in a planned, controlled manner, in accordance with engineering standards and safety requirements.

In the end, İBB resolved the technical, financial, and contractual problems of the suspended and high-risk projects it had inherited, and brought them into operation one after another. It thereby expanded Istanbul's public transport capacity and secured sustainable, safe transportation along corridors with high passenger demand.

After June 2019, rail investment gathered substantial momentum thanks to a sound, sustainable financing model and qualified teams. In this context, **91.5 km of rail lines** have been completed and placed at the service of Istanbul residents to date, with the entire investment cost, including the vehicles, covered. Once the Göztepe–Ümraniye Metro Line, scheduled to open in a few months, enters service, the total length of rail lines put into operation will reach **105 km**.

That 105 km of track will represent **91 new stations across 22 districts and ten rail-system lines**, made available to the people of Istanbul with their costs borne by İBB.

Today, projects costing **€500 million** are described as “megaprojects.” In metro projects, that figure can easily exceed **€600 million** once the purchase of vehicles is included. The 105 km of rail system is therefore more than a figure for distance: it is an enormous investment drive worth billions of euros, shaping Istanbul's future.

Despite every obstacle placed in our path by the government, we became the administration that built the most metro lines in the history of local government in Türkiye!

Despite the pandemic, the global economic crisis, the financial burden imposed on the national economy by the February 6 Kahramanmaraş earthquakes, and countless political obstructions, Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality constructed an average of **14 km of rail system annually** during our administration. Moreover, these investments were made without taking out a single loan from state-owned banks throughout our term.

And as I mentioned earlier in discussing the loans, the Ministry deducted in **one year** the Treasury allocation that it should normally have deducted over **twenty years**. This considerably increased the financial burden on İBB for the lines transferred to it. Furthermore, the planning and procurement of rolling stock for these lines are carried out by İBB, not by the Ministry. [31]

Do you know how we accomplished all this? Through vision, qualified bureaucrats, good governance, and by earning the confidence of the markets and these major financial institutions.

*

As I said, because **Act 60** relates primarily to metro loans, I have focused on them. But I would also like to touch very briefly, in just a few sentences, on our other advances in transportation.

Let me begin with the manufacture and procurement of transport vehicles. Since 2019, Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality has initiated a fundamental transformation in investment in rail systems. When we took office, we faced numerous vehicle procurement projects that had either nearly stopped or

had never begun because of insufficient financing. By resolving these problems one by one, we continued strengthening Istanbul's public transport infrastructure.

Between **June 2019 and March 2024**, financing was arranged and **176 rail-system vehicles** were manufactured and entered service after completion of signaling tests (**144 metro vehicles + 30 trams + 2 funicular vehicles**). During the same period, financial planning was completed for **278 additional rail-system vehicles** intended for different lines; their production and testing are still underway. In short, an investment program involving **454 rail-system vehicles** was managed during this period. This is an extraordinary record.

In addition to those 454 vehicles, our financing work continues for the acquisition of another **348 new vehicles**, to expand rail-system capacity and improve passenger comfort in the coming period. In other words, we are far, far ahead of the previous administration not only in building rail systems, but also in manufacturing and procuring the vehicles that run on them.

Rail-system projects currently being carried out by İBB have a combined length of **44.7 km**, encompassing **six separate lines**. Together with **two lines totaling 10.8 km** under construction by the Republic of Türkiye's Ministry of Transport and Infrastructure, the total length of rail systems under construction across Istanbul is **55.5 km**. [32]

On **May 22, 2026**, the **4.4 km Samandıra–Sultanbeyli section** of the Çekmeköy–Sultanbeyli Metro Line opened for passenger service. With that, every stage of the **M5 Üsküdar–Sultanbeyli Metro Line** was complete. For the first time, our administration brought the metro to Sultanbeyli, cutting the journey between Üsküdar and Sultanbeyli to **50 minutes**.

With the Göztepe–Ümraniye metro also scheduled to open in the final quarter of the year, the total length of urban rail systems in Istanbul will reach **415.6 km by the end of this year**, counting only the lines due to be completed by İBB (**İBB: 261.7 km / UAB: 153.9 km**).

We have **four major rail-system projects** blocked because they have not been included in the Public Investment Program. Except for the Eyüpsultan–Bayrampaşa Tramway, feasibility studies, route surveys, and technical designs for the projects listed in the table have been completed, and the necessary ministerial approvals obtained. But because these projects have not been included in the Public Investment Program, they have been unable to move to the implementation stage.

Continuity note: This paragraph continues on printed page 191, where the repeated applications and the Eyüpsultan–Bayrampaşa Tramway are discussed. Footnote numbers 29–32 refer to Tables 26–29 in the Turkish edition. The source does not identify the subject of the April 30, 2020 transfer explicitly in the sentence quoted here; its ambiguity has been retained.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED *How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services*

English translation · Original printed pages 191–194

Because these projects were not included in the Public Investment Program, they could not proceed to the implementation stage. We applied repeatedly for each one, but received no reply. Although the Eyüpsultan–Bayrampaşa Tramway was not included in the Public Investment Program, we allocated a share of İBB's own resources and began construction in 2024. The line is scheduled to enter service in 2027. Work is actively continuing, and physical progress has now reached 29 percent.

Despite more than twenty applications in total for the four blocked projects, no positive step has been taken toward including them in the Public Investment Program. Had these projects been admitted to the program when we applied, they would have been completed long ago, bringing Istanbul approximately 70 kilometers of additional rail lines and considerably shortening the daily journeys of millions of residents!

Would a government knowingly do harm to its own citizens? It would—and it does—because its sole concern is how to harm Ekrem İmamoğlu. It can see nothing else.

A Summary of Our Transportation Revolution

This is why we are in prison: because of this record, because of the success they could not stop! [33]

The rail systems built, including those financed by İBB, amount to 105 kilometers, with another 44.7 kilometers under construction. We will thus have built approximately 150 kilometers. The total length of rail lines currently in operation in Istanbul is 402.6 kilometers (248.7 kilometers operated by İBB and 153.9 kilometers by the Ministry of Transport and Infrastructure).

Nearly half of all Istanbul's metro system has been built and/or financed during our administration! Think about it: my colleagues and I have accomplished in our term as much metro construction as İBB mayors did in thirty years! How could they not be disturbed by us?

On May 22, 2026, the 4.4-kilometer, four-station Samandıra–Sultanbeyli section of the Çekmeköy–Sancaktepe–Sultanbeyli Metro Line opened to passenger service. For the first time in its history, Sultanbeyli got a metro under our administration, bringing the travel time between Üsküdar and Sultanbeyli down to fifty minutes.

With the Göztepe–Ataşehir–Ümraniye metro entering service in the last quarter of 2026, the total length of Istanbul's urban rail network will reach approximately 415 kilometers. By 2029, if the lines had not been blocked, we would have exceeded 500 kilometers. Furthermore, with the addition of the new-generation express metro HIZRAY—our project beyond even the megaproject scale, which we call our “star project”—the target length of Istanbul's rail network beyond 2029 is approximately 740 kilometers. With HIZRAY, it will be possible to travel from Beylikdüzü to Sabiha Gökçen Airport in a record fifty-five minutes! The line will carry 1.5 million passengers a day. We are pursuing all this work effectively; before long, we will have largely solved Istanbul's transportation problems!

That is precisely why we are here today! Because we achieved what the AKP could not achieve in Istanbul in twenty-five years...

As you can see, all the loans cited in this *indictment of slander* have been transformed into tremendous infrastructure for this city! [34]

*

Our colleague Ceyhun Avşar heads the Rail Systems Department, the most important part of the revolution we carried out in transportation. Sadly, he too is being held in detention and tried alongside us in this case. During his questioning, Mr. Ceyhun tore the indictment of slander and the expert reports on which the prosecutors relied to pieces. But that was not all he did. He also demonstrated, with all the facts, how every appointment we made was based on merit and how our departments worked tirelessly, around the clock.

Cebeci

Of course, the unfounded allegations in the indictment are not confined to rail systems. I have spoken about the loans, which constitute approximately one-third of the indictment; now I would like to say a few words about Cebeci. As you know, Cebeci accounts for roughly the remaining two-thirds of the allegations!

The Cebeci affair was one of the issues splashed across headlines for days as the greatest alleged loss to the public in the entire case and the subject of the gravest accusations. For months it dominated public discussion, and they used it to trample all over us.

Almost all the allegations of “public loss” and “corruption” in this indictment rest on these two absurd claims.

My colleagues in the legal profession have already given extremely clear technical explanations concerning the Cebeci allegation. I believe there is no one left in our country who has not understood them.

The prosecution speaks of a supposed “public loss” of 110 billion Turkish lira at Cebeci! As with the loans, this is an absurd accusation advanced solely to “inflate” the indictment.

According to the prosecution, this supposed “loss” at Cebeci consists of two items:

- Allegedly, 31 billion lira arising from unauthorized dumping of excavated material; - Approximately 80 billion lira in alleged damage to mineral reserves.

Now let me ask: what official institution made a finding that could support an accusation of this magnitude? Which public authority declared that “unauthorized dumping took place here”? Which inspection report substantiates these allegations?

Not a single public body responsible for inspecting the Cebeci area has made such a finding. As we heard here, the calculations presented to us as a loss to the public lack not only any connection with İBB, but even a legal or technical basis.

First, everyone needs to understand exactly what Cebeci is. The case file creates the impression that this was a project İBB established on its own initiative. The truth is exactly the opposite.

Cebeci is, in fact, a project of the Ministry of Energy and Natural Resources and the Directorate General of Mining and Petroleum Affairs—MAPEG—operating under that ministry. Indeed, it was a

government project included in the Presidency's 100-Day Action Plan.

Cebeci was an uncontrolled and dangerous area where criminal organizations operated freely, offenses and illegal activities occurred continually, and the environmental effects—air pollution and noise—severely harmed local residents. In response, the government announced a rehabilitation project in 2018. That same year, the Cebeci area was designated a “Mining Region,” becoming Türkiye's first, and indeed only, mining region. The ministry and MAPEG drew up the project.

Thus, from the outset, this was a process led by the government and carried out with the knowledge and under the supervision of state institutions. İBB became involved solely by decision of the ministry. It was brought in to bear the investment burden. The costs of expropriation, the financing burden, and the operational risks were placed on İBB, while the fundamental powers remained with the central government.

When we took office in June 2019, we found that the project had become seriously bogged down. The AKP government, incapable of planning anything properly, had also failed to foresee the enormous burden of the expropriation costs it had placed on İBB. The cost of expropriation was 12 billion Turkish lira at the time—112 billion lira in today's money! **112 billion lira!** That amount was nearly equivalent to the entirety of İBB's annual investment expenditure in its 2018 budget! In short, they had designed an impossible project that would have caused an immense loss to the public; we prevented that loss.

The project's two-year term was also nearly over. The 40 million lira cash deposit and the 230 million lira letter of guarantee furnished by İSFALT, both in the currency of that period, were at risk. In total, İSFALT faced a loss equivalent to 2.5 billion lira in today's money. There was also the risk that İSFALT would be barred from public tenders and that one of İBB's largest subsidiaries would face bankruptcy. Moreover, if the project had continued in its original form, it would have caused serious environmental devastation: tens of thousands of trees would have had to be cut down.

So what did we do? We did not walk away from the project. Through the work of İSFALT and İBB, the project was revised twice. As a result of those revisions, the construction of the protective berm was abandoned, while the other investments—roads, connections, environmental protection measures, and so forth—were retained. The project turned out very well, fulfilled its purpose, and cost İBB a much more modest sum. Thus, thanks to the judgment, vision, and skills of our competent bureaucrats, order was brought to the Cebeci area, and we saved the public from unnecessary costs running into the hundreds of billions of lira!

We did not cause a loss to the public; we delivered substantial public benefit, achieved major savings, and made the local population happy as well.

Look at this photograph. [35] MAPEG, the institution with authority over the area, approved the revised project. Indeed, the project's provisional acceptance was also completed. Thanks to our intensive work, İBB overcame this challenge into which it had been drawn under AKP rule.

Yet today, all responsibility for a project initiated by the government and carried out under the supervision of state institutions is being placed solely on İBB! [36]

Translator's continuity note: The final sentence is completed using the beginning of printed page 195. The next installment resumes with the heading “Who Has Authority in Cebeci?” Footnote references [33]–[36] refer to tables in the original book.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED *How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services*

English translation · Original printed pages 195–198

Who Has Authority in Cebeci?

The answer to this question is extremely important. Cebeci is a Mining Region; under the law, primary authority rests with the Ministry of Energy and Natural Resources.

The competent authorities are:

- The Ministry of Energy and Natural Resources. - MAPEG (the Directorate General of Mining and Petroleum Affairs). - The Istanbul Governor's Office. - The Mining Region Commission, chaired by the Governor's Office, which also provides its secretariat; and Sultangazi Municipality, which oversees the area through its municipal enforcement officers.

Who issues mining licenses? The ministry, MAPEG. Who authorizes dumping in a mining region? The ministry, MAPEG. Whose responsibility is it to inspect whether the dumping is carried out correctly and does not damage the mines? The ministry, MAPEG.

Who is responsible for the activities in the Cebeci mining region and for oversight of the Cebeci project and the dumping operations? The Governor's Office Mining Region Commission. Who chairs the commission? The Governor.

So what is İBB's position here? İBB is merely one of the institutions represented on the commission. İBB and İSFALT are, in a sense, the *contractors* for the Cebeci project. In other words, the prosecution ignores the fact that “all authority belongs to the central administration” while trying to place all responsibility on İBB alone! This is an entirely political and malicious choice that disregards both legislation and the law. Moreover, the case file establishes that MAPEG conducted regular inspections in the area, on average once every two months. Meetings of the Mining Region Commission were held regularly. This was an official process carried out under the supervision of the Governor's Office.

Now I ask: if, as the prosecution claims, enormous illegal activity really took place, what were these state institutions doing? Did MAPEG, the Governor's Office, and Sultangazi Municipality somehow fail to notice the alleged millions of truck journeys?

There are only two possibilities: either these allegations of dumping are entirely false and imaginary, or the minister, the Director General of MAPEG, the Governor, and the officials of Sultangazi Municipality neglected their duties and abused their authority.

My colleagues and I have been held in pretrial detention for seventeen months on the basis of these allegations. Yet in those seventeen months, has the prosecution taken a statement from even one person at the ministry, MAPEG, the Governor's Office, or Sultangazi Municipality—let alone detained anyone? No!

There is not even the slightest responsibility that can be attributed to Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality in relation to the Cebeci mining and excavation site. If anything improper occurred, it is

clear who would be responsible and how the truth should be brought to light.

Frankly, there is something here I find very difficult to understand. While the public officials who bear legal responsibility for this site have not even been heard as witnesses, depriving people of their liberty for months and trying them in detention merely because they worked for the company concerned is incompatible with both conscience and the law!

The Allegation of Illegal Excavated-Material Dumping

The prosecution alleges that illegal dumping worth **31 billion Turkish lira** took place. Well, who authorized this dumping that they claim was illegal?

The institution that must authorize all operations in a mining region, including excavated-material works such as backfilling and dumping, is the Ministry of Energy and Natural Resources. İBB is actually prohibited from granting such permission.

Article 7/21 of the Mining Law is perfectly clear on this point:

> *"In order to prevent the loss of reserves in mining license areas, such license areas may not, irrespective of the classification of the land, be used as dumping sites for excavated earth, slag, construction and demolition waste, or similar wastes; nor may public institutions and organizations grant dumping permits for mining license areas. However, where the Directorate General determines that the reserves in a mining license area have been exhausted, the Directorate General may grant permission to public institutions and organizations. Where the exhaustion of reserves cannot be established, or where reserves are found to exist, requests submitted by public institutions and organizations to the Directorate General for dumping permits shall be evaluated as overlapping investments under paragraph 15 and resolved in accordance with the relevant provisions."*

Now let us look at paragraph 15:

> *"Permission shall be granted by the Directorate General for other investments at the same location that overlap with license areas for Group I and Group II(a) minerals in which no investment has been made, licenses issued for all types of construction raw materials used in structures such as crushed-stone works, rough construction, dams, ponds, ports and roads, and license areas for minerals in other groups whose proven reserves have not been determined."*

Because aggregate is a Group II mineral as described in the law, the provision states that the Directorate General—that is, MAPEG—authorizes overlapping investments in such areas. And the ministry, through MAPEG, granted permits in **2021 and 2023** for the dumping now alleged to be illegal.

We have explained that, under the law, MAPEG is responsible for authorizing the dumping of excavated material in the mining region, investigating illegal dumping, and preventing damage to the mines. So who took action when reports of illegal dumping surfaced? MAPEG? The Governor's Office? Sultangazi Municipality? The police? No. The **only institution that acted** in response to reports of illegal dumping was İBB!

Under our administration, on **20 January 2023**, İBB sent Sultangazi Municipality an official letter asking whether any illegal activity was taking place there. In **March 2023**, the AKP-run Sultangazi Municipality wrote back unequivocally that no illegal dumping had occurred, that the area was under

municipal enforcement supervision around the clock, that there was police oversight, and that no irregularity had been observed. Indeed, a record had also been made in **2022** stating that no violation had been found in this regard.

In its reply to our letter conveying complaints about illegal dumping of excavated material, Sultangazi Municipality stated:

> *"As a result of the technical examinations conducted, it has been determined that no excavated material has been dumped illegally from outside and that the companies concerned continue their activities in compliance with the law and within the boundaries of their permits."*

In that same letter, Sultangazi Municipality said that it inspected these excavated-material dumping activities within its district **"24 hours a day, seven days a week."**

We wrote to Sultangazi Municipality about reports of illegal dumping, and we also sent a report to the Governor's Office. Through that report, we asked the Governor's Office to assign general law-enforcement personnel so that an adequate team of municipal enforcement officers, environmental protection personnel and law-enforcement officers could be formed to combat illegal excavated-material dumping, taking into account the areas of responsibility of the gendarmerie and the police.

While I had already ordered an examination and investigation of the matter, while I had filed a criminal complaint with the Istanbul Chief Public Prosecutor's Office against those who had taken bribes, and while I had said to the Governor's Office, "Come, let us resolve this illegal dumping problem under your coordination and protect our environment," to accuse me in connection with this matter is an unprecedented act of unconscionable injustice!

The mentality that ignores the former governor, **Ali Yerlikaya**, the current governor, district governors, the police, district municipalities and the relevant ministers in connection with illegal excavated-material dumping declares **me alone** guilty, although I bear no fault whatsoever. It is like declaring only one of four ballot papers placed in the same envelope invalid...

*

Now a glaring problem of logic presents itself. If illegal dumping worth **31 billion lira** really took place, how did the Governor's Office fail to see it? How did the ministry and MAPEG fail to notice it? How did the police fail to detect it? Why did Sultangazi Municipality's enforcement officers not report it? If the prosecution were genuinely **"pursuing the truth,"** would not its very first task be to investigate these public officials?

Never mind investigating them: the prosecution does not even mention these institutions in the indictment! Never mind investigating them or taking them into custody in dawn raids: the prosecution did not even summon the officials of these institutions to give statements! It still has not summoned them! Can an indictment be this biased, this unlawful? A document of shame...

The object, of course, is not to uncover the truth. It is to remove a political rival from the race at any cost.

*

According to the indictment, **Murat Gülibrahimoğlu** is a hardened criminal operating within the **“İmamoğlu criminal organization.”**

Yet Gülibrahimoğlu's companies have been conducting dumping operations in the area since **2014**. Moreover, as to how he came to hold a stake in the Cebeci area:

1. The transfer of mining licenses to him took place with the approval of the ministry and MAPEG.

2. The Governor's Office appointed Gülibrahimoğlu as a member of the Mining Region Commission. Moreover, in **March 2024**—just **one year** before the allegations concerning the “criminal organization”—the Governor's Office signed a protocol with this **“hardened criminal”!**

Gülibrahimoğlu is not in that region thanks to me! He was there long before I was, through his strong ties to the AKP.

Translator's continuity note: The last sentence is completed with the beginning of original printed page 199. The account of Gülibrahimoğlu continues there. Original footnote 36 refers to Table 33.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED

How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services

English translation · Original printed pages 199–202

He was operating in that area long before I was, thanks to his strong connections with the AKP. Murat Gülibrahimoğlu, a former AKP member with close ties to the government, did not become the most influential figure in Cebeci through his alleged “closeness” to İBB, but through the government's support at every stage.

You persistently questioned many of the defendants being tried in detention in this courtroom about how assistance-card donations were made at the municipality. Yet a tax-inspection report, which the case file seems almost to have forgotten, documented that the owner of the company whom they had labeled an alleged “organization executive” regularly sent those very shopping cards to AKP-run municipalities, governor's offices, and district governorates. In short, the plot constructed by the prosecution has tripped up its own authors, and the truth has once again come to light through a document in their own file.

I address those who claim that Murat Gülibrahimoğlu was close to İBB and supported me: the payments he made in the 2024 elections to the company running my opponent's election campaign, to the *Akit* newspaper—which shamelessly insults even my family—and to foundations publicly known for their closeness to the government are all on record! His payments to pro-government media outlets and to foundations whose governing bodies include members of the President's own family are on record!

In 2024, **5,700,000 Turkish lira** was transferred to Akit Televizyon ve Radyo Anonim Şirketi. In 2024, **2,000,000 Turkish lira** was transferred to the İlim Yayma Cemiyeti, whose board of trustees is chaired by Bilal Erdoğan. The pro-government Beyoğlu Education and Culture Foundation received **1,000,000 Turkish lira in 2024** and **2,000,000 Turkish lira in 2025**. The pro-government Bab-ı Ali Development, Culture and Solidarity Association received **2,000,000 Turkish lira in 2024**. The pro-government International Science and Solidarity Association received **1,000,000 Turkish lira in 2024**. The Istanbul Children's Foundation, affiliated with the Istanbul Governor's Office, received **10,000,000 Turkish lira in 2024**. Moreover, on **3 May 2025**, after the operation, Güney Cebeci Madencilik A.Ş.—in which Gülibrahimoğlu holds a **70%** stake and is the decision-maker, while İSFALT holds **16%**—sent another **5,000,000 Turkish lira** to Akit.

Let me tell you something even more striking: my supposed organization executive (!) provided vehicles free of charge to the author of this defamatory indictment, today's new minister!

What sort of “criminal organization” is this, in which my alleged organization executive finances my political opponent's campaign and gives free vehicles to those who carried out the March 19 coup against me and my colleagues? And then they say, “Murat Gülibrahimoğlu has submitted a petition invoking effective remorse.”

First, let us emphasize that this petition was submitted in Murat Gülibrahimoğlu's name by a lawyer using a forged certificate of authority. Even if the petition genuinely reflected Murat Gülibrahimoğlu's free will, what would it prove? What is surprising about a man who plainly dislikes

me politically wishing to make a statement against me in order to save himself and return to his country?

The prosecution says that illegal dumping took place and that **80 billion Turkish lira** worth of mineral reserves were lost. But what is that allegation based on? A single opinion. And the person giving that opinion had coordinated the project for years and had even been rewarded by the Ministry for that very work!

So I ask: why did this academic, who personally coordinated and implemented the project, not prepare a report on such a loss of reserves while the project was underway? Why was no loss identified for years? Why did this allegation emerge only after the operations—and as a result of who knows what pressure?

None of these allegations is credible.

More than **seven million** illegal truck journeys supposedly took place and damaged the mines, and the academic coordinating the project knew nothing about it—until he suddenly "woke up" after the operations! And despite all the time available to you, you have offered no report other than that academic's opinion in support of your allegation.

Oh, come on! Who would believe any of this? Besides, the real issue is not how much the reserves may or may not have diminished. The real issue is: if they did diminish, **who was responsible?**

I repeat: **the responsibility for protecting the mineral deposits in the mining area rests with the Ministry and MAPEG, not with İBB.**

*

In conclusion:

Honorable Members of the Court,

You, too, listened to the facts about Cebeci for days in this courtroom. You know very well that the Cebeci allegations, which account for **70% of the indictment**, have completely collapsed! And more than merely collapsing, those allegations have exposed how Murat Gülibrahimoğlu—supposedly one of the key figures in the "İmamoğlu organization"—worked for the government and financed the government's election campaigns! You might even call that divine justice!

Everything the prosecution and the malicious mind directing it have tried to do has come back to strike them, because the truth has a habit of revealing itself sooner or later. So, are you thinking of doing anything about this? If Gülibrahimoğlu is guilty, if the money he earned from Cebeci is criminal proceeds, then you must immediately summon the people and institutions he financially supported to give statements! Notice that I am not demanding dawn raids or detention, as was done to us. At least summon them to give statements. Let us at least see that happen!

For months they wrote that I had caused excavation spoil to be dumped illegally in Cebeci and that the money had come to me. My colleagues and I have spent months in detention over informers' false allegations about "shopping cards." So what has emerged? What are the facts?

We see that Gülibrahimoğlu's excavation revenues went to the AKP's election campaign, to Sultangazi Municipality, and to Akit, which insults me and my family every day!

Murat Gülibrahimoğlu's employee said so: the assistance cards went to the AKP Provincial Headquarters and the Governor's Office! So where are they?

Those who wrote this worthless, defamatory indictment even had the nerve, without the slightest shame, to list Murat Gülibrahimoğlu as a senior “executive” of my supposed organization! An “organization executive” who works against me and finances my opponents?

As for Fatih Keleş, who has been subjected to one of the greatest judicial assaults in history in connection with this alleged act and throughout the indictment, he is a deeply valued colleague and friend of mine for his achievements at İBB Sports Club, his political identity, and his character as a businessman!

Such reckless defamation is truly unprecedented! If the allegations about illegal excavation dumping and damage to mineral reserves in this so-called indictment are actually true, and if the prosecutors have even a little sincerity, then it is not we who should be put on trial, but those who held the actual authority and legal responsibility: **the Governor, the officials of the Ministry and MAPEG, and Sultangazi Municipality!**

*

Finally, I want to talk about my working life, my family, and our family business, because these matters directly concern my family. Alongside my beautiful homeland and my beloved nation, my family is what I hold most sacred. My family does more than give meaning to my life: I have learned so much from them that it is my family that has made me who I am.

From my father I learned honesty, hard work, and the determination to struggle. From my mother I learned the meaning of love and self-sacrifice. They passed on to me manners and values. From my beloved wife, Dilek, I learned what it means to walk through life together, the beauty of building a family, the strength of women, and respect for differing views. And I learn from my children every single day. I am so proud of them that words cannot express it. My beautiful family, I love you all so much. While this government, its instruments, its media, and its trolls have subjected you to a period of unprecedented cruelty, I take pride in the way you stand firm every day!

I said that my family is sacred to me, and I regard everyone else's family in the same way. I even regard the families of those who have inflicted all this suffering on me in that way. That is what the upbringing and moral understanding I received from my family demand. It is also what our nation's ancient culture and faith demand. What has been done to my family today has no place in our culture, our history, our faith, or the conscience of our nation.

I must also address the attacks aimed at holding my family and those close to me hostage—attacks explicable not by the rule of law but only by the **“law of the enemy.”**

The allegations leveled at my father, Hasan İmamoğlu, are the product of an attempt by those unable to defeat me politically to break my will through my family. This has reached such a merciless point that even the retirement pension of my father, a man who has served this country honorably for

years, was seized. There is no legal explanation for an attitude that reaches even for the modest pension a father has earned through a lifetime of honorable work, his most legitimate entitlement. It is a horrifying spectacle of madness, showing how every boundary can be crossed in pursuit of political revenge. The same boundless hatred reached my child, my son Selim İmamoğlu. Without a single concrete reason or any legal basis, they imposed a travel ban on a young man, my son Selim, simply because his surname is “İmamoğlu.” As a father, I watched with profound sadness as my child's name was dragged through the courthouse corridors and his future was surrounded by uncertainty, solely because of the surname he bears. To strip a young man devoted to science of his freedom to travel simply because his surname is İmamoğlu exposes the pitiful state of justice and the mentality of blackmail.

Continuity note: The sentence beginning at the end of printed page 202 is completed with its continuation on page 203. The next installment will resume with the following paragraph.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED *How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services*

English translation · Original printed pages 203–206

Our family company's business activities have continued only in the area where we reside. All the transactions being discussed were genuine commercial transactions; they are documented, and the payments are known. There is not a single matter that calls for questioning!

My father's sixty years in business, our family's seventy-five years, and my own thirty-five years tell the story of honest, principled Anatolian tradespeople: a clean, lawful livelihood that has provided employment to thousands. We have a history in business in which everyone has been given their due! Let those who wrote and commissioned this so-called indictment account for their unexplained wealth—not me!

They have gone so far off the rails that even family relationships have become crimes in their eyes.

They made my wife's elder brother, Cevat Kaya, a member of this imaginary organization merely because he is my brother-in-law, even though there was not a single concrete act attributed to him. The indictment did not name even one act on his part. He told you here that he did not even understand what he was being accused of. Of course, he too was released immediately after being heard in this courtroom. But he was held hostage in prison for an entire year!

Trying to turn a family tree into an “organizational chart,” portraying bonds of kinship as criminal connections, shows just how sordid a point the architects of this operation have reached. Not content with that, and with the same boundless lawlessness, they arrested my other brother-in-law in a separate case, brazenly extending their policy of taking my family hostage and blackmailing us.

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The attacks on my family did not stop at attacks on individuals. You attacked and seized the fruits of years of my family's work and, worse still, tried to stain our family's honor! That is something I will never accept!

First, I want to state something plainly and unequivocally: I have always been 100 percent transparent about every aspect of our family company, İmamoğlu İnşaat. From the day I decided to enter politics, I have exercised the utmost care in this regard.

All the accounts and operations of our family company have continued on the principles of complete transparency and professional corporate management. This has always mattered enormously to me. I never wanted the slightest stain on my name or my family's; for that reason, both my family and I acted with extraordinary care.

When I was elected Mayor of Beylikdüzü, our companies were already successful, particularly in Beylikdüzü and neighboring districts, and had built thousands of individual units and homes. İmamoğlu İnşaat had an excellent reputation. It was a respected company, and it remains so. I will explain this shortly; it is very important that everyone know. In our culture, speaking about such things is genuinely considered immodest, but you have left me no other choice.

After becoming mayor, I kept my distance from İmamoğlu İnşaat. When I was elected Mayor of Istanbul, we made certain decisions as a family: our company would not undertake projects in districts outside the area where it was already established; it would remain in that area, would not pursue growth for its own sake, and would carry out only enough projects to sustain its existence. We made these decisions especially to avoid even the suggestion of impropriety involving public institutions. For us, our family's name and honor mattered above all else.

Let me tell you this plainly: everyone knows how hard I work and how entrepreneurial I am when I set myself a goal. Had I not entered politics, I would have devoted myself to making İmamoğlu İnşaat one of the largest construction companies in this country—and I would have succeeded. But I did not do that. Neither did my family. Because our country's future mattered more to us. I chose the harder path, the path of politics. Had my aim been to become richer, to amass a larger fortune, I would not have endured all these hardships or chosen politics; I would have expanded my already successful company! For that very reason, we drew up a roadmap to place the business on a professional footing, with arrangements suited to each area of activity, accountability, and transparency. In fact, over eleven years I have not visited our companies' offices or projects even ten times in total! That is how careful and principled I am.

Good people, good families of my beautiful country...

The work of generations of the İmamoğlu family, our assets, everything we had accumulated through countless hardships and sacrifices, was seized overnight. There is no final court judgment, no evidence, not even a crime! Because the government wanted it, the labors of three generations of a family were wiped out in a single night.

Depriving innocent people of their families and their freedom is, of course, the most painful punishment. But there is a second punishment, and it affects not only us but all eighty-six million of our people. These lawless and heavy-handed actions are wrecking our entire economy, impoverishing eighty-six million people...

To seize citizens' property, possessions, and title deeds with such abandon is one of the worst things that can be done to an economy. Investment will not come to a country where the fruits of people's labor are not secure. Such a country cannot develop. And that is precisely what Türkiye is experiencing today. The ratio of foreign direct investment to GDP has returned to the levels of the 1990s.

That is why you must understand exactly what you have seized: the labor of an entire family, the days and nights and weekends of work, everything earned by the sweat of their brows.

Like millions of people in this country, I am the enterprising son of a hardworking family of tradespeople. We made a living against the odds, and I learned to do so when I was a child. My father has worked for sixty years, and I have worked for nearly forty. Yes, I started working as a child. Yes, like many children of Türkiye, I learned at an early age to support my family.

Since the subject has arisen, I want to tell you a little about that life. What I am about to describe is, in truth, a story of Türkiye. Mine is the story of a village boy, a working person, who built his life through perseverance and struggle, learned the ethics of work, labored relentlessly, often finding comfort in small moments of happiness, and eventually succeeded.

Let me say now what should be said at the end of those years of struggle in business: politics and the bureaucracy in Türkiye must be accountable to the people! Regardless of party or position, all of us must pass through the scrutiny of the people and of justice. I have proposed it repeatedly: a Political Ethics Law must be enacted, and every politician, senior bureaucrat, judge, prosecutor, and their families must regularly disclose their assets. I am ready for that, because I did not make my money from politics. I earned it before entering politics.

I repeat: in our culture it is considered improper to talk about such things, but you are forcing me to do so. Thank God, before entering politics I was a businessman and a man of means. **I did not become wealthy through politics!** As always, I am ready to account for everything. There is nothing from the day I was born until today for which I cannot account. Can everyone do the same? Come on, then—**I challenge you!** I wonder how those who entered politics with a single ring are doing today...

I will not tell you my entire life story. But I must tell you about some of the experiences that shaped who I am today and influenced my political outlook, and about the fruits of years of work that you unlawfully seized overnight.

From childhood onward, I saw with my own eyes the sweat streaming down the faces of working people. We were a family in which everyone, women and men, young and old, took on part of the work. Indeed, I could say *families*, for there were many relatives on both my father's and my mother's sides. Across the villages of Trabzon and into the city center, our families had an extraordinary tradition of **imece**, working together to help one another. Everyone needed to work very hard. And so I must admit that there were many things I missed in the years from childhood to university, and even a little beyond.

I managed, by stretching what little time and opportunity I had, to play games with other children, go to football matches, kick a ball around, and go to the seaside. Because at the center of our family life there was always work—relentless work.

From the age of six, taking part in the discipline of opening the shop at 6:30 or 7:00 in the morning instilled in me a very particular seriousness and sense of discipline. That shop would open at that hour. We would step inside with the right foot, saying *Bismillah*—“In the name of God”—and praying for abundance. The day would begin with cleaning and preparation, and we would wait with a smile for the blessing of the first sale. That seriousness, discipline, and smile would shape my philosophy of life and my character in later years. From the 1950s onward, with the support of his brothers, my late grandfather Mehmet İmamoğlu built up the İmamoğlu timber business, creating a line of work that extended from carpentry to timber processing and the sale of various wooden products. As his first grandchild, I was, so to speak, raised at his knee, and he was one of the people from whom I learned so much.

At the end of the 1960s, the construction materials and hardware business my father established under the name İmamoğlu Ticaret added a second branch of commerce to our lives.

Continuity note: Original printed page 207 continues with the family's farming, market trading, and work in Trabzon. The next installment resumes there.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED *How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services*

English translation · Original printed pages 207–210

While our family engaged in commerce in the city, we also farmed in the villages. We grew hazelnuts in Cevizli village and tobacco in Yıldızlı village, produced various vegetables, and raised a considerable number of livestock. Because this work was carried out largely through women's labor, it was another extremely important part of our productive life, though one that was not readily visible from outside. More particularly, it provided the women of the household with an independent income of their own. My mother was an economically independent woman, whose hands smelled of the earth. Both my grandmothers would personally sell what they had grown at their market stalls, turning their produce into earnings.

These were extraordinary experiences. At the shop, even before I had fully learned to read and write, I was learning to sell goods and keep accounts. I did manual labor, worked as a laborer, and carried sacks of the agricultural produce my mother had grown to the market for sale. I did every kind of work that business life required.

From 1976 until I graduated from high school in 1988, I was immersed in working life like any other laborer. From the age of six, given responsibilities appropriate to my years, I was becoming, so to speak, a tradesman raised behind the counter; a worker who understood the value of physical labor and the sweat of one's brow; and a manager whose respect for the dignity and seriousness of running a business was shaped by lived experience. No amount of money or formal education can buy such valuable experience. It teaches you about life.

My father's building-materials business was growing in central Trabzon, where he became the main distributor for various brands.

In my prison cell, I tried to draw by hand sketches of the places where I had lived and worked, both in central Trabzon and in my village. I wanted people to understand how I lived in those places and how deeply I had been involved in production, work and commerce. I wanted them to see how, from the age of five or six until I finished high school, I was raised by my mother and father in a world of honest earnings and hard work.

In the sketch you can see my first steps in commerce.[37] It traces the years when I helped sell produce from my mother's fields at the women's market and the hours I spent working at the businesses İmamoğlu İnşaat, İmamoğlu Kereste (1) and İmamoğlu Kereste (2). In that same small area, directly across from my primary school, I also encountered the profound human experience of growing up alongside orphaned children at the Child Protection Institution. That is the vast little world I have drawn for you.

In Yıldızlı village, I tried to portray the life I shared with my mother, a life full of work, from raising livestock to keeping chickens. The sketch also includes the time I spent organizing a building-materials warehouse that, at nearly one thousand square meters, was large by the standards of its day; the adjoining integrated timber workshop; and my working life, including night shifts at a

petrol station roughly six hundred meters away. These are not exaggerations. They are facts.[38]

I can say this with confidence: from the age of five or six to eighteen, I was a close observer of how the building-materials industry developed. Having worked in the trade myself, I acquired a deep familiarity with, and understanding of, its materials. As a family involved in construction from every angle, we also entered a successful period of residential building when my father moved into contracting in 1982.

We could never have grown in this way without integrity in our trade. Integrity brought us friends and, in time, strengthened friendships that lasted for years. Thank God, I carried that same honesty and integrity from our business into every part of my life, including politics.

Between 1984 and 1994, my father also added a petrol station on the road between Trabzon and Akçaabat to his business activities. The night shifts there could be difficult, but those years ingrained in me the habit of working day and night.

In the 1980s, when a car arrived, I did not simply fill its tank; I immediately cleaned its windows as well. Sometimes people left me a tip. Window cleaning became common at many Istanbul petrol stations much later. But while I was still in high school, I was already practicing it as part of my father's principle of customer-oriented service.

Some of my father's friends knew me as his son, while a considerable number knew me as one of his workers or employees. That enriched my ability to relate to people in many different ways. And so, thank God, I became a politician who can connect and communicate easily with people from every walk of life, someone who understands and shares in the lives of his fellow citizens.

In short, after extraordinary experiences in Trabzon, I left for Cyprus in 1988 to attend university. I threw myself passionately into my studies. For two years, I also played as goalkeeper for Türk Ocağı Sports Club, earning money through my own efforts as a footballer, with the appreciation of the club's president and management.

In 1990, I transferred to Istanbul University in full compliance with the rules and procedures applicable to everyone. My father had moved to Istanbul two years earlier. By then he had completed a construction project in Yalova and was working intensely on ongoing projects in Göztepe and Trabzon. It was time to stand beside my father and build things together. These were difficult years for business. He was struggling to establish a new business life in a vast city. The effects of the Gulf crisis and the war on the markets, and particularly the economic measures of 5 April 1994, hit the construction industry especially hard.

In 1991—fully thirty-five years ago—my father, with his encouragement, made me a formal partner, and together we began our construction experience in Istanbul with the construction of commercial premises in Merter. Toward the end of that same year, we invested in a plot of land and began our first construction project in Beylikdüzü. That may well have been a turning point in our lives.

Meanwhile, I was commuting to my studies in Avcılar, first from our home in Bağlarbaşı and then from Göztepe. I had also become my father's business partner and was taking responsibility for, and closely following, construction projects in Merter and Beylikdüzü. My days were extraordinarily busy. I would travel all over Istanbul, taking public transportation ten or twelve times a day. I remained

involved in sports at university, playing goalkeeper for the university team. I also devoted serious effort to marketing, telling everyone I knew—from classmates to other acquaintances—about our buildings and projects, and working hard to sell properties while they were still under construction. Perhaps I did not realize it then, but my father was steadily increasing my responsibilities and, in a sense, giving me greater authority.

As our workload grew, so did our business. We were also involved in restaurants and the food sector for nearly twenty years. At different times, we operated restaurants and food businesses in Merter, Üsküdar, Şirinevler, Gaziosmanpaşa and Beylikdüzü. These businesses also created different opportunities for different members of our family. In 1998, establishing a bakery production business became another important investment and experience in my life. We were producing 35,000 loaves of bread a day.

Whether managing an institution or serving as mayor, a manager must be able to stand alongside the people who work for them, to feel part of their team.

I count myself fortunate to have grown up experiencing every aspect of working life. That experience taught me to respect the rights of workers, strengthen trade-union rights, and remember employees in both good times and bad. Did you know that an investigation was opened against me when I was mayor of Beylikdüzü because I gave employees pay increases considered too generous? Yes, I had given my staff a bonus on May Day. Throughout my time as mayor, I put into practice many examples of standing with labor and workers. Because I know what work means. I know what it means to give people fair compensation for the sweat of their brow.

Now, let me turn to the construction industry.

We achieved many worthwhile things over the course of thirty-five years. I consider the years up to 1999 one distinct period of my business life and 2000–2014 another. The 1999 Gölcük earthquake changed my perspective on construction, and the way I did business, in many different respects.

After becoming mayor in 2014, I had very little time to devote to business—almost none. I continued to follow my businesses and companies only to a very limited extent, receiving selected updates while professional managers ran their operations. I can say that after 2014 I shaped my life around certain decisions of principle and precautionary measures.

Entering Beylikdüzü as a business location almost from the district's beginnings gave our company momentum and helped it grow. It also enabled me to view the industry and the region's needs more comprehensively. I witnessed firsthand, from 1990–91 onward, the transformation of what had been an area of entirely vacant plots into Beylikdüzü, Esenyurt, Büyükçekmece, Avcılar and even Bahçeşehir. We did not simply build homes. We tried to contribute to every aspect of life—from schools and mosques to sports, culture and other needs. Our family held to an important principle: business should be understood within the wider responsibility of benefiting the community. We are a family that likes to be of use to the people and places among whom we live.

Of course, the region had its difficulties. It was very new and only beginning to experience municipal services. It needed schools, mosques, green spaces and virtually everything else you could imagine.

But I also had some fortunate opportunities during those difficult years. Sometimes I met prospective customers in my restaurants; at other times I went out to meet traders in places such as Sirkeci, Mahmutpaşa and Laleli, introducing our Beylikdüzü projects and selling properties.

With brochures in hand, at the age of twenty-six or twenty-seven, I traveled to cities such as Kahramanmaraş, Gaziantep, Kayseri and Trabzon to sell homes.

Source notes: 37. See Table 34. 38. See Table 35. The final sentence begins on printed page 210 and concludes at the start of page 211.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED *How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services*

English translation · Original printed pages 211–214

I did not come to know Anatolia through politics. I came to know my beautiful country as I grew from childhood into youth, traveling in pursuit of an honest living.

I came to know my people. I never felt the need to go anywhere else. I always went to the people. I was among my people while earning my living, and I never left their side when serving them in politics.

I do not regard traveling from city to city, visiting workplaces in different sectors, meeting businesspeople and selling homes in my twenties as experience that came easily. Those were highly instructive days, when I worked hard to earn an honest living. That is how I came to know every corner of Istanbul and its people in all their diversity. I know Istanbul street by street. I know who lives where, how they live and what they need. Because I do not merely look: I see, and I feel. If the question is one of data, the best data on Istanbul is stored in my own memory, accumulated over thirty-five years. I came to know the wonderful people of this country by seeing them and speaking with them.

What I witnessed in the area devastated by the earthquake of August 17, 1999, where I went with a truckload of relief supplies, changed my view of the construction industry. I decided that rather than pursuing enormous projects, we could offer customers greater happiness and safer living through smaller-scale residential developments containing a limited number of homes. And so, with the year 2000, I began a new chapter in my professional life.

Yes, the earthquake completely changed the way I looked at construction, at projects, and at creating living spaces for people.

Looking back more generally at the work in which I had been involved from its foundations in 1991—excluding projects undertaken before me or during the same period by my father and our family in Trabzon and Istanbul—I see that we truly produced worthwhile work and projects. Within that framework alone, we were involved in thirty-five projects, most undertaken through our company and some as personal investments.

Across those thirty-five projects, we produced, or had under development, **2,511 residences, 141 villas, 107 offices and 429 shops: a total of 3,188 independent units**. I am proud of the commercial activity and investments we generated.

In saying this, I must also speak of **Tuncay Yılmaz**, General Manager of İmamoğlu İnşaat. Solely because of his professional position at our company and his longstanding friendship with me, he was declared part of this fabricated so-called “criminal organization”—first as a manager and later as a member with a special status.

Legitimate business activities and social relationships conducted openly for years were portrayed as if they were the activities of an organization and subjected to an attempt at criminalization. Branding

the commercial life and friendships of a legitimate company executive as “organizational activity” is an enormous absurdity dressed up in legal language.

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Let me repeat: we produced more than three thousand independent units. Throughout that process I enjoyed the honor and blessings of a business life in which we reached agreements with thousands of families and parted on good terms, with mutual goodwill. In other words, when I entered politics, I was a businessman who had developed, built and sold more than three thousand premises; an entrepreneur concerned with society and eager to contribute to social life and its needs. For the first time in my sixteen years in politics, I am speaking about my business career. That is the modesty with which I was raised.

I do not make speeches about a ring, nor do I flaunt my wealth! I am someone with social conscience and convictions, someone who entered politics to bring benefits to his nation. That is the difference between me and those who are trying to eliminate me through the courts.

I have said it everywhere, time and again: let us all be held accountable. What did each of us have before entering politics, before acquiring public office, and what do we have now? Let us all account for ourselves before the nation, in fair courts! Let the truth distinguish the innocent from the guilty! But I know they lack the courage. They are cowards; once again they will run from accountability!

Our family has a business built on the labor of three generations, and an important construction company that we founded thirty-five years ago. Simply to “eliminate” me from the race, those in power seized the assets of this family—a family whose women, men and children have worked and sweated for three generations—and appointed a state trustee to manage them!

Let no one say, “This only happened because İmamoğlu entered politics; it could never happen to me.” What has been done to the İmamoğlu family today could be done tomorrow to anyone's assets, property or title deeds. Indeed, they are already doing it, and they will continue! When the rule of law collapses, everyone can one day be crushed beneath the wreckage.

The right to property is among the most important human rights, because property represents the rightful fruits of labor and the security a person builds by working day and night for their children. Sadly, investment does not flow to a country where property rights are arbitrarily violated. No one invests. Without investment, unemployment rises, and with no new jobs being created, everyone works for low wages. Eighty-six million people become poorer. Inflation does not fall, because confidence is absent. **Confidence is the supreme authority in the economy.** An assault on property rights destroys economic confidence and deals the economy a fatal blow.

As long as you appoint trustees over the fruits of three generations of a family's labor on flimsy pretexts, no economic program will succeed, and eighty-six million people will continue to struggle to make ends meet. That is why arbitrary rule and injustice destroy prosperity. That is why we always say: **Where there is no justice, there can be no prosperity.**

A person is, in a sense, the place where they live. The reason I entered politics lies in that sentence. When I was still in primary school, helping my father at his workplace in central Trabzon, I made friends with children at the child welfare institution right next door. I must say how profoundly they

broadened my outlook when I was just eight or ten years old. My friendships and conversations with children who were deprived of, or separated from, their parents and beginning life with limited financial means helped me understand life and the realities of our country more deeply.

Later, making Beylikdüzü our home opened new horizons for us. We chose Beylikdüzü as the center of our commercial life and began working there. Over time, the place we loved began to give us a sense of belonging.

Then, in 1995, I married, and I decided to associate the idea of family with Beylikdüzü for the rest of my life. With its sea, air and level terrain, I dreamed of what Beylikdüzü might become. With green spaces, cultural centers, parks and sports facilities, it could become one of Istanbul's most attractive districts.

I might not have been an architect or engineer, but in my imagination I was already designing a **Beylikdüzü Model** for the future. That dream, which might one day provide the foundation for an "Istanbul Model," still seemed distant to me in those years. Yet dreams have no horizon: you bring the future closer by dreaming of it first. Thus, in the mid-1990s, the dream of building a fair, orderly, modern and livable city began to take root in me.

Later, in 2002, I became an executive of Trabzonspor, the football club of my hometown. I was working frantically, dividing my time between Istanbul and Trabzon. There were simply not enough hours in the day. My organizational abilities, sense of responsibility and belief in teamwork gave me new and different experiences. In 2008, together with some friends, we founded Trabzonspor Basketball Club—which now competes in the Süper Lig—and I served as its vice president.

My belief in, and attachment to, the city where I lived motivated me enormously. It was precisely that belief that drew me toward politics. Although Beylikdüzü was like a corner of paradise in Istanbul, it was growing without a plan because of a lack of vision. If this continued, it would be plundered and squandered through an ugly, reckless approach to urban development. This pained me deeply. For I knew that if the city where you live is not planned, thoughtful, fair and visionary—in short, if it is not free—then you cannot be free either. That was why I had to become involved and help shape the Beylikdüzü of the future: an exemplary Beylikdüzü. It was this motivation that led me into politics.

In September 2009, I became **CHP district chair in Beylikdüzü**. I held that position for four and a half years. A social-media post I made in 2012, while I was still district chair, remains a particularly valuable record of my ideals, my desire to succeed and my goals for change. [39]

If I was to win the race for mayor of Beylikdüzü in 2014, I would need to end my business career and devote all my energy to political life. I accepted that choice—and did exactly that.

The secret of our success was always hard work: being one with our people, truly listening to them, truly embracing them, and finding solutions to their problems. I worked seven days a week, like someone on the ground in the field. Colleagues who saw me began to believe in me more deeply and work harder themselves. Leaders win elections and leaders lose them; but there is nothing that a committed team, united by faith in its leader and focused on a common goal, cannot accomplish. The magic of our victory lies in that collective spirit.

When the sun rose on **Sunday, March 30, 2014**, almost all our volunteers were still at the election office. They did not leave until the count was finished. That experience captured the very spirit of the victory that would later carry us to the leadership of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality.

Voter turnout that day was **over 90 percent**. We received **50.8 percent of the vote**—

Source note: [39] See Table 36. The final sentence continues on original printed page 215; the next installment begins with its remaining words.

CHAPTER SIX — CONTINUED *How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services*

English translation · Original printed pages 215–218

—and defeated the AKP candidate by a margin of **11.2 percentage points**. Just five years earlier, the CHP had lost the election with 30 percent of the vote. In other words, we had increased the CHP's share of the vote by **70 percent**! Moreover, Beylikdüzü was the only district in Istanbul to pass from the AKP to the CHP in the 2014 local elections.

As mayor, while creating new places for the city, we said, **“The culture is yours; the city is yours.”** We cultivated a sense of belonging to the city that had previously been neglected. Cultural activities and social gatherings were insufficient, and civil society organizations concerned with the problems of their neighborhoods had not been given the opportunity to form and develop. We established a service system operating around the clock and used social media groups to respond to problems immediately. Art, sport, the sea—whatever comes to mind—all are part of culture, all have a place within it. Fishing is culture; so is reading a book. We devoted tremendous effort to bringing culture to people, and we succeeded.

In Beylikdüzü, we created hundreds of thousands of *dönüms* of high-quality green spaces where people could walk freely, spend time and breathe. **Yaşam Vadisi (Valley of Life)**, in particular, symbolizes the great transformation we achieved in Istanbul. Anyone looking at my political outlook today can see, in that symbol, the whole story from past to present.

We established a network of social solidarity in which **the giving hand would not see the receiving hand**. Through the Food Bank we established in Beylikdüzü's neighborhoods, we distributed tens of thousands of food parcels; through the Dost Eller Store (“Friendly Hands”), we delivered unused clothing to people in need. These initiatives were the forerunners of our award-winning programs, such as **Askıda Fatura** (“Pay It Forward: Bills”) and **Askıda Bilet** (“Pay It Forward: Tickets”), which we would later implement at the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality and which resonated across Türkiye. We did not stage ostentatious iftar dinners that amounted to waste, with food ultimately thrown away. Instead, we delivered iftar meals to the homes of people in genuine need. In all of this, we neither exposed anyone's circumstances nor put anyone on display. That was what a humane approach demanded.

We built schools and places of worship, without ever countenancing discrimination on the basis of religion, language, race or sect. We opened health, sports and cultural centers. We organized events, concerts and discussions that reached across Türkiye. When I proposed a Classical Music and Jazz Festival, people asked, “Who would come to Beylikdüzü to listen to classical music and jazz?” But we held it anyway. More than **half a million people** attended the inaugural **Peace and Love Gatherings** in 2014, a multifaceted festival of culture and the arts.

Sharing life together in Beylikdüzü became our priority. We developed every improvement project together with the people living in the city, helping them feel that they truly belonged to Beylikdüzü. Governed through **collective wisdom**, Beylikdüzü became a happy, free and appealing place within just five years. And, thank God, its people came to love us dearly. I could see their sincerity, warmth and outpouring of affection in the streets. Children and young people, older residents, women and

men alike would throw their arms around me when they saw me.

Our success continued and grew stronger during the second five-year term under our mayor, **Mehmet Murat Çalık**.

The legitimacy of my political career and that of my colleagues, and the authority to hold office, come from the votes of our people. In other words, from **the national will**—not from this document of slander, which has long since found its rightful place in the rubbish bin.

My belief in Atatürk shaped my political path.

Entering politics was not an easy step. My family was not detached from politics. My grandfathers supported the Democrat Party. My father had been involved in the Motherland Party for many years, while my mother's side of the family had supported the Republican People's Party for generations.

I came from a conservative family. Like a typical Anatolian family, I grew up in a social environment devoted to faith, homeland and the Republic, and grateful to **Mustafa Kemal Atatürk**, the founder of our country.

I remember as vividly as yesterday the stories my great-grandfather **Mevlüt İmamoğlu**, a veteran of the War of Independence, told me about that struggle and Atatürk. They left a profound impression on me. That is why, if I was going to enter politics, I had to do so with that conviction and motivation, upholding those values.

My path was the path of the **Republican People's Party**, founded by Atatürk. I joined the CHP in 2008. I should also proudly add that my wife, **Dilek**, supported my decision on one condition: for her, the CHP was the only possible choice.

Türkiye must change. But I understood that **Türkiye could change only if the CHP changed**. I said so publicly immediately after the 2023 general election. Then we embarked on another process. The CHP changed and began to move decisively toward its goal. Our nationwide success in the 2024 local elections, in particular, greatly disturbed certain people. Our determined steps toward my presidential candidacy also prompted some to set their plan in motion. They were troubled by the successful work we had done because they had become detached from the public. My genuine encounters with people, with women and children, troubled them. They no longer had such moments of their own. When they saw that they could not stop this wave of affection, they chose to use the law as a tool. The reality we are living through today is that **these are political trials**. They are measures taken to obstruct and halt the success we built painstakingly, stitch by stitch, through day-and-night work, faith, sincerity and solidarity with the people. Every segment of society sees and knows this.

In the Türkiye we dream of, such an understanding of political competition would never be acceptable. For we are people who know and live, to the very marrow of our bones, the conviction that **“Sovereignty belongs unconditionally to the nation.”** The people are the strongest and the ones whose claim is most legitimate. And when the time comes, the people know very well whom to replace.

To establish a country in these lands where everyone can live in peace and prosperity, with justice, harmony and fraternity: **that is my dream**. Despite all this suffering and wrongdoing, I have not lost

hope. I know that in the second century of our Republic I will see a very strong Türkiye.

We will entrust responsibilities to this country's capable, ethical sons and daughters—people with a deep sense of duty who have dedicated themselves to serving their homeland. That is my dream.

Atatürk said, **“The person who loves their country most is the one who performs their duty best.”** I love my country dearly, and I strive to perform my duties as well as I possibly can. As a CHP politician, I have proved that: I defeated this government and the person at its head **four times**! I won because I worked exceptionally hard and fulfilled my duties properly. Why else would the people have entrusted me with this responsibility time and again?

I ran my election campaigns alongside my teammates, like a team, like a family. At the ballot box, I did not leave the smallest opening; I fought to defend every vote to the end, without infringing upon anyone else's rights. Years ago, when people were only beginning to discuss my candidacy for mayor of Istanbul, I said: **“If a leader believes, runs at the front, works very hard and demonstrates that conviction, then—especially in Istanbul—you can find millions of people who believe just as strongly and who will throw their minds, their struggle and their spirit into the effort.”** That is how we reached millions of people.

To understand what was happening in politics, I went out into the streets. The streets had always been my natural setting. I attached particular importance to two places: the markets and bazaars, and the crowded bustle of **İstiklal Avenue**. The language of a neighborhood market tells you everything. What I saw there was a loss of hope, followed by despair and anxiety. Let me ask you: why should a child in primary school have to live with anxiety? One child asked me to find a job for his mother. I have never forgotten that encounter.

Poor governance, injustice and the economic devastation they bring are present in every corner of the country. People's lack of confidence and their struggle to make ends meet have become overwhelming. **The cause is an authoritarian one-man regime!** A republic that has moved away from democracy, the separation of powers and a parliamentary system. Without justice and peace at home, we cannot make ends meet or put our economy back on track.

They no longer have the energy to pull Türkiye out of the dead end into which they have driven it. They spend their last remaining energy crushing the opposition. But they are mistaken. Unless Türkiye returns to the path of law and democracy, it will never escape its present circumstances. My dream is to restore merit, ethics and conscience to this country. I know the human talent exists here; capable people are all around us. But there is no place for them in this grotesque system that has been imposed upon us.

Where people experience a profound sense of justice, there is nothing they cannot accomplish. In fact, by awarding most municipalities to the opposition in the last election, the public sent a message to the government. People want fresh thinking to take charge. **That is why I became a candidate. That is why I am in prison: because they are afraid.**

Politics demands struggle, the pursuit of shared ideals, and the highest form of sacrifice in service to one's country and people.

Our understanding of leadership has been one that draws people into the effort and makes them the principal owners of the political struggle. That was precisely what brought us success. Politics is the ideal arena for the mechanism of **collective wisdom** that I value so deeply—

Continuity note: The final sentence continues on original printed page 219; the next installment resumes with its remaining words.

CHAPTER SIX — CONCLUSION

How We Put an End to Waste and Delivered Services

Original printed page 219 · English translation

Politics is the ideal arena for the mechanism of collective wisdom that I value so deeply. For our people, our destination is a life of equality, prosperity, dignity and justice. People who strive for a just life, who struggle to bring it about; citizens who work for children, young people, women, nature and humanity. That is the path my political companions and I have chosen.

There is always hope, and our dream is not far away. I will walk this path alongside millions as we work to achieve it.

*

My dear nation,

The prosecution tried to build this worthless fabrication of an indictment upon its invented stories about loans, Cebeci and İmamoğlu Construction! I have explained to you just how hollow, baseless and absurd its three greatest accusations really are!

With these fabricated allegations, they tried to smear me, my family and our family company! With these fabricated allegations, they recklessly seized the company, property and assets that a respected family had established and developed through immense effort over three generations!

Do you know why? Why such anger, such jealousy, such blind ambition? Because even if they keep me imprisoned, I have left behind a great legacy embraced by millions: my achievements in the district of Beylikdüzü and, most recently, the Istanbul Model.

They will be defeated by the Istanbul Model!

CHAPTER SEVEN

The Real Reason Behind This Case: The Success of the Istanbul Model

Original printed pages 220–222 · English translation

My beloved nation, my dear fellow citizens,

As I have just explained, in Istanbul we delivered far more work for the public good with fewer resources. How was that possible? It was possible thanks to our honest administration and our commitment to merit. Moreover, we underwent 1,600 inspections and emerged cleared from every one of them.

That is why you, too, know that the reason my colleagues and I are being tried here is not “corruption.” Quite the opposite: it is that we put a stop to corruption, to the plunder of Istanbul and to the hundreds of billions of dollars in profits generated by zoning decisions! Beyond all this, the true source of the political hostility behind this case is the tremendous success of the Istanbul Model!

What we are experiencing is an attempt by people who fear the people's will to eliminate their rival through undemocratic means, on an unprecedented scale, in order to hold on to their seats. What drove that handful of self-seeking people to this point was the great success my colleagues and I achieved in governing Istanbul, and the hope our relationship of trust with the people inspired throughout Türkiye.

For we set out to make this city—neglected for years, treated as though it were one politician's private property, and exploited for the interests of a handful of people—a city belonging to all Istanbul residents. And we succeeded. I emphasize: **we succeeded.** In doing so, we showed the whole country that something better is possible. We ended the system of waste and private gain in Istanbul and governed it honestly. We put into practice a model focused on the people and on delivering results: the Istanbul Model.

Above all, the Istanbul Model means returning power to its rightful owner: the people. Before us, power in Istanbul was held by a handful of individuals. This power, based on the belief that “we are in power anyway,” recognized no law. It opened earthquake assembly areas, streambeds, military land and green spaces to development, disregarding citizens' safety and their right to life. They practiced partisanship even in the distribution of social assistance, to which citizens were entitled. They were so consumed by their own interests that they could ask, “Are we supposed to build a metro for people who don't vote for us?”

They wielded their authority recklessly, without listening to citizens or seeking the views of scientists. They neither consulted nor worked with institutions they did not regard as their own. For example, throughout my five years as mayor of Beylikdüzü, the metropolitan administration acted as though I did not exist. They ignored every initiative I made, every proposal I submitted,

when I said, “Let us join hands and quickly solve our citizens' problems.” They dealt with us only when they wanted to obstruct us.

They saw themselves as the owners of Istanbul. We, however, see ourselves not as Istanbul's owners but as its **guardians**. For us, this city and this country have only one owner: the citizens, the nation. That is why we have not made a single decision without listening to citizens, scientists, civil society organizations and professional associations. We have never adopted a single measure that discriminated among Istanbul's 39 districts or its 16 million residents.

Because we recognize our nation as the sole owner of this city and country, we have also treated everyone elected and entrusted with authority by the people as our equal, deserving of the same respect. Our fellow district mayors and council members elected from other parties know very well the care we showed them and the effort we made to work together.

If you regard the people as the sole owners of this city and yourselves as its guardians, there is only one thing to do: **give the people what rightfully belongs to them!** And that is precisely what we did.

We returned to the people their right to participate in governing the city. We began sharing our governing authority with citizens by making it participatory and transparent. One example is our “Bütçe Senin” (“Your Budget”) initiative, through which we prepared part of Istanbul's budget together with its residents.

We prepared our “Vision 2050” document together with Istanbul residents, through an exceptionally comprehensive and inclusive process involving civil society organizations, academics, experts and public representatives.

Our “İstanbul Senin” (“Istanbul Is Yours”) application—which they have tried, through a post-truth and utterly irrational fiction, to portray as an act of espionage—is another instrument for increasing citizens' participation in governance and decision-making.

As I said, we became Istanbul's guardians. That has two other important meanings: we also became guardians of Istanbul's magnificent natural environment and its unique history.

First, We Protected Istanbul's Natural Environment

We added **14 million square meters of green space** to Istanbul! We restored to the people their rights in urban public spaces. We rehabilitated streambeds and urban forests and opened them for public use. We put an end to illegal development along the seafront, lakeshores and city squares, making those areas suitable for citizens to enjoy.

When we took office, one-fifth of Istanbul's natural areas had been destroyed. I am talking about an area large enough to plant 26 million trees. We both stopped this plunder and restored damaged land. We opened 18 “Life Valleys,” completed five urban forests and nature parks, 22 public squares, 264 neighborhood and district parks, and four restorations of historic green spaces.

Without doubt, one of our most special projects was the **Büyükdere Atatürk Nursery** in Sarıyer. We proudly brought back to life this 250,000-square-meter plant nursery, a legacy of Atatürk. We saved it from the threat of being opened to development, and from the AKP mentality that had repeatedly attempted to do so!

*

Perhaps for the first time in its history, İSKİ went beyond rehabilitating waterways and transformed the land surrounding rehabilitated streams into Life Valleys. During our administration, we brought **824,411 square meters of Life Valleys** into the use of Istanbul residents.

In these and similar projects, we did more than end flooding and water inundation in Haramidere. We also turned those sites into productive green spaces and transportation projects. More importantly, we succeeded in ending the loss of life. In Haramidere alone, remedying years of accumulated neglect cost nearly **10 billion Turkish lira**.

There were **189 locations** where wastewater was mixing into the Bosphorus, the Golden Horn and the sea. We stopped this and eliminated those unsightly scenes.

Translator's continuity note: The next sentence, beginning with the biological and advanced biological wastewater treatment rate, appears on original printed page 223 and is reserved for the next installment.

CHAPTER SEVEN — CONTINUED *The Real Reason Behind This Case: The Success of the Istanbul Model*

English translation · Original printed pages 223–226

We increased the rate of biological and advanced biological wastewater treatment from 38 percent to 58 percent.[40]

Look at the striking figures in this table. During the AKP administration from 2014 to 2019, new drinking-water treatment facilities with a daily capacity of 33,000 cubic meters were brought into operation. Under our administration, that figure rose to 700,000 cubic meters—**21 times as much!**

The capacity of newly constructed wastewater treatment facilities, meanwhile, was 312,000 cubic meters per day in the AKP's 2014–2019 period. In 2019–2026 it increased fourfold, approaching 1.3 million cubic meters per day.

Since 2019, through İSKİ, Istanbul's water and sewerage authority:

— We have invested a total of **290 billion Turkish lira**.

— We have increased wastewater recovery capacity by **40 percent**.

— Acting as guardians of Istanbul, we have stopped wastewater from flowing into the Golden Horn and the Bosphorus at **189 locations**.

— Whereas only **706 meters** of stormwater tunnels were built in 2014–2019, we constructed **15,374 meters** in 2019–2026, substantially reducing the risk of flooding and inundation.

— Under our **Human Right to Water** policy, we supplied Istanbul residents with **616 million cubic meters of water free of charge**. In this way, we provide the people of Istanbul with support totaling more than **4 billion Turkish lira annually**.

— When we took office in 2019, the rate of water loss and leakage was **22.34 percent**. Through our projects and investments, we reduced it to **18.48 percent**, saving **195 million cubic meters** of water.

— During 2014–2019, only **282 illegal structures** were demolished in water catchment areas. During our administration, we demolished **1,738 structures** that violated the regulations.

— Through infrastructure work addressing chronic flooding, we put an end to flooding at **156 locations**.

— We established a **Disaster and Emergency Management Directorate** and brought **three logistics centers** into service.

For an environmentally friendly Istanbul, we obtained our energy from renewable sources. To help meet Istanbul's demand for electricity, we commissioned solar-energy systems, biomass power plants, waste-incineration facilities, and systems generating energy from landfill gas. In this way, part of the electricity needs of millions of people was met.

There is something else we have guarded: **Istanbul's unique historical heritage.**

We Protected Istanbul's Historical Heritage

Preserving our ancestors' legacy is not a matter of grand words; we preserved it through immense effort! We protected Istanbul's industrial history and cultural heritage. The name under which we brought these efforts together was **İBB Miras**—the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality's heritage initiative.

From the Basilica Cistern to the Rumeli and Anadolu Fortresses, from mosques, historic burial grounds and tombs to exceptional buildings such as Bulgur Palas and Taş Mektep, restoration and the restoration of these places to useful public life took shape under the İBB Miras name. Many more investments brought municipal government committed to delivering results to new heights. Over six years, in an effort unprecedented in its scope, we carried out maintenance and repairs on **nearly 50,000 cultural heritage assets**. We brought contemporary museums to Istanbul. We opened **42 museums** within six years and undertook extensive renovations in our existing museums.

İBB Miras became a world-renowned name for the meticulous care and restoration of historic monuments, its reputation extending far beyond Türkiye. Its employees did their work not merely because a contract required it but with love and passion, earning everyone's respect as an example of professional merit.

We also carried forward Istanbul's historical heritage of tolerance and inclusion in the field of faith. We established a **Faith Desk** to enable people of every belief to engage with our institution. For the first time, in our Directorate of Cemeteries, we brought representatives of different faith traditions into funeral services—not only imams, but also **dedes, meles, Ja'fari imams, priests and rabbis**. Through our Faith Desk, we also met with senior religious representatives of every faith and discussed our policies and services together. We raised our support for places of worship to the highest level, without distinguishing between mosques, cemevis and churches.

We returned to the people what was rightfully theirs in Istanbul's budget. In this way, we became the local administration that provided the greatest social assistance and support, and made the most investments in metro lines, transportation, the environment, infrastructure, culture and the arts, and sports in the history of Istanbul and Türkiye.

I will soon explain in detail what we accomplished by returning the people's due to the people. But first I want to draw attention to **how we changed the direction in which money flows within the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality**. Because everything we achieved was possible precisely because we changed that flow.

Before us, the municipality's budget did not reach citizens directly. It followed an extraordinarily winding and questionable route. The people's money would first pass through the coffers of certain privileged foundations and associations, favored individuals, and companies. For example, before our time, the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality did not have a single student dormitory or a single childcare center, nor did it provide university students with scholarships. Instead of spending money directly on these services, the municipality would hand it over to particular individuals, associations and foundations. It would construct dormitory buildings but not open them directly to young people; it would turn them over to those familiar foundations and associations. Where we provided scholarships to hundreds of thousands of university students, they awarded scholarships to a few

political figures to study abroad.[41]

We ended this circuitous flow of money. In the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, money now travels in a straight, direct line: **it comes from the people and goes directly back to the people. No one else's hands touch it!**

If we had acted like our predecessors, distributing the people's money among centers of private gain before it could reach the people, using it for our own interests, we could never have delivered so many projects, services and investments—and we would never have been elected again!

Think about it: with far fewer resources, we carried out many times more projects and provided much more social assistance than previous administrations. We simply concentrated on our work. Under unprecedented pressure from those in power, gripped by severe financial constraints, we worked with all our strength, safeguarding every single kuruş.

As I explained earlier in detail, when we took office in June 2019, we inherited an enormous debt burden and an empty treasury. The preceding administration could easily obtain and use loans from İller Bankası—the Bank of Provinces—and public banks. **From 2019 to today, we have not been allowed to borrow a single kuruş from İller Bankası or the public banks.** And it was not only us: public banks even refused loans to residents who wanted to undertake the urban transformation of their homes together with KİPTAŞ. For years, we have struggled against a mentality so hostile toward its own citizens that it would treat them as enemies merely to harm a political rival!

As I explained earlier, they prevented us from using most of the project loans we had secured abroad on very favorable terms. These were urgent, vital projects for Istanbul, including metro lines. Yet, blinded by vindictiveness and driven by a sinister hostility, they refused to provide the signatures they were required to give. To stop us from working, they were prepared to punish the people of Istanbul!

All the measures they took to restrict the municipality's financial resources and suffocate us under financial pressure would make a very long list. It is a list of shame for our country and our state. But we did not give up. We found solutions under every set of circumstances, delivering a record level of projects, services and investment.

For the six years before my arrest, what we accomplished was a source of pride for us as human beings, as citizens and as administrators. Our work is also **proof of our innocence**. You cannot blot out the sun with mud! Against the slanders extracted through threats and pressure, against gossip, stand concrete facts. With fewer resources, we achieved much more that benefited the people and served the public interest. Could there be clearer proof?

I address those who, in their attempts to substantiate politically contrived accusations unsupported by any real, concrete evidence, have been digging here and there—those who searched for money on my father's land and at my colleague Mustafa Bey's country house: **The money you are looking for is right before your eyes, throughout Istanbul and even across the country.** You need not go far. Walk around Silivri for a while and you will see where the money you are looking for has gone.

The money you seek is in the **KİPTAŞ Silivri Fourth-Stage Social Housing Project**, where we enabled **1,396 families** to own homes. Even in the most difficult period, during the pandemic, we helped thousands of families become homeowners with fixed installment payments!

The money you seek is in the **more than 6 billion lira** we invested in drinking water and infrastructure in Silivri. It is in the **Silivri Seymen Biomass Power Generation Facility** and the **Seymen Waste Disposal Facility** that we brought into operation. It is in the **Silivri Boğluca Life Valley**. It is in **Silivri Müjdat Gürsu Stadium**, which we completely renovated and expanded. It is in the **Selimpaşa Junction improvements**. It is in the **five childcare centers** we opened in Silivri. It is in the **Silivri Kent Lokantası**, our affordable municipal restaurant. It is in the support we gave to Silivri's farmers and fishers.

And do you know what matters most? **We never practiced partisanship.** At the time we made these investments and delivered these services to Silivri, its mayor belonged to the **Nationalist Movement Party (MHP)**. Because for us, all Istanbul residents are equal: we served them without regard to which party they voted for. **There is no place for partisanship in our hearts!**

Translator's continuity note: The closing sentence above continues onto the opening lines of printed page 227. The next installment will begin with the paragraph that follows it.

CHAPTER SEVEN — CONTINUED *The Real Reason Behind This Case: The Success of the Istanbul Model*

English translation · Original printed pages 227–230

... Party (MHP). Because all the people of Istanbul are equal in our eyes; we served them without looking at which party they voted for. There is absolutely no place for partisanship in our hearts!

We succeeded because we spent public resources, which had been siphoned off through corrupt pipelines to certain centers, on the people. We gave the people what rightfully belonged to them! That is precisely why my colleagues and I are here today. I say it plainly and unequivocally: the reason for this plot is not that corruption was committed at the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, but that corruption has not been possible there since 2019!

Those whose lucrative gains from the people's rights were cut off have tried, ever since we took office, to prevent us from serving the public through countless accusations, media smear campaigns, and administrative investigations.

We are here because we declared, “The days of serving particular men, individuals, groups, religious communities, foundations and associations in Istanbul are over.” We are here because, in six years, we changed the system they had established over twenty-five years, and because the people gave that change their emphatic approval in the 2024 elections.

We regarded Istanbul, this ancient city, as one of the world's greatest inheritances entrusted to us by Mehmed the Conqueror, a treasure liberated by Mustafa Kemal Atatürk from a five-year occupation by imperialist powers. With this understanding, we carefully protected all of Istanbul's historical, natural and cultural values. As I explained earlier, without making a single zoning amendment for private gain, we opened publicly owned spaces for the use of our citizens. We never deviated from the principles we established and organized ourselves around from the very first day in office. We said that this city belonged not to a privileged few, but to sixteen million people. We said that everyone living in this city would be treated equally, without any discrimination. We promised that no child in this city would be left to their fate, no mother left alone, no young person left without hope, and no pensioner forgotten. We said that everyone living here would feel the strength of the state and the warmth of social solidarity at their side.

We said Istanbul would become a just, green, productive and creative city. We did everything we said we would. We ended waste, established justice, brought transparency, made merit our guiding principle, and always put the people first. With an approach grounded in fiscal discipline and the fair distribution of resources, we delivered exemplary, impeccably clean budget management. In this way, we became the administration that provided the greatest social support in Istanbul's history, invested the most in transportation, infrastructure and the environment, and was the most investment-oriented and innovative.

Do you know why our citizens do not believe the slanders and corruption allegations directed against us? Because they know better than anyone where the municipal budget has been spent; they can see it with their own eyes. They see it in the free *Halk Süt* milk we distribute; in the City Restaurants, childcare centers and student dormitories we have opened; in our Mother Card program and *Halk*

Ekmek bread kiosks. They see it in market-shopping assistance for pensioners, scholarships and education support.

We strengthened the *Halk Ekmek* bread factory and expanded its kiosks throughout the city. Our *Askıda Fatura* (“Pay It Forward: Suspended Bills”) initiative was another first introduced during our administration. It arrived like a lifeline during the terrible period when the economic crisis coincided with the pandemic, bringing relief to hundreds of thousands of families.

We had already tripled the municipality's social assistance. In addition, programs such as the mutual-aid *Askıda Fatura* initiative gave Istanbul residents relief at their most difficult moments. While we faced obstruction in this work, we received praise and awards from around the world.

Delivering “FIRSTS” is a matter of vision. Together with my colleagues, we brought so many firsts to Istanbul. Let me give you a few examples. Among those firsts are the Regional Employment Offices.

When I said during the 2019 election campaign that we would open employment offices, my opponent's first reaction was, “That is not your job.” They mocked us, because empowering the people has never been among their concerns. But we remained focused on our goal and made it a reality. Despite a severe pandemic and an economic crisis created by those in power, through **34–35 Regional Employment Offices**, we helped **300,000 people** find employment.

And it was not only through the Regional Employment Offices that we unlocked Istanbul's productive potential. *Enstitü İstanbul İSMEK* was also extremely important to us; we reached more people across a wider range of disciplines. With more than one million registrations, the Enstitü İstanbul İSMEK centers set a historic record. We provided face-to-face education to one million people. Moreover, 75 percent of İSMEK's beneficiaries are women—another source of pride for us.

We revived agriculture in Istanbul. We stood by our farmers and supported local producers. These forms of assistance were unprecedented in the municipality's history. We provided diesel fuel, dairy-cattle feed and free animal feed, as well as support with seedlings and planting. When we took office, there were 693 registered farmers. Today that number is approaching 11,000. We support precisely **10,818 farmers**: 6,374 in crop production, 1,970 in animal husbandry, 679 in beekeeping and 1,795 in fisheries.

Istanbul welcomes millions of tourists each year. To develop the city's tourism potential, we launched the *VisitIstanbul* brand. During our administration, Istanbul became one of the world's three most visited cities. Greater tourism means livelihoods and income for thousands of hoteliers and small businesses.

Furthermore, as I explained in considerable detail a moment ago, while doing all this, we brought Istanbul more than four times as much metro-line construction as the average achieved in the preceding twenty-five years. We delivered more than fifteen times as much metro-line construction as was achieved during Erdoğan's term as mayor.

Our citizens see our honest, transparent and fair management of the budget in the enormous increase in metro construction and investment. They see it in the vast infrastructure investments we have made, and in the life valleys and urban forests we have opened.

Those trying to put us on trial through slanders and plots lack both the understanding and the moral character to comprehend or appreciate the high ethical standards and transparency with which we governed Istanbul. Indeed, we are here precisely because we stood in the way of profiteering.

I explained this to you in detail earlier. Under AKP mayors, just **130 projects** that we identified generated **85 billion dollars—4 trillion Turkish lira—in windfall gains** for a privileged few. An immense sum! This is the people's money—the people's money! So where is it? In the pockets of a handful of people, of course! The interests of that handful of people lie behind this case. We are being thrown into dungeons so they can make trillions more.

Let me share an important note from the archives. Do you remember what Erdoğan, who has governed Türkiye for nearly a quarter of a century, once said? “We failed to appreciate the value of this city. We betrayed this city, and we are still betraying it. I, too, bear responsibility for this.” Yes, I confirm it: you betrayed Istanbul, and we rescued Istanbul from you!

One of the greatest reasons we are here today is **Canal Istanbul**. Canal Istanbul is a project of betrayal that would cause an irreversible disaster for nature and the environment. In reality, it is the *Concrete Istanbul* project. I am not speaking only of the harm it would inflict on Istanbul, its natural heritage and the environment. I am speaking of the tens of billions of dollars that would flow into the pockets of a handful of unidentified people whose identities have never been disclosed. That is why this canal is not only a *Concrete Istanbul* project; it is also a project to plunder and pillage Istanbul. One person made the decision. One person made promises and commitments to a handful of domestic and foreign individuals. Canal Istanbul and the land around it were put on the market. Everything was proceeding smoothly for them—until they came up against us. We stood against this project of betrayal with all our strength. We took this struggle so far that, during the 2024 local elections, they could not even bring themselves to mention Canal Istanbul by name.

Now they dream of getting rid of us and of collecting the profits they expect from the betrayal of Canal Istanbul. It is such an act of betrayal that, in the midst of a climate crisis, they did not even spare Istanbul's water resources. In the middle of the night, they removed the drinking-water designation of **Sazlıdere Dam**, which supplies the water needs of hundreds of thousands of Istanbul residents. They did not ask us. They did not ask scientists. They did not consult experts. The Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality, which is responsible for the city's drinking water, learned of this betrayal only when Erdoğan's presidential decree was published in the *Official Gazette* in Ankara. Acting alone, with a single signature, Erdoğan had stripped Sazlıdere Dam of its status as a source of drinking water.

As you know, they subjected our İSKİ General Manager, who sealed the construction sites and opposed the development, to every form of harassment they could devise. Because they see nothing but concrete; because they have set their minds on constructing buildings with views of the dam and making certain people rich! Because even at the cost of betraying Istanbul, they still cannot satisfy their hunger for zoning profits! They gave no thought to the climate crisis or water scarcity. Our beautiful country is being governed with such a lack of vision that its rulers do not even understand that water is the most important natural resource of the twenty-first century.

Since I have mentioned our water resources, I must tell you the story of **Melen Dam**. Then you will see what genuine public loss looks like! This is no coffeehouse gossip, but a matter supported by

concrete documents!

The fifteen-year story of Melen Dam is a concrete example of the decay, incompetence, ignorance and arrogance of the governing mentality. They turned Melen Dam—of which they boasted, “We have solved Istanbul's water problem until the year 2071”—into a complete tale of lies and a never-ending saga! Construction of Melen Dam began in 2012, and they announced it would be finished in 2016. They were so confident that the minister responsible at the time even specified the day and hour: “We will inaugurate the dam on December 7, 2016, at 1:59 p.m.” Here we are in July 2026, and there is still no dam.

Translator's note: The Turkish source prints the Regional Employment Office count as “34 35,” without punctuation or explanation. The translation preserves that apparent ambiguity as “34–35” rather than silently selecting one figure. The sentence about Melen Dam begins on printed page 230 and is completed using the first two words of page 231.

CHAPTER SEVEN — CONCLUSION *The Real Reason Behind This Case: The Success of the Istanbul Model*

English translation | Original printed pages 231–234

The dam is still nowhere to be seen. Not only have they failed to complete the Melen Dam, they also concealed the reason for the delay from the nation for years.

It was from me that our people learned the truth about the Melen Dam: that there had been major technical errors in its construction, and that cracks had developed in the dam body. Those errors were entirely the result of the arrogance of the minister of the time. Engineers had warned him, but he refused to listen.

When I first visited the Melen Dam in 2019 and saw these problems for myself, I wrote to the relevant institutions demanding that they be remedied without delay, and repeatedly asked what had become of the process. New tenders followed. First, they said construction would be completed in 2022; then they announced 2025. Finally, a tender held last month set a target of 2030. Just think: if it really is finished in 2030, the AKP will have taken twenty years to complete a single dam!

Unfortunately, our nation has been made to pay the price for this terrible negligence and irresponsibility, this immense incompetence and disregard for merit. The sole cause of the enormous public loss at Melen, the wasted time and resources—and the unnecessary energy costs—is the arrogance of the AKP government. Scientists and engineers warned them; the minister did not listen. In the end, the inevitable happened, and the dam remained beset by problems.

When we calculate the resources spent correcting the mistakes made at Melen—repairs, reconstruction, and so forth—together with the energy benefits lost because the dam was not completed on time, we arrive at a cost of **911 million dollars**, or **approximately ONE BILLION DOLLARS**, a very substantial portion of which constitutes a direct loss to the public! Who is responsible for this billion dollars? Has anyone launched an investigation? Is anyone standing trial? This situation sums up the AKP's hypocrisy. [42]

I am filing a criminal complaint here and now over the public loss incurred at the Melen Dam! An enormous amount of time and resources was squandered. Imagine what could have been done with a billion dollars... There is a plainly evident public loss of one billion dollars, yet to this day no one has even been investigated.

I have said this many times before, and I say it again now: **hand the Melen Dam, which they have made such a mess of, over to the İBB.** My colleagues—every one of them qualified, honest, and devoted to their duties—will put matters right in the shortest possible time and in the best possible way. Because there is an immense gulf between them and us in mentality, ability, and seriousness.

Their love for Istanbul, their interest in Istanbul, is a love of unearned gains, plunder, and pillage. Their concern is a concrete canal, concrete towers, and the enrichment of a handful of people. But mark my words: their ambitions will be thwarted. The nation will not permit this greed, this betrayal.

Together with my colleagues, I stand accused of having formed a supposed “criminal organization” beginning in Beylikdüzü in 2014! My political journey is a story of success that began in Beylikdüzü. And at the heart of that story are people and culture. The path from the mayoralty of Beylikdüzü, a

newly established district far from the center, to the mayoralty of the Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality was anything but easy. But it is the story of loving this homeland, giving it everything one has, working tirelessly, and succeeding together.

We showed what should have been done instead of the wrongs committed by the central government. We worked to ensure that the people of Istanbul felt the consequences of its failures as little as possible. **We showed how a state ought to be governed—in Istanbul! We showed what a people-centered, action-oriented administration looks like—in Istanbul!** That is what frightened them. We demonstrated to our nation that Türkiye, too, could be governed far better.

Rather than take our practices as an example, those who lagged behind us chose to throw us all into Silivri. That is their idea of competition: recognize no law, observe no rules, buy the referee, trip your opponent—anything, so long as you win.

They did all that, but they forgot that the true referee is the nation. Even if they refuse to see it, the people see. They see our priorities, and theirs. They have a handful of people whom they must keep happy. We cared about the happiness of all sixteen million, regardless of whom they voted for.

I have discussed this already, but let me briefly remind you here: to make sixteen million people happy, first we had to entrust the work to those who knew how to do it. That is why we were meticulous in assembling our teams. We ended the system of *"The bearer of this card is an acquaintance of mine"*—the culture of appointments through personal connections. We placed merit at the very heart of our approach to service. When assigning responsibility, we did not ask whose relative or associate someone was; we assessed scientifically whether they could do the job and entrusted it to the qualified. We were transparent in our assessments.

And you can see my colleagues here for yourselves. They have explained so eloquently how thoroughly they understand their fields and how they put the state and the people first in their work that there is no need for me to say another word about merit. I am proud of every one of them!

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As you know, at the end of June 2019, we received our certificate of election and took over the municipality's administration with my colleagues... **Exactly seven years ago!** We are now marking our seventh anniversary. I would like to give you just a few brief examples of what we have accomplished in seven years.

We solved Istanbul's chronic flooding problems. We restored the Basilica Cistern to the place of honor it deserves. We transformed the Çubuklu Silos into a center for culture and the arts. We returned Eminönü Square to the people of Istanbul. We set out to prepare our children for the future. We supported them at every step. We stood steadfastly by women. We reached record levels of female employment. In short, **we put women first, mothers first, children first.** With childcare centers rapidly multiplying across Istanbul, we both gave mothers greater freedom and provided equality of opportunity to children, who are Türkiye's future. [43] We put our pensioners first—from our city restaurants to comprehensive social assistance and support for market shopping.

We put our young people first. The scholarships we provided to university students and the dormitories we built to tackle the housing crisis show where our priorities lay.

A government that has been in power for twenty-five years could not do these things because it scattered its resources among a handful of people. So occupied was it with enriching its own circle that it did not care about children's futures. [44]

We put all sixteen million Istanbul residents first: young people, children, older people, shopkeepers, pensioners. We did not create an oligarchic circle around ourselves, as those in Ankara did, and then work for that circle's happiness and wealth.

That is why we were chosen again and again. We emerged successful from every ballot box. And we did not limit ourselves to Istanbul: in disasters, earthquakes, and fires, we always rushed to help our fellow citizens throughout Türkiye. The Istanbul Model became a source of hope and an alternative for all of Türkiye.

No power will be able to stop it. We will turn hope into lasting transformation. Every city in Anatolia and Thrace will become as attractive as Istanbul! Quality of life will rise everywhere in Anatolia and Thrace! We will bring investment and services to all of Türkiye and develop every province! **We did it in Istanbul; we will do it across Türkiye!** We will take our experience of building a people-centered life—founded on solidarity, development, and prosperity, in which no one is left behind—to every part of the country. **The Istanbul Model will become the Türkiye Model!**

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As I have explained before, the nation always has the final say, and time and again it has affirmed our honest and proper administration. Tens of millions of our people want us to turn the Istanbul Model into the Türkiye Model. **That is precisely why we are here: because our nation now wants change!** Our people are tired of the government's mismanagement, tired of living in “crisis” year after year, tired of becoming poorer year after year. They truly have had enough. The government knows this very well, too; that is why we are here.

Now tell me: if they did not know that they would certainly lose power in fair elections, would they go so far as to commit such enormous acts of lawlessness? They would not.

They act so recklessly, inflicting such injustice and cruelty to eliminate their rivals, because they know our people have had enough of their misgovernment.

Let us take a closer look at the government's twenty-four years in power. Because, as I have said, **I am not defending myself here. I am putting them on trial!**

Source references retained: [42] See Table 39; [43] See Table 40; [44] See Table 41. These tables are referenced in the original book and are not reproduced in this installment.

CHAPTER EIGHT ## Now I Am the One Putting You on Trial

English translation · Original printed pages 235–238

I have told you what my colleagues and I accomplished in Istanbul, and I have described the Istanbul Model. I do not speak in terms of “promises.” I speak on the basis of what we have actually done.

We will carry that same success, that same good governance, throughout Türkiye. We succeeded in Istanbul; we will succeed in Türkiye. We will establish the “Türkiye Model.” In a moment I will explain our vision and our plans in this regard—**OUR DREAM FOR TÜRKİYE.**

But first we must properly examine the world, our country, and what the AKP government has done over the past twenty-four years. Unless we understand the grave mistakes that have been made, we cannot build the right vision.

As I have said many times, my colleagues and I are not the ones being tried here today. That is why I am not “defending” myself. Quite the opposite: **I AM PUTTING THE COUPS OF MARCH 19 AND MAY 21, AND THE CONDITION OF OUR COUNTRY TODAY, ON TRIAL!**

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I address those in power: You are attempting to put me on trial, but it is in fact 86 million people who are passing judgment on your administration and the harm you have done to our country.

To begin with, those in power do not understand the changes sweeping the world, and they are darkening our country's future. The world is being drawn toward one of the most profound turning points in human history. Advances in artificial intelligence are opening a new age. The technological revolution is also overturning economic balances. Over the next twenty-five years, the ways in which goods are produced will change fundamentally. Societies that cannot adapt to this transformation, that cannot produce advanced technology, have no chance of making progress. It is impossible for a Türkiye ranked forty-third in innovation to be genuinely independent and have a voice in tomorrow's world.

The unipolar world order has collapsed, and international institutions have lost their influence. A disorder in which “might makes right” now prevails.

Cyberattacks, data manipulation, and information warfare are advancing at frightening speed and creating new arenas of conflict. But it is the world of work that is paying the heaviest price for this transformation. The exploitation of labor is becoming less visible but more deeply entrenched. People work longer hours, in more precarious conditions, and in greater isolation. The institution of the family is weakening; the sense of solidarity in society is disappearing.

Societies will either manage this transformation or be crushed beneath it. Those in power neither understand nor manage it, and Türkiye is therefore on the verge of missing the train!

If we fail to carry out the necessary reforms; if we cannot strengthen democracy, the rule of law, and our institutions; if we cannot reshape our economy to meet the demands of the age and establish a development model founded on science and technology, we will miss that train. Our people will not attain the prosperity they deserve. They will face a struggle for survival even harsher than today's. We will become a society poorer, more hopeless, and more unhappy than we are now.

That is why we must be strong. Not merely militarily or economically: we must also be strong morally, institutionally, and socially. We must act together as a nation, guided by reason and science. We must build an order based on democracy, the law, and merit, and make production, education, and technology strategic priorities. The next quarter-century will either be a period of renewed ascent or go down in history as a time of missed opportunities.

Unfortunately, the ruling party's policies are steering us toward the worse of those two outcomes. We object to this and point the way forward. We say: They could not do it; we can. We say: We are coming not to destroy, but to build.

What stands before us is a political structure that avoids competition, fears defeat, and obstructs Türkiye's progress even at the cost of harming our country.

Türkiye is governed today by an administration that, simply to stay in power, damages every part of the state and all the hopes of the people. Having lost its way and its balance, and having made lawlessness virtually its sole style of politics, this administration turns the power entrusted to it by the nation against the nation itself. **And it is losing.**

Everyone can see it: the power of those who imagine themselves owners of the state and masters of the people is dwindling by the day. Those who abandoned people who stood loyally beside them in favor of people drawn to them by self-interest can now find neither loyalty nor favors to distribute. The pie is shrinking; the pyramid of patronage is falling apart. Yet those competing for a slice of that shrinking pie are still preoccupied with battles over spoils and thrones.

They compared us to “the tentacles of an octopus.” Yet the real “tentacles of the octopus” are **this grotesque Presidential Government System!** As a result of this system, the entire Republic of Türkiye has been handed over to a single political party—even to a single individual! No separation of powers remains, no checks and balances, no oversight. The octopus has many tentacles, but five in particular: **the legislature, the executive, the judiciary, the pro-government media, and affiliated companies.**

The legislature is under control. The President, who is also the chairman of his party, chooses his party's members of parliament, creating from the outset a parliamentary majority that submits to him. Moreover, under this system the President prepares the budget, can veto laws, and uses decrees to narrow Parliament's sphere of authority. Our venerable Grand National Assembly has been turned into an institution that carries out one person's wishes!

The executive already consists of one person. Under this system, all executive power rests with the President. Ministers are reduced to the President's secretariat. Furthermore, the President single-handedly appoints and dismisses all public officials and governs the country by decrees bearing his signature alone.

I will discuss **the judiciary** in greater detail shortly, but in brief: the President appoints, directly or indirectly, almost all the members of the Council of Judges and Prosecutors—which holds the fate of every judge in its hands—and of the Constitutional Court.

The octopus's **fourth tentacle is the pro-government media**, because this system cannot survive without a vast machine for shaping public perception. This is why almost all independent media groups were, in one way or another, taken over, and pro-government figures were enabled to purchase media

groups with money from state-owned banks. And as for TRT, the public broadcaster financed by the taxes of 86 million people: it is already the most partisan television organization of all! TRT directed the most unscrupulous slanders against us during this process. Every day, it violates its constitutional duty of impartiality.

Independent channels, meanwhile, are struggling to survive under penalties imposed by RTÜK, the radio and television regulator, and judicial pressure on journalists. In short, the media—called the "fourth estate"—has become the octopus's fourth tentacle under this system, directly tied to one person.

One of this system's principal objectives is also office, position, and material advantage: acquiring both power and the financial benefits that power provides. Another objective is to perpetuate that power through the enormous assets accumulated and controlled.

In that context, **affiliated companies** form the tentacle through which the vast economy of patronage surrounding one person and his party generates profits and transfers wealth. What are these affiliated companies? First, Türkiye's largest public companies were transferred to the Türkiye Wealth Fund, and the keys to those companies were handed to the President. As chairman of the Fund's board, together with a handful of associates he appointed to that board, he manages these assets as he pleases, beyond the oversight of the Grand National Assembly. The total assets of companies within the Türkiye Wealth Fund amount to **13 trillion Turkish lira—300 billion US dollars!**

In addition, numerous major business groups were seized and transferred to the Savings Deposit Insurance Fund (TMSF); they, too, are run by bureaucrats appointed by the President. In other words, the President indirectly manages those companies as well. The total assets of companies under TMSF control are approximately **1 trillion Turkish lira, or 22 billion dollars!** All the major projects centered on extracting economic rents are also awarded to a few companies close to the President.

I will explain the details shortly. These are also fields in which hundreds of billions of dollars in rents are generated. And the guarantor of those rents is the Treasury of the Republic of Türkiye—in other words, our 86 million citizens. All these rent-generating projects carry Treasury guarantees!

Beyond everything I have listed, in reality every company in our country must somehow remain "connected" to those in power; otherwise no one knows what might happen to it tomorrow!

We always talk about the absence of freedom of the press and freedom of expression, but **freedom of enterprise is absent too. Property rights are not protected either.**

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In short, in the Presidential Government System they established using the attempted coup of 2016 as a pretext, there is no separation of powers, no judicial independence, no guarantee of fundamental rights. There is a Constitution, but it carries no force. What is there instead?

Continuity note: The answer to this closing question begins on original printed page 239 and will open the next installment.

CHAPTER EIGHT — CONTINUED *I Am the One Putting Them on Trial*

English translation · Original printed pages 239–242

Arbitrariness. A system without rules, in which every decision is made by “one man.” In this system, there is no “nation”; there is only a handful of people. The key positions of the state are filled with people whose only qualification is loyalty to the President. Nobody does their job without orders from the Palace. There is neither a system nor a set of rules governing the operation of the state. Making and unmaking administrative decisions has become commonplace. A decree issued one day is changed the next; an entire university—Bilgi University—is shut down and reopened within a single day, as though it were the lid of a jar!

They sold this monstrosity to the people with the promise that “coalitions would end.” They did not. Coalitions are now formed before elections. Those who have made democracy dependent on the 50-plus-one rule have made both themselves and the nation victims of this absence of a functioning system. Our state, founded on a deeply rooted tradition, has become the state of a single individual. Yet in this country's tradition, decisions are reached through consultation, the state is governed with justice, and the people's rights always come first.

Our august Parliament, which remained open even during the War of Independence and helped determine the country's destiny, has now been reduced to a notary's office, there to ratify legislation that the President and the handful of people in power wish to enact. The country is governed not from Parliament but from a palace filled with advisers.

They are seeking to inflict a comprehensive institutional collapse upon our state. In such a system, there can be no merit, no justice—only arbitrariness and nepotism. They have created such a grotesque system that the judiciary has been placed entirely at the executive's command.

When Judicial Independence Was Destroyed, Justice Was Destroyed Too...

Today, almost all the members of the Council of Judges and Prosecutors (HSK), which controls the judiciary, are the choices of the President—that is, of the chairman of the governing party. In other words, the judiciary is neither impartial nor independent. Whether it is merit-based is also open to question. And who is in prison today? The presidential candidate chosen by the people. To whom are we supposed to complain about whom? Which prosecutor's or judge's misconduct could we report to the HSK and expect any result?

Consider this: the person who wrote the so-called indictment before you is now the person who holds the fate of this panel of judges in his hands! The Minister of Justice is both the chair of the HSK, with its considerable powers, and the authority responsible for deciding whether to initiate any disciplinary investigation involving judges. Can there be judicial independence under such circumstances?

And what happens when the HSK is not—and cannot be—independent and impartial? Exactly what happens in my cases: the HSK assigns whichever judge it wants to whichever case it wants. The principle of the lawful, predetermined judge is set aside; a court is assembled for a particular person. Signing a judgment that those in power do not want becomes an act of courage. It takes heroism.

Under this system, a deputy minister who is a politician can be specially appointed chief public prosecutor in Istanbul, carry out to the letter the orders received from the head of the political authorities, throw innocent people into prison on the strength of slanders, and then be rewarded with a ministerial position!

Only fifteen years after the conspiracy trials, and ten years after the traitors' attempted coup, our country is still being made captive to factions within the judiciary and political efforts to reshape it. One of the principal causes of the decay and collapse we are experiencing today is the condition into which the judiciary has been brought. Türkiye's honorable judiciary deserves better than this.

Especially over the past ten years, while countless judicial attacks and politically motivated arrests have targeted opponents, the judicial establishment has been reshaped accordingly. Members of the judiciary who wish to serve the state and justice honorably have been lost within this system. Let me therefore send my greetings from here to the eighteen judges who were transferred in my various cases because they failed to “make the government happy”! Neither I nor our nation nor history will forget those who manage to remain courageous, principled, and fair in these times. Be certain of that.

Senior judges who have acted solely in accordance with the law have faced threats and insults from politicians. The President of this country has acted so far outside the law as to say, “I do not comply with the decisions of the Constitutional Court.” Members of the judiciary have been subjected to punitive transfers. In one recent example, a judge who treated us humanely at a hearing and said, “You may drink water,” because our throats were dry was transferred from Istanbul to Kahramanmaraş.

They have established such political domination over the judiciary that, with one expert witness, two secret witnesses, and one prosecutor, the mayor of Istanbul—a city of sixteen million people, elected three times—and the main opposition party's presidential candidate can be arrested! The expert witness is notorious for reports commissioned against the opposition; the secret witnesses are instruments of political operations; and prosecutors act on political orders.

I warned you before, and I warn you again: those who dare do this to us today can, tomorrow, take away anyone's freedom, diploma, title deed, or money in the bank in a single day—and they are already doing so. Those who say, “Nothing will happen to me,” should watch carefully what is happening today. The methods of those intent on clearing the ground of anyone they consider an obstacle are well known.

These people do not even need evidence. If you expect the presumption of innocence, that hope is in vain too. How many honorable mayors, politicians, public officials, and sons and daughters of this country have been photographed in handcuffs? How many lies have been spread about them in the media?

When I set out to serve my country, I was prepared to pay any price. But the real issue is our beautiful Türkiye, our beloved nation. For when the judiciary is not independent of political authority, citizens' fundamental rights and freedoms are under threat.

If rights and freedoms are threatened, if there is no justice, if the law operates differently depending on the person, then there is no state in any meaningful sense. And without the state, no one has security of life or property.

That is when a local judge, seeking to curry favor with those at the top, refuses to implement a Constitutional Court decision despite being constitutionally obliged to do so. That is when compliance

with the European Court of Human Rights' judgments finding rights violations becomes a matter of political bargaining, despite the Constitution's explicit provisions.

I have been in the same prison as an elected member of Parliament for fifteen months. The Constitutional Court has issued not one but two decisions concerning Can Atalay. Yet Mr. Atalay is still in prison rather than where he belongs: Parliament. They have refused to comply with the Constitutional Court's decision concerning Tayfun Kahraman. They ignore the judgments of the European Court of Human Rights concerning Osman Kavala and Selahattin Demirtaş. Can any of this be reconciled with law, justice, or a state that has a constitution and rules?

The greatest harm the AKP has done to this country in its twenty-four years in power has been to destroy justice and the sense of justice.

“Justice is the foundation of the state.” A state is built upon justice; it is governed through justice and grows stronger through justice. Justice is the source of state authority: a just state enjoys greater legitimacy in the eyes of its people, the bonds of unity and solidarity become stronger in a society where everyone is equal before justice, society produces, and the people ultimately prosper. Justice is the most important bond between the state and the nation. In this country, where trust in the judiciary has fallen to around 20 percent, unless justice is restored, that bond will be severed.

That is precisely why we are fighting: to prevent that bond from breaking. We are fighting those who seek to separate the state and the nation, which belong together as closely as flesh and nail.

They have destroyed local democracy as well. Hardly a day passes without pressure on opposition-led local administrations, arrests, the appointment of government trustees, or transfers of political allegiance secured through threats. During its twenty-four years in power, the AKP has divided local governments—the foundation of democracy—into “those who are with me and those who are not.” It has turned a blind eye to the wrongdoing of those on its side while subjecting the others to pressure unprecedented in the history of the Republic.

The most convenient method is to appoint a trustee. Because our opponents lack democratic decency, in Türkiye today, if you belong to the opposition, winning an election brings punishment rather than reward. For years the government has brandished the threat of appointing trustees over local governments like a club. It finds a pretext, brings secret witnesses into play in provinces and districts it failed to win, levels an accusation against the mayor, and appoints a district governor or provincial governor as trustee before any trial has even determined whether the alleged offense occurred. At first it used this method in the East and Southeast, disregarding the voters' will; now it does not hesitate to use it anywhere in the country. We have opposed the appointment of trustees wherever it has happened.

The government's coalition partner now appears to oppose it too, yet nobody takes action to change the law, and the Ahmets still cannot take up their offices! Perhaps there is no longer any such thing as the People's Alliance; perhaps this country is governed by just one person. In that case, these appeals have lost their meaning.

Those in power now govern without even taking the trouble to get elected. And because their mentality puts private gain first, they have no intention of relinquishing the profits to be made from urban land. The games played in municipal councils, and the shameless transfers of allegiance procured through judicial harassment, pressure, blackmail, or promises of benefit, all point to one thing: those in power

regard every means as legitimate if it helps them win, and they disregard the people's will.

Türkiye does not deserve this disgrace, this contempt for the people, this lawlessness. Türkiye must free itself from this gangrene. **If we move forward, there is so much we can achieve; if we stand still, we will perish!**

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The first step in Türkiye's advance will be democracy and the rule of law; the most critical step will be **THE ECONOMY**.

Continuity note: The final sentence begins on printed page 242 and is completed using the opening words of page 243. The economic discussion continues in the next installment.

CHAPTER EIGHT — CONTINUED *I Am the One Putting Them on Trial*

English translation · Original printed pages 243–246

The first step in Türkiye's march forward will be democracy and the rule of law; its most critical step, however, will be **THE ECONOMY**. As we move away from justice and democracy, the economy, too, is shaken.

Look at the figures. The government announced that per capita income would reach $25,000 in 2023! Do you know what that means? It means 97,000 lira a month! [45] Yet today the average wage in our country is the minimum wage: 28,000 lira! The government said unemployment would be 5% in 2023; today, broadly defined unemployment in our country is 30%! What is more, in 2011, when those targets were announced, inflation was 10%; in 2023, inflation had reached 65%; and now inflation is still 32.6%, among the highest rates in the world!

The government has met none of its targets, and none of its promises carries any weight anymore. Our country and our economy are heading not toward improvement, but toward deterioration! With confidence in the rule of law destroyed, long-term investment is no longer coming into our country.

Foreign direct investment, which reached 3.5% of Türkiye's economy in 2006, had fallen to virtually zero by 2026, excluding foreigners' purchases of housing. Investments in factories, which were a source of employment growth twenty years ago, are now at a level incapable of generating jobs. And when investment does not come, the result is that one person in every three in Türkiye is unemployed.

With $20–30 billion in "hot money" flowing in to take advantage of high real interest rates, the interest bill paid out of our taxes keeps multiplying. In just the last two years, 5 trillion lira has been paid in interest from the budget!

Immediately before the transition to the Presidential Government System, interest payments accounted for 8.4% of budget expenditures; today that share has reached 15%! Wasn't interest supposed to be a sin? Then isn't it a sin to make this nation pay so much interest for nothing, merely because of the government's mistakes?

In an economy like this, sadly, the flight of brains and capital is accelerating. In recent years, around four million highly educated, successful young people have settled abroad. A population the size of an entire country has emigrated from among us! Twenty-seven percent of our young people fleeing the present administration are either engineers or doctors.

Domestic capital, too, is increasingly turning abroad. Around $2–3 billion leaves the country every year to purchase homes overseas. In 2025, for the first time, the amount of foreign currency Turkish citizens invested in real estate abroad surpassed the amount foreigners invested in real estate in Türkiye.

In 2025, in just one year, our citizens' direct investments abroad—the businesses and factories they established—reached a historic record of $10 billion! The total stock of Turkish companies' overseas investments has now exceeded $60 billion.

This is capital fleeing a country without justice, without the rule of law, where no one can feel secure in life or property! Imagine for a moment that, had there been legal certainty, those $60 billion had been turned into factories, employment and livelihoods in our own country.

Merit is collapsing in the state's economic institutions, and arbitrary, misguided decisions are being made. Only the interests of a handful of people are considered. As a result, inequality in income distribution becomes ever more pronounced; inflation cannot be brought under control; poverty deepens. In other words, our economy is rotting, collapsing.

Average annual inflation in OECD countries is 4.4%, and the European average is 3.3%. If even according to TÜİK—Türkiye's official statistical institute—annual inflation here stands at 32.6%, then actual inflation is at least 50%!

Inflation in the two items that most affect our people's lives—food and rent—is higher still!

The Cost: One-Man Rule Has Driven Türkiye Toward Collapse

The value of our currency has been devastated. Before the Presidential Government System, one dollar was worth 3 Turkish lira; now it takes 46 Turkish lira to buy one dollar!

The price our nation paid for the exchange-rate-protected deposit scheme (KKM), which they introduced to keep the dollar exchange rate from rising, is a full **$64 billion**. Just think of it: 3 trillion lira—3 quintillion in the old currency! Sixty-four billion dollars is equivalent to approximately 15–20% of Türkiye's annual central-government budget revenues! A price paid for nothing, entirely because of the government's mistakes.

You have rounded up hundreds of people here on preposterous charges. You have piled one slander and fabricated allegation upon another. The cost to our nation of these unlawful decisions, this malignant way of thinking, taken simply to make one person happy, is now **$250 billion**: 11.5 trillion lira—11.5 quintillion in the old currency! This money came out of our people's pockets. I explained the cost of March 19 to you earlier.

Because of the March 19 coup, the price our people have had to pay to bring inflation down has both increased and extended over a longer period.

Nowhere else in the world is there an administration that has spent so long telling the fairy tale that it will bring inflation down while loading the burden onto people on fixed incomes and devastating the middle class.

Let me tell our nation the reason for its struggle to make ends meet and the dagger plunged into the heart of our economy. **Today's government is the cause; the bad economy is the consequence!** Those responsible for this bad economy cannot fix it. Not only has the economy deteriorated as a whole, but income inequality and the transfer of wealth have also reached extraordinary proportions.

Today the minimum wage of 28,075 lira is 7,100 lira below the May hunger threshold of 35,174 lira announced by Türk-İş! The poverty threshold is 114,576 lira; the minimum wage is four times lower than the poverty threshold! [46] Inflation of at least 30% is expected by year's end. That means the purchasing power of the minimum wage will fall from 28,075 lira to 19,652 lira. Over the same period, the hunger threshold will reach 40,000 lira. When half of our country's salaried workers earn the minimum wage, how are our people supposed to survive? The minimum wage has become our nation's

average wage.

The wealthiest 10% in Türkiye owns 68% of total wealth. Yet the poorest 50% can claim only 2.6% of that wealth!

Thanks to a mechanism for transferring wealth that exploits the severe fluctuations in our economy, a small segment of society has multiplied its fortunes. Our nation has paid the price.

Türkiye's overall poverty rate has risen to 21.2%. The poverty threshold has increased twelvefold over the last ten years. Eighteen million of our citizens live in conditions in which they cannot even meet their most basic needs. Six out of every ten people are in debt. In Türkiye, even having a job is no longer a remedy for poverty.

Because of the exchange-rate surges they have sometimes deliberately engineered, and the high-interest policies pursued in recent years by those who set out declaring that "interest is the cause, inflation is the result," hundreds of thousands of tradespeople and business owners are now struggling to survive.

According to TESK figures, **120,423 tradespeople** closed their shops and ceased trading last year alone. This means an average of 330 tradespeople shutting their doors every day—a reality in which thirteen tradespeople go out of business every hour.

Another problem fueling income inequality is unemployment. Even according to TÜİK figures, broadly defined unemployment across Türkiye stands at **30.1%**: twelve million people are outside working life, with no income, no security, and a future that has been taken from them!

It is our young people who grieve me most. Youth unemployment is at a disastrous level. More than six million young people are not participating in the labor force, or cannot participate. Even if two-thirds of them are in education, adding the remaining third means that the actual broadly defined unemployment rate among 15-to-24-year-olds is at least 40%! These are unemployment rates unheard of and unseen before! The young people who do manage to enter working life are either forced to accept low wages or sit at home with their families as their mental well-being deteriorates. Thirty-six percent of our young people aged 25–34 still live with their families. What kind of situation is this, in which a thirty-year-old sits at home with their family, unemployed?

Alongside our young people, it is our pensioners who grieve me most. Retirement, which in other countries is a period of well-earned rest and reward, has become a period of growing poverty and struggling to stay afloat in ours. Among 17.7 million pensioners, the average monthly pension is 23,000 lira. Once the loss of purchasing power caused by high inflation during the first five months is taken into account, that amounts to 19,182 lira. What is a retired citizen, condemned to subsistence living, supposed to do with that money? Twenty percent of Türkiye's population is retired. Yet our pensioners receive only 6.1% of gross domestic product. You work for forty years, you strive, you pay your contributions, and you retire—and then those running the state tell you that "pensioners are a heavy burden on the budget." That is their mentality. No good can come to this country from a mentality that regards pensioners as a burden.

Another important issue I want to draw attention to concerns both the food on our nation's tables and our country's independence and security: **agriculture**. While the strategic importance of agriculture and food is increasing around the world, agriculture in Türkiye contracted by 9% last year! We now

derive only 5% of our national income from agriculture. Yet agriculture accounts for 16% of employment, rising to 25% when people who farm as a second occupation are included. This is a terrible inequality inflicted upon our citizens working in their fields, vineyards, and orchards! As those engaged in agriculture grow poorer, the number of people living in villages is rapidly declining. In Europe, governments invest billions of euros to make village life more attractive. Here, no one lifts a finger. The average age of our farmers is approaching sixty—around fifty-seven! Agricultural employment, which stood at 4.9 million in 1927, had risen to nine million by 1991; according to the most recent count, in 2025, the number of registered farmers was **2.4 million**.

Source references: [45] See Table 42; [46] See Table 43. Monetary figures and economic assertions above are translated as presented in the original speech, without independent verification.

Continuity note: The final sentence on printed page 246 continues at the opening of page 247 and has been completed here. The next installment begins with the discussion of agricultural machinery and farmers' debt.

CHAPTER EIGHT — CONTINUED *I Am the One Putting Them on Trial*

English translation · Original printed pages 247–250

According to the most recent count, in 2025, the number of registered farmers had fallen to 2.4 million!

Most of our tractors—the principal source of power in agriculture—are more than forty years old! That means crop losses, low productivity and high costs. As of 2026, farmers' outstanding agricultural loans to public banks and Agricultural Credit Cooperatives exceeded 1.3 trillion Turkish lira. And I am not even counting what they owe on credit to suppliers, tradespeople and dealers. Five years ago, total agricultural debt was around 130 billion lira. In the past five years, farmers' debt has multiplied approximately 9.8 times. With inflation in input costs, the burden of interest, low prices for their produce and inadequate support, how can farmers whose debt has grown tenfold in five years continue to produce? How can they feed our 86 million citizens food that is both affordable and of high quality?

The priority of this government has never been our people; it has always been a privileged handful. They used billions of dollars in resources from Ziraat Bank to enable businesspeople close to them to acquire media groups! Most of those debts were never repaid. With the stroke of a pen, they wrote off hundreds of millions of dollars in tax debts owed by a handful of favored businesspeople, while seizing even our farmers' seeds and agricultural chemicals!

The supply chain itself is a system of plunder. From field to supermarket, a product changes hands dozens of times; the grower, haulier, wholesaler and market trader are left with next to nothing, while the public pays exorbitant prices.

Over twenty-four years, they have created a system in which nobody wins. Both the farmer who produces and our people who consume are victimized. Domestic production is penalized while imports are encouraged. For some reason, the companies authorized to import are always selected from circles close to the governing party. And, for some reason, import permits are issued precisely at harvest time.

Within the same system, large supermarket chains have come to dominate the market, and monopolies supplying agricultural inputs can manipulate prices at will. In the absence of agricultural planning, bumper harvests leave crops selling for virtually nothing and a year's labor going to waste. The government merely watches. It takes no strategic decisions; it is incapable of doing so. Its policy of patching every shortage with imports condemns our people to expensive food. This cannot go on! Agriculture is a matter of national security. Our state cannot be exposed to such grave danger.

There is no bread in the house; the cooking pot remains empty. Meat has become a distant dream, yet we have a government appointing trustees to chicken businesses! We face a government that seeks to solve every problem by throwing people into prison! In agriculture, as in every other field, this government has succeeded in creating a situation in which everyone loses: the people are condemned to expensive food, while the farmer is going bankrupt!

Likewise, workers labor for wages below the hunger threshold, and factories close because they cannot cover their costs! A handful of bureaucrats draw five salaries, while civil servants cannot make ends meet!

There is no justice in the judiciary, and there is no justice in any of this government's policies. Yet let us never forget: **Justice or Misery! Without justice, there will be nothing cooking in the pot!**

Agriculture has collapsed, and at the same time we are missing a vitally important opportunity in industry. With the Customs Union, our industry gained strength in the 1990s, when it generated a quarter of our national income. Thanks to that industrial drive, we achieved annual growth of 4.5–5 percent. But from the 2000s onward, and particularly under this government, that progress stalled and gave way to decline.

The services sector was inflated, while industry's share of national income fell to around 20 percent. Industrial employment stands at its lowest level in four years; in just the past year, employment in industry declined by 180,000 people. Because this government has been incapable of developing an economic policy and has obsessed over interest rates instead, modern new industrial practices have not spread across Anatolia.

We have come nowhere near achieving regional development. Today the Marmara Region alone generates nearly half of Türkiye's entire economic output, while Eastern Anatolia accounts for around 4 percent! Marmara's economy is fully ten times the size of Eastern Anatolia's!

The development gap between west and east has deepened with every passing year. They concentrated on opportunities for private gain in the western provinces; they have made not the slightest progress toward regional development or prosperity for our citizens in the eastern provinces.

We have failed to make the transition to high technology, to sectors such as electronics. We have not been able to invest with our own resources; for the past twenty years, we have grown through debt-dependent consumption financed from abroad. Foreign borrowing goes largely toward sustaining debt and financing consumption, rather than production.

We used cheap foreign credit to build, fueling consumption; instead of producing goods with added value, we buried our resources in concrete.

Our inability to produce high-tech, high-value-added goods is both a cause and a consequence of our dependence on debt. Government policy focused on short-term gains. Construction boomed, but long-term investments in technology were forgotten.

High-technology goods account for only 3 percent of our exports! In South Korea and Vietnam, that share is at least 35 percent! We are missing this opportunity too, because this government has no vision in this field either.

The world's technological transformation is taking place through electronics, software and artificial intelligence. Here at home, production capable of reaching world standards remains virtually nonexistent. We lack a stable environment in which new technologies can be developed and scaled

up. We do not devote sufficient resources to research and development. Our international patent output is almost nonexistent.

The law has collapsed, the economy has collapsed, agriculture has collapsed, industry has collapsed... And most importantly, our education system, too, is in the midst of a profound collapse.

Quality education has become a service that families with money must purchase for their children. Today, 92 percent of our school-age children attend public schools at the primary, middle and secondary levels. The deliberate weakening of public education means sacrificing our future.

Although investments and incentives have been directed toward private schools, a substantial proportion of teachers are employed without job security and on low wages. Parents who send their children to private schools are forced to take out loans to cover tuition. Yet quality education is a constitutional right that the state is obliged to provide equally and free of charge to every citizen.

Our average years of schooling lag behind Europe's, and our examination results are poor. We do not have enough graduates in science, technology, physics and mathematics. According to OECD data, the average duration of education among people aged twenty-five and over in Türkiye is nine years; in other words, our average educational attainment corresponds to leaving middle school before completion or reaching the beginning of high school. Across the OECD, the figure is fourteen years. Likewise, according to the OECD's PISA assessments administered to fifteen-year-old students around the world, Türkiye is below the OECD average in all three fields: mathematics, science and reading comprehension.

There is no safety, either. Students and teachers face violence, while gangs roam around schools. Children and teachers lose their lives in armed attacks at our schools.

Such is this destructive mentality that it is now doing everything it can to destroy even Boğaziçi University, one of the world's notable universities... The President shut down and reopened Bilgi University practically overnight. Why did he close it, and why did he reopen it? We do not know. Under one-man rule, one man does whatever he pleases.

They have turned the education system into something they constantly erase and rewrite. Inequality begins at the very start. Our children cannot access preschool education: childcare centers are too few and too expensive, while kindergartens are effectively fee-paying because of parental contributions.

We will put an end to this! Public schools will be the best schools in the country. We will spend the education budget on public education. Without dividing children into “yours” and “ours,” we will raise standards in all our schools. A strong Türkiye is possible only with free, high-quality, scientific and modern education!

Foreign policy is among the areas to which we must devote the greatest care. The AKP's twenty-four-year record in foreign policy has produced not consistency but constant lurches from one position to another. These reversals have been presented as “strategic flexibility.” Yet a course that continually zigzags is not strategy; it is a loss of direction.

Foreign policy must be conducted with the institutional judgment of the state. It requires institutional memory, competent personnel and a culture of consultation. Under the AKP, however, foreign policy decisions have increasingly been confined to a narrow circle, while the accumulated expertise of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs has been pushed aside.

Foreign policy was pursued through harsh rhetoric amplified during election campaigns, through what might be called “rally-ground diplomacy.” Leaders who were subjected to the harshest language yesterday appear in warm photographs together today. The example of Sisi is there for all to see.

States can, of course, repair their relations. But reversals this sharp erode trust. International relations have a memory. Words carry weight.

Policy toward Syria is another of the clearest examples of how the AKP has conducted foreign policy through inconsistency rather than strategy. From the slogan of “zero problems with neighbors,” we have arrived at a position of having problems with almost everyone. An enthusiasm for regime change, a sectarian outlook and bombastic rhetoric aimed at domestic politics have pushed Türkiye away from the role of a constructive, solution-oriented actor.

Negotiations with the European Union have effectively been frozen for years. Visa liberalization has not materialized. The Customs Union cannot be updated. Turkish manufacturers and entrepreneurs have reached the point of being almost entirely shut out of the EU market.

The European Union has said so very clearly: without progress in democracy and the rule of law, neither visa liberalization, nor the modernization of the Customs Union agreement—so badly needed by our industry—nor membership negotiations can be contemplated.

Continuity note: The final sentence is completed with the opening words of printed page 251. The next installment begins with the subsequent paragraph on the F-35 and S-400 programs.

CHAPTER EIGHT — CONTINUED *I Am the One Putting Them on Trial*

English translation · Original printed pages 251–254

We were removed from the F-35 program. The decision to purchase the S-400 system cost billions of dollars and exposed Türkiye to sanctions. The S-400s, purchased on the grounds of an urgent security need, were never even unpacked. The defense industry was plunged into serious uncertainty.

Because of the personal relationship cultivated with the President of the United States, Türkiye joined the Board of Peace and remained silent about the continuing human tragedy in Palestine and the attacks on Iran.

We stood by as the balance between Türkiye and Greece that the United States had traditionally sought to maintain in the Aegean and Cyprus was shifted entirely in favor of Greece and the Greek Cypriot side.

We merely watched as the Turkic republics and Syria's new administration developed close relations with the Greek Cypriot Administration of Southern Cyprus...

All of this shows that foreign policy has been driven by immediate political needs instead of Türkiye's long-term interests.

You may try as hard as you like to manufacture the image of a “world leader” at home with a photograph, a video, or the appearance of a personal relationship. The concrete realities, however, continue to work against our country.

Foreign policy is not a stage for performances. Foreign policy is the art of quietly achieving results. When foreign policy continually generates crises and distrust, international investors perceive greater risk, financing costs rise, the exchange rate comes under pressure, and access to technology becomes more difficult. In other words, foreign policy directly affects citizens' lives. Employment falls, inflation rises, and families struggle to put food on the table. The price of misguided foreign policy is heavy.

The principle of international relations is non-interference in other countries' domestic affairs. Yet Türkiye has at times appeared interventionist in its regional policies, reinforcing the perception that it acts from sectarian and ideological motives. This has weakened the advantage Türkiye derives from its secular and balanced identity.

My criticism is not ideological; it concerns how the state is governed. Türkiye's interests demand an institutional, transparent foreign policy, not one based on personal relationships. Decisions made beyond the scrutiny of the nation and Parliament do not strengthen the country. Real strength derives from the people and the legitimacy conferred by elections—not photographs taken across the ocean.

A strong Türkiye is one whose laws and institutions are strong and whose word can be trusted. The seriousness of statecraft requires consistency. Foreign policy should not be pursued merely to get through today, but to build tomorrow.

I am here because I defend this principle. And I will continue to defend it.

*

The irresponsible approach we have seen in the economy, agriculture, education, and foreign policy has also been imposed on our country in matters of the environment and urban planning. The government has treated our country's land, air, and water as nothing more than real-estate development opportunities.

The so-called “zoning amnesty,” introduced under the pretext of providing services to citizens, even “pardoned” buildings that were not earthquake-resistant. They conferred legal status on a total of **3.1 million structures**, including **301,000 buildings in the earthquake zone**.

In the Kanal Istanbul project they sought to drive into the very heart of Istanbul, they more than doubled the special project area to **1,305 hectares**. Kanal Istanbul is a rent-seeking development project that will destroy Istanbul. It is a disastrous project that will create enormous risks during an earthquake, bring an additional **1.5 million people** whom the city cannot accommodate, and dry up its water resources. My colleagues and I have fought—and continue to fight—this project with all our strength. Yet the government that has thrown us into prison is quietly continuing construction associated with Kanal Istanbul. I say it again: **Either the Canal or Istanbul!**

Because of their distorted approach to urban planning, between **2018 and 2023**, housing prices in Istanbul soared by **900 percent** and rents by **786 percent**, intensifying the housing crisis.

Not only did the government lack a sound vision for urban planning, it never had a vision for the environment or any real environmental sensitivity. Between **2018 and 2023**, Türkiye became the country importing the most waste from Europe. They turned Türkiye into Europe's dumping ground.

The government failed to understand the value of our forests or protect them. They sacrificed our forests to fires, rent-seeking development, and mining—and continue to do so. Between **2004 and 2025**, fires damaged **432,000 hectares** of forest. There was not even a proper plan to combat them. During the same period, **593,000 hectares** of forest were allocated to uses other than forestry. By **2025**, the total forest area allocated to non-forestry uses had reached **845,000 hectares**.

This same government caused hundreds of thousands of trees to be cut down in the Kaz Mountains, increased the number of licensed mines in our country from **1,186 to 386,000**, and gave unquestioning approval to **104 very large mining projects**. In the Akbelen Forest near Milas alone, for example, trees were felled for a mining site covering approximately **740 dönüms**.

*

Those who came to power promising to end restrictions, poverty, and corruption did precisely the opposite. Restrictions are now everywhere and in every field; poverty has spread throughout society; and the corruption they have perpetrated is the greatest in the history of the Republic!

I will now present clear evidence of the enormous transfer of resources, and of the rentier system established, between **2002 and 2026**.

We are not talking about minor irregularities or ordinary allegations of corruption. What stands before us is a map of highly organized, privileged structures fostered by the public authorities and the power of the state.

The total alleged loss to the public attributed to hundreds of people in the defamatory document now before us—based entirely on lies and a handful of accusations extracted through pressure and oppression—is **$3.5 billion**. Roughly one-third of this **$3.5 billion** consists of absurd, baseless allegations concerning international loans. The other two-thirds concerns the Cebeci Mining Area, where the accusations are products of the prosecutors' imagination. I have explained all of this in detail.

While the politically motivated chief prosecutor occupies Türkiye with these lies, I will explain how, over **24 years of AKP rule**, hundreds of billions of dollars were transferred from the people's pockets to a privileged group. Do you know why I must explain these things here? Because so-called “public losses” and “corruption” are not established by coffeehouse gossip and hearsay.

Public losses and corruption are demonstrated openly, concretely, and with figures—as with the corruption committed under AKP rule. Proof of a public loss or corruption rests on concrete data. Allow me to explain.

Of course, I can only give you a broad outline, showing the tip of the iceberg. If I went into the details—if I discussed the corruption committed every day—I would have to speak for weeks. Let us see whether the prosecution will investigate these matters too.

Public losses are established through documents and figures, not through three or five secret witnesses or defamatory statements obtained under pressure by prohibited interrogation methods.

Everything I am about to describe is documented. There is no need for secret witnesses or false testimony.

During AKP rule, economic value was transferred to a handful of privileged people close to the government not only through direct cases of corruption, but also through public guarantees, public land, zoning changes, privatizations, allocations of natural resources, and the management of public assets beyond effective oversight.

Through public institutions controlled by the AKP, substantial public resources were transferred to a few companies acting hand in hand with the government. The value of those resources was continually increased, and all these transactions were kept behind a veil of secrecy.

Hundreds of billions of dollars were distributed to a handful of people to finance those in power! That money comes directly from our people's pockets—from the VAT paid when buying milk or bread and from taxes deducted from wages at the end of each month. For **24 years**, instead of returning to our country in the form of education, healthcare, and pensions, this money has flowed to those in power and the handful of people around them.

Let us examine the principal channels through which this enormous loss to the public was created.

1. Wealth was transferred, and public losses created, through public-private partnerships and state-guaranteed infrastructure projects.

The most visible and largest economic component of the rent-seeking system established during AKP rule is the **public-private partnership (PPP) system**, operated through bridges, highways, airports, and major transportation projects.

In almost all these projects, Treasury guarantees indexed to foreign currencies are provided, long-term operating rights are granted, and the risks associated with the projects are assumed on behalf of the public.

The repeated appearance of a small number of companies is itself an indication that tenders were tailored to particular beneficiaries. Moreover, proper feasibility studies are not carried out. Instead of projects being designed to meet citizens' needs, they are initiated at contractors' request. That is why airports where planes do not land and bridges that cars do not cross keep making headlines—and **86 million people** pay the bill.

We have never opposed the construction of major projects as such. We said they should be undertaken through sound planning, scientific feasibility studies, competitive tenders, and reasonable levels of Treasury support. We opposed airports without arriving aircraft; we objected to paying **ten or twenty times** a project's actual cost.

Continuity note: The last sentence is completed using the opening words of printed page 255; the next installment will begin with the next paragraph concerning the cost of a bridge and highway project.

CHAPTER EIGHT — CONTINUED *I Am the One Putting Them on Trial*

English translation · Original printed pages 255–258

We are outraged that, for a bridge and highway project with a construction cost of $1 billion, a handful of contracting companies close to those in power should be paid ten or twenty times that amount under build-operate-transfer agreements! We oppose the Treasury-guarantee model, contracts concealed from the public, and nontransparent tender procedures. We oppose the substantial advantages granted to particular companies when critical provisions of many agreements are changed after the tenders have been awarded.

These contracts are withheld from us on the pretext that they are “trade secrets”; they are kept beyond the scrutiny of the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye and the public. There can be no “trade secrets” in any project financed by the people! Moreover, the operating periods of investments whose contracts have long since expired, and which should have reverted to the state, are being extended through further nontransparent, backroom agreements. Sometimes additional tenders are hastily announced just before the contracts expire, as though someone were trying to carry off the goods before a fire, simply to secure an extension.

Most of these projects have mortgaged our nation's income for thirty years! Every year, billions of dollars in Treasury payments—that is, money belonging to all of us—will flow to a handful of companies close to the government.

The central problem is the Treasury (public) guarantees provided for these projects and the scale of their contracts.

When we consider the magnitude of those guarantees and contracts, we can clearly see just how great a risk the public has assumed and how vast an economic opportunity has been opened up to the private sector.

According to data from the Presidency of Strategy and Budget, investments totaling **$142 billion** have been made through the public-private partnership model over the past twenty years. How much citizens and the public sector have paid to date—and how much they will pay in the future—remains entirely opaque.

Healthcare projects account for ten percent of the total investment. Yet the amount a former health minister cited as the sum the public would have to pay for hospitals alone (**€322 billion**) is more than twice the **$142 billion** reported by the Presidency of Strategy and Budget!

There is neither transparency nor consistency in these figures. We are talking about hundreds of billions of dollars in public money and losses to the public, yet those in power do not—and cannot—provide our nation with a transparent accounting.

2. Wealth was transferred, and losses inflicted on the public, through a network of zoning decisions, land transactions, and urban development profits.

During AKP rule, planning authority, zoning decisions, and the conversion of public land were also used as major instruments for transferring wealth.

The key institutions in this network of privilege and development profits are TOKİ, Emlak Konut REIC, the Ministry of Environment, Urbanization and Climate Change, the Privatization Administration, municipalities, and the Türkiye Wealth Fund.

In this network, profit arises from the increase in land values brought about by changes to development plans. But rather than distributing that benefit across the city and among our entire nation, it once again goes into the pockets of a handful of people.

TOKİ's principal mission was to build social housing. Over the years, however, luxury housing projects came to the fore. Public land was handed over to selected companies at below-market prices.

Revenue-sharing models were created in which the public sector was consistently at a disadvantage. Changes to development plans granted unfair advantages to a handful of companies and individuals!

Emlak Konut, meanwhile, became the market-facing arm of this system. Through large-scale projects, particularly in Istanbul, public land gained value within private developments, while planning decisions conferred substantial advantages on selected investors.

The value of the development profits generated in Istanbul alone under AKP rule was at least **$85 billion**.

3. Wealth was transferred, and losses inflicted on the public, through energy, mining, and natural resources.

The privatization of thermal power plants, hydroelectric power projects, and electricity distribution networks placed enormous economic value under the control of particular companies. Energy and mining projects were pursued despite objections raised to protect our natural environment and living spaces.

Today, Türkiye is among the countries with the greatest intensity of mining-license issuance in the world. The number of mining licenses increased **325-fold in twenty-three years**!

The government never stops to ask whether the damage it causes is worth the supposed benefit. All that matters is enriching its supporters, endlessly feeding the privileged circle it has created.

Between 1923 and 2002—throughout the entire history of the Republic before the AKP came to power—approximately one thousand mining licenses were issued across Türkiye. As I explained earlier, under the AKP that number reached **386,000**!

Another striking issue is the environmental impact assessment process. According to official figures, between 2002 and 2024 the relevant ministry issued a total of **84,000 decisions** under the Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) Regulation. Of these, **75,000** were decisions that an “EIA Is Not Required,” while more than **7,000** were “EIA Positive” decisions. In other words, in **98 percent** of all projects submitted, the ministry acted like a notary merely rubber-stamping applications. Nobody cared about the environment we are obliged to protect for our children and grandchildren!

There are also matters in the energy sector that we cannot fully understand because of the lack of transparency, but which have nevertheless resulted in major losses to our country.

Under this government, only a few years ago, an international arbitral tribunal ordered our country to pay **$1.47 billion**. Do you know why? Because, regrettably, we transported oil into our country "illegally," without the involvement or permission of Iraq's central government. Once again, our nation will pay the price. But our people will certainly ask: "Who profited from this, and which companies lined their pockets?" No one has the right to damage Türkiye's legal standing and reputation in this way.

Another item whose cost we can calculate directly concerns the conversion of debts from foreign currencies into Turkish lira in the electricity and thermal power plant sectors. By granting this advantage to selected companies, they deliberately caused a total loss of **$2.5 billion** to our Treasury.

4. Wealth was transferred, and losses inflicted on the public, through the healthcare public-private partnership network.

The hospitals known as "city hospitals," built and operated under public-private partnerships or a "build-lease-transfer" model, are a black hole that has effectively taken the Ministry of Health's budget hostage.

They initially set out with **34 projects**. But when the appalling costs underlying this PPP model began to emerge, they were forced to hastily limit the project to **18 hospitals**. Through nontransparent contracts, hidden as though behind a shield of secrecy, they established a system of exploitation lasting a full **28 years**: three years of construction and twenty-five years of operation.

City hospitals are a clear example of projects created in response to contractors' demands. The long-term, state-guaranteed loans secured by the contractors were denominated in foreign currency. Consequently, although most hospital costs consisted of construction using domestic inputs and only a small proportion involved imported medical equipment, **100 percent of the construction cost** was guaranteed in foreign currency. The rent paid under the heading of a "service fee," despite containing no imported component, was also granted a foreign-currency guarantee.

The Ministry of Development had announced that **$30 billion** in total rent would be paid for these eighteen hospitals over twenty-five years, but the actual calculations exposed this claim as false. Independent economists estimated that the total twenty-five-year commitment would reach at least **$81 billion**. Meanwhile, the health minister of the time openly acknowledged, before Parliament's Planning and Budget Committee, the burden imposed on this nation's future: he officially stated, in his own words, that if all **34 hospitals** entered service, the potential maximum payment would amount to no less than **€322 billion**!

Although they later said that this figure had been reduced, the essential problem remains: there is still no transparency whatsoever! Behind the excuse of "trade secrets," the accounts are concealed even from the Grand National Assembly.

I repeat: where public money is being spent, there can be no such thing as a "trade secret."

Türkiye's total exports last year amounted to **$273 billion**. In other words, according to the former health minister's statement, the cost of these hospitals is approximately one and a half times the value of everything all of Türkiye's businesses and companies sold abroad in an entire year.

That is how reckless this government is with the figures. It has only one concern: enriching itself and the handful of people around it. Yet with just **$10 billion**, we could have built twenty fully equipped, much more efficient state hospitals, each with five hundred beds, from the ground up. The money paid to city hospitals in only two and a half years could have provided our nation with fifty hospitals offering a total of **25,000 beds**. Instead, they chose to transfer the money to **seven privileged companies** for twenty-five years, for just eighteen hospitals.

5. Another means of transferring public resources to private interests under AKP rule was privatization.

Strategic public assets built up over many years through the people's taxes were transferred to private companies under highly controversial terms and various pretexts.

Türk Telekom is emblematic of this betrayal. A foreign company pledged its Türk Telekom shares as collateral to obtain loans from Turkish banks; it did not repay those loans or make the necessary infrastructure investments. It took the money left in the company's accounts at the time of privatization, along with the money accumulated afterward, and departed. **Turkish banks were left to bear the loss.**

Continuity note: The last sentence is completed using the opening words of printed page 259. The next installment begins with the following paragraph about the Türkiye Wealth Fund's intervention in Türk Telekom.

CHAPTER EIGHT — CONCLUSION *I Am the One Putting Them on Trial English translation · Original printed pages 259–261*

The loss was left for Turkish banks to bear. The Türkiye Wealth Fund was brought in to rescue the banks from this predicament and bought back the shares with public money. It was a fiasco from beginning to end.

We all remember the example of the Tank and Pallet Factory. This strategic asset was handed over for twenty-five years for a mere **$50 million**. Why? Was its true value perhaps paid to others in other ways?

A loan from Ziraat Bank was used to create a pro-government media establishment. A greenfield site with no financial value, which no honest banker would ever have accepted as collateral, was accepted as security and the loan was approved. Today, that loan appears year after year in the Court of Accounts' reports as the largest nonperforming loan in the Turkish banking system.

6. The network surrounding the Türkiye Wealth Fund became another model of wealth transfer.

The principal assets held by the Türkiye Wealth Fund include Turkish Airlines (THY), Türk Telekom, BOTAŞ, Ziraat Bank, Halkbank, Vakıfbank, Çaykur, PTT, Borsa İstanbul, Eti Maden, and the Turkish Petroleum Corporation (TPAO).

This fund has evolved into a structure beyond parliamentary oversight. Through it, public assets have been used as collateral or as instruments for borrowing.

Through the Wealth Fund, public capital is managed by an off-budget mechanism. Erdoğan is chairman of the Fund's board of directors. Its other board members are a handful of people close to Erdoğan. Without being subject to privatization laws or parliamentary scrutiny, a handful of individuals can mortgage or sell our most important public companies as they please.

Because the Wealth Fund is not run according to a transparent management model, the companies it controls have been removed from the Treasury's open accounting mechanisms. In other words, public assets have been taken beyond the nation's oversight! Under the new regime imposed upon them, these institutions are run as if they were a holding company. But at the head of this holding company there is no prudent businessperson. Instead, there is a mentality that squanders the accumulated labor of **86 million people over a century**, thinks only of enriching those around it, and hollows out institutions through lavish salaries.

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You know how you put businesspeople through the wringer here merely because they donated a childcare center to Istanbul, calling it extortion, calling it coercion? Take a look at which foundations and organizations have received contributions from those companies that have been allowed to feed off the state for decades!

We are talking about **billions of dollars** here, billions! Is there one courageous prosecutor willing to investigate these matters? Let the minister who masqueraded as a chief prosecutor take up these files as well, and let us see his courage. Is there a brave prosecutor who will investigate to whom the state's Treasury was handed over, while we meticulously spent the İBB budget for the people of Istanbul? Over twenty-four years, they could have written an entire book on losses to the public. An entire book!

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I have described the bitter point to which twenty-four years of AKP government have brought our country and our people. Because do you know who the real parties to this case are?

This case is between those who have condemned half the nation to the minimum wage, who present poverty as fate, and those who will bring prosperity and wealth to Türkiye through sound policies. It is between those who grant every conceivable privilege to enormous companies while forgetting the shopkeepers who are the backbone of this country, and our tradespeople who struggle to earn an honest living through the sweat of their brows. It is between those who forgive hundreds of billions of lira in taxes owed by favored companies at a stroke of the pen, and farmers whose tractors are seized over tax debts, workers whose wages are eroded by the tax burden. It is between those who belittle people's struggle to make ends meet, and families who cannot buy their children even a pair of boots in winter. It is between those who condescend to “bestow” a holiday bonus on pensioners before elections as though giving alms, and our pensioners who have worked all their lives but cannot buy their grandchildren chocolates for the holidays. It is between those who dine on buffalo milk and dragon fruit in palaces, and mothers and fathers in a country where a kilogram of apples costs **100 lira**, who cannot even put a piece of fruit in their child's school lunchbox.

Seven million babies in our country live on the brink of hunger! What could be more terrible than that? This case is between a government that makes our children cry from hunger so it can maintain its extravagance, and our children who cannot enjoy the conditions they deserve and whose futures have been mortgaged.

It is between those for whose own children every door opens while consigning a third of our young people to insecurity, unemployment, and hopelessness, and those young people who reach the age of thirty and still have to live in their parents' homes because they cannot find work. It is between a government that has turned our country into one of the world's biggest drug-transit centers in the last ten years, and families whose children fall into the traps set by drug and gambling gangs.

We know whose side we are on. We stand with pensioners who cannot buy their grandchildren chocolates. We stand with mothers devastated by the sight of their babies crying from hunger. We stand with young people forced to depend on their families, unable to marry or build lives of their own. We stand with our young people whose cries go unheard. We stand with millions of families struggling against poverty. **We stand with the people! We stand for a better future!** And it is equally clear whose side the government is on.

But the truth is there for everyone to see: **Türkiye is greater than the Palace! Türkiye is greater than one man! Türkiye is greater than the fears and ambitions of those in power!** They imagine themselves to be the most powerful government this land has ever seen. Yet they are afraid

of the people. Türkiye does not need leaders who fear the people. It needs leaders who walk alongside them!

I have only been able to describe a fraction of the devastation inflicted in twenty-four years. I would have to speak for weeks to describe it all! Our nation now sees very clearly what has been done, and it is saying **ENOUGH!**

However much they resort to tyranny and try to play for extra time, their time is up. There can be no winning a battle of wills against the people.

The people will prevail! We will build the beautiful Türkiye that our nation deserves. And you will see: we will achieve it together with our people, through policies that put the people first—transparent, accountable, democratic, and just!

CHAPTER NINE *The Türkiye I Dream Of English translation · Original printed page 262*

I am now going to read you another passage from the indictment. This is how the indictment describes my alleged purpose in forming the so-called “criminal organization”:

“That he first aimed to become the sole decision-maker within the party to which he belonged and to take control of his party, and that the next objective, the third purpose, was to become his party's presidential candidate in the forthcoming presidential election.”

In other words, I am supposed to have established this so-called “criminal organization” in order to become a presidential candidate! I supposedly formed it to become President and govern the country—or, to use their terminology, to “seize control” of it!

My dear people, beautiful people of my beautiful homeland,

Since this is the central allegation of the so-called indictment, I must tell you about **the Türkiye I dream of**. I must explain what kind of Türkiye there will be when I become President, so that you can decide: could such a Türkiye be the objective, the dream, of a “criminal organization”? You decide whether our concern is to assume responsibility for governing through the nation's votes, democratically, or to “seize control” of the country. You decide whether our dream for Türkiye can even belong in the same sentence as the word “crime.”

They claim that we established a so-called “criminal organization” in Istanbul. On the contrary, I have told you what we achieved in Istanbul through honesty, merit, and vision. We will do throughout Türkiye what we have done in Istanbul. These are not empty promises, because **we have already succeeded!** We succeeded in a megacity of sixteen million people, despite a thousand and one obstacles.

That is why, at this point, I must speak about our country's future. For this so-called indictment describes our dream for Türkiye as a crime—even as the central objective of the alleged organization!

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English translation · Original printed pages 263–266

This politically contrived trial, this coup of March 19, is an attempt to place a mortgage on our country's future. And our struggle is not simply an objection to the injustice being committed today. Our struggle is for Türkiye to become the best country it can be.

To achieve that, we must first grasp the great transformation the world is undergoing in the twenty-first century. Today, nations distinguish themselves not only through military strength, the size of their economies, or their populations, but through their dreams, their ambitions, and the sense of a future they offer their people.

Our Republic, too, was born of a dream for Türkiye. At the heart of that dream—which inspired not only our nation and our region, but the whole world—were the sovereignty of the people, in other words democracy; progress; enlightenment; and the aspiration to attain, and indeed surpass, the accumulated achievements of humanity: modern civilization. Equality, justice, freedom, and peace formed the spirit of that dream.

We achieved some of what we dreamed of. In other respects, we fell short. Had we not fallen short, we would not be here today; such blatant attacks on the sovereignty of the people would not be possible; our people would not be so poor, so unhappy, and so hopeless; and our country would not be marked by such profound inequality and injustice. We now stand in the early decades of the twenty-first century, having missed its first quarter.

In the second quarter of the twenty-first century, without losing any more time, we want to reclaim our future and bring the Republic of Türkiye to the fullest realization of its potential.

Those who govern Türkiye today have no dream for our country's future. They have no conception of that future, no blueprint for it. They have nothing left to offer the people.

They pretend otherwise: they sell lies and counterfeit dreams, while dozens of pro-government television channels broadcast relentless propaganda, around the clock. Worst of all, they want us to live inside those lies. They seek to make us slaves to false dreams. They try to sell us the nightmare we are living through as though it were reality itself, so that we will neither see nor understand nor feel it. Yet this is our reality: the nearly ninety million people of this extraordinary country, situated at one of the world's most strategically important crossroads, are made to work for one man and his entourage—for the handful who have gathered around them. They are made to sacrifice their children, their labor, and their lives to the whims and worldly ambitions of a tiny clique.

A ramshackle, grotesque regime is being built in Türkiye today. Its architects want it to endure. And in this regime, there is nothing for the people!

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In everything I have done, in every responsibility I have undertaken, I have worked to strengthen our shared reason, shared feelings, shared values, and shared dreams. As a presidential candidate, both my duty and my greatest ideal are to dream of a Türkiye together with my fellow citizens—and make that dream real. I want us to leave not a single citizen behind; not to rise by stepping on one another, but to stand together, unite, and lift one another up, until we become the brightest crescent and star the world has ever seen. We deserve this. We can accomplish it. That is why I am here today: the dream of a better Türkiye!

And that is why I am being tried by people who have no dreams. Those who can no longer dream, who have nothing left to say about Türkiye's future, whose time has passed, have envied those who dream. They have been jealous of us, afraid of us—and they have attacked us.

The Türkiye we dream of is not the dream of one person, one party, or one privileged group. It is the shared dream of everyone who lives on this land. For we believe wholeheartedly in the Republic and in democracy. Let us never forget that the Republic and democracy are unique and precious precisely because they bring the people's dreams together.

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As the world changes, those in power merely watch. We will not watch. We will change things!

At a time when the world is once again being remade from top to bottom, the price our country pays for its rulers' pursuit of their own fortunes, while they simply watch the world and this enormous transformation pass them by, is immense.

Our problems grow more serious by the day, and every day we become more disconnected from the world. We are being deprived not only of democracy, justice, freedoms, and rights; we are falling further behind the economic and technological transformation that is gathering pace around us.

Indeed, production, trade, finance, and technology are changing across the world; relations between states, international institutions, and political regimes are being reshaped.

Technological transformation—led by artificial intelligence, automation, and digitalization—is changing economies and the ways goods are produced, consumed, and distributed. New routes are being added to international trade, and new production and supply chains are emerging. Fierce competition is taking place among states for control of the energy sources, new trade routes, and rare-earth elements whose importance is growing as production technologies change and economies evolve. Sadly, Türkiye is near the back of this competition, watching quietly from the sidelines.

It is not only the world economy and global trade that are changing. The international political order is changing too. These profound transformations in the global economy and in world politics are also reshaping national economies and domestic politics. Economic and social inequalities are deepening everywhere. The gulf between countries that possess advanced

technology and those that do not is widening. Democracies are becoming more fragile, and authoritarian regimes are on the rise.

The great transformation the world is undergoing, and the new risks it brings, make certain things more essential than ever: a strong and effective state; government guided by consultation, knowledge, reason, and justice; a capable, merit-based civil service; a sound economy built on production; a strong military; genuine democracy; a scientific education system that encourages innovation; and a nation whose people stand in solidarity, trust one another, and share a sense of their common future.

That is how a country survives in this new world. Unfortunately, our country is not on that path. This is why we are becoming poorer so quickly. As the world advances, we are falling behind. We are losing our future. We must put an end to this—urgently and without fail!

And there is only one way to do so: **a great drive for reform!** Our country needs a profound and far-reaching reform program. Through a great drive for reform, we must catch up with the economic and technological transformation that is once again changing the world.

This is no laughing matter. We have reached a genuine crossroads, as we have several times before. We faced such a crossroads at the beginning of the nineteenth century, when it became clear that the Ottoman Empire could not continue as it was. We faced another when we emerged defeated from the First World War.

At both crossroads, we undertook major initiatives and tried to shield our country from still greater disasters. Most notably, after our defeat in the First World War, we fought our War of Independence under the leadership of Gazi Mustafa Kemal Atatürk and founded the Republic. Today, our country once again stands at a great crossroads. Once again, we need a great drive for reform!

For our country's survival, and to secure for it the place it deserves in a changing regional and international order, we must launch a great drive for reform. Only through such a drive can we make our state powerful and our bureaucracy capable and merit-based.

Only through a great drive for reform can we become a country governed by justice, consultation, science, knowledge, and reason. Only through such a drive can we establish genuine democracy, strong institutions, an innovative intellectual climate, and a society bound together in solidarity. Only through such a drive can we make our state strong, our people at peace, our society prosperous, our young people happy, and everyone free and secure. Only through such a drive can we once again keep pace with a changing world.

For years, my colleagues and I have been working on this great drive for reform, together with our country's most knowledgeable experts and through the widest possible process of collective deliberation.

Even prison could not stop us. On the contrary, we worked harder still. We are ready. We seek the responsibility of governing our country and carrying out this great drive for reform as soon as possible.

This government no longer has a dream for Türkiye. Nor does it have the capacity to realize any dream or vision.

Our vision is not a collection of empty promises or empty words. The revolutions, the pioneering achievements, and the great structural reforms we have carried out in Istanbul—a megacity of sixteen million people—are there for all to see. I have already spoken about them.

Despite all the government's efforts to obstruct us, we succeeded in Istanbul. When we assume the administration of the country through the favor and trust of our people, we will be able to carry out many times more reforms.

This is who we are: we conceive a dream, a vision—call it what you will—and work day and night with the most capable teams to turn those dreams into reality.

Vision: an ambitious but firmly grounded conception of the future. **Reform:** the determination to transform, renew, and rejuvenate. **Delivery:** implementation, turning ideas into practice.

Vision, reform, and delivery are at the heart of our national strategy.

Continuity note: The closing phrase is completed with the first word of printed page 267. The next installment resumes with the following sentence.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English translation · Original printed pages 267–270

Vision, reform, and delivery are part of our very nature. That is precisely why we are in prison! We are imprisoned because our people have seen that we can offer what those in power can no longer offer society, that we can govern far better than they can. But let no one worry: we will certainly build the Türkiye of our dreams!

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I would like to tell you a little about our dream for Türkiye and briefly set out the main outlines of our comprehensive reform projects. And at the outset, I want to emphasize something essential: **People are the foundation and the focus of the Türkiye we envision!**

In the Türkiye we envision, not a single citizen will be left behind. For this country's true national wealth lies not in its mines, buildings, roads, or bridges, but in its people.

Every citizen is among this country's greatest riches. Every child's talents, every young person's energy, every woman's labor, every older person's experience, every citizen's dignity—these are the nation's wealth. Only a reform movement that places the people of this country at its center, and channels young people's abilities and energy into production and progress, can succeed.

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Because people are the foundation and focus of our dream for Türkiye, we will build a strong state capable of confronting the risks and threats created by a changing world. But that state will serve the nation, not take orders from a handful of people.

A cornerstone of our dream for Türkiye is **a strong state in the service of its people**. Only with a strong state and a merit-based civil service can we effectively meet our citizens' needs. Only with a strong state can we withstand threats and risks such as wars, conflicts, and natural disasters—including earthquakes—and remain safe.

To strengthen our state and make our bureaucracy merit-based, we will end the one-man state and establish a state governed by institutions and rules, a state founded on the rule of law.

We will build a just state. Citizens will feel the state's strength not with fear, but with trust. They will see the power of the state standing beside them, not against them.

Our state will draw its strength not from individuals, but from the nation, justice, institutions, and rules. Those who govern will not stand above the law; everyone, including those in power, will obey the law.

We will make the state the state of all its citizens—not merely of those in power.

Our state will not be a party-state. We will erase partisanship from the very institutional memory of the state! Nor will our state be a dynastic state.

No one's surname, personal connections, or loyalty will take precedence over the law, merit, or the will of the people. The citizens of this country will live not in fear, but freely asserting their rights.

We will govern Türkiye not for the interests of a handful of people, but for the shared future of all 86 million.

From the highest office to the lowest, we will entrust every position to those qualified to hold it. Merit, not loyalty, will be the measure of public-sector employment. We will govern the state through reason, science, knowledge, and consultation, just as we will govern it through merit. Reason, knowledge, and science will prevail in public administration.

We will establish a system guaranteeing the independence of every regulatory and supervisory institution of vital importance to economic stakeholders.

With inclusive state institutions, we will build an inclusive economy. Here I want to emphasize something important: for us, one of the most essential elements of inclusion is **equality between women and men**. A strong state does not silence half its population; it makes their labor, knowledge, and leadership part of the country's future. We will see many more women in management at every level of the state. As I explained earlier, we tripled the number of women managers at Istanbul Metropolitan Municipality.

We will do the same in governing Türkiye. As women gain a stronger voice in the state, the economy, and politics, women's rights will advance in every sphere. Women will enjoy the safe, productive, healthy, and happy lives they deserve.

We will make the actions of public administration open and subject to scrutiny, and the state transparent. Every level of state administration will be accountable; every administrative action will be open to oversight.

Those who govern the state will be answerable to the people and will serve the people. They will be the people's servants.

Simplicity and humility will prevail in government offices and in every public position. Arrogance, ostentation, and extravagance will cast no shadow over the business of the state or public administration. People who bring the state into disrepute, who treat citizens with arrogance, envy, discrimination, and favoritism, will not rise to the highest offices; they will learn the weight and responsibility of public service.

We will make public administration straightforward, simple, and effective, and put an end to waste.

The administration of the state will also be accountable to the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye, the sole body in which the national will is represented in its broadest form. Parliament's powers of oversight will be strengthened.

Above all, we will rescue public administration and politics from the decay in which they have become mired! Establishing clean government, an honest civil service, an impartial judiciary, and clean politics will be our first priority. **Immediately upon taking office, we will pass a Political Ethics Law through Parliament!** On the day our party was seized through a coup, our esteemed party

chairman wrote to the leaders of all political parties, proposing that they jointly establish a working group on a Political Ethics Law. Sadly, this coup by the government also prevented that work from getting under way. We will resume it swiftly at the first opportunity—swiftly!

Every politician and every senior public official—the president, ministers, undersecretaries, department heads, members of Parliament, prosecutors, and judges—will file a declaration of assets upon taking office and regularly every year thereafter. These declarations will be audited regularly. And not only they themselves: their family members will have to file declarations too!

A strong state is also one that puts the safety of its citizens' lives at the center of its responsibilities.

We will prepare our state for disasters such as earthquakes and floods, and make it effective in extraordinary circumstances such as climate and food crises and migration. No one will be left weak and helpless in difficult situations or times.

Unfortunately, our state failed the test of the February 6 earthquakes. While at most a few hundred people die in earthquakes of similar intensity in other countries, we lost **52,000 of our people, according to official figures**. Perhaps many more. That is unacceptable. In the Türkiye we envision, people will be the state's central concern, and protecting their lives will be our most important responsibility.

We will build a Türkiye in which, during disasters, social upheavals, and emergencies, people speak not of a failure of coordination but of the decisive response of a strong state.

We will undertake a long, patient, and determined effort to make our cities earthquake-resistant. We will not surrender human life to speculative development, manipulations of zoning regulations, negligence, or short-term interests. A strong Türkiye is not a country of buildings that gleam on the outside but are rotten within.

A strong Türkiye is a country with solid foundations, structurally sound buildings, dependable institutions, and safe cities. A strong Türkiye is one in which citizens can trust their state and say with peace of mind, “My state considered my safety before I even had to.”

For that reason, I make this promise here: **Within five plus five years of our government, Türkiye will be fully prepared for earthquakes!** Not a single one of our people will have to live in fear of an earthquake!

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A strong state depends on strong local governments.

To make our state effective in meeting the needs of our country and its citizens, we will decentralize administration and share the state's power and resources with elected local governments. We will achieve effective governance through decentralization.

We will make local governments more effective without departing from the principle of a unitary state.

We will democratize local governments, develop effective oversight mechanisms, expand their powers and budgets, and broaden their areas of responsibility.

To ensure good governance in local administration, we will make democratic participation, transparency, and accountability the norm.

We will put a definitive end to the trustee-appointment system: we will remove from our legislation this disgrace to democracy, a system introduced by the government through an emergency decree-law.

We will make our cities resilient and make life in them safe, spacious, and affordable. We will end an urban-development policy based on speculative gains from zoning, profit, and partisanship. We will regard our cities not as opportunities for speculative development, but as fair and healthy places to live, in harmony with nature and human dignity.

Our cities will be filled with spacious, thoughtfully designed public squares where people can gather and move freely. Because we will realize the dream of a Türkiye that is **not afraid of its public squares**. We will build a Türkiye unafraid of citizens coming together, speaking, objecting, rejoicing, mourning, or celebrating.

Continuity note: The last sentence runs into printed page 271, where the source continues: “We will build a Türkiye …”. Its concluding statement about public squares will appear at the start of the next installment.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English translation · Original printed pages 271–274

We will build a Türkiye that is not afraid of its citizens gathering, speaking, objecting, rejoicing, mourning, or celebrating. Our public squares will be the shared heart of this country.

We will not leave our citizens vulnerable and helpless in the face of risks such as disasters, climate and food crises, and migration. We will make our cities resilient to disasters and prepare our citizens to face them.

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As I have explained, our strong state will meet all the basic needs of our people. Our people-centered state will make great strides, especially in healthcare and education.

When we speak of *"the Türkiye I dream of, centered on people,"* we must begin with health. The Türkiye we envision is a healthy Türkiye. Because healthcare is not a favor bestowed upon people; it is a fundamental right.

We will establish a new, robust healthcare system that every citizen can access, one that delivers quality care befitting human dignity. Our aim is not merely to manage existing problems, but to build one of the finest healthcare systems in the world.

The healthcare system we dream of is not one in which the entire burden falls on our doctors, physicians can spare only a few minutes for each patient, and hospital corridors are overcrowded. We want a system in which everyone eats well, receives regular health checkups, and is treated with the individual care they deserve when they fall ill. We envision a Türkiye that places preventive medicine, family healthcare, early diagnosis, and dignified treatment at its center.

In a healthy Türkiye, our people will truly feel healthy, too. Health begins in the mind and in our emotions. Türkiye is among the OECD countries with the fastest growth in antidepressant use. Over the last ten years, the number of boxes of antidepressants sold has risen from 40 million to 71 million. Antidepressant use has increased by 77 percent! This is not normal. It is a sign of profound unease, unhappiness, and hopelessness in society. You have damaged our nation's mental health. You truly have!

As financial worries, fears about the future, oppression, and anxiety recede—and as a sense of freedom, joy, happiness, trust, economic well-being, and hope return to our country—a genuinely healthy Türkiye will become possible.

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Another central priority of our state, devoted to serving the people, will be education.

Education means equality of opportunity. One of the state's foremost duties is to give every child the same opportunity at the beginning of life. That is why public schools will be the best schools in Türkiye! Education will be free and of high quality.

First and foremost, in the Türkiye we dream of, education will begin with widely available early-childhood centers.

These centers will not merely lessen the disadvantages mothers face in working and social life. They will also be the first public spaces where our children socialize at an early age, form bonds of trust with society, and make a healthy and equal start in life.

Early-childhood centers will give all our children a future in which they can compete with the world. They will provide equality of opportunity.

According to United Nations studies, the strongest investment a country can make in its future is to strengthen education for children between the ages of zero and five. That is because the human brain grows most rapidly during those years. According to PISA research, children who receive at least two years of preschool education before primary school go on to perform much better academically. We are falling behind the world because those who govern us have neither the vision nor the will to act on this issue.

My colleagues and I understood the importance of these centers and put that understanding into practice in Istanbul. Now we will do the same throughout Türkiye! Women and children across the country will benefit.

These are not impossible dreams. When we give up so-called “prestige,” palaces, armies of bodyguards, private aircraft, and an endless appetite for extravagance, every child in Türkiye can enjoy equality of opportunity!

No child's destiny in this country will be limited by the circumstances of the home into which they were born. From the very beginning, education will be the foundation of equal opportunity, social solidarity, and our shared future.

Education will no longer be a source of inequality that determines children's destinies. It will be a doorway through which everyone can pursue their dreams. Our children will receive a colorful education in beautiful schools surrounded by greenery, not in ugly concrete school buildings.

No child will have to abandon their dreams because of the neighborhood they were born in, their family's income, or the resources available to their mother and father. Every child in this country will learn, from an early age, to say, “I can do it,” and to dream.

Together with our teachers, we will build an education system in which teachers are happy and feel secure.

Our children will be safe; mothers and fathers will have peace of mind. One of the first instructions I will give upon taking office will be to make every school earthquake-resistant as a matter of urgency! I cannot think of a more pressing issue.

The safety of our children and teachers will also be ensured through appropriate security personnel. I cannot think of anything more important than our children's lives.

Most importantly, our children will not sit through lessons at school on an empty stomach! Can a hungry child learn? Can a hungry child's brain develop? Can a hungry child be happy or feel safe?

According to OECD and PISA studies, one in every four children in Türkiye goes to school hungry! We are the country in the worst position on this measure among OECD members. Even according to our own Turkish Statistical Institute, 39 percent of our children aged zero to seventeen are “at risk of poverty or social exclusion.” These figures are appalling.

Under our government, every child in every public school will receive free meals! Our children will be able to eat healthily, learn, and enjoy equal opportunities.

What could possibly matter more? For God's sake, what problem could be more important than our children's hunger? Nothing matters more than this.

A country's standing is measured not by the size of its palaces but by the value it places on its children. As I said, the Türkiye we dream of puts people first. People!

In the Türkiye we envision, universities will not be institutions that merely award diplomas. They will be places where our vision of the future—our vision for Türkiye—is conceived, debated, and, of course, criticized. Because a country's future is built by the courage of free minds.

When academia is free, it produces. When academia is free, it dreams and innovates. When academia is free, it engages with the world, contributes to it, and adds to the shared knowledge of science and humanity. But academia under the control of the state, politicians, and narrow vested interests withers. It loses touch with the world, trading merit for loyalty, creativity for obedience, and science for fear. It becomes captive to nepotism.

We will realize Türkiye's decades-old, unfulfilled dream of autonomous universities. We will free our universities from political pressure, arbitrary appointments, and an atmosphere of fear. We will safeguard academic freedom with the utmost care.

Rectors, deans—in short, university leadership—will be chosen by the academic staff of each university. In making those choices, academics will also consult their universities' student unions. When university leadership is determined through collective deliberation within the institution, both students and faculty members will become more motivated and productive. All will be more successful.

Look at what the government has done to Boğaziçi University. A university that was the pride of our country once ranked among the world's top 200 in international rankings. Now it has fallen below the top thousand. What a shame! This is an attempt to destroy a vital national asset. Why? Because neither the faculty nor the students embraced the government-appointed “trustee administration.” Their motivation collapsed. Many academics left the university or were dismissed.

You have no right to do this! You certainly have no right to squander, on a whim, the assets our country has built with great effort over decades!

Türkiye will not be a country where universities are shut down overnight by arbitrary decision and then reopened by another arbitrary decision.

We will raise working conditions in academia to international standards. We will build a Türkiye in which scientists can work securely, freely, and productively, and young researchers can advance through curiosity, hard work, and creativity rather than anxiety about their future.

We will restore strong ties between Türkiye's academic community and the world's leading academic institutions. We will turn our universities from inward-looking organizations into institutions open to the world—competing with it and producing knowledge alongside it.

Our young people will know that when they graduate from this country's universities, they will find work immediately—and well-paid work at that. Because they will graduate with advanced qualifications.

Today, however, the quality of our universities has been driven so low that a university degree is unfortunately no longer a guarantee of a future. Nearly one million young university graduates are unemployed! A grave figure.

The unemployment rate among university graduates averages 3 percent in OECD countries, but 10 percent in ours. That points to a structural problem.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English translation · Original printed pages 275–278

One of the most pressing problems facing our young people is housing. With our people-centered approach to government, student dormitories were among the very first things we established in Istanbul.

What we accomplished in Istanbul, we will accomplish across Türkiye. And these dormitories will be more than places to sleep. They will be homes for free thought, the creation of knowledge and technology, friendship, meaningful conversation, culture, the arts, and communal life. We refuse to accept a Türkiye in which young people struggle to find a roof over their heads and are left at the mercy of networks of vested interests. We will build a Türkiye in which every young person can live safely, with dignity and freedom, in modern conditions.

A country whose universities are not free cannot have a free future. A country whose universities are closed to the world cannot understand the world. A country that condemns its young people to anxiety over housing, making ends meet, and their futures cannot dream great dreams.

The Türkiye we envision is not one in which young people are silenced, but one in which they think, speak, create, debate, and dare to change the world.

We do not want a generation raised on resentment. Never. Our compass is love, tolerance, and patriotism.

As our great leader, Gazi Mustafa Kemal Atatürk, said: **“We want generations whose minds are free, whose consciences are free, and whose learning is free!”**

Sadly, our finest minds are now emigrating because they cannot find here an atmosphere of freedom in which their intellect, dreams, and ideas can flourish! Perhaps our children enjoy better living conditions abroad, but every one of them longs for home. They all want to return to their country. The time to ask “Why aren't they coming back?” has long since arrived. These young people want room to breathe. They want freedom, justice, and hope. But they cannot find them. The oppressive regime established by those in power is too constricting for great minds. And so our brightest people are enriching other countries today.

In the last ten years, **more than four million highly educated young people** have settled abroad “permanently”! Do you know what that means? There are dozens of countries in Europe with populations of around four million. An entire country of highly educated people—people capable of competing internationally, people receiving job offers from around the world—has emigrated from Türkiye! The value these four million people will create abroad is beyond calculation. This is a loss of national wealth measured not in billions, but in **hundreds of billions of dollars**. And the overwhelming majority were educated in our own schools. This is how a country becomes impoverished.

We will prepare our children for the world that is coming.

The foundation of everything is **education**! The dream of a prosperous Türkiye begins with education. Without fundamental educational reform, our 86 million people cannot become more

prosperous, and our country cannot prepare for the risks and opportunities of the new world.

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Yes, in the Türkiye we dream of, a strong state will meet all our citizens' essential needs in the best way possible and to the highest standard. You may ask how we intend to do that.

We will both spend our budget wisely—efficiently, without waste, and with people at its heart—and revive our economy. We will reach our true economic potential. We will bring about Türkiye's great economic leap forward. We will put into practice a productive, fair, sustainable, high-value-added development model of the kind we have almost forgotten even how to dream of.

The era of this government without vision will end: an era that has allowed our country's immense accumulated wealth to decay, become frozen, lose value, and disappear; that has based everything on selling off our assets and borrowing at high interest rates; that has favored a debt economy over the real economy and an economy of concrete and real-estate rents over an economy of production.

Today's government sold off cheaply the assets that rightfully belonged to our children and even our grandchildren, spent the proceeds, and then borrowed at high cost on behalf of future generations as well.

They have **consumed our tomorrow today**, with an appetite that could never be satisfied. They burdened our children with debt and left almost no assets to stand against those debts. They could not get enough of selling things off—and they are still selling them.

Türkiye will have an economy that multiplies its resources instead of exhausting them, empowers its people instead of wearing them down, and invests in the future instead of mortgaging it.

In the Türkiye we dream of, the economy will not be a means of enriching a narrow circle of interests. It will operate within a system that increases the shared prosperity of the nation.

Those who produce will prosper. Those who invest will prosper. Honest labor will be rewarded. Knowledge will be rewarded. Technology will be rewarded. Entrepreneurship will be rewarded. In short, those who work and earn their living through their own skill, intelligence, and effort will prosper.

Agriculture, industry, culture, science, and technology will reinforce one another. Türkiye will become one of the centers of the new economy. From artificial intelligence to green energy, from biotechnology to the defense industry, from software to the creative industries, and from agricultural research and development to health technologies, we will have a say in the fields that will shape the world's future.

A mindset unable to foresee the future of the world economy cannot build that future either.

We will not choose our course according to whichever way the wind happens to blow, or according to short-term opportunities for private gain. We will put into practice a vision that looks ahead, analyzes the future, and makes sound use of our strengths.

We will bring together the intelligence of our young people, the courage of our entrepreneurs, the work of our scientists, and the productivity of our workers in this country's great drive for development.

One of the Turkish nation's most distinctive qualities is its entrepreneurial spirit and courage. We will support that spirit. We will not stand in its way; quite the opposite, we will encourage it on objective terms and with equal opportunity for all.

We will support our entrepreneurs throughout the world. How many truly world-leading brands have we created? Fewer than the fingers of one hand.

Successful countries achieve this through their people and their vision, by investing in research and development. Education is indispensable to a revolution in production and high-value-added manufacturing—as I said earlier when discussing our fundamental educational reforms—but investment is indispensable too!

When accession negotiations with the European Union began in **2005**, annual investment inflows to our country, previously around **$1 billion**, suddenly rose toward **$30 billion**. In recent years, however, the ratio of investment inflows to our GDP has fallen back to the levels of the 1990s.

As investments multiplied in the years following 2005, our people experienced a relative increase in wealth and development. So why did investment in Türkiye rise so sharply in 2005? Because Türkiye had met the **Copenhagen political criteria** and had begun EU accession negotiations—in a manner that was credible at the time. The Customs Union was also a sound international agreement for its time. In short, investors regarded Türkiye as a **“safe haven”**: a country that cared about legal certainty and had a strong trade agreement with the European market. For the same reasons, Turkish investors could concentrate on investing in their own country.

A country with an outstanding strategic position, immediately beside the world's wealthiest market—the European market—and in a customs union with that prosperous economy; a qualified, hardworking population; and a land of extraordinary beauty: a uniquely attractive place to invest.

And what did those investments bring our people? **New jobs and livelihoods.**

Investment meant new factories, new service sectors, and new technologies and know-how arriving in our country. In two words, it meant **prosperity and development**. And indeed our people became relatively more prosperous in those years. But the vast sums flowing into the economy were not put to good use; they were buried in rents and concrete.

Because of the mistakes made particularly over the last fifteen years, and because we have moved away from the rule of law at lightning speed, we are losing all our economic gains.

And as long as the government does not change, we will go on losing ground and becoming poorer. Every day under this government will make our people poorer, while a handful of privileged individuals grow richer still.

The indispensable conditions for investment are **legal certainty, investment security, equality before the law**, and a system in which the rules do not change according to who someone is, the circles they belong to, or whom they know.

It means a Türkiye where property rights are protected, contracts are honored, the judiciary is independent, institutions are inclusive, and none is surrendered to arbitrary power.

It means a Türkiye where all state institutions—especially those of vital importance to the economy, such as the **Central Bank, TurkStat (TÜİK), the Banking Regulation and Supervision Agency (BDDK), the Capital Markets Board (SPK), the Competition Authority, and the Energy Market Regulatory Authority (EPDK)**—treat every participant in the economy equally, make rational economic decisions, and can operate independently of irrational political pressure.

It means a Türkiye where the economic statistics produced by TurkStat are trustworthy and scientific.

It means a Türkiye where the Central Bank is run by competent economists who do not listen to the irrational experiments of political **“so-called economists.”**

As a result of those irrational experiments, Türkiye is still struggling with **some of the highest inflation in the world**! Had our institutions been strong, independent, and staffed on merit, this could never have happened: **our economy would never have been thrown into such disarray!**

Continuity note: The last sentence is completed using the first word of printed page 279; the next installment starts with the following paragraph.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English translation · Original printed pages 279–282

Our economy would not have been thrown into disarray!

We will have genuinely strong, competent, honest and independent state institutions.

We will guarantee genuine freedom of enterprise. We will not confine an entrepreneur's dreams within the narrow expectations, permissions and privileges of certain circles. We will clear the way for everyone in this country who wants to establish a business, produce, invent, export and reach out to the world.

What Türkiye needs is not an economy kept afloat by debt, struggling to breathe through concrete construction and merely getting through each day. Türkiye needs a new development model grounded in knowledge, labor, production, justice and trust. We will establish that model. We will make Türkiye a country that produces again, inspires confidence again and grows prosperous again—but, most importantly, one that *grows prosperous together*.

Let me make you a very clear promise. When we carry out these powerful structural reforms in the economy; when strong and capable state institutions make rational, predictable decisions; when investment flows into our country; when we repair our relations with all our key economic partner countries, particularly those in Europe; when the minds and capital that emigrated return to Türkiye; when we resolve our chronic current-account deficit through high-value-added production; when we direct investment efficiently through the right vision and system of incentives; and, above all, when the state's institutional structure is repaired and a competent administration takes office, confidence will be restored.

Confidence is what governs the economy. When confidence returns to this land, watch how we soar! Watch the children of this country prosper! See how inflation falls, purchasing power rises and every one of our citizens gains a life worthy of human dignity!

Those days are very close. The prosperous Türkiye of our dreams—a Türkiye that inspires confidence and has attained prosperity—is very close!

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Furthermore, to achieve economic prosperity, we must put the right vision into practice alongside everything I have described.

Let me put it very simply: **We cannot grow rich by continually selling cheap goods!**

Otherwise, as we are today, we will remain trapped in the category of a “middle-income country,” or even fall further behind as the world advances. What we must do, therefore, is “sell expensive goods”—in other words, sell high-value-added, high-technology products.

Because the present government has no vision in this area, today **high-technology exports account for only 3% of Türkiye's total exports!** We cannot become prosperous as a nation in this way.

That is why we say: science first, production first, prosperity first. Without production, industry, science and technology, a state cannot be strong. A country cannot become great through construction and foreign borrowing alone; its people will not attain prosperity. And without prosperity, there can be no peace in the country, no peace of mind for its people.

To bring prosperity to the country and peace of mind to our people, we must build an economy founded on production, industry, knowledge, science and innovation.

We will make industry and high-technology manufacturing, and production with added value, the backbone of prosperity, employment and development.

We will draw up a **New Industrial Plan** to increase our country's productive strength, technological capacity and ability to compete internationally.

We will make every sector of the economy innovative, efficient and sustainable. Through technological transformation in production, we will produce abundant, high-quality goods. Rising productivity will be the engine of economic growth. And higher productivity is impossible without technological transformation.

As we revive industrial output and raise productivity, we will also establish a predictable and stable macroeconomic environment. We will make our country one in which the rule of law prevails, property rights are guaranteed and trust is justified. We will develop a Türkiye-centered system of value-chain management. We will place our country in a pivotal position within global supply chains. We will create a production network with our neighbors, with Türkiye at its center.

To secure supplies and manage the costs of energy and intermediate goods, we will reorganize domestic networks. We will build the **Anatolian Development Corridor**, linking Anatolia through industrial, logistics, agricultural and energy routes.

We will transform the geography of production. We will build a new economy in which not only the Marmara Region but every region of our country develops through its own strengths. We will restructure every region in accordance with its particular potential, human capital, natural resources and culture of production.

To develop an economy capable of competing globally and providing all our citizens with safe and prosperous lives, we will pursue a well-designed, long-term and consistent policy for science, technology and innovation.

We will launch the **One Million Production Specialists mobilization**. Across Türkiye, we will train a skilled and substantial workforce in advanced manufacturing, automation, robotics, software, chip manufacturing, artificial intelligence and digital production.

To bring production together with science, knowledge and technology, we will align the education curriculum with our goals for digital and green transformation.

We will establish new institutions to carry out our science, technology and innovation policies.

We will establish a **Presidency of Science, Technology and Innovation** to determine long-term priorities and goals in these fields and develop policies consistent with them. We will not drift from one direction to another; we will move forward with a deliberate vision.

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The Türkiye we dream of is a country in which the nation as a whole grows richer, not merely a select group becoming wealthier on paper. It is a country that does not merely grow, but **grows fairly**; a Türkiye where the bread on the people's tables does not shrink as the economy expands.

Because our vision for Türkiye puts people first, our country's growing prosperity will advance hand in hand with social justice. Let me repeat: **We will leave no one behind. We will leave no one hungry or without shelter.**

The Türkiye of our dreams is founded not on selfishness but on solidarity; not on privilege but on fairness; not on plunder but on production.

For our people to enjoy peace and security, we must increase prosperity and share it fairly.

We will put an end to low income and poverty being handed down to future generations as though they were fate or an inheritance.

We will ensure that every citizen has an income sufficient to live securely and with human dignity.

We will ensure that everyone has a minimum income—a **Basic Citizenship Income**—and strong social rights. Neither the Basic Citizenship Income nor the lowest retirement pension will fall below the hunger threshold; both will be set at a level befitting human dignity.

We will establish a transparent, predictable, graduated and fair pension system.

Additional payments made to serving civil servants will also be reflected in the pensions of retired civil servants.

We will also democratize the structure of the **Minimum Wage Determination Commission**, which sets the minimum wage that has effectively become the “average income” of our people. Labor will have a voice, and decision-making processes will be transparent and participatory.

We will not leave anyone dependent on arbitrary and unreliable social assistance. We will implement a comprehensive, citizen-centered, transparent, measurable, sustainable, accountable and participatory social policy.

We succeeded in Istanbul. We **tripled the number of households receiving social assistance**, and we did so through inclusive, equitable practices that respected human dignity.

We will bring our citizens a level of prosperity in which they no longer fear the future, look ahead with trust and hope, and see life as a blessing rather than a burden.

Owning a car or a home, or having a job, will no longer be a “distant dream,” as it is today! Our citizens will not be occupied with merely “surviving”; they will lead lives worthy of human dignity.

Respect for the value of labor is an ancient and deeply rooted principle of this land. We are a nation that has carried through generations the moral teaching of the Prophet Muhammad, who said, **“Pay the worker the wages due to him before his sweat has dried.”** Yet for many years, regrettably, we have fallen far short of this standard. Our dream for Türkiye is of a country that upholds this ethic of labor, places labor—of every kind and at every level—at its center, and ensures that workers receive their full due, on time.

It is a Türkiye that regards sweat and toil, knowledge, skill, creativity and productivity as parts of the same great endeavor of labor.

It is a Türkiye that values the labor of workers, farmers, civil servants, engineers, teachers, healthcare professionals, artists, small tradespeople and entrepreneurs.

In the Türkiye we envision, working people will not have to defend their rights on their own. Trade unions will be strong; the right to organize will be guaranteed; employees will be free to demand **decent wages, safe working conditions and a dignified life**. For where labor is not protected, there can be no justice. Where labor loses its value, prosperity cannot endure.

Continuity note: The last sentence is completed using the opening of printed page 283. The next installment continues with the following paragraph on sharing prosperity throughout society.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 283–286

...to demand decent wages, safe working conditions, and a life of dignity. For there can be no justice where labor is not protected. And prosperity cannot endure where labor is devalued.

We will put an end to wealth being the privilege of a small minority. We will spread prosperity throughout society.

We will establish an order in which those who produce and those who invest while taking risks can earn a return; workers receive their due; hard work is rewarded; young people's labor is not exploited; and women participate in working life on an equal footing and from a position of strength.

We will truly listen to employers and employees alike. We will listen attentively to their problems.

We will once again convene the Economic Council, which has not been functioning for years, on a regular basis, restoring its former pluralistic structure.

These consultations will bring together employers' and producers' organizations, trade unions, and ministers whose responsibilities relate directly to the economy. Everyone will be able to speak freely and with a focus on solutions.

We will launch a National Occupational Safety Mobilization. Workers' health and safety will cease to be a process that exists only on paper.

We will make the Unemployment Insurance Fund a fund for working people once again. We will make it easier for citizens who lose their jobs to qualify for benefits.

We will establish a first-job guarantee model for young people. The moment a young person graduates, they will not be cast into a life of uncertainty.

In Istanbul, we achieved many “firsts” that, at the outset, no one believed possible. We will achieve them across Türkiye as well. We will remember that we are all in the same boat. We will talk, criticize, and listen. Through collective wisdom, we will devise fair solutions for every stakeholder.

We will revive these lands' traditions of charitable foundations, solidarity, philanthropy, and the moral duty to “give back,” in a contemporary spirit.

We will build a Türkiye in which those who prosper remember their debt to society, those who grow strong do not crush the weak, and those who become wealthy contribute to their country.

The Türkiye we dream of is not a country where everyone struggles to save themselves alone. It is a Türkiye where we grow stronger together, produce together, prosper together, and enjoy a better life together.

We will ensure fairness in taxation. We will put our tax structure on a sound footing; the share of consumption taxes, such as value-added tax (VAT) and special consumption tax (SCT), will decline. We will reduce the burden of indirect taxes on our people. At the same time, without ever penalizing investors or raising taxes, we will establish a proper tax system. Everyone will pay a reasonable tax,

fairly and honestly. We will also reduce the tax burden on wage earners. In short, we will establish tax justice. And we will do this without imposing new or additional taxes.

Most importantly, **real wages will rise**. Despite annual pay increases, the money in our people's pockets will no longer be eroded by inflation.

We will also ensure a fair budget. What is a budget? It is the decision about how the taxes you pay—the fruits of your labor—will be used, and according to which priorities.

Today, Türkiye's public finances have been systematically and profoundly undermined by secret appropriations, off-budget funds, off-budget assets, public spending beyond effective oversight, and expenditures hidden behind the shield of “commercial confidentiality.”

The power of the purse will once again rest with Parliament, where **100 percent of our nation** is represented. The budget will be **100 percent transparent**. We will conduct an extensive consultation process when preparing it.

It will be a people-centered budget. We will manage our resources effectively, focusing on our people's health, our children's education, the well-being of pensioners, support for farmers, ensuring that the poorest are not excluded from society, and supporting production.

We will account for every last kuruş we spend from your precious taxes; parliamentary oversight will be strengthened. We will ensure that every kuruş is spent not on waste, ostentation, or pointless investments, but in ways that expand our future opportunities.

Every kuruş of tax you pay to this state through your labor—whether income tax, VAT, SCT, or social insurance contributions—will return to you and your children in the form of education, healthcare, better employment and food on the table, better pensions: in short, a better life. **Together we will write our economic constitution.**

We will launch a great nationwide economic mobilization for Türkiye, bringing together workers, farmers, industrialists, tradespeople, entrepreneurs, trade unions, cooperatives, academics, young people, women, local governments, and professional organizations.

We will combine planning with freedom of enterprise, public-minded reasoning with the creativity of the market, and social justice with productive capacity.

Neither arbitrary state intervention, nor an unregulated system of plunder, nor an economy sustained solely by debt, nor a model of growth that distributes privileges to a favored few. Our objective is to build an economy that is productive, fair, free, sustainable, and capable of competing with the world.

Drawing on a great collective wisdom, and guided by the right vision, we will decisively implement every necessary structural reform and chart Türkiye's new course of development.

In the Republic's second century, together with our nation, we will achieve the great Turkish miracle, the great economic leap forward!

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But structural reforms and a sound economic vision alone are not enough to achieve this great Turkish miracle. We also need a strong society united around the same goal, a powerful sense of unity and solidarity, and social peace.

The Türkiye we dream of will not be one that fights over identities and differences. It will be a country where people can live openly in accordance with their identities, without fear or concealment, without asserting superiority over others or trampling on anyone else's rights. We will build a Türkiye in which everyone regards themselves as an equal and dignified citizen of this country.

This country will live at peace with its own history and the diversity of its society. It will be a Türkiye that does not deny its past, does not ignore its suffering, and regards its differences as a source of richness rather than a threat. We will build a Türkiye that is not at war with itself.

Until now, many have tried to stretch barbed wire between us. They have tried to erect walls between our neighborhoods, identities, faiths, and ways of life. They wanted to accustom us to regarding one another with suspicion, fearing one another, and becoming deaf to one another's suffering.

In truth, they did not succeed. There is no barbed wire, no wall, in the heart of our nation. But if even the smallest stretch of barbed wire remains anywhere, we will tear it out. **We will tear down every wall.**

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As I said, “We will tear down every wall.” Here, I would also like to say a few words about the Kurdish question.

First, as someone who knows his nation well, let me say this: contrary to what some would have us believe, there are no walls or barbed-wire fences in our people's hearts. The people of Anatolia are the people who inspired Rumi. The venerable Mevlânâ gave voice, on these lands, to love, tolerance, and the cause of humanity; even today, he remains a light to all humankind.

Across a thousand years of Anatolian history, and through the succession of our traditions of statehood—from the Seljuks to the Ottomans to the Republic of Türkiye—we have shared a profound common destiny. As millions of citizens have migrated throughout Türkiye, from Anatolia to Thrace, east to west, north to south, Turkish and Kurdish lives have become closely interwoven. That coexistence has also become a bond of family: in our country we have witnessed, and continue to witness, millions of marriages between Turks and Kurds. It is not only a shared social life, history, and everyday existence. Family unity, in its most sacred form, is also among the strongest foundations of these lands. As in my own immediate family, all 86 million of us are witnesses to this reality. And beyond all this, we also share a strong bond of faith and culture and, at its heart, a great common civilization.

Atatürk, too, described this in his definition of a “nation”: **“Having accomplished great things together in the past, having shared sorrows and joys, and continuing the will to live together in the future.”**

The great miracle, the great revolution, of our Republic is **equality before the law**. Everyone, regardless of their faith or ethnic origin, is equal before the law. Everyone has the same rights. Together with secularism, this essential principle has been a defining feature distinguishing our country from countries of the Middle East. Through the Republic, we rooted out of our collective spirit the model of endless chaos and collapse known as the “Lebanon model”! For that very reason, it would be wholly wrong to enact separate laws based on faith or ethnic origin and establish a system built on collective privileges granted according to identity. Dividing citizens according to their identities and making separate legal arrangements for them will not solve our problems. It will create even greater problems that we may never be able to resolve. We must not turn our country into a country of ethnic or religious communities.

Yet we must also heed the grievance voiced by a significant proportion of our Kurdish citizens. What is that grievance? They say: **“Equality that goes no further than equality before the law does not allow us to keep our language and culture alive as we wish, or to preserve and develop our identity.”**

Continuity note: The quoted grievance begins at the end of printed page 286 and concludes in the opening line of page 287. The next installment will resume with the paragraph that follows.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 287–290

To become one nation together and to make our land a homeland for all of us, we must understand this grievance well. Of course, Turkish is the official language of the Republic of Türkiye and its language of education; this is one of the fundamental characteristics of our state and cannot be a matter for dispute. Yet the existence of our common official language does not prevent us from discussing, on democratic ground, our citizens' demands to keep their own language, culture, and identity alive.

Undoubtedly, the dismantling of the terrorist organization is the foremost step. But the Kurdish question is not merely a security issue. It cannot be resolved solely by dissolving a terrorist organization. The Kurdish question is also a matter of rights and freedoms in the context of democracy, and a matter of receiving a fair share of development in the context of the economy. This government, which exploits even the security dimension of the question for shallow, short-term electoral calculations and has a dismal record on democracy and the economy, cannot resolve the Kurdish question. The solution is not the "Lebanon model," as this government increasingly appears to desire! The real keys to a solution are the most advanced, contemporary, universal human rights standards and pluralist democracy.

Within this framework, the first and most important pillar of resolving the Kurdish question is to reinforce equal citizenship. Let us strengthen our national unity by reinforcing equal citizenship; let us deepen our national solidarity, the conscience we share in our hearts, and our common dreams.

Let us recognize the right of all the valued citizens of our beautiful country to preserve and develop their languages and identities, and provide them with the means to do so. This is a contemporary, universal human right.

Let us open the way for Kurdish to be taught in more classes and for longer periods in our schools, and for Kurdish history and literature to be studied.

I have spoken sincerely about this myself: I am making an effort to learn Kurdish. Sometimes, when embracing my fellow citizens in Istanbul, I feel saddened when I cannot understand what an elderly woman says to me. That is why I am learning it: so that not even the smallest wall remains between one heart and another...

In essence, we resolve the Kurdish question by strengthening equal citizenship within our country, deepening our brotherhood in our region, and increasing prosperity throughout our country and our region.

I have spoken about equal citizenship. Strengthening our bonds of brotherhood in our region is also critically important for regional peace and our security. Kurds in Iraq and Kurds in Syria alike should feel assured of our brotherhood.

The third pillar of a solution is increasing prosperity, both within our country and across our region. Türkiye is a great country. A Türkiye that has established a modern, pluralist democracy, the rule of law, and freedom, and has resolved the Kurdish question, will be greater and stronger still. It will

become the North Star of our region.

Türkiye is one whole. If Istanbul, Bursa, and the Marmara region develop while Van, Diyarbakır, and Şanlıurfa fail to receive the share of that development to which they are entitled, the will to remain one united Türkiye is weakened. Sadly, over 24 years, this government has taken no concrete and comprehensive steps to redress inequalities between regions.

Justice is not a matter confined to the courts. Justice means distributing prosperity to every corner of our beautiful country. It means working, producing, earning, and sharing as a nation. We will raise prosperity to a level where everyone living in our country can feel its benefits.

To these three fundamental pillars of a solution we must add a fourth—one that is indispensable and of the utmost importance: democracy, freedom, and justice for all 86 million people.

The profound problems of democracy, freedom, and justice in our country today affect our entire nation. Without resolving them, no other problem can be resolved.

That is why I say this plainly: this government can never resolve this issue. It cannot be handled as a strategy for winning elections. Unfortunately, the government is approaching it today without sincerity.

A commission was established in the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye. I was, in fact, the first politician to propose setting up such a commission. My party, too, joined it with the intention of contributing constructively. But after months of work, what emerged from the commission's report?

These were its recommendations: press freedom and freedom of expression should be strengthened; trial without detention should be the rule; the system of appointing trustees should be abandoned; and the judgments of the Constitutional Court and the European Court of Human Rights should be implemented scrupulously!

As though they were mocking our intelligence... All these principles are already in our Constitution! It is this government that refuses to put them into practice!

It is this very government that appoints trustees everywhere. It is this same government that fails to implement, and refuses to respect, the judgments of the Constitutional Court and the European Court of Human Rights; that has journalists, comedians, politicians, and young people arrested! It is this government that has hundreds of people, including elected mayors, imprisoned without a shred of evidence. And it is this government that continues to hold Kurdish politicians, above all Selahattin Demirtaş, hostage in prison to this day...

Let me go further. As you know, another case was brought against me and some of my colleagues over the "Urban Consensus" (*Kent Uzlaşısı*). What was our supposed crime? **"Ensuring the election of Kurdish candidates in western cities who otherwise could not have been elected."** Imagine that as a crime! I am not making it up; that is what the prosecution wrote.

So I repeat: the government is insincere and can never resolve this issue. For at its heart this is an issue of democracy, freedom, equality, and justice. Those who approach it as an electoral strategy swiftly return to their true nature once elections are over.

Our nation will make its greatest leap forward in a Türkiye where our national unity is secure, the indivisible integrity and unitary structure of our country are safeguarded, and every citizen feels free and equal.

What we need is to crown the Republic with democracy, and we will succeed. We achieved this in a city with the largest Kurdish population in Türkiye. We will achieve it throughout our country as well.

A democratic resolution of the Kurdish question will not only strengthen Türkiye's domestic peace. Across the region stretching from Syria to Iraq, it will also enhance Türkiye's security, diplomatic influence, and contribution to regional peace. It will help secure peace in the Middle East and, through that, our national security.

The vision entrusted to us by Atatürk, the founder of our Republic—**"Sovereignty belongs unconditionally to the nation"** and **"Peace at home, peace in the world"**—will remain our unwavering compass.

For many years our nation has endured great suffering. Over the past 40 years, we have also lost tens of thousands of martyrs to terrorism. I feel and share the pain of all the mothers who have lost their children on this soil. Without denying that suffering, and with respect for it, our greatest duty will be to carry our country toward a future without suffering, bloodshed, tears, or the loss of more lives as martyrs.

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We said we would tear down every wall within our country. We will also tear down the walls built between Türkiye and the world. We will make this country cease to be one that has withdrawn into itself, afraid of its own people and of the world.

Our dream for Türkiye is one of a great embrace: Türkiye rediscovering itself, in all its history, geography, nature, and social and cultural fabric. It is the dream of reconciliation, of finding common ground, of rebuilding the will to live together.

Our dream for Türkiye is a new partnership in which no one claims superiority over anyone else; no one is treated as lesser, greater, acceptable, or illegitimate because of their ethnic origin, faith, or ideology; and everyone is regarded as a rightful owner of and stakeholder in this country.

We will build this partnership together. Because Türkiye will become truly strong, truly free, and truly great only when it is at peace with all its children.

May I tell you something? Tearing down walls cannot be achieved simply through commissions, laws, or dogma—although those things, too, must of course be pursued sincerely. I was the first politician to say this out loud, and I stand by every word!

Türkiye will attain whatever the highest standards of human rights in the modern democratic world demand—for every single one of its citizens! But real change comes through love, sincerity, and embracing one another. Sometimes the smallest human gesture can break down a wall more effectively than any bulldozer. And this embrace must begin at the very top of the state. A president who regards those who do not vote for him almost as "enemies" cannot accomplish it. Even if he passes a hundred laws, he still cannot. It will never take root. Insincere paint will simply wash away.

This will be our greatest responsibility: to be the President of all 86 million people, with all their differences; to treat all 86 million equally; to love and embrace all 86 million with the same sincerity.

Our 16 million fellow Istanbulites can bear witness that we did this in Istanbul. No one forced us to. We did not do it merely because it was our “duty.” We did it because it came from within us. We did it because we carry love for human beings in our hearts.

Our hearts are large enough to hold every one of the 86 million—every child, every woman and man, every elder and young person. We will not exclude a single person. We will listen attentively to all 86 million; if even one person says they do not feel equal, that will become our greatest concern. This is the greatest promise we can make to you.

Continuity note: The final paragraph is completed with the opening lines of printed page 291. The next installment begins after this paragraph, with the passage on living in harmony with nature.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED

The Türkiye I Dream Of

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 291–294

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Not only will our people make peace with one another; all of us will also make peace with nature.

By the grace of God, we have the most beautiful country in the world. Our greatest responsibility is to protect its incomparable natural environment for our grandchildren's grandchildren.

Environmental policy will be among our highest priorities. In the Türkiye we envision, our cities will be livable. We will not be held captive by concrete, profiteering or unplanned development. We will bring together cities and agriculture, people and nature, and development and sustainability.

We will build a country where everyone has access to clean water, clean air, safe food, green spaces, culture, art and a good life. Because this nation has the right to live well.

In the Türkiye we envision, cities will once again be built for people. We will create cities where children play safely, older people walk in peace, young people can breathe freely, women move about without fear, and everyone feels they belong. We will expand green spaces everywhere in our cities.

We will live in harmony with nature. We will love it. We will cherish the world's most beautiful country and its most beautiful natural environment as the apple of our eye.

We will cherish our olive groves.

We will protect our forests from fires by anticipating the risks posed by climate change.

Knowing that water is among the most precious resources of the twenty-first century, we will safeguard every water source as the apple of our eye.

We will never allow projects of environmental destruction such as Kanal Istanbul to go ahead!

We will understand nature; we will grasp what it is telling us. We will take seriously the truths revealed by floods, fires, droughts and earthquakes.

The Türkiye we dream of is a Türkiye that lives as one with its soil, water, air, trees, seas, animals and people.

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By protecting our natural environment, we will also protect our food security. Indeed, agricultural reform will be one of our most important reforms.

When our people are asked today about the most important problem affecting their lives, they answer: access to affordable, good-quality food. Think about it. In twenty-first-century Türkiye, they have drained the abundance from a fertile country that was once self-sufficient, where food was said to be “cheaper than water”!

In twenty-first-century Türkiye under AKP rule, our people's foremost concern is being able to eat enough to survive. In twenty-first-century Türkiye, millions live on the brink of hunger. Their concern is not living well or eating healthily. It is simply eating enough to stay alive.

Mothers and fathers struggle to provide their children with the sufficient, balanced nutrition they need to grow up healthy. What a dreadful state we have reached! We have millions of pensioners, low-income citizens and unemployed people who have long since given up even dreaming of meat, chicken, fruit, vegetables or cheese. Millions of mothers and fathers are distressed because they cannot buy cheese and eggs for their children. There are grandmothers and grandfathers who cannot buy chocolates for their grandchildren even on religious holidays. How did we come to this? All because of the government's mismanagement...

In the Türkiye of our dreams, there will be abundance and plenty! All 86 million will not merely have enough to eat: they will eat well. They will be able to nourish themselves in a manner worthy of human dignity. Children will eat well and healthily, and they will thrive. After a lifetime of work, people will not have to count every last kuruş in old age just to fill their stomachs! They will be able to enjoy good food.

We will devote substantial resources to developing agriculture, supporting our farmers and revitalizing our villages. Agriculture will be one of the most important items in our budget!

By restoring village life and providing the necessary infrastructure, we will encourage younger generations not to abandon their villages—and even to choose village life over city life. Our human resources will grow stronger.

We will raise the educational attainment of our farmers. This is essential for effective and productive agriculture. We will provide farmers with every form of support they need. Agriculture is vital to a country's strength and independence.

Through a **“Production Model with Guaranteed Purchase,”** we will not leave producers at the mercy of the market. Even before sowing their seeds, farmers will be able to lock in their selling prices transparently through futures transactions on commodity exchanges. Moreover, because agriculture is a difficult and vulnerable sector, it is sustained by substantial incentives everywhere in the world. Support for agriculture is the largest item in the European Union's budget.

We will strengthen coordination in production, encourage producer associations and reduce the number of intermediaries; food will become cheaper.

Our agricultural teams have prepared dozens of reforms. I cannot set them all out at length here, but I can say this much: in the Türkiye of our dreams, our farmers, our citizens engaged in animal husbandry, and every citizen living in our villages will enjoy an entirely new standard of life and prosperity!

We know that, in today's world, a country without food security, a country unable to meet its own food needs, can never be independent!

In the Türkiye of our dreams, we will guarantee food security for our entire nation.

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Now I want to speak about perhaps the most important subject of all: **justice!** In the Türkiye of our dreams, justice will come before everything else! Justice for everyone!

Justice is the foundation of the state. This is not merely a fine saying; it is the essence of the very idea of the state. The state is legitimate only insofar as it is just: the exercise of state power is legitimate only when founded upon justice. A just state is also indispensable to social peace. Without justice, the foundations of the state are shaken. Without the rule of law, it is power rather than rights, and tyranny rather than conscience, that prevail in society.

Today, Türkiye suffers from two great forms of poverty: **economic poverty and a poverty of justice.** Economic poverty crushes the livelihoods, labor and futures of millions of our people. A poverty of justice destroys the nation's trust in the state, its sense of living together and its faith in the law.

These two forms of poverty are directly connected. Where there is no justice, there can be no prosperity! **Justice or misery!**

Türkiye is unjust today. Trust in the institutions of justice has been gravely wounded. There are enormous courtrooms and imposing courthouses, but citizens do not believe they will find justice inside those buildings. This is one of the greatest calamities that can befall a country.

At least **80 percent of society** does not trust the justice system. What could be more terrifying than that? Türkiye has never thirsted for justice as desperately as it does today. We will quench that thirst. In the Türkiye of our dreams, justice will return.

Judges will be independent. They will not be afraid, they will not take instructions, and they will decide cases according to the files before them and their consciences. If they render an unwelcome judgment, their case will not be taken away from them, nor will they be transferred to another city.

Prosecutors will protect the interests of the public and the law—not those of particular circles, vested interests or political calculations. The judiciary will cease to be an instrument for eliminating the government's opponents. We will establish a genuine system of justice that protects citizens' rights.

The door to our dream opens with justice. We will undertake a major reform of the judiciary. We will free the judiciary from political tutelage. We will make the courts worthy of trust. We will end corruption in the judiciary; we will shut down the “marketplaces” in which millions of dollars change hands within the justice system. When citizens go to court, they will encounter not the wrath of the state but the scales of law and conscience.

Justice first, freedom first, democracy first: that is what we have said, and what we will continue to say. The countries that will be strong in this new world are those that secure the consent of their people, set their citizens free, and mobilize the knowledge and energy of all their citizens around a shared purpose.

Countries like ours, where injustice prevails, much of the population is excluded and embittered, and the nation's peace is destroyed, cannot be strong in this changing world.

Both because we deserve it and because we want our country to be strong, we will make our citizens free and our nation secure and at peace. For that reason, we will say: freedom first, democracy first. And because we believe the world should turn around justice, we will say: justice first.

To establish justice swiftly, we will make the **rule of law and the supremacy of law** prevail.

Continuity note: The following paragraph, beginning with measures to free the judiciary from executive interference, starts on printed page 295 and will open the next installment.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 295–298

We will free the judiciary from the executive's grip and ensure its independence and impartiality. Through reform of the Council of Judges and Prosecutors (HSK), we will establish judicial independence on a structural basis. We will ensure that a majority of HSK members are elected by Parliament and by senior legal professionals and judges.

The Minister of Justice will no longer chair the HSK; a politician will no longer hold the fate of every judge in their hands.

We will introduce guarantees of case assignment and geographical tenure for judges and prosecutors. Anyone with a political background will be barred from entering the judicial profession.

We will end the dominant role of interviews in recruitment to the profession and prevent politically motivated staffing.

We will ensure that members of the Constitutional Court are elected by a qualified majority in Parliament; they will no longer all be selected by a single individual, as is the case today.

We will multiply the number of women serving in all the judiciary's key institutions—in the HSK, the Constitutional Court, the Supreme Election Council (YSK), the Court of Accounts, the Court of Cassation and the Council of State. The absence of women from our Constitutional Court today is a disgrace. Yet this country has tremendously accomplished women judges, prosecutors, lawyers and academics. This is unworthy of a modern Türkiye!

Just as we say justice first, we will say freedom first.

First and foremost, we will bring to an end the climate of a “state of emergency” in which we have lived for years, and return to the rule of law.

We will introduce the necessary measures to secure the release of those arrested and convicted for their political activities, for expressing their views or for criticizing those in power. There will be no more “prisoners of conscience” in our prisons.

We will make pretrial detention an exceptional measure and put an end to citizens being taken from their homes or workplaces by law enforcement except in cases where they are caught in the act of committing an offense.

We will remove the offense of “insulting the President” entirely from our Penal Code. Every citizen will be free to criticize politicians: a politician's duty is not to silence criticism, but to listen to it.

We will reinstate all those dismissed by emergency decrees (KHKs) who have been acquitted by independent courts.

We will do everything in our power to make Turkish politics genuinely pluralistic. We will put an end to the treatment of social and political opposition as “sedition and mischief,” and to accusations of treason directed against it. We will recognize as legitimate every idea, organization and political

party that does not advocate violence.

Conversely, we will also end the prevailing impunity in certain areas. We will establish a justice system that prevents every form of violence against women, children and animals, protects victims, and ensures that perpetrators cannot escape accountability before the law.

Just as we say justice first and freedom first, we will say democracy first. To make our state a state governed by the rule of law once again, we will fully establish the separation of powers. The legislative, executive and judicial branches will be distinct from one another.

Despite the excessively high electoral threshold, the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye remains the institution in which our nation is most broadly represented. We will restore Parliament to the center of Turkish politics and once again make it the foundation of the national will.

We will also ensure that Parliament properly fulfills its oversight function. Ministers and the bureaucracy will once again be subject to parliamentary scrutiny.

Whether or not we secure the number of parliamentary seats required for a constitutional amendment, we will pursue cooperation and compromise with other parties to the fullest possible extent and, with our nation's approval, secure the transition to a **Democratic Parliamentary System** founded on a genuine separation of powers.

We will put an end to the Presidential Government System.

We will end the practice of governing the country through presidential decrees issued by one person—a practice that has destroyed predictability in our country and made the administration of the state dependent on one individual's will rather than on institutions and rules.

We will close the policy councils operating under the Presidency and transfer their functions to the relevant ministries and institutions.

We will restore decision-making through collective wisdom within the executive, as in the past. All appointments to state positions will be subject to decisions reached through collective judgment and to scrutiny based on merit.

Starting with ourselves, we will firmly establish a **two-term limit** within the executive!

Political parties are indispensable institutions of democracy. The judicial attacks carried out against political parties today, and especially against the CHP, are unacceptable. Political parties are the organized expression and voice of different opinions within society. We will respect that voice. Political parties will be able to develop freely.

We will undertake a modern reform of political financing, one of the most important conditions of clean politics. Politics, moreover, must not be used to divide society continually into opposing camps, turn people into enemies of one another, or treat a rival as something to be destroyed. **Politics is the art of building a shared life.**

We may have different programs, different priorities and different proposals for solutions. But we must never forget that we are citizens of the same country, that we share the same future and that

we are all in the same boat. Türkiye needs a politics that encourages dialogue rather than enmity; unites rather than divides; and inspires hope rather than fear.

In the Türkiye I dream of, politics is not a battlefield but a democratic forum in which collective wisdom and a shared future are built. Parliament, political parties, elections and the ballot box are all institutions through which that common purpose is expressed. We will restore these institutions.

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And, of course, we will initiate a great process of social consensus for comprehensive **constitutional reform**. Türkiye will cross a new threshold in its constitutional development, a history extending back at least to 1808. From the Charter of Alliance (*Sened-i İttifak*) to the Tanzimat reforms, from the constitutional-monarchy eras to the Republic, and from multiparty political life to the present, we will crown our constitutional quest—which has suffered a grave reversal under the Presidential Government System—with a modern, democratic, pluralistic and freedom-oriented constitution.

This will not be the constitution of one person, one party or one government. It will be **the nation's constitution**.

Through broad consensus and the participation of every segment of society, we will realize our dream of a modern constitution.

Our Parliament will regain its dignity. The people's Assembly will again become the center of the people's will. We will establish a Parliament that exercises oversight, debates, legislates, demands accountability and produces collective wisdom.

The Grand National Assembly of Türkiye is the one institution in which all the voices, all the colors and all the views of our country are represented. That is why it is so precious.

In the Türkiye we envision, Parliament will once again be the people's parliament. We want a Parliament in which the national will is genuinely expressed, different views can be freely voiced, oversight functions and collective wisdom is forged. We will build not a Türkiye in which Parliament has been rendered powerless and politics imprisoned within the decisions of a narrow circle, but one in which the people's voice and will occupy the center.

This grotesque, dangerous, antidemocratic **“one-man system”**—the Presidential Government System—will come to an end! Türkiye does not need limitless authority concentrated in a single person; it needs an effective but accountable executive. We will establish a system of government that can take swift decisions while remaining bound by law, that is strong yet subject to oversight, that delivers results yet answers for its actions.

Democracy is not merely going to the ballot box from one election to the next; indeed, even elections are now in danger. Democracy is a system in which citizens participate in every sphere of life. As citizens participate, they become more aware; as they become more aware, they assume responsibility; and as they assume responsibility, they become masters of their own destiny.

Participation means citizens becoming politically engaged, governing themselves, making collective decisions and sharing responsibility. In Türkiye, we will build a powerful democratic culture rising from the grassroots upward, rather than one dominated by the state's top-down hegemony.

We have all the experience we need to do so. We know that local governments are among the most fundamental arenas in which democracy operates. We have seen, lived and felt this through our own experience. In municipalities, neighborhoods, public squares, city councils and solidarity networks, we have seen the tremendous energy generated when people take part in decision-making not only at election time but at all times.

Türkiye will democratize from the local level toward the center. We will build a new system of participation extending from neighborhoods to cities, from cities to Parliament, and from Parliament to the state. Citizens will become active participants, not merely people who are governed; problem-solvers, not merely complainants; partners in their country's future, not merely voters.

And we know something else very well: **constitutions exist to protect citizens' freedoms and fundamental rights, and to limit those in power.**

Continuity note: The next paragraph, beginning on printed page 299, develops this principle. The passage above ends at the close of printed page 298.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English translation · Original printed pages 299–302

A constitution must safeguard freedom and guarantee universal human rights. Through an effective separation of powers and mechanisms of checks and balances, it must not leave an entire nation at the mercy of one person.

What did the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen say more than two hundred years ago? **“A society in which the separation of powers is not established has no constitution.”**

Our system has no separation of powers. That is why fundamental human rights and freedoms cannot be protected: what protects human rights and freedoms is not a collection of “ornamental provisions,” but a judiciary capable of making decisions independently of political authority.

While we are on the subject, let me remind you of something else: genuine democratic constitutional reform can be undertaken only by a government that has truly embraced democracy and is at peace with the founding vision of our Republic.

A government that, only nine years ago, introduced the concentration of powers through the worst constitutional amendment in the Republic's history; a government that has effectively occupied the main opposition party and installed a puppet trustee; a government that has appointed trustees to dozens of municipalities; a government that has thrown dozens of opposition mayors and municipal officials, along with the opposition's presidential candidate, into prison—such a government will not, **cannot**, carry out democratization! Constitutions drawn up by authoritarian governments are invariably designed to entrench, prolong and reinforce their own power.

A few token “liberal” provisions are added to the constitutional package in attractive wrapping, but the real objective is to prolong and strengthen the government's hold on power by one means or another. And when the time comes, those supposedly “liberal” provisions are never applied! I warn you: let no one fall for these fairy tales!

Do you realize the danger? I ask you once again: **Do you truly realize the danger?**

The government that brought the “one-man regime” to our country in 2017 is now, in 2026, seeking to make it permanent. It is seeking to establish a “sultanate,” a “dynasty.” As their own mentors told them: the Republic, democracy, human rights and freedoms are too much for your people; you would do better to return to the sultanate...

They are bent on silencing the opposition, every dissenting voice, journalists and young people, and throwing them into prison. They have appointed a trustee to the main opposition party and effectively occupied it!

Do you really grasp what is happening? Let me repeat: **They have effectively occupied the main opposition party—the founding party of the Republic of Türkiye, the party founded by Atatürk!**

As the opposition's presidential candidate, I stand before you in this courtroom today. My colleagues and I are in prison on the strength of utterly absurd accusations.

This government has rendered our Constitution null and void and is also striving to obliterate our democratic history, our culture and our national sovereignty!

Those in power are attempting a transition to a new and pitch-dark regime. Everyone must wake up. Everyone must see the danger clearly!

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There is one final, extremely important field I want to address: **our country's foreign policy and national security.**

Do not be taken in by the propaganda broadcast around the clock on dozens of government-controlled television channels. Our country is in a deeply alarming situation in this field as well.

We have a foreign policy devoid of transparency. We do not know who controls it, or in whose hands command actually rests!

Because controlling one individual is far easier than controlling parliaments, state institutions and thousands of competent public servants, none of us knows where our foreign policy and our relationships with other countries are heading, why particular actions are being taken or whose interests they serve. We do not know what threats may await us in the future. Everything unfolds behind closed doors, without accountability to the nation...

The world is once again changing at extraordinary speed. And it is not only the global economy and trade that are changing.

The international order built after the Second World War is changing too. Alliances between states are giving way to new ones. Uncertainty and the absence of rules dominate global politics.

Military conflicts and the potential for conflict are increasing. As force is used ever more frequently in relations between states, the technologies and methods of warfare are also changing.

Wars fought on conventional front lines are giving way to missile systems, cyberattacks, unmanned aerial vehicles, space technologies and artificial-intelligence-supported hybrid warfare. Security must now also be ensured along energy routes, in data centers, at ports, in financial systems and across digital networks.

The world is going through an unprecedented period of **“multiple crises.”** Today the international system is not merely unstable; it is also unjust and lawless.

The climate crisis, migration pressures, income inequality, energy security, water and food problems, the growing fragility of democracies and the rise of authoritarian tendencies affect all humanity. The gap between countries that possess technology and those that do not is widening here too.

Periods of great uncertainty and transition in international relations also offer nations important opportunities to set new goals and make great advances. That is precisely why Türkiye faces a historic choice.

Either we become a country that turns inward, erodes its institutions, loses legal certainty and merely struggles to get through each day... Or, in the Republic's second century, we build a Türkiye that strengthens its democracy, restores its institutions, produces advanced technology and has a voice in world affairs through a strong military and strong diplomacy. **I stand for the second path.** I believe in Türkiye's potential.

I believe this nation possesses the accumulated knowledge and capacity to establish once again a state—and a foreign policy—that inspires confidence, is predictable, strong and respected. Türkiye is not merely a country situated amid crises. It is also a unique strategic hub linking Europe, the Black Sea, the Mediterranean, the Middle East, the Caucasus and Central Asia.

A Türkiye governed properly will not simply create prosperity for its own citizens. It will be a force for peace, stability, development and democratic hope throughout its region.

That is the Türkiye we will build in the Republic's second century.

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We will once again make Türkiye a respected, strong and trustworthy country—a country that helps set the direction of events.

We will conduct foreign policy not with bombastic rhetoric but with reason, knowledge, merit and a strategic understanding of statecraft.

Türkiye's foreign policy objective in the Republic's second century is clear: to be a democratic power that safeguards its national independence, brings prosperity to its citizens, promotes peace in its region and enjoys high standing in the world.

Once again, the citizen—the human being—will be at the center of our foreign policy. Foreign policy is not simply a matter of relations between states. It is a public policy that directly affects citizens' security, jobs, incomes, the standing of their passports and their futures. Under our government, therefore, foreign policy will become an instrument of development: one that attracts investment, increases production, creates employment, reduces energy costs, expands trade networks and makes it easier for citizens to connect with the world.

Likewise, our citizens and our brothers and sisters of Turkish origin living across the world will no longer be treated as second-class members of the family anywhere. They will receive the equal and dignified treatment they deserve. We will fundamentally change the mentality that regards them as material for domestic politics and develop policies that enable them to serve as bridges of friendship between the countries where they live and Türkiye.

Türkiye will once again become a predictable country. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs, with its institutional capacity, merit-based system and ability to plan strategically, will once again become a center of sound statecraft. Foreign policy will be conducted through institutions, not personal

relationships.

Parliament's oversight role in foreign policy will be strengthened. Transparency and accountability will be our guiding principles.

We Will Establish a Strong Partnership with Europe

Türkiye's direction is toward democracy, the rule of law and the goal of contemporary civilization. That is why we will revive the goal of membership in the **European Union**.

As we all know, our accession process has been in the “deep freeze” for years—indeed, the reality is worse: as our democracy has deteriorated, we have moved further away from that goal with every passing day.

Under our government, Türkiye will achieve membership of the European Union. Because EU membership is not simply a foreign policy preference; it is also an objective encompassing democracy, the rule of law, economic prosperity and institutional excellence.

Continuity note: The discussion of EU membership continues on printed page 303. The next installment will begin with that page's opening paragraph.

CHAPTER NINE — CONTINUED *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 303–306

Moreover, this is not merely a question of membership. Today, our country is missing many valuable opportunities. Because of the deterioration of our democracy, we cannot modernize our Customs Union with the European Union, even though our industry urgently needs it. Nor can we secure visa-free travel for our people.

Yet all of these things are entirely achievable. Under our government, we will accomplish them swiftly. We will modernize our Customs Union with the EU and broaden its scope. We will secure visa-free travel to Europe.

We will make Türkiye not a country waiting at Europe's doorstep, but an important part of Europe and one of the countries shaping its future.

Türkiye will help Europe become a more universal, more pluralistic, and more globally engaged union. In doing so, we will also strengthen Europe's global influence.

You will see: under our government, Türkiye will not merely join Europe; it will become a leading country in Europe!

We will firmly maintain our NATO membership and our place within the Western alliance. But we will do so not as passive participants, but with an approach that helps set the direction.

Our nearly eighty years of membership in the Council of Europe are a guarantee that our legal system remains aligned with shared democratic standards. Unfortunately, because of democratic backsliding, our country today has the status of a country “under the monitoring procedure” at the Council of Europe. This is unworthy of Türkiye!

Under our government, Türkiye will once again be one of the Council of Europe's strong and respected voices.

Türkiye will vigorously defend its national interests and safeguard its strategic autonomy, while also being a powerful part of the democratic world.

We Will Pursue a Multidimensional and Balanced Foreign Policy

Our strong position within the Western alliance does not mean reducing foreign policy to a single axis. Türkiye's geostrategic position, its accumulated experience over centuries, and its cultural depth give us a wider, unique perspective.

We will therefore develop our relations with Central Asia, the Turkic world, the Caucasus, the Middle East, Russia, China, Africa, the Balkans, and the countries of the Global South on the basis of mutual respect, equality, and shared interests. We will establish deep bonds of empathy and cooperation with the peoples of those regions.

We will do all this not through grandstanding, nostalgia, or a desire to dominate, but through mutual respect, shared prosperity, the principle of peace, and common aspirations. We will pursue it not as an “ideological” undertaking, but on a strategic foundation rooted in our country's paramount interests.

In this new era, Türkiye will be a country that resolves crises rather than magnifying them; builds dialogue rather than generating tensions; facilitates rather than polarizes; and develops its capacity for mediation rather than deepening conflicts.

Türkiye is uniquely capable of connecting East and West, North and South, Europe and Asia, its region and the wider world. Türkiye will become a center of peace. It will be a country that uses its strength for development and for humanity.

Türkiye's greatest strength is not merely its military capacity. Its real strength lies in its history, geography, culture, democratic experience, and people. Thanks to the founding vision of the Republic, Türkiye can inspire its entire region.

If our country has been spared sectarian and ethnic strife, that is thanks to the fundamental freedoms introduced with the Republic—freedom of religion, conscience, and expression—and to secularism.

Secularism is the guarantee that people of different faiths and denominations can live together in peace. Just look at the countries of the Middle East that have failed to establish this: they have yet to escape chaos, bloodshed, and conflict!

To help turn the Middle East from chaos toward peace, we will become a guiding North Star that inspires the entire region. We know the value of our Republic, and by inspiring others through the ideal of the Republic of Türkiye—by leading through example—we will restore Türkiye's soft power.

Through our democracy, science, education, culture, productive capacity, and understanding of the social state, we will once again become a source of inspiration in our region. We will work to protect and strengthen democratic values everywhere.

Türkiye Will Play an Active Role in the Global Order

As a new world order takes shape, Türkiye will have a seat at the table.

We will have a voice on every critical issue, from the climate crisis to the governance of artificial intelligence, and from energy security to reform of global trade.

We will take an active role in areas such as United Nations reform, international tax justice, migration management, combating global inequalities, trade policy, and ethical rules for digital technologies.

Türkiye will not be a country that merely watches developments unfold; it will propose solutions and help set the course. For our goal is a democratic, productive, strong, self-confident, respected Türkiye whose voice carries weight in the world.

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Alongside foreign policy, national security will be among our highest priorities. Here, too, we will establish a vision of a strong state.

A strong state rests on strong institutions. A strong state rests on a strong economy. But a strong state also requires powerful and credible defensive capabilities.

We will treat Türkiye's national security not as a matter belonging to one political party, but as a matter of our state's deep-rooted tradition and our nation's highest interests.

We will approach national security comprehensively. We will build a state structure resilient not only to military threats but also to cyberattacks, irregular migration, organized crime, threats to energy security, disinformation, economic vulnerabilities, and social polarization. For security means more than protecting borders. It means ensuring that citizens can live in peace. It means protecting justice. It means strengthening social unity.

We will strengthen the Turkish Armed Forces once again on the foundations of high discipline, merit, and professionalism. We will eliminate the harmful influence of politics over the armed forces while making parliamentary oversight by the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye effective.

We will reinforce institutional traditions. We will restructure the system of military education to meet the needs of our age.

We will build a modern military capable of advanced operations on land, at sea, in the air, in space, and in cyberspace, and one that has kept pace with technological transformation.

We will ensure border security without compromise. We will fight illegal migration and human-smuggling networks effectively.

We will make cybersecurity capacity one of the fundamental pillars of national security.

We Will Make a Leap Forward in the Defense Industry

This is not solely a matter of security. It is also technology policy. It is industrial policy. It is development policy.

We will carry forward the accumulated achievements of our defense industry, built collectively by our nation. We will administer it as a field of national capability of which we can all be proud, and shape it into a structure that responds rapidly to the needs of the Turkish Armed Forces, reduces dependence on foreign suppliers, and increases exports.

We will launch major investment programs in artificial intelligence, electronic warfare, engine technologies, aviation, space technologies, advanced materials, and cybersecurity.

We will strengthen the spillover of knowledge and technological expertise from the defense industry into other sectors. Incentive mechanisms will be established to prevent brain drain from this sector, and we will bring highly qualified professionals living abroad back to our country. Here, too, as in every field, transparency, institutional integrity, and merit will be our guiding principles.

Our objective is clear: a Türkiye capable of ensuring its own security; strong within its alliances; prepared for crises; producing advanced technology; possessing powerful deterrent capabilities; and, at the same time, putting peace first. Atatürk's principle, “Peace at home, peace in the world,” is not merely a wish he left us: it is our most important compass!

This principle expresses the vision of a Türkiye that grows stronger and more influential through the diplomacy of peace. It is a declaration that if Türkiye itself is not at peace and living in tranquility, the world cannot be at peace either.

We will revive this formidable tradition of statecraft, which has earned its place in history. We know that a strong foreign policy is possible only with a strong democracy, a strong economy, competent institutions, and social solidarity.

In the Republic's second century, Türkiye will once again make a great leap forward. And the foundations of that leap will be democracy, law, merit, production, and security.

As the world passes through turbulent times, what Türkiye needs most is to be a country that has established peace within its own society, whose people have embraced one another, whose institutions are sound, whose historical consciousness is strong, whose people are happy and hopeful, whose young people are free, and whose minds are enlightened.

Continuity note: The final sentence is completed with the opening words of printed page 307. The next installment resumes with the following paragraph.

CHAPTER NINE — CONCLUSION *The Türkiye I Dream Of*

English translation · Original printed pages 307–309

…a country whose young people are free and whose minds are enlightened.

Today, Türkiye's greatest security challenge does not consist solely of external threats. Its greatest security challenge is the crisis into which the country has been driven by a conception of government that has failed to establish peace within its own society, treats its own citizens who criticize those in power as enemies, and weakens democracy and the rule of law. For democracy and the rule of law confer legitimacy on a state. We see, both around the world and in our own region, what becomes of regimes whose legitimacy has been weakened.

True security is possible only in a country whose citizens trust one another, live together in peace, and share an awareness of their common history and a vision of their common future.

The devoted armed forces, police service, and intelligence institutions of the Republic of Türkiye belong not to an individual, a party, or a faction, but to the nation, the Constitution, and our shared future. Türkiye will be truly strong when these institutions serve as guarantors of law and democracy.

The Türkiye we dream of is a country that stands for peace at home and respect abroad; the rule of law at home and standing abroad; democracy at home and trust abroad.

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We have prepared comprehensive reform programs in all the areas I have discussed. Our roadmap is ready down to the smallest detail. We developed these programs with large teams of highly qualified people and through wide-ranging collective deliberation.

Having said all this, do you know the most important goal in our dream for Türkiye? **The Republic will belong to everyone!**

The road to social peace and national strength runs through unity, solidarity, and a legal order that treats every citizen as one and the same. Only if we make the Republic everyone's republic, refuse to divide citizens, and leave no one behind can we become a peaceful, united, and strong nation.

To make our Republic the republic of every citizen—of everyone—we will recognize citizenship as our most fundamental common ground. We will regard all our citizens as equal. We will not divide them into those deemed “native and national” and those deemed otherwise. We will regard everyone as belonging to this country and everyone as part of the nation!

We will trust in what unites us through our shared history and common homeland. On those shared foundations, we will build a common future and bring our citizens together around the idea of that future.

We will not go anywhere near polarization. We will avoid words and actions that cause our citizens to look upon one another with anxiety or mistrust.

No one will have to fear for their rights or their legal protections. We will defend the rights both of those who vote for us and of those who do not.

We will not pit our cultures, identities, faiths, or convictions against one another. We will keep our distance from culture wars.

We will protect secularism, an indispensable principle of a democratic state and the guarantee that people of all different faiths can live together in peace and on equal terms.

There will be no division, in our eyes, between citizens deemed acceptable and unacceptable, respectable and unrespectable. We will regard every citizen as worthy of acceptance and respect. We will consider everyone's differences deserving of respect.

We will allow no one to see themselves as superior or inferior because of their ethnic origin, faith, or political views, or to establish dominance over others. Everyone will live openly and proudly, in safety and without fear, according to their identity, faith, and political convictions.

We will favor no one and wrong no one. We will create a legal order and social environment in which everyone is different and everyone is equal. We will become a country where citizenship makes everyone equal. **The Republic will belong to everyone.**

*

We are at a historic crossroads! Two choices lie before us: either an utterly dark new regime—let us call it by its name, a dictatorship and a sultanate—will take hold, or we will choose a brighter path. We will defend our Republic, our democracy, and our national sovereignty, and realize our dream for Türkiye!

We must all embrace that dream together, because such a country is possible. I believe in the Türkiye we dream of with all my heart, mind, and soul! I have not the slightest trace of doubt! We will achieve it, and we will achieve it immediately at the first election!

We will break open the doors of the Silivri dungeons forever, and a new Türkiye will be born; our nation will finally be able to breathe!

What did we say in our dream for Türkiye? **Justice First, Freedom First!** That is precisely what we mean.

I believe Türkiye can become the very best version of itself. I believe in this nation's energy, intelligence, conscience, and industriousness.

A Türkiye in which every citizen lives with dignity; every child can dream; every young person looks to the future with confidence; every woman is free and equal; every identity can exist in

peace; every worker receives the reward of their labor; and every person feels they belong. A strong, transformative Türkiye, a leader in the world.

A Türkiye whose people are happy to be Turkish citizens, whose passport commands respect.

Not a republic of fear, but a republic of happy, self-confident, free people. Such a Türkiye is not a distant dream.

Such a Türkiye is possible! Such a Türkiye is this nation's right!

And here today, despite all the pressure, all the injustices, and all the obstacles, I say this: **We will never abandon this dream!** For Türkiye's dream is far greater than the Silivri dungeons, this (so-called) courtroom, this staged trial, this cheap theater, the coups of March 19 and May 21, this oppression and torture, and these political calculations! Fear will not determine this country's future; hope will.

Peace and harmony, not conflict, will determine it. Bridges, not walls, will determine it.

Together we will dream of Türkiye! Together we will make that dream grow! And together, we will certainly succeed!

CHAPTER TEN *This Nation Has Lived Free, and Free It Shall Remain*

English translation · Original printed page 310

As I approach the end of my remarks, I offer my gratitude to my family, all my fellow citizens, my companions on this journey, and the Republican People's Party's organization, members, and elected, legitimate leadership before May 21. I express my gratitude to my esteemed brother and companion, our party chairman, Mr. Özgür Özel, who today stands firm in defense of democracy and the people's will in Türkiye.

I extend my deepest gratitude to the Union of Turkish Bar Associations, the Istanbul Bar Association, and all the bar associations that have supported us, standing with us in the struggle for the rule of law with the same resolve.

I offer my heartfelt thanks to all the political party leaders, organizations, and members who have not left us alone in this struggle for the Republic and democracy; to all civil society organizations; and to all our citizens who have carried our voices, stood beside us, and prayed for us!

I extend my boundless gratitude to the free and independent media organizations, their executives, journalists, reporters, and all their staff, who have amplified our voices and stood firm despite every form of pressure. In recognition of this historic responsibility, I thank them sincerely on behalf of our nation. **I am grateful that you are here!**

Here today, I embrace all of Türkiye, in all its colors, with all its history, all its suffering and hopes, and all its future. I salute Türkiye.

I wish to give special thanks and send a special greeting to our young people. They have stood at the forefront of this struggle from the very beginning. They have suffered severe repression and violence, yet I know that in their hearts and souls they have not given up; they know a better Türkiye is possible. They carry that hope in their hearts.

I promise our young people: **Together, we will keep that hope alive!**

Continuity note: The final sentence carries on into printed page 311. The next installment will begin with “We will never give up!”

CHAPTER TEN — CONTINUED *This Nation Has Lived Free, and Free It Shall Remain*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 311–314

We will never give up! The Türkiye they deserve, the Türkiye we dream of and that I described a moment ago—a happy, peaceful, free, just, productive Türkiye—will become a reality!

All of Türkiye, and the entire world following this courtroom from afar, witnessed the collapse of an attempt by those in power to eliminate a political rival through the courts. Although this trial began as a case built on a conspiracy, it evolved, over the course of the proceedings, into an important milestone on the road toward Türkiye's bright future. In this courtroom, we saw the blow dealt by the nation to a government inclined toward injustice. We witnessed how repression and oppression strengthen society's resistance.

This case exposed the darkness into which our country has been dragged. But it did more than that.

This case became an arena of struggle that, breaking free of the darkness, revealed a guide to the road toward Türkiye's brighter future. It became a front of resistance against oppression.

The darkest hour of the night is the hour closest to dawn. The saying addressed to a tyrant, "May your oppression grow, so that your end comes sooner," is another expression of the same truth. When oppression and darkness reach their peak, liberation is closest at hand. History has always shown this to be so.

Precisely the opposite of what the political mind—or mindlessness—that devised this trial intended has come to pass.

What emerged from this courtroom was not fear, but hope! Not defeat, but strength! Not surrender, but resolve! Not hatred, but love; not anger, but common sense; not helplessness, but confidence! What emerged from this courtroom was stronger unity, solidarity, and resistance. A new Türkiye is being born from this courtroom.

The shortsighted political mind that devised this trial collapsed here, just as the indictment did. Because it created its own opposite.

Evil made goodness grow. Darkness multiplied hope. The conspiracy awakened the will to struggle.

Those who devised this trial are now brooding: "What have we done? How did we open the door to the birth of our own opposition, to growing solidarity throughout society, and to the strengthening of a collective will that will shape the country's future?" They are furious.

Of course, this case should never have happened. Trust in the judiciary should never have been shaken. The law should never have been turned into a dirty instrument of politics. Hundreds of my fellow travelers and their families should never have had to endure such immense suffering. Yet this trial has had one important redeeming consequence: it has exposed to our nation those responsible for the darkness that has brought our country to this state.

That is why I say that this trial will be of enormous significance in building a new era. It will occupy a profoundly meaningful place in our beautiful country's recovery, in ending this dark order, in bringing this period of decline and disorder to a close. Future generations will read about this trial. They will study the defenses delivered here. They will learn about the words spoken here, the resolve displayed here, the spirit of struggle, the resistance, and the demand for justice rising from prison cells.

There is no escaping history. History will drag you out from wherever you are hiding. But we will not leave our fate to history and historians! For the true judge of this case is our nation. Its true witness is our people.

Its true observers are the democrats of the world: hundreds of millions of people committed to human dignity and universal human values. The ones to whom this trial truly belongs are the young people burning to wrest back their stolen future.

I dedicate every word I have spoken here to you, young people! We dedicate every breath, every hardship, every word, and every effort of the struggle that my colleagues and I have carried on here to you!

We are resisting here for the future you deserve. We are working to lay the first brick of the future you deserve. For your sake, we will never abandon this struggle!

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In the near future, when democracy, freedom, equality, and justice are established anew, the cry, the resistance, and the struggle rising from this Silivri courtroom will be among the most important forces shaping that new era.

As I keep saying, they are asking themselves now: "What have we done?"

"We could not foresee that such light would be born from darkness. We failed to calculate that hope would emerge from repression. We did not understand that oppression would ultimately give rise to a far stronger demand for justice." That is how they accuse one another.

When they set out with such an utterly empty script, they failed to reckon with the possibility that the nation would see through their conspiracy, even with dozens of pro-government media channels at their disposal. They thought, "Make the lie big enough and people will believe it." But it did not work. Those without a consciousness of history cannot understand the course of history. They cannot see that darkness heralds the light. They cannot grasp that oppression deepens the pursuit of justice.

Türkiye's children and young people will read about these Silivri trials, learn from them, and study them so that they never return to such darkness. From these trials, they will learn the value of democracy, freedom, the rule of law, and justice.

For the young people who never bowed to the darkness, this trial will stand as a guarantee that such darkness will never return.

Today, our country, our future, and our freedoms are being held hostage by a government whose time has expired, one that has become a plaything in the hands of this or that interest, together with the

handful of vested-interest networks gathered around it. This handful of people looks down on citizens. It believes itself entitled to plunder. It imagines the state is its own property, and the nation merely a silent spectator to its rule. But this order has reached the end of the road. It has exhausted itself. Yes, the cost has been enormous. Türkiye's future has been plundered. Its institutions have been hollowed out. Its social fabric has been damaged. Democracy, justice, freedom, and the economy have suffered grave wounds. Yet our country will rebuild its future by learning from the dark climate this government has imposed upon us.

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Dear Young People,

Above all, it is you who will build an entirely new order so that a period like this can never happen again. We will build that new order together.

I know what you have been going through. Because you write letters to me. Here in this twelve-square-meter cell, between four walls, I spend my days thinking about your troubles. I read, line by line, about the lives you have been forced to lead. Your letters and your messages renew my determination to work; they help me gather my strength. Because I feel an immense sense of responsibility toward you.

I know what it is like to get up early, perhaps change buses three times to reach a job interview, only to return with the words, "We'll call you." I know how you withdraw to your room that evening without telling anyone at home. I know that although your KPSS public-service examination score is sufficient, you have been put off for years with the words "next time," because no positions have been opened. I know what it is like to graduate from a vocational high school, diploma in hand, yet be unable even to find an internship, to be turned away with the words "You have no experience." I know how inflation and the loss of value of the Turkish lira wiped out all the capital in the business you opened with such high hopes, and how you could tell no one as you pulled down the shutters.

I know the young couples who keep postponing marriage because they cannot afford even the rent, let alone the cost of a wedding. I know you go into the factory at seven in the morning and come out at seven in the evening, pay half your wages in rent, and spend what remains on bills. I know how, after spending hours on your motorcycle in traffic, in rain or snow, you come home with trembling hands. I know the conditions under which my brothers and sisters working as motorcycle couriers struggle to survive.

I know the young people who worked so hard to secure a place in dentistry, yet work in cafés on weekends because they cannot afford their equipment and clinical expenses, and wake up exhausted even on mornings when they have classes. How do I know? I know from Ayşe, who wrote to me from Ankara.

I know that, so as not to burden your parents, you work night shifts in jobs entirely unrelated to your studies. I know how you hear that your friends have gone abroad and say, "At least one of us got out." And I know that something inside you breaks as you say it.

I know you share a single room with three people to pay the rent, cut back on food, and still remember to post a smiling photograph on social media in spite of all life's difficulties. They begrudge

you even that smile.

I know all your sorrows and problems, straight from the realities of life. I know them from the young people who write to me from every corner of Türkiye.

Today I want to tell you one thing before anything else: **You did not deserve this.** The bright young people living on these lands do not deserve this! This burden should never have been placed on your shoulders. Your lives should not have been like this. You received a better education than we did; you understand the world better. And despite all that, a harder life than the one faced by the previous generation has been put before you.

This is not your failure. It is the failure of those who should have laid all this country’s opportunities at your feet. Yes, they have failed. This beautiful homeland is in the hands of people who are unsuccessful, unqualified, and irresponsible.

Continuity note: The address to young people continues on original printed page 315; the next installment starts with its opening paragraph.

CHAPTER TEN — CONTINUED *This Nation Has Lived Free, and Free It Shall Remain*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 315–318

I want to tell you one more thing. This struggle is not a struggle between me and Recep Tayyip Erdoğan. They are trying to portray it that way, but it is not. The real struggle is between the mentality that has stolen your hopes, your dreams, and your desire to remain on these lands, and the millions of young people who want to build that future.

I am merely one voice in this struggle. Its true owners are you. And I say this sincerely: the meaning of this case, of this struggle, is far greater than I am. Every day I have spent in Silivri has reminded me of that anew.

You are founding partners in this country. Whatever neighborhood or city you grew up in, whatever opportunities you had, you have a say in what happens on these lands.

Our dream is to live in a homeland where all my brothers and sisters—in the East, the West, the North, and the South—have access to equal opportunities. We can accomplish this only together. You have not forgotten “We were succeeding together,” have you?

Everything that has happened has been meant to erase this from your minds... Because they know that what we achieved in Istanbul we will achieve across Türkiye as well. Because they know we will succeed together, because they saw that together we would bring justice, democracy, and prosperity to our country, they threw us into the dungeons of Silivri.

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Dear young people, the young people who are Türkiye's future...

You have lived through all this; you have felt it down to your very bones. You understand!

You, above all, will establish an entirely new order so that such a period can never happen again. We will establish this new order together.

Isn't life a little like that, too? Sometimes a heavy price must be paid before the meaning of certain values can be understood in all its depth. You know that the true value of health is fully appreciated only when it is lost. Today, too, the Turkish nation understands far better the value of democracy, law, justice, freedom, and prosperity.

Young people have come to understand very clearly why their future was stolen. They will learn how to reclaim that future from this struggle, from the determination demonstrated in this courtroom.

This is the determination behind the struggle to make Türkiye a peaceful, happy, and just country. And what is the determination emerging from this courtroom if not Türkiye's unity, happiness, fraternity, embrace, and hope in all its diversity?

This case was not designed merely against one person, one group, one political party, or me, Ekrem İmamoğlu. Its target is the Republic, democracy, justice, and the sovereignty of the people. It is

Türkiye's unity and integrity. It is the fraternity of its people. It is Türkiye's shared future. The target of this case is your present and your future.

They wanted to demonstrate this: “Look, this is how we put on trial the politics we do not want, the values it represents, and the millions who vote for it. We erase them from history. We annihilate them through a declaration of nullity!”

Those who deal in nullity have grown far too accustomed to it. But you cannot extinguish the people's will, the people's intelligence, or their common sense with some fabricated “ruling of nullity.”

As I said, this case produced its own opposite. This display of power eventually turned into helplessness. It turned into fear, into desperation. The fear and desperation of those who brought this case became unmistakable.

This time they began saying: Let us hide this conspiracy trial from the public; let no one discover or hear that the indictment is a fabricated scenario. They feared the hearings being broadcast on television. They tried to censor them.

Why? Because Silivri was giving rise to its very opposite. Injustice was producing a manifesto for justice. Repression was strengthening resistance.

From a small village in Anatolia to Istanbul's crowded neighborhoods, people across Türkiye began following this case that they wanted to conceal from the nation. Often they followed it silently, in their consciences. After all, the most important court is the court of the people's conscience.

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When they saw that this, too, was not working, they took another path. They said: Let us seize the Republican People's Party. Let us sever it from the struggle for democracy rising in Silivri. Let us make it part of the dark order we ourselves established.

They thought the CHP's loyal supporters would fall for this scheme. They imagined they could once again take the CHP away from its elected leadership by means of a court ruling and install a leadership of their own choosing. In that way, they assumed, CHP supporters would abandon the struggle for democracy and the rule of law, turn away from their ideal of freeing Türkiye from the dark order we have established and building a new future, and place themselves under our protection. How clever, isn't it?

They called this “absolute nullity.” In other words, declaring something invalid. Treating it as though it never existed. Denying history. Erasing memory. March 19 was a coup against the future. The May 21 coup of absolute nullity was a coup against the past.

They reasoned: We will declare history null and void, and the people will erase from their memories the history we have erased. Then we can keep plundering the country's resources and prolong our reign. And we will even call this “reason of state”! They assumed that when the people heard the words “reason of state,” they would lose their memories.

These people are so devoid of reason that they imagine they can declare history, lived experience, and everything we have learned to be null and wipe it all away. They expect the people to submit willingly to this amnesia. And they call that reason of state. It is an insult both to the state and to reason. But above all it is an insult to the family of the Republican People's Party, to these people and their intelligence. Most of all, it is an insult to your intelligence, young people!

Now they have seen the struggle grow even greater. The Republican People's Party family refused to accept this coup by nullity. Today, the people are casting aside this senseless attempt to nullify their own will.

Today, the people reject and repudiate both the Palace responsible for this lawlessness and the Palace's trustee who embraces the declaration of nullity! The nation did not allow its archive to be erased, and it never will! The spirit of this new struggle has been renewed all the more.

What will they do now? Will they lock all of Türkiye up in Silivri? In fact, by trying to imprison the whole nation, are they not locking themselves in a dungeon? Did they not annul and rerun the election in 2019 as well? And did they not then receive a resounding slap from the people? This time it is not a slap. It is a tsunami.

What are you going to do? Declare the coming elections null and void as well? No. Türkiye is finding itself again in the face of all these absurdities, these post-truth coups against the past and the future. It is rediscovering truth in the face of post-truth.

That is why this stop in Silivri matters so much. Because Silivri is no longer merely a place; it is the court of history, where the nation defends its memory, its will, and its future.

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Young people, I want you to hear from me just how deeply we—Ekrem İmamoğlu and my companions in this struggle—feel and understand what you are going through.

They may try to keep us in a dungeon in Silivri, but they can never make us abandon our ideals. And at the center of our ideals stand you: the beautiful future you will build. I, Ekrem İmamoğlu, understand you and feel what you are going through...

I feel and see that fighting a harsh battle for survival, both economically and emotionally, is standing in the way of our children and young people's dreams, driving them into a state of entrapment and despair.

Our young people, who for years suffered from “anxiety about the future,” are now anxious about the present itself. Forget planning a future for themselves: they cannot get beyond asking, “What am I supposed to do right now?” How can a generation struggling simply to survive imagine a hopeful future?

Now that our Republic has passed its hundredth year, did it come into being so that mothers and fathers would have to sacrifice their children, their children's future, hopes, and dreams to the ambitions of those in power?

For heaven's sake, how can there be a generation that does not feel safe in the centennial year of the Republic? What kind of state allows children to faint from hunger in their schools? How can there be a generation that does not feel safe at school? What kind of state cannot provide a meal at school? What kind of state cannot provide a place to live for young people who have earned a place at university? What kind of state cannot tolerate young people's self-expression, their humor, their festivals, and their joy, and instead drags them away, handcuffs them behind their backs, and fills prisons with them? What kind of state leaves mothers and fathers fearing for their children's safety, leaves children to hunger and poor-quality education, abandons young people to housing problems, unemployment, and poverty, and destroys their freedoms, hopes, and dreams?

In such circumstances, how can we expect our young people to lift us up and carry us toward something better?

Through all these difficult conditions, my wonderful young brothers and sisters continue their struggle to live, refusing to give up despite everything. I am proud of them. I am proud of you, dear young people!

For the first time in Türkiye, a generation is poorer than the generation that came before it. **That is the problem that must be placed on the table first.**

Continuity note: The discussion of solutions begins on original printed page 319; the next installment resumes with that paragraph.

CHAPTER TEN — CONTINUED *This Nation Has Lived Free, and Free It Shall Remain*

English Translation · Original Printed Pages 319–322

The solution is a Republic of Türkiye that provides social justice, fairness in the distribution of income, and equality of opportunity from east to west. That is my process for finding a solution. My vision of a solution is, of course, first and foremost a Türkiye secure from every threat surrounding it. The country I dream of is one in which all our children and young people live under equal and just conditions. That is the real solution I am talking about.

Let everyone hear me, and let them tell those who have not heard: young people no longer want to struggle merely to survive; they want to be able to dream. They want to move forward. They do not want fear, anxiety, and apprehension; they want to experience freedom to the fullest. They want opportunities that will enable them to compete with all their peers around the world and to earn respect.

We owe them that. This is the real problem, and I have explained the solution to you in the chapter on *The Türkiye I Dream Of*. What will make it happen is a government filled with people sufficiently qualified, honorable, and courageous to face the realities of life, understand problems, and develop solutions.

Not a government staffed through family ties, friendships, and partisanship, but one formed by capable sons and daughters drawn from our **86 million citizens**.

Look, we now live in the age of artificial intelligence. It is an age in which knowledge spreads rapidly and is quickly interpreted and turned into products. While young people in many countries are forging ahead in these fields, I cannot—and will not—sit idly by and watch our own young people fall behind!

I promise that, through collective wisdom, we will identify our needs and mobilize every resource at our disposal for young people.

Over the next **15 to 20 years**, we will act swiftly to overcome the risks and threats ahead, opening opportunities for young people through advanced technologies and engineering founded on basic scientific knowledge. We will surge forward through science and, by producing and prioritizing agriculture, industry, and technology, design a future in which our young people can work in prosperity. We will produce together.

And never, ever doubt that we will have a Republic of Türkiye that provides them with the conditions in which they can work most productively and live the happiest possible lives.

I am as certain as I am of my own name that those currently governing this country neither care about these matters nor possess the knowledge, talent, and skills needed to take action. That is why they must leave immediately, to be replaced by an administration at peace with technology, innovation, science, art, sport, and nature—one that places society's interests and young people's futures before its own interests.

Young people, I give you my word: together we will emerge from this darkness; together we will overcome this psychological anguish and this sense of helplessness!

They thought they could erase history. They were wrong. The people refused to let their historical record be erased; their spirit of resistance was renewed and strengthened. With that spirit renewed, we cry out once more: build as many barricades as you wish, order as many prosecutions as you like—you cannot change the course of history! For no power can stand in the way of an idea whose time has come, or of inevitable change!

When the winds of change begin to blow in the people's hearts, no power can stop them! We will continue to march upright in the squares where that wind is blowing, at the very heart of change. We will become the very wave of irresistible change that you have failed to stop. So do not be deceived by the country's current political agenda. These are all mirages, all illusions.

We face a government that in no way reflects the true attitude or character of our nation. We are living through a period in which nothing is real, yet everything seems possible.

Those in power and those around them have been backed into a corner. They are seeking to secure their own futures by joining forces with certain powers abroad. In doing so, they have closed their eyes completely to the suffering and problems of those left behind.

We will give them the answer they deserve and send them home! Then, together, we will continue along our bright path with profound conviction. These are the words of Ekrem İmamoğlu and his companions, who for more than a year have been dreaming beautiful dreams for their country, morning and evening, in their cells in Silivri.

I love you all dearly. Our hope stands strong; set your minds at ease! Do not worry, and know that **I am here! I am not going anywhere!** Until everything is put right and back on track, I will never give up! **We will never give up!**

They are condemning Türkiye to the rule of one person, to profiteering, plunder, and pillage, and to an unplanned, directionless future. They are trying to confine the country within a **1,150-room Palace** and place limits on its young people.

We promise you happiness, peace, solidarity, freedom, equality, and an equal stake in our future across **814,578 square metres** of Türkiye's territory. We promise to make our country a leader in science, education, culture, art, sport, entrepreneurship, technology, and development—from the Caucasus to Persia, from the Middle East to the Balkans and Europe—and, under the leadership of you, our young people, to make it a guiding star for the world.

We are ready to shoulder the responsibility for Türkiye. We are ready to give Türkiye the brightest period in its history. We are ready to lift our nation up once more, making it one of the happiest and most prosperous peoples in the world—a nation at peace with itself and proud of its country.

They are trying to prevent Türkiye's bright future by imprisoning us. They think that by silencing us they can stop the birth of the Turkish miracle. But their efforts are in vain.

We are ready. And Türkiye is ready. We are ready to close the age of hatred, resentment, and violence, and open an age of love! We are ready to give everyone forgotten by this government the dignified, safe, and happy life they deserve! We are ready to give young people back their future!

We have sworn to work day and night so that young people can once again dream in our country. We are ready to rid fertile Anatolia of the poisons that have afflicted it and make it one of the world's paradises.

We are ready to make our cities—with their historic fabric, all their colors, all their flavors, and all their vitality—among the most livable cities in the world. We are ready to bring the abundance of this country to the tables of our people. We are ready to make the state of this country the people's state; its justice, justice for all; its democracy, everyone's dignity, everyone's guarantee of security, and everyone's common home.

Above all, we are ready to build a Türkiye where young people dream not of leaving this country, but of rebuilding it. We are ready to achieve the Turkish miracle.

Within the very first hours after we leave Silivri, Türkiye will come to its senses. The march toward the great miracle will begin. Gloom will disperse, despair will retreat, and optimism and hope will settle into the soul of this country. The dark fog will lift. The sun will shine much more brightly on these lands! A sense of justice will awaken in people's hearts. As those who do not wish Türkiye well are gripped by panic, our people will embrace one another once more. Our awareness of being one nation, our sense of shared destiny, and our bond of brotherhood will prevail. The door will be thrown wide open to the dream of a great, just, prosperous, productive Türkiye—beautiful in nature and in its cities, with smiling people living in peace.

Together, we will restore this country's hope!

Young people: **This country is yours! This future is yours! This struggle for democracy is yours! This quest for justice is yours! This dream of a beautiful Türkiye is yours!**

Despite the severe oppression we are enduring, my colleagues and I are not giving up. And I can see that you are not giving up either! With every letter you send, you strengthen resistance; with every act of resistance, you nurture hope. You make your stand at graduation ceremonies.

Even when people try to silence you onstage, you show that you will not be silent. In workshops, at workbenches, and on night shifts, however tired you may be, you refuse to give up standing tall. Even when you know that you may be turned away in job interviews because you have no influential relative whose name you can invoke, you still work hard in examination halls and refuse to abandon your determination to make your own way through your labor. Even when they try to silence you on social media, you refuse to stop writing, sharing, and defending your freedom of expression. Even knowing the price you may pay, you refuse to abandon the public squares. Whatever they do, you do not let them steal your joy.

And I am not giving up either.

Dear young people, never forget: love of one's homeland is a conviction, a way of life. Love of one's homeland is a struggle that never ends.

Stand up for Türkiye, for the indivisible integrity of our homeland, for our flag, and for our dreams. Stand up for our state, our institutions, our cities, and nature—for its air, water, seas, forests, soils, plateaus, and mineral resources. Never allow betrayal!

Be ready, my friends! Ready to build a new generation of politics; to keep the Republic alive forever; to strengthen democracy; to transform the Grand National Assembly of Türkiye into a parliament where, through its pluralistic composition and strong powers, the people truly have a voice and the country's problems are debated; to establish the rule of law, the separation of powers, and an independent judiciary; and to defend elections and the ballot box as the sacred trust of our nation!

The future belongs to you! You are the ones who will come!

Now is the time to struggle! Let us march, my friends...

Translator's note: The source states “814.578 m2” in its description of Türkiye's total territory. The figure and unit are reproduced as printed, although the unit appears inconsistent with the context.

APPENDIX — SOURCE PAGE 323

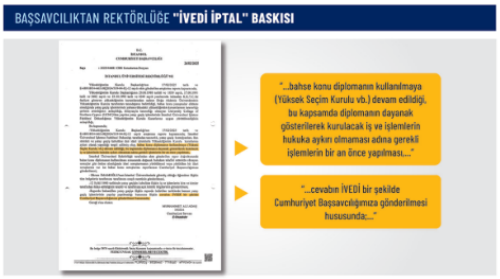
English figure headings and explanatory key | Original graphics retained for reference



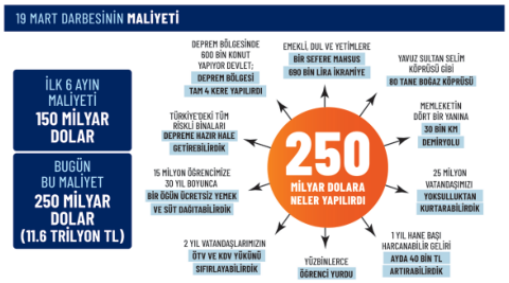
İMAMOĞLU CEZA DAVALARI

DAVA KONUSU / ADI	MAHKEME
İBB DAVASI	İstanbul 33. Ağır Ceza Mahkemesi (Eski adıyla 40. Ağır Ceza Mahkemesi)
BEYLİKDÜZÜ DÖNCMİ İHALE DAVASI	Büyükçekmece 10. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
DİPLOMA CEZA DAVASI	İstanbul 59. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
DİPLOMA DAVASI	İstanbul 5. İdare Mahkemesi
AKIN GÜRLEK DAVASI	İstanbul 14. Ağır Ceza Mahkemesi
BİLİRKİŞİ SATILMIŞ DAVASI	İstanbul 2. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
CASUSLUK DAVASI	İstanbul 25. Ağır Ceza Mahkemesi
"AHMAK" DAVASI	İstanbul Anadolu 7. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
ŞADİ YAZICI'YA HAKARET DAVASI	Anadolu 16. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
SAVCILARA HAKARET DAVASI	İstanbul 27. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
SERKAN ŞAHİN'E HAKARET (ÇİRKİN) DAVASI	Bakırköy 33. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
ORDU VALİSİNE HAKARET (RADİT) DAVASI	Ordu 4. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
USULSÜZ HARCAMA DAVASI	Büyükçekmece 21. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
KURULTAY DAVASI	Ankara 26. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi
BEYLİKDÜZÜ MAKAM ARACI DAVASI	Büyükçekmece 21. Asliye Ceza Mahkemesi

TABLO 1: Ekrem İmamoğlu aleyhine açılan ceza davaları.



TABLO 2: Savcılığın İstanbul Üniversitesi Rektörlüğü'ne yazısı.



TABLO 3: 19 Mart darbesinde eriyen paramızla neler yapılırdı?

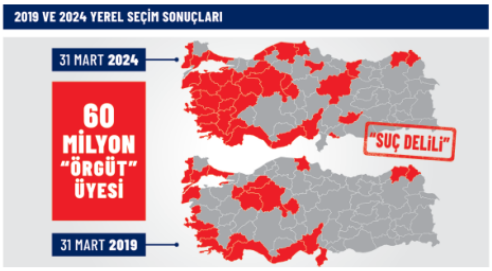
TABLE 1 — Criminal Proceedings Filed Against Ekrem İmamoğlu — The graphic lists the subject of each case and the court hearing it, including the İBB, Beylikdüzü procurement, diploma, Akın Gürlek, and other cases.

TABLE 2 — Prosecutor's Letter to Istanbul University Rectorate — The graphic alleges that the prosecutor's office pressured the rectorate to cancel the university diploma. The two orange panels reproduce selected passages of the letter.

TABLE 3 — The Cost of the March 19 Intervention — Graphic claim: $150 billion in the first six months, reaching $250 billion (TL 11.6 trillion). The graphic compares this amount with housing, pensions, transport, health and other potential public benefits.

APPENDIX — SOURCE PAGE 324

English figure headings and explanatory key | Original graphics retained for reference



TABLO 4: "1 No'lu Suç Delili": Mart 2024 seçimleri sonrası CHP'nin kazandığı belediyeler.



TABLO 5: "2 No'lu suç delili": İstanbul'da CHP 26 ilçe belediyesi kazandı, 39 ilçeden 32'sinde Ekrem İmamoğlu birinci geldi.

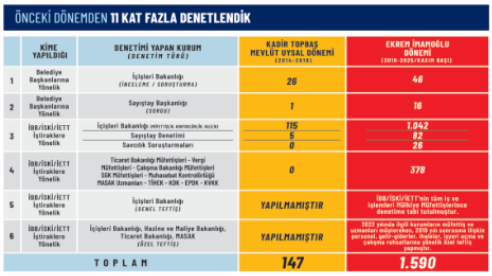


TABLO 6: İddianamede bulunan, yol arkadaşlarımızın yüzleri kırmızıyla işaretlenmiş Kurultay fotoğrafları "iddianamedeki suç delilleri!"

TABLE 4 — "Evidence of Crime No. 1" — Municipalities won by the CHP after the March 2024 elections. The red-map legend claims "60 million votes for democracy"; "Criminal Evidence!" appears as a satirical stamp.

TABLE 5 — "Evidence of Crime No. 2" — CHP won 26 of Istanbul's 39 district municipalities; Ekrem İmamoğlu came first in 32 districts. The graphic compares the election results.

TABLE 6 — "When Did Attending the CHP Convention Become a Crime?" — Convention photographs with members of the author's team circled in red. Caption: Photos from the party convention, submitted in the indictment as "criminal evidence."



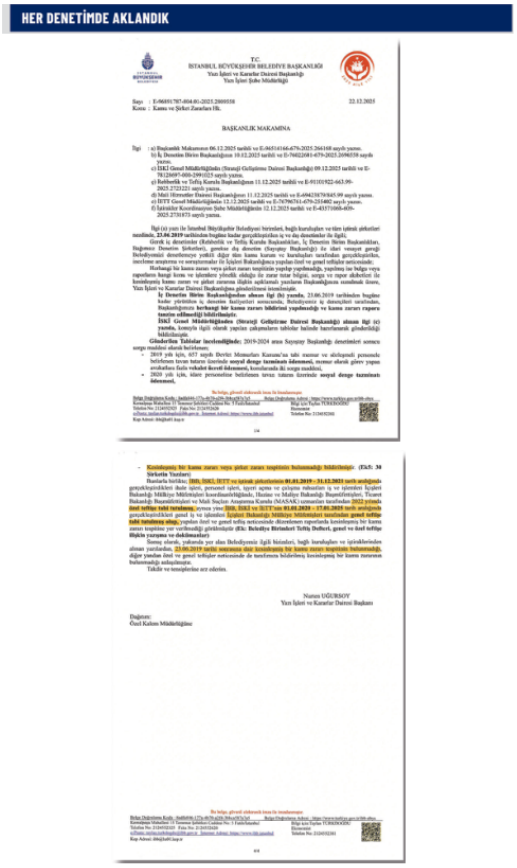
TABLO 7: AKP dönemi ve İmamoğlu dönemi denetim sayısı mukayesesi.



TABLO 8: Soruşturmalara ilişkin fotoğraflar.

TABLE 7 — Comparing Audit Counts — Headline: “We Were Audited Eleven Times More Than in the Previous Period.” Displayed totals: Kadir Topbaş administration (2014–2019), 147 audits; Ekrem İmamoğlu administration (2019 onward, as labeled), 1,590 audits. Note that the original chart breaks out internal, external and other audit types.

TABLE 8 — Photographs Relating to Investigations — Headline: “They Tried to Intimidate Us with Absurd Investigations.” The six examples concern a pandemic solidarity campaign; waiting outside a bakery; hanging posters; removing a portrait of Sultan Mehmed the Conqueror; water dispensers installed through Istanbul Foundation and İSKİ; and opening 150 daycare centers.

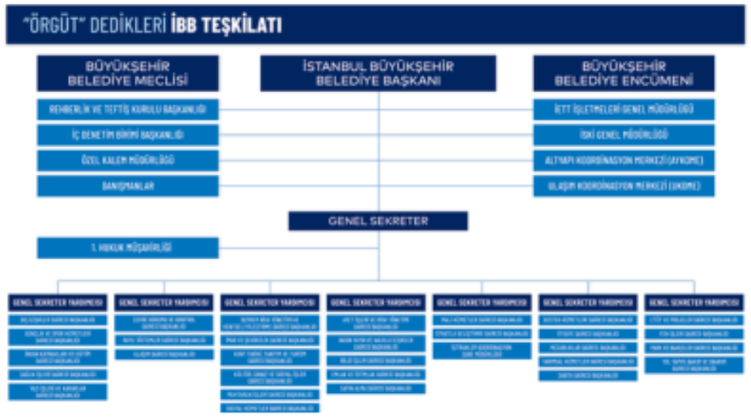


TABLO 9: Yazı İşleri ve Kararlar Dairesi Başkanlığı'nın 22 Aralık 2025 tarihli yazısı.

TABLE 9 — Letter from the Department of Correspondence and Decisions, December 22, 2025 — Reproductions of the original two-page Turkish official correspondence. For documentary accuracy the original scans are preserved unchanged. A full certified translation of this correspondence is not provided in this installment.



TABLO 10: Kaç kez "duydum", kaç kez "tahmin ediyorum" ve benzeri muğlak ifadelerin kullanıldığını gösteren tablo.



TABLO 11: İSKİ, İETT ve 30 iştirak şirketini gösteren tablo.



TABLO 12: AKP dönemine ait yolsuzluk dosyaları.

TABLE 10

Frequency of "I heard," "I assume," and similar ambiguous expressions.

TABLE 11

Chart showing İSKİ, İETT and the 30 subsidiary companies.

TABLE 12

Corruption case files relating to the AKP administration.

Presentation note: English translations are provided for the source captions. The original charts and documents remain in Turkish and are reproduced unchanged to preserve figures and source material.



TABLO 13: Başakşehir'de askeri arazi üzerinden yapılan yolsuzluk.



TABLO 14: Bahçeşehir KİPTAŞ arsa alım yolsuzluğu.



TABLO 15: Vatan Caddesi'ndeki taşınmaz üzerinden yapılan yolsuzluk.

TABLE 13

Alleged corruption involving military land in Başakşehir.

TABLE 14

Alleged corruption in KİPTAŞ's Bahçeşehir land purchase.

TABLE 15

Alleged corruption involving the property on Vatan Avenue.

Presentation note: English translations are provided for the source captions. The original charts and documents remain in Turkish and are reproduced unchanged to preserve figures and source material.

2009-2019 AK PARTİ DÖNEMİ İMAR DEĞİŞİKLİKLERİ

KONUSU	1/5000	1/1000	1/500	TOPLAM
DONATI ALANLARINDAN DONATI ALANLARINA DEĞİŞİM	1081	1171	5	2257
MAHKEME KARARINA İSTİNADEN YAPILAN DÜZENLEME	92	77	1	170
İMARLI ALANLARDAN DONATI ALANLARINA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİM	463	679	6	1148
DONATI ALANLARINDAN İMARLI ALANLARA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİM	260	454	2	716
SINIR DÜZENLEMELERİ KAPSAMINDA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİKLİKLER	72	476	12	559
İMARLI SAHAYA FONKSİYON VE/VEYA YAPILAŞMA ŞARTLARINDA DEĞİŞİKLİK YAPILMASINA İLİŞKİN DÜZENLEMELER	489	1011	11	1521
PLAN NOTLARINDA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİKLİKLERE İLİŞKİN DÜZENLEMELER	156	379	1	536
PLANSIZ ALANLARDAN DONATI ALANLARINA DEĞİŞİM	41	47	0	88
PLANSIZ ALANLARDAN İMARLI ALANLARA DÖNÜŞÜMÜ İÇEREN DÜZENLEMELER	18	23	0	41
TEKNİK EKSİKLİKLİĞİN GİDERİLMESİNE İLİŞKİN DÜZENLEMELER	56	210	4	270
ULAŞIM PROJELERİNE İLİŞKİN PLAN TEKLİFLERİ	152	184	0	336
TOPLAM	2.890	4.710	42	7.642
Parsel Bazlı İmar Artışı Yapılan Arsa Sayısı				2.278

TABLO 16: AKP dönemi (2009-2019) imar değişiklikleri.

2019-2026 BİZİM DÖNEMİMİZDEKİ İMAR DEĞİŞİKLİKLERİ

MÜELLİFİ İBB OLAN TEKLİFLERİN KONUSUNA GÖRE SAYISAL DAĞILIMI	1/5000	1/1000	1/500	TOPLAM
DONATI ALANLARINDAN DONATI ALANLARINA DEĞİŞİM	90	84	1	175
MAHKEME KARARINA İSTİNADEN YAPILAN DÜZENLEME	16	2	0	18
İMARLI ALANLARDAN DONATI ALANLARINA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİM	27	19	0	46
DONATI ALANLARINDAN İMARLI ALANLARA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİM	15	14	0	30
SINIR DÜZENLEMELERİ KAPSAMINDA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİKLİKLER	8	8	0	16
İMARLI SAHAYA FONKSİYON VE/VEYA YAPILAŞMA ŞARTLARINDA DEĞİŞİKLİK YAPILMASINA İLİŞKİN DÜZENLEMELER	25	7	0	32
PLAN NOTLARINDA YAPILAN DEĞİŞİKLİKLERE İLİŞKİN DÜZENLEMELER	47	14	0	61
PLANSIZ ALANLARDAN DONATI ALANLARINA DEĞİŞİM	10	8	0	18
PLANSIZ ALANLARDAN İMARLI ALANLARA DÖNÜŞÜMÜ İÇEREN DÜZENLEMELER	4	3	0	7
TEKNİK EKSİKLİKLİĞİN GİDERİLMESİNE İLİŞKİN DÜZENLEMELER	0	0	0	0
ULAŞIM PROJELERİNE İLİŞKİN PLAN TEKLİFLERİ	42	50	0	92
TOPLAM	285	209	1	495
Parsel Bazlı İmar Artışı Yapılan Arsa Sayısı				69

TABLO 17: Yönetimimizdeki imar değişiklikleri.



TABLO 18: "Yüzyılın yolsuzluğu" AKP dönemi imar rantı.

TABLE 16

Zoning plan amendments under the AKP administration (2009–2019).

TABLE 17

Zoning plan amendments under our administration.

TABLE 18

"Corruption of the Century": zoning windfalls under AKP rule.

Presentation note: English translations are provided for the source captions. The original charts and documents remain in Turkish and are reproduced unchanged to preserve figures and source material.



TABLO 19: 2 Nisan 1996, dönemin İBB Başkanı Recep Tayyip Erdoğan: "Kaçak yapılara ruhsat verip bağış alıyoruz."



TABLO 20: Daha az kaynakla, kat kat fazla iş yaptık!



TABLO 21: Yolsuzluk endeksi, hukukun üstünlüğü ve basın özgürlüğü endekslerinde ülkemizin büyük gerilemesi.

TABLE 19

April 2, 1996 — Then-İBB Mayor Recep Tayyip Erdoğan: "We grant permits to unauthorized buildings and receive donations."

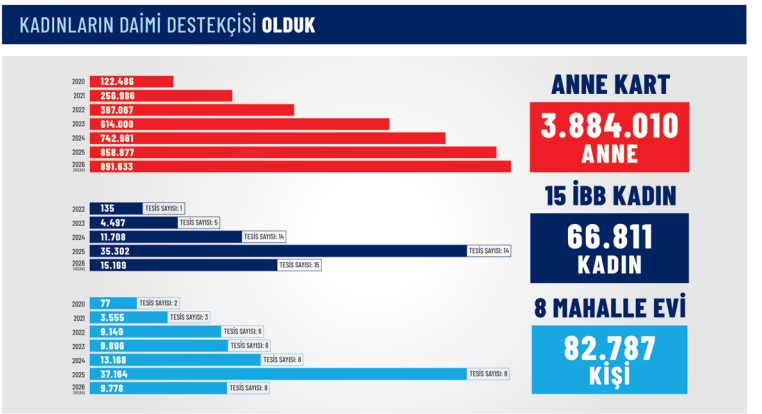
TABLE 20

We accomplished many times more with fewer resources!

TABLE 21

Türkiye's significant decline in the corruption, rule-of-law, and press-freedom indices.

Presentation note: English translations are provided for the source captions. The original charts and documents remain in Turkish and are reproduced unchanged to preserve figures and source material.



TABLO 40: Kadınların daimi destekçisi olduk.



TABLO 41: Çocuklarımızı geleceğe hazırlamak için yola çıktık.

Table 40 — We have been steadfast supporters of women.

Table 41 — We set out to prepare our children for the future.



TABLO 42: İktidarın 2011'de açıkladığı 2023 hedefleri. Yıl 2026 oldu, ülkece 2023 hedeflerinin de çok gerisindeyiz.



TABLO 43: Asgari ücret, ortalama emekli aylığı ve açlık sınırı, yoksulluk sınırı grafiği. Milletimizi açlık sınırına mahkûm ettiniz!

Table 42 — The government's 2023 targets, announced in 2011: even in 2026, Türkiye remains far behind them.

Table 43 — Minimum wage, average retirement pension, hunger threshold and poverty threshold. You have condemned our people to live below the hunger line!